MARKETLIFE MINISTRIES

SOUL DUST REVIVAL

A 365-DAY DEVOTIONAL THROUGH

The Psalms

“My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word.”

PSALM 119:25 (NKJV)

DAYS 1–365 · PSALMS 1–150 · UNIVERSAL EDITION

The Soul Dust Team

Soul Dust Revival: A 365-Day Devotional Through the Psalms — Universal Edition

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Written and compiled by The Soul Dust Team.

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READ · REFLECT · RETURN

FOREWORD

A Word Before the First Page

Friend, before you read a single page, you should know how this book came to be. We did not write it from a mountaintop. We wrote it from the dust.

There came a season for each of us when the Christian life felt thinner than we wanted to admit. Prayer felt mechanical. The Bible felt familiar but distant. From the outside, nothing looked broken. On the inside, something was clinging to the dirt. Then Psalm 119:25 named it — a soul clinging to dust — and in the same breath asked God for revival according to His Word. It became a prayer we had to learn to pray.

The book itself began at a table. Five men sat down over several days of live, unscripted conversation about Scripture, about sin, and about what it takes for a soul to get up off the ground. One of them, Brad Bird, has spent many years as a full-time Bible teacher, several of them as a pastor, and he brought years of sermon notes and teaching material with him.

All of it, the recordings and the notes, was then compiled with the help of artificial intelligence. A book that asks you to be honest should be honest about how it was made. The AI gathered, sorted, and shaped the raw material. It did not supply the convictions. The Scripture, the theology, and the burden for the reader came from the table. Every page was then read, corrected, and approved by the team before it went to print. A shovel does not make the soil rich. It only turns it over. What feeds a soul is the Word of God.

That work is revival, and it is God’s work, not yours. You will not find a program here. You will find Scripture opened slowly, your sin named plainly, and Christ, who does for you, in the dust, what you cannot do for yourself. He raises you.

If your soul has settled low, you are the one we had in mind at that table. You are not too far down. Read slowly, with a Bible open and, if you can, a friend beside you. Bring your real life into it. Christ is not waiting for the cleaned-up version of you. He is already with you in the dust.

May the Lord do what only the Lord can do, and revive you according to His Word.

In the dust, and yet not without hope,
The Soul Dust Team
MARKETLIFE MINISTRIES

PREFACE

How to Walk This Year

This is a long walk in one direction. One psalm, or one stretch of a psalm, for each day — all one hundred and fifty of them across a year, carrying the cry that gives this book its name. Psalm 119:25 prays, *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV).

Each day is built the same way, on purpose. A key verse opens the page. A short reading sits with the psalm, sometimes pausing where the Hebrew opens something the English smooths over. Lift Up Your Eyes turns your face to Christ before you set the page down. Then one question — not a quiz but an invitation, worth answering out loud or in a journal rather than reading past.

Scripture in this book is quoted from the World English Bible, which is in the public domain. The one exception is the anchor verse, which is quoted from the New King James Version wherever it appears and is always marked as such.

Do not rush it. Read slowly, with a Bible open, and if you can, with another person. Bring your real life into it — your fears, your patterns, your weariness, the things you have not said out loud in a long time. If you miss a day, do not go back and hurry to catch up. Pick up with today. Christ is not waiting for the cleaned-up version of you. He meets you where you are, and He revives according to His word.

365 DAYS IN THE PSALMS

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Six Faces of the Dust

Before you begin the walk, it is worth asking plainly what the anchor verse means when it says the soul clings to the dust. Psalm 119:25 prays, *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). The word dust carries more than one weight in Scripture. Naming its faces will help you recognize, day by day, which dust is clinging to you — and where God is reaching into it. Scripture speaks of the dust in at least six ways, and answers all six with a seventh.

I Frailty and Mortality

You are a creature. *"Yahweh God formed man from the dust of the ground"* (Genesis 2:7), and the word after the fall is plain: *"For you are dust, and you shall return to dust"* (Genesis 3:19). Sometimes the dust is not sin but finiteness — tiredness, aging, the limits of a body that wears out. That is not a sign that God is displeased with you. *"He remembers that we are dust"* (Psalm 103:14). What you need in that dust is not self-improvement but revival, from the One who has never forgotten what you are made of.

GENESIS 2:7 · GENESIS 3:19 · PSALM 103:14 · ECCLESIASTES 12:7

II Humiliation and Lowliness

"For our soul is bowed down to the dust" (Psalm 44:25). In Scripture, lying in the dust pictures being brought low — loss, shame, oppression, grief. The psalmist cries, *"You have brought me into the dust of death"* (Psalm 22:15). This dust often comes from suffering, not failure. Even here Lamentations holds out a thread: *"Let him put his mouth in the dust, if it is so that there may be hope"* (Lamentations 3:29). God draws near not when you soar but when you are pressed into the ground.

PSALM 44:25 · PSALM 22:15 · LAMENTATIONS 3:29

III Sin and Decay

After the fall God told the serpent, *"you shall eat dust all the days of your life"* (Genesis 3:14). Dust became the food of the cursed. Job said, *"I have become like dust and ashes"* (Job 30:19). Some dust is inside you: compromise, neglect, unconfessed sin, affections that have drifted. The soul clings to it because sin entangles and habits enslave. Paul felt the weight: *"What a wretched man I am! Who will deliver me out of the body of this death?"* (Romans 7:24). And he knew the answer: *"I thank God through Jesus Christ, our Lord!"* (Romans 7:25).

GENESIS 3:14 · JOB 30:19 · PSALM 7:5 · ROMANS 7:24–25

IV Worldliness

Dust stands for what is temporary and passing. Of the rich the psalm says, *"when he dies he will carry nothing away"* (Psalm 49:17). Isaiah asks, *"Why do you spend money for that which is not bread?"* (Isaiah 55:2). The soul clings to dust when it fastens onto lesser loves — comfort, approval, control, success — none of which can revive or satisfy. Even good gifts become dust when they take God's place. Paul's word is direct: *"Set your mind on the things that are above, not on the things that are on the earth"* (Colossians 3:2).

PSALM 49:17 · ISAIAH 55:2 · COLOSSIANS 3:2 · JAMES 4:4

V Death and Despair

Sometimes the dust means death drawing near, in body or in spirit. *"For my soul is full of troubles. My life draws near to Sheol"* (Psalm 88:3). David argued with God from the edge: *"Shall the dust praise you? Shall it declare your truth?"* (Psalm 30:9). There is a despair so heavy it feels like dying — numb, dry, spent. The good news is that God's word revives not only the sin-weary soul but the death-weary one. No darkness is too far down for the breath of His word to reach.

PSALM 88:3 · PSALM 30:9 · JOB 17:16

VI A Place God Delights to Revive

Here is the gospel surprise: God often chooses the dust as His starting point. *"He raises up the poor out of the dust"* (Psalm 113:7). He dwells *"with him also who is of a contrite and humble spirit, to revive the spirit of the humble"* (Isaiah 57:15). In Ezekiel's valley the word went out — *"You dry bones, hear Yahweh's word"* (Ezekiel 37:4) — and breath came. At a tomb in Bethany Jesus cried, *"Lazarus, come out!"* (John 11:43). Dust is not the end. It is the ground where resurrection begins.

PSALM 113:7 · ISAIAH 57:15 · EZEKIEL 37:4–5 · JOHN 11:43

VII The Christ-Centered Lens

All of it gathers into one Person. Christ entered the dust: *"The Word became flesh, and lived among us"* (John 1:14). He carried the curse: *"For him who knew no sin he made to be sin on our behalf"* (2 Corinthians 5:21). He lay in the dust of death, all the way down. And He rose: *"But now Christ has been raised from the dead"* (1 Corinthians 15:20). Every kind of dust this book names — frailty, humiliation, sin, worldliness, despair — He answered by going into it and coming up out of it. So when you pray Psalm 119:25, you are praying to the Word made flesh, who came up out of the dust and reaches down to bring you with Him.

JOHN 1:14 · 2 CORINTHIANS 5:21 · 1 CORINTHIANS 15:20

◆

DAY 1 · JANUARY 1 · PSALM 1

Two Trees, Two Soils

> *"He will be like a tree planted by the streams of water, that produces its fruit in its season, whose leaf also does not wither."*
> — PSALM 1:3

Psalm 1 opens the whole songbook with two people and two kinds of ground. One drifts — walking, then standing, then sitting — and ends *"like the chaff which the wind drives away"* (Psalm 1:4). Chaff is the husk left on the threshing floor, light enough for any breeze to carry off. The other has roots in wet soil: *"He will be like a tree planted by the streams of water"* (Psalm 1:3). The Hebrew verb behind *"planted"* is shatal, to plant or to transplant. This tree did not seed itself on the bank. It was dug up somewhere dry and set down by the water by another hand.

That is where this year starts — with what you are. *"Yahweh God formed man from the dust of the ground"* (Genesis 2:7), and dust left alone does what chaff does. It dries out and blows away. Psalm 119:25 prays, *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). The drifting life in Psalm 1 is rarely a wild one. More often it is a life never moved to the water, losing a little green each season until nothing holds it to the ground.

The flourishing life did not move itself either. Psalm 1 never tells the tree to walk to the river. It tells you the tree was planted. The same is true of you in Christ. Jesus said, *"I am the vine. You are the branches. He who remains in me and I in him bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing"* (John 15:5). The fruit is not squeezed out of the branch by strain. It is drawn up from the root, through wood that only has to stay attached.

So before this book asks one thing of you, it tells you where life comes from. Not from effort. Not from trying harder to be green. Life comes from being carried to the water and kept there. The delight Psalm 1 describes — *"his delight is in Yahweh's law. On his law he meditates day and night"* (Psalm 1:2) — is not the price of being planted. It is what a planted tree does. It drinks. Every page of this year is a place to drink.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

One Tree drank the stream fully and never withered, and He was cut down for you. Christ hung on a tree of wood, cut off from the land of the living, and rose on the third day as the firstfruits of new life. You are grafted into His root. The green in you is His life, not your effort.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you straining to make yourself green, instead of letting Christ keep you planted by the water?

◆

DAY 2 · JANUARY 2 · PSALM 2

The Kings Who Rage

> *"You are my son. Today I have become your father."*
> — PSALM 2:7

Psalm 2 opens with noise. *"Why do the nations rage, and the peoples plot a vain thing?"* (Psalm 2:1). Kings stand up, rulers huddle, and the plan is to throw off God's rule: *"Let's break their bonds apart, and cast their cords from us"* (Psalm 2:3). Remember what those kings are made of. Dust is shaking its fist at the One who shaped it from the ground. Heaven's answer is not panic. *"He who sits in the heavens will laugh"* (Psalm 2:4). It is not cruel laughter. It is the calm of a Maker who has never once been in danger from what He made, the way a mountain is in no danger from the wind that rattles a fence post at its foot.

The same revolt runs on a smaller scale in you. It sounds reasonable. It wants its own way with its money, its time, its tongue, its body. It calls God's commands ropes when they are a fence around a field. That is the oldest lie in the garden — that you can be your own god. A soul gripping that throne stays in the dirt, because the throne was never yours to hold and it is heavier than you think.

The center of the psalm is a Father speaking over a Son: *"You are my son. Today I have become your father"* (Psalm 2:7). The New Testament hears that line fulfilled in Jesus. At the Jordan the voice came again: *"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased"* (Matthew 3:17). Hebrews applies Psalm 2 to Christ directly (Hebrews 1:5). The King God has set on Zion is no tyrant. He is the beloved Son, and He has a cross in His history.

And the Son shares the family name. Paul writes, *"you received the Spirit of adoption, by whom we cry, 'Abba! Father!'"* (Romans 8:15). The psalm closes with a door, not a wall: *"Blessed are all those who take refuge in him"* (Psalm 2:12). A rebel does not earn the welcome by winning an argument with heaven first. The refuge is already open. Whoever runs in out of the storm is not crushed for the old revolt. That one is called a child.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The kings did their worst to the Son. They took counsel against Him, nailed Him to a cross, and sealed His grave with a stone. God raised Him and seated Him as King anyway. The fist you raised against heaven can open now. Lay it in His pierced hand. Christ makes rebels into sons and daughters.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you still holding the throne of your own life with a closed fist?

◆

DAY 3 · JANUARY 3 · PSALM 3

The Lifter of My Head

> *"But you, Yahweh, are a shield around me, my glory, and the one who lifts up my head."*
> — PSALM 3:3

David wrote this psalm running from his own son Absalom. Betrayal does not come closer than that. The road out of Jerusalem was lined with voices, and they said the cruelest thing a soul can hear: *"There is no help for him in God"* (Psalm 3:2). Another psalm names the feeling exactly: *"For our soul is bowed down to the dust"* (Psalm 44:25). Face down in the road. Written off. Sure that even God has closed the account. You may know that voice. It rarely shouts. It speaks quietly, in your own accent, at the end of a long day: this one is past fixing.

Watch what David does. He does not argue with the voices. He answers them with a name: *"But you, Yahweh, are a shield around me, my glory, and the one who lifts up my head"* (Psalm 3:3). Not a shield in front, where the attack can still come from the side, but a shield around. Every angle is covered, including the ones David cannot see. Then comes the lifter of the head — a hand under the chin of someone staring at the ground, turning the face back up.

Then the plainest miracle in the psalm: *"I laid myself down and slept. I awakened; for Yahweh sustains me"* (Psalm 3:5). A hunted man slept. That is what it looks like to stop clinging to your own watchfulness. You can lie down because someone else stays awake: *"Behold, he who keeps Israel will neither slumber nor sleep"* (Psalm 121:4). Revival is not first a feeling in the chest. It is a head lifted by another hand and laid back down in peace.

The One who lifts bowed heads knows the ground. In Gethsemane Jesus *"fell on the ground, and prayed that, if it were possible, the hour might pass away from him"* (Mark 14:35). At His trial His face was struck and spat on. He went lower than shame could ever push you, down past every place you have been ashamed to be seen, so that no shame of yours lies outside His reach. When the voice says there is no help for you in God, the cross has already answered it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

At the cross the crowd said God would not rescue Him. Christ was laid in the dust of death under real condemnation, and on the third day the Father lifted His head. Because He rose, that lie can never be the last word over you. Let Him lift your face today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What shame keeps your face toward the ground — and will you let Christ lift it?

◆

DAY 4 · JANUARY 4 · PSALM 4

Room in the Tight Place

> *"Answer me when I call, God of my righteousness. Give me relief from my distress. Have mercy on me, and hear my prayer."*
> — PSALM 4:1

The Hebrew behind *"relief"* in Psalm 4:1 is rachav, a verb that means to grow wide or to enlarge. David's prayer is about space: make room for me. Picture a narrow place — walls pressing in, no space to turn, chest tight. Then room. Breath. David asks for it plainly: *"Answer me when I call, God of my righteousness. Give me relief from my distress"* (Psalm 4:1). God does not scorn the request, because *"he knows how we are made. He remembers that we are dust"* (Psalm 103:14).

You know the narrow place. A week with no margin. A conscience with no rest. A bill, a test result, a conversation you keep putting off. The instinct is to shove the walls back yourself — work later, sleep less, worry harder. But room is something God gives. Notice who David asks. A pressed soul cannot widen its own cell by leaning on the walls. It can only ask the One who holds the walls in His hand.

From inside that pressure David hears the crowd: *"Many say, 'Who will show us any good?'"* (Psalm 4:6). Everyone is scanning the road for the next thing that might fill them. David has stopped scanning, because he has been given a deeper joy: *"You have put gladness in my heart, more than when their grain and their new wine are increased"* (Psalm 4:7). A full barn is a good gift. It is not the thing that holds you up when the walls close in.

So the psalm ends in bed: *"In peace I will both lay myself down and sleep, for you, Yahweh alone, make me live in safety"* (Psalm 4:8). The God who makes room is the God who lets a tired person sleep. The safety was never yours to hold up. You can put it down at night and pick the day up again in the morning, because He never put it down at all. Rest is not a reward for finishing. It is trust with its eyes closed. The God who never sleeps is the reason you are allowed to, and the walls that pressed you all day are still in His hand while you are not watching them.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was pressed into the narrowest place on earth. In Gethsemane "his sweat became like great drops of blood falling down on the ground" (Luke 22:44), and then the cross held Him fast. He was crushed there so you would have room in Him. Lie down tonight in the peace He paid for.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you pushing on the walls yourself instead of asking God for room?

◆

DAY 5 · JANUARY 5 · PSALM 5

Morning Voice

> *"Yahweh, in the morning you will hear my voice. In the morning I will lay my requests before you, and will watch expectantly."*
> — PSALM 5:3

One word repeats in Psalm 5:3, and it is easy to rush past it: morning. *"Yahweh, in the morning you will hear my voice. In the morning I will lay my requests before you, and will watch expectantly"* (Psalm 5:3). David does not pray when he gets around to it. He prays first, in the gray hour before the day buries him. Then he watches, like someone at a window waiting for the sun to clear the ridge. Prayer, for him, is not a speech. It is a request set down and an eye kept on the road.

Drifting prayer runs in the opposite order. God gets the leftovers — a few mumbled words at the end of a spent day, after the phone and the news and the list have had their turn. Then the line feels dead and you wonder why. Nothing dramatic happened. A heart just settled, grain by grain, away from the One it meant to seek. That is how most dust gathers on a soul. Slowly, quietly, and usually before breakfast. No one decides to drift. The day simply gets there first, and by the time you reach for God your hands are already full of everything else.

Scripture keeps tying God's mercy to the morning, as if He means to meet you before the day hardens. *"They are new every morning. Great is your faithfulness"* (Lamentations 3:23). Jesus kept the same hour: *"Early in the morning, while it was still dark, he rose up and went out, and departed into a deserted place, and prayed there"* (Mark 1:35). The sinless Son began His day with the Father. If He sought that hour, you need it more, because your heart cools faster than His ever did.

Bringing your voice to God in the morning is not a productivity habit. It is letting the Word speak over a tired soul before anything else gets to. And notice why David dares to come at all: *"But as for me, in the abundance of your loving kindness I will come into your house"* (Psalm 5:7). He does not walk in on his record. He walks in on God's kindness. So can you, tomorrow, at first light, with the coffee still too hot to drink.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The offering David laid out each morning has been made once for all. Christ gave Himself on the cross and rose at first light on the first day of the week. Because of Him you come to a Father who wants to hear your voice. You do not have to earn the welcome at dawn. It is already yours in His Son.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What has been drifting in you during the hours you give to everything before you give anything to God?

◆

DAY 6 · JANUARY 6 · PSALM 6

Tears in the Dust

> *“I am weary with my groaning. Every night I flood my bed. I drench my couch with my tears.”*
> — PSALM 6:6

Psalm 6 does not tidy itself up. David is worn to the thread: *“Have mercy on me, Yahweh, for I am faint. Yahweh, heal me, for my bones are troubled”* (Psalm 6:2). Then comes the cry that has no answer yet: *“But you, Yahweh—how long?”* (Psalm 6:3). His strength is gone. His eyes are swollen. His bed is wet every night. Grief has worn him down to the bone. This is the dust of depletion, where frailty and sorrow run together until you feel yourself crumbling back into the ground you came from.

There is a stubborn idea that God comes near only after you pull yourself together — that you have to be presentable before you are welcome. Psalm 6 tears that idea up. The one who is heard here has nothing left to manage and nothing left to hide. *“I am weary with my groaning. Every night I flood my bed. I drench my couch with my tears”* (Psalm 6:6). Then, with no warning: *“Yahweh has heard the voice of my weeping”* (Psalm 6:8).

Look at the hinge, because the whole psalm turns on it. Nothing in David’s circumstances changes between verse 6 and verse 8. The enemies are still there. What changes is that somewhere in the weeping he becomes sure he was heard. *“Yahweh has heard my supplication. Yahweh accepts my prayer”* (Psalm 6:9). Grace did not wait for him to compose himself. It met him face down on a soaked pillow, in the middle of the night, before anything was fixed. That is still how it comes. Not after the crying stops, but inside it.

This is the God who *“is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit”* (Psalm 34:18). Through Isaiah He says He dwells *“with him also who is of a contrite and humble spirit, to revive the spirit of the humble”* (Isaiah 57:15). He is not drawn to the impressive. He comes down to the dust. If you have been waiting to feel stronger before you pray, stop waiting. The tears are not in the way of the prayer. The tears are the prayer.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

You do not climb out of the dust so God can come to you. He came down into it. “Jesus wept” (John 11:35), was troubled to the point of death, and went into the grave. He rose, and He “will wipe away every tear from their eyes” (Revelation 21:4). Bring Him the wet pillow tonight.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What grief have you kept from God, as if He could only welcome a version of you that isn’t falling apart?

◆

DAY 7 · JANUARY 7 · PSALM 7 (VV. 1–10)

Glory in the Dust

"Yahweh, my God, I take refuge in you."
— PSALM 7:1

David is under accusation, and his fear has a picture: *"let him tread my life down to the earth, and lay my glory in the dust"* (Psalm 7:5). Glory in the dust. Reputation flattened, standing lost, the name you built ground into the dirt of the road. The proud dread it most, and sooner or later everyone tastes some of it. A soul that clings to its own glory is clinging to something already headed for the ground. You can watch it happen in a hard week: the review that goes badly, the rumor at church, the job title that disappears in a reorganization. The ground comes up fast, and it does not care what you were called yesterday.

Yet David does something you would not expect. He asks to be examined: *"Yahweh, my God, if I have done this, if there is iniquity in my hands … let the enemy pursue my soul, and overtake it"* (Psalm 7:3–5). He would rather be searched than safe. Most people run to God the way they lock an office door — to keep the inspection out. David runs in with every light on and the drawers already open.

How can a sinner pray that boldly? Because his refuge is not his own innocence. *"My shield is with God, who saves the upright in heart"* (Psalm 7:10). The shield is not David's record. The shield is God. You can afford to lose an argument, a title, even a friend's good opinion. You can afford to have your name pressed into the dust when your real life is held somewhere the enemy cannot reach. Paul says it straight: *"For you died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God"* (Colossians 3:3).

And Christ's glory went into the dust first. He *"emptied himself, taking the form of a servant"* (Philippians 2:7), and became *"obedient to the point of death, yes, the death of the cross"* (Philippians 2:8). He was accused falsely, stripped, and laid low in your place. Because His glory went down and rose again, yours is safe even when someone grinds your reputation into the road. Let the name go. The life is hidden, and no one can dig it up.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ let His glory be trampled. He stood before false witnesses, said nothing in His own defense, and was crucified between criminals. Then God raised Him and gave Him the name above every name. Hide your name in His today. The Judge who searches you is the Savior who carried your verdict.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What piece of your own glory are you guarding so hard, when your life is already hidden with Christ?

◆

DAY 8 · JANUARY 8 · PSALM 7 (VV. 11–17)

The Pit He Digs

> *"He has dug a hole, and has fallen into the pit which he made."*
> — PSALM 7:15

The back half of Psalm 7 watches someone dig a trap and fall in it. *"He has dug a hole, and has fallen into the pit which he made. The trouble he causes shall return to his own head"* (Psalm 7:15–16). That is how sin behaves. It circles back. What gets dug in the dark for someone else becomes the hole under your own boots, and the shovel is usually still in your hand.

Live inside your own patterns long enough and you feel this in the bones. The bitterness you fed ate at you, not at the one you resented. The hidden habit dug out the ground you thought you stood on. The small lie needed a second one to hold it up. Paul gave it as a farmer's rule: *"Don't be deceived. God is not mocked, for whatever a man sows, that he will also reap"* (Galatians 6:7). That kind of dust does not blow in from outside. It builds up from within, one shovel at a time, until the hole is deep enough to stand in without being seen.

But David is not gloating from the edge of the pit. He knows the trap from the inside, and he ends in worship: *"I will give thanks to Yahweh according to his righteousness, and will sing praise to the name of Yahweh Most High"* (Psalm 7:17). His thanks rest on God's righteousness, not his own. His feet are not on loose dirt anymore. They are on the one ground that has never given way under anyone who stood on it.

Another psalm tells the rescue in full: *"He brought me up also out of a horrible pit, out of the miry clay. He set my feet on a rock, and gave me a firm place to stand"* (Psalm 40:2). Christ went down into the deepest pit there is — the grave — and came up out of it. The hole you dug for yourself does not have to be where you stay. The pit is real. The hand reaching into it is stronger than the walls, and it has nail scars in the palm. Grab it. That is all the rescued ever do.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The trouble that circles back on the sinner fell on Christ's own head at the cross. He stepped into the pit you dug and took its full weight. Then God raised Him out of the grave on the third day. Take the hand that reached down that far for you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What pit have you been digging in the dark that is already giving way under you?

◆

DAY 9 · JANUARY 9 · PSALM 8

What Is a Mortal

“What is the son of man, that you care for him?”
— PSALM 8:4

David lies on his back under a sky he did not make: *“When I consider your heavens, the work of your fingers, the moon and the stars, which you have ordained”* (Psalm 8:3). Fingers, not arms. The whole night sky is fine work to God, like stitching. Then comes the question every small creature asks sooner or later: *“what is man, that you think of him? What is the son of man, that you care for him?”* (Psalm 8:4). The honest answer looks small. A short life under a huge sky, here and then gone.

Scripture does not soften that. *“For you are dust, and you shall return to dust”* (Genesis 3:19). You can feel it at a graveside, on a hospital ward, or on a clear January night when the cold reaches through your coat. You are not large. And yet. The Hebrew verb behind *“think of him”* is zakhar, to remember, to call to mind. When God remembers in Scripture, He moves. *“God remembered Noah”* (Genesis 8:1), and the water went down.

Then the line that should stop you: *“For you have made him a little lower than the angels, and crowned him with glory and honor”* (Psalm 8:5). Dust, crowned. You are not an accident lost in a crowded universe. You are a creature the Maker chose to honor and to set over the works of His hands (Psalm 8:6). That dignity was bent and broken in the fall. It was not erased, and God has not forgotten what He meant it to be when He first knelt in the dirt of Eden.

Hebrews lifts this psalm higher still: *“But we see him who has been made a little lower than the angels, Jesus, because of the suffering of death crowned with glory and honor”* (Hebrews 2:9). The eternal Son took the frame formed from the ground. He wore a crown of thorns before the crown of glory. So the wonder of Psalm 8 is not finally the size of the sky. It is that the One who set the stars in place bent down into a manger, and lower, into a tomb, to lift dust like you into His own honor.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

You are small, and the Maker remembers you. More than that, the Son became one of you. Christ carried your nature to the cross and carries it still at the Father’s right hand. His crown of glory was won through a crown of thorns, and He shares it with dust.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you feel small and forgettable, what changes if you are remembered by the God who became one of you?

◆

DAY 10 · JANUARY 10 · PSALM 9 (VV. 1–10)

A High Stronghold

> *"Yahweh will also be a high tower for the oppressed; a high tower in times of trouble."*
> — PSALM 9:9

David sets out to praise with all of himself: *"I will give thanks to Yahweh with my whole heart. I will tell of all your marvelous works"* (Psalm 9:1). Then the reason lands in the middle of the psalm: *"Yahweh will also be a high tower for the oppressed; a high tower in times of trouble"* (Psalm 9:9). A high tower. Not a hole in the ground where rising water can still find you, but a height the flood cannot climb, built on rock above the river. In David's country that meant a fortress on a ridge, where a family could watch the raiders below and know they could not climb.

This rescue is meant for people at the bottom — the ground down, the pushed out, the ones Scripture pictures with their faces in the dust. It is not for those who already have a tower of their own. If you have built your safety out of savings or reputation or plain stubbornness, Psalm 9 will not sound like good news yet. It starts sounding like good news the morning the water reaches the second step and keeps coming.

The line that holds the psalm together is aimed at trust: *"Those who know your name will put their trust in you, for you, Yahweh, have not forsaken those who seek you"* (Psalm 9:10). To know God's name is to know what He is like. The record is plain. He has not abandoned one person who sought Him. Not one. A drifting soul trusts God in theory and flinches in practice, half expecting to be dropped back into the mud. A reviving soul learns the name well enough to lean its full weight on it.

The tower has a face. Paul says of Israel in the wilderness, *"they drank of a spiritual rock that followed them, and the rock was Christ"* (1 Corinthians 10:4). The high place lifting the oppressed out of the flood is not an idea. It is the crucified and risen Lord, who went down into the deepest water there is and came up, and who now is a refuge for everyone the world has ground into the dirt. Climb. The door is open.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went to the bottom of the flood. Judgment rolled over Him at the cross, and He was buried under it. Then He rose, and now He is the high tower no flood can reach. Lean your full weight on His name today. He has never dropped anyone who ran to Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What belief about God keeps you crouched in the low ground instead of running to the high tower?

◆

DAY 11 · JANUARY 11 · PSALM 9 (VV. 11–20)

He Lifts the Needy

> *"For the needy shall not always be forgotten, nor the hope of the poor perish forever."*
> **— PSALM 9:18**

The second half of Psalm 9 turns to the people the world files away — the afflicted, the needy, the ones at the bottom of every list. It makes them a promise: *"For the needy shall not always be forgotten, nor the hope of the poor perish forever"* (Psalm 9:18). It does not say the trouble lifts by morning. It says their hope has a floor under it that does not rot. And it says who is keeping count: *"He doesn't forget the cry of the afflicted"* (Psalm 9:12).

You may suspect you have slipped into the forgotten category. Too needy. Too slow to change. Too many trips to God with the same ache. You assume He must be tired of hearing it. Psalm 9 refuses that arithmetic. The needy are not God's afterthought. The low place is where He stoops first. David prays from there without embarrassment: *"Have mercy on me, Yahweh. See my affliction by those who hate me, and lift me up from the gates of death"* (Psalm 9:13).

This is the surprise running all through Scripture: God starts in the dust. *"He raises up the poor out of the dust. Lifts up the needy from the ash heap, that he may set him with princes"* (Psalm 113:7–8). Ash heap to a seat with princes. Your need has never disqualified you from His attention. It is the very thing that draws it, the way a cry in the night draws a parent down the hall before the second cry comes. You do not have to clean up your need before you bring it. The need is the reason to come, and the ash on your hands does not make Him look away.

The psalm's last prayer is oddly small: *"Let the nations know that they are only men"* (Psalm 9:20). A reminder of dust. You are a creature, not a god. The day you accept that, the weight of holding up your own world slides off your shoulders. It lands on the only shoulders strong enough to carry it — the ones that already carried a cross up a hill outside Jerusalem and did not set it down.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The Son of God became needy for you. Christ was laid in a borrowed manger, buried in a borrowed tomb, and deserted by His friends at the end. God did not forget Him. He raised Him on the third day. In Christ your need is remembered, and your hope will not perish.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What have you decided you are too needy to keep bringing to God?

◆

DAY 12 · JANUARY 12 · PSALM 10 (VV. 1–9)

Why Do You Stand Far Off

> *“Why do you stand far off, Yahweh? Why do you hide yourself in times of trouble?”*
> — PSALM 10:1

Psalm 10 does what tidy religion rarely allows. It looks God in the face and asks why He is hiding. *“Why do you stand far off, Yahweh? Why do you hide yourself in times of trouble?”* (Psalm 10:1). There is no rebuke for the question. No footnote apologizes for it. No prophet steps in to correct the tone. It sits in the middle of the Bible because honesty is welcome in God’s presence — even the honesty of someone pressed into the dust and sure no one is coming. God would rather hear your complaint than your silence. A complaint is still speech addressed to Him. Silence has usually stopped expecting an answer.

Then the psalm describes what it sees while God seems silent. The arrogant prosper: *“His ways are prosperous at all times”* (Psalm 10:5). The wicked man tells himself, *“I shall not be shaken. For generations I shall have no trouble”* (Psalm 10:6). He waits in ambush for the weak. You have watched some version of this — the one who cuts corners and gets promoted, the bully who never pays, the liar who sleeps fine and wakes rested.

The usual response is to go quiet. You feel the distance and decide silence is the safer reply, as if naming the gap might widen it. So the ache goes underground. What goes underground does not vanish. It sours into a low cynicism that prays less every month. That is a kind of dust too — a heart drying out for lack of honest speech with God, settling into a despair it never says out loud, not even to itself.

Scripture keeps modeling the braver way. *“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”* (Psalm 22:1). *“How long, Yahweh? Will you forget me forever?”* (Psalm 13:1). These are not failures of faith. They are faith dragging the felt absence of God straight into the presence of God and setting it down there. You can ask why He stands far off, and ask it to the God who came near enough to be forsaken for you. He can take the question. His Son asked it, nailed to wood, in front of a jeering crowd.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

At the ninth hour Jesus cried out, “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” (Matthew 27:46). He was truly abandoned in your place, so your sense of abandonment is never the final truth about you. Three days later the silence broke. Bring your why to Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What complaint about God’s distance has been souring into silence instead of being spoken to His face?

◆

DAY 13 · JANUARY 13 · PSALM 10 (VV. 10–18)

But You Do See

> *“But you do see trouble and grief. You consider it to take it into your hand.”*
>
> — PSALM 10:14

The wicked man’s whole theology fits in one sentence: *“God has forgotten. He hides his face. He will never see it”* (Psalm 10:11). That lie lets someone do in the dark what they would never do in daylight. The same lie, in quieter clothes, lets you assume your private dust goes unwatched — that what no one sees does not quite count, and the screen you closed fast enough is closed for good. Most people live as if a door shut is a door forgotten. You lock the drawer, delete the message, change the subject at dinner, and tell yourself the matter is finished.

The psalm answers head on: *“But you do see trouble and grief. You consider it to take it into your hand”* (Psalm 10:14). God is not an absent landlord. He sees, and He takes things into His hand. Nothing has been filed away unnoticed. Not your sin. And not the harm done to you. Both edges of that sentence cut, and you need both of them more than you know. A God who saw only your sin would crush you. A God who saw only your hurt would flatter you. Scripture gives you a God who sees the whole of you.

He sees your sin, so the hiding was never working and the exhausting act can stop. But the same verse goes on: *“You help the victim and the fatherless”* (Psalm 10:14). He also sees your wound — the burden no one noticed, the blow that put you on the ground, the years of carrying something nobody asked about. The God who misses none of your failure misses none of your pain either. He keeps both accounts, and He keeps them in His own hand.

The psalm ends with God bending down: *“Yahweh, you have heard the desire of the humble. You will prepare their heart. You will cause your ear to hear”* (Psalm 10:17). He does not watch from a distance. He leans in and turns His ear toward the low place. The seeing God is a stooping God. The One who stooped lowest knelt in your dust at the cross, where every hidden sin and every silent wound was taken into His hands.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ’s hands were nailed open so your sin and your sorrow could be taken into them. He saw everything you hide and loved you anyway, all the way to the grave. He rose with those scars. Let the One who sees put His hand on what you have hidden.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Would it change your week to believe God sees both your hidden sin and your hidden pain?

◆

DAY 14 · JANUARY 14 · PSALM 11

Why Flee When You Have a Refuge

"In Yahweh, I take refuge."
— PSALM 11:1

The advisers crowd around David with sensible panic: *"Flee as a bird to your mountain"* (Psalm 11:1). Then their reasons: *"For, behold, the wicked bend their bows. They set their arrows on the strings"* (Psalm 11:2). And the question underneath all fear: *"If the foundations are destroyed, what can the righteous do?"* (Psalm 11:3). It is reasonable counsel. The arrows are on the string. The ground is shaking. Fly to the next safe ledge. Every frightened heart has a ledge in mind: a move, a new job, a different church, a fresh start somewhere the trouble cannot follow.

David has hidden in plenty of real caves, and still he refuses. His reason is the psalm's first line: *"In Yahweh, I take refuge"* (Psalm 11:1). When your refuge is a Person instead of a place, you do not have to bolt every time the foundations crack. The drifting soul is always in flight — to the next distraction, the next drink, the next hour of scrolling that quiets the panic for a while. That restless fleeing is its own dust. It settles for husks because it has forgotten it already has a home.

So David lifts his eyes from the shaking ground to something steadier: *"Yahweh is in his holy temple. Yahweh is on his throne in heaven"* (Psalm 11:4). His throne did not wobble when David's did. The crisis that has you packing a bag has not moved heaven an inch. *"His eyes observe"* (Psalm 11:4). The one being hunted is also being watched over, every step, by eyes that do not close. You can be hunted and held at the same time. David was, and he slept in caves with an enemy outside and a King above him.

The psalm ends with the reward that ends all flight: *"For Yahweh is righteous. He loves righteousness. The upright shall see his face"* (Psalm 11:7). Dust runs from ledge to ledge. A child of God lands and looks up. In Christ that face is not hidden from you. You can stop flying, because the refuge you keep fleeing toward has been your home from the start, and He is not going anywhere.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did not flee when the foundations shook. He set His face toward Jerusalem and the cross and held steady while the ground opened under Him. He rose, and He is now the refuge that cannot be moved. Land in Him today. Stop flying.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What do you run to when the ground shakes, instead of landing in Christ?

◆

DAY 15 · JANUARY 15 · PSALM 12

Pure Words for a Dusty World

> *"Yahweh's words are flawless words, as silver refined in a clay furnace, purified seven times."*
> **— PSALM 12:6**

David is sick of words. *"Everyone lies to his neighbor. They speak with flattering lips, and with a double heart"* (Psalm 12:2). He lives in a flood of language that cannot be trusted. So do you. From the moment you wake you are sold to, spun, flattered, and warned — words built to move you, not to tell you the truth. That is the dust of the world settling on a soul through the ear, a fine layer every day until it is all you hear. After enough years you stop noticing it. The noise starts to sound like the truth.

The proud even boast about it: *"With our tongue we will prevail. Our lips are our own. Who is lord over us?"* (Psalm 12:4). Against that flood David sets one thing: *"Yahweh's words are flawless words, as silver refined in a clay furnace, purified seven times"* (Psalm 12:6). Silver put through the fire again and again until nothing false is left in it. God's Word has been through that fire. It does not flatter you. It does not spin you. It has no angle on you but your good. It will tell you hard things, but it will never tell you a false one to keep you buying.

That is why a reviving soul keeps going back to the Word and not only to its own racing thoughts. Your thoughts lie to you constantly — about God, about yourself, about whether you are too far gone. The refined silver does not. Psalm 119:25 prays, *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). The dust withers. The Word does not: *"The grass withers, the flower fades; but the word of our God stands forever"* (Isaiah 40:8).

Notice what God says into all the noise: *"Because of the oppression of the weak and because of the groaning of the needy, I will now arise"* (Psalm 12:5). The purest word in the universe bends toward the groaning in the dust. And that Word took flesh: *"The Word became flesh, and lived among us"* (John 1:14). In a world of voices trying to use you, His is the one voice that has only ever spoken to save.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the flawless Word, tested in the hottest furnace there is. At the cross every promise God made was put through fire, and on the third day it came out true. Trust the one Voice that cannot lie. Let Him speak over the noise this morning.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Whose words have been settling on your soul more than God's?

◆

DAY 16 · JANUARY 16 · PSALM 13

How Long in the Dust

> *"How long, Yahweh? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me?"*
> — PSALM 13:1

Four times in two short verses the same words break loose: *"How long, Yahweh? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me? How long shall I take counsel in my soul, having sorrow in my heart every day?"* (Psalm 13:1–2). This is the prayer of someone at the end of their patience, someone who has waited past the point where waiting feels like faith. The Bible hands it to you as a model, not a warning. You are allowed to pray your exhaustion.

There is a weariness in it that feels like dying: *"Behold, and answer me, Yahweh, my God. Give light to my eyes, lest I sleep in death"* (Psalm 13:3). David is not just sad. He is running out of life, sliding toward the ground, and he says so to God in plain words. No polish. No religious phrasing. No pretending he has made peace with it already, the way people sometimes pray when they want to sound further along than they are. Just the truth about how low it has gotten, said to the only One who can do anything about it.

Then watch the turn, because the turn is everything. The psalm that opens with the fear of being forgotten closes three verses later: *"I will sing to Yahweh, because he has been good to me"* (Psalm 13:6). Nothing in his circumstances changed. What changed is where he set his eyes: *"But I trust in your loving kindness. My heart rejoices in your salvation"* (Psalm 13:5). He did not climb out by himself. He leaned on a love he did not make, a loving kindness that was there before the trouble started and would be there after it ended.

That is the movement this year keeps teaching. Not pretending the how long away, but letting lament lead down through honest grief and out the other side into trust. Lament and song are the same prayer said at different hours. The One who turns one into the other is Christ, who entered the dust of death, slept the sleep of death in a borrowed tomb, and woke on the third day. Because He woke, your how long has an ending.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ cried out in the dark and slept in death for you. On the third day God gave light to His eyes again. Because He rose, your lament has a sure ending, even if you cannot see it from here. Stay with God until the song comes. He has been good to you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What is your how long right now — and are you praying it to God, or rehearsing it alone?

◆

DAY 17 · JANUARY 17 · PSALM 14

None Who Does Good

> *"They have all gone aside. They have together become corrupt. There is no one who does good, no, not one."*
> — PSALM 14:3

Psalm 14 is hard because it refuses to grade on a curve. *"Yahweh looked down from heaven on the children of men, to see if there were any who understood, who sought after God"* (Psalm 14:2). The report comes back: *"They have all gone aside. They have together become corrupt. There is no one who does good, no, not one"* (Psalm 14:3). The first instinct is quick and quiet. Surely there is an exception. Surely it is me. You know your own heart well enough to doubt that, but not well enough to stop hoping. So you keep a private list of reasons you are better than most.

Most people spend years building the case. You compare yourself to the neighbor with the temper, the coworker who drinks, the relative everyone avoids at Thanksgiving, and you come out looking fine. The curve is generous when you draw it yourself. But the measure in Psalm 14 is not the neighbor. It is God looking down from heaven. Under that light the curve disappears. Paul gathers this very psalm into his argument and lets it fall on everyone: *"There is no one righteous; no, not one"* (Romans 3:10).

A reviving soul stops fighting this verse and finds that the surrender is a relief. Admitting it is not the end of you. It is the door out. As long as you defend your own goodness, you cannot receive a goodness you did not earn. The verdict has to land before the gift can be opened. A patient who insists he is well will not take the medicine, however good the doctor and however full the bottle on the counter.

And the gift is there, hidden under the hard sentence. *"God is in the generation of the righteous"* (Psalm 14:5), and for the poor, *"Yahweh is his refuge"* (Psalm 14:6). Then the psalm looks up the road: *"Oh that the salvation of Israel would come out of Zion!"* (Psalm 14:7). It came. It walked out of Zion carrying a cross. The bad news is total, and that is exactly what makes the good news good. You do not have to polish your dust into gold. Christ has given you His.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the one exception Psalm 14 could not find. He did good every day of His life, and then He took the place of the corrupt on the cross. "For him who knew no sin he made to be sin on our behalf" (2 Corinthians 5:21). Stop grading yourself. Receive His righteousness as a gift.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What part of you is still trying to be the exception — and what would it free up to lay that down?

◆

DAY 18 · JANUARY 18 · PSALM 15

Who Shall Dwell

> *"Yahweh, who shall dwell in your sanctuary? Who shall live on your holy hill?"*
> — PSALM 15:1

The psalm opens like a gate with a guard: *"Yahweh, who shall dwell in your sanctuary? Who shall live on your holy hill?"* (Psalm 15:1). The answer is a portrait of a flawless life. *"He who walks blamelessly and does what is right, and speaks truth in his heart"* (Psalm 15:2). No slander. No harm to a friend. No bribe. No lending at interest to squeeze the poor. And this line: *"he who keeps an oath even when it hurts, and doesn't change"* (Psalm 15:4).

Read the list slowly and something sinks in your chest. Keeps an oath even when it hurts. Speaks truth in the heart, not just with the mouth. You have broken promises that cost you less than this one asks. You have said true things with a false heart. If this is the guest list for God's house, the door is shut, and you are standing outside it in the cold with everyone else. That is not a misreading, and it is not God being harsh. That is the point. Psalm 15 is not a ladder for you to climb. It is a longing for you to feel.

The Old Testament keeps raising a standard no one can reach, and it does it on purpose, to bend dusty eyes upward, searching for Someone who can. And there was Someone. The blameless walk, the truth in the heart, the promise kept though it cost Him everything — the whole portrait describes Jesus. Peter says it plainly: Christ is the one *"who didn't sin, 'neither was deceit found in his mouth'"* (1 Peter 2:22). He alone climbed the holy hill on His own record.

Then the gospel hidden in an ancient checklist: He shares His standing with those who never could stand. *"For him who knew no sin he made to be sin on our behalf; so that in him we might become the righteousness of God"* (2 Corinthians 5:21). You live on the holy hill on His record, not yours. The guard at the gate looks at you and sees Christ. *"He who does these things shall never be shaken"* (Psalm 15:5). In Him, neither will you be.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ kept His oath when it hurt. He had promised to save, and He did not change His mind in Gethsemane or on the cross. He walked blamelessly up the hill of Calvary and gave you His place in God's house. Live today as someone already welcomed in.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you still auditioning for a place on God's hill that Christ has already won and given you?

◆

DAY 19 · JANUARY 19 · PSALM 16

The Lines Have Fallen

> *"The lines have fallen to me in pleasant places. Yes, I have a good inheritance."*
> — PSALM 16:6

David borrows the language of a land survey. In Israel a family's inheritance was marked out with measuring lines, and where the lines fell decided a great deal — fertile valley or stony slope, a spring or a dry wash. A family lived for generations on whatever the rope marked out. There was no trading up. David looks at the boundaries of his own life and says, against much of the evidence, *"The lines have fallen to me in pleasant places. Yes, I have a good inheritance"* (Psalm 16:6).

What makes that remarkable is that his life was full of caves, betrayals, and graves. He is not describing an easy lot. He is describing a satisfied one, and the verse before tells you why: *"Yahweh assigned my portion and my cup. You made my lot secure"* (Psalm 16:5). His inheritance was never finally the land. It was God Himself, and God does not get worse with the weather. Earlier he has said it outright: *"You are my Lord. Apart from you I have no good thing"* (Psalm 16:2).

Most people survey their boundaries and feel mostly the rocky parts — what is missing, where the lines fell badly, the field someone else got. That survey always comes out short, because the map of your circumstances does not show the best thing you have. If the LORD is your portion, the best of your inheritance is not inside the fence line at all. It is the One holding the measuring rope, and He does not shrink when the harvest does. A bad year can take the crop. It cannot take the Owner of the field, and He has given Himself to you.

Then the psalm rises into a joy death cannot touch: *"For you will not leave my soul in Sheol, neither will you allow your holy one to see corruption"* (Psalm 16:10). Peter preached these words at Pentecost as a prophecy of the empty tomb (Acts 2:27). Christ came up out of the dust of death, so the psalm's last line belongs to everyone who is in Him: *"In your presence is fullness of joy. In your right hand there are pleasures forever more"* (Psalm 16:11).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Every earthly portion is something you cannot carry past the grave. Christ went into the grave and came out, and God did not let His Holy One see decay. Because He rose, your inheritance is secure on the far side of death. Hold your fields loosely. Hold Him tightly.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where do you keep re-surveying the rocky parts of your life instead of resting in God as your portion?

◆

DAY 20 · JANUARY 20 · PSALM 17

The Apple of His Eye

> *“Keep me as the apple of your eye.”*
> — PSALM 17:8

David asks for a startling nearness: *“Keep me as the apple of your eye. Hide me under the shadow of your wings”* (Psalm 17:8). The apple of the eye is the pupil — in Hebrew, ishon. It is the most instinctively guarded spot on the body. Something flies at your face and your eyelid shuts before you can think. No one has to remind you to protect it. David asks God to guard him that way, without a second thought, every time. Not after a request is filed. Not once he has proved he is worth the trouble. Reflexively, the way a body guards what it cannot live without.

That is a lot for a small creature to ask of its Maker. Not to be kept at a polite distance and generally looked after, but to be held that close. And it is not presumption, because God used the same words first. Moses sang that God found His people in a wasteland: *“He surrounded him. He cared for him. He kept him as the apple of his eye”* (Deuteronomy 32:10). David is only asking God to keep doing what He said He does.

The second picture deepens the first. A hen does not shelter her chicks from across the yard. She pulls the small, trembling things underneath, against the warmth of her own body. Jesus used that very image over Jerusalem: *“How often I would have gathered your children together, even as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, and you would not!”* (Matthew 23:37). The shelter was offered. The tragedy was the refusal, not the reach. His wings are still open. The only question is whether you will come in out of the weather or keep standing in the yard.

So the God this psalm reaches for is not a supervisor watching from a distant office. He guards you as closely as His own eye and gathers you under His wing. And David ends with a hope that outlasts the grave: *“As for me, I shall see your face in righteousness. I shall be satisfied, when I awake, with seeing your form”* (Psalm 17:15). The long sleep ends. You wake, and the face you have trusted in the dark is the first thing you see.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Outside Jerusalem the hen spread her wings. Christ stretched out His arms on the cross and took the blow that would have fallen on you. Because He was struck, you are kept as the apple of God’s eye. Under His wings is the safest place in the world.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you holding God at arm’s length, forgetting that He keeps you as closely as His own eye?

◆

DAY 21 · JANUARY 21 · PSALM 18 (VV. 1–12)

I Love You, O LORD

"I love you, Yahweh, my strength."
— PSALM 18:1

This long psalm of rescue opens with a word David rarely uses toward God: *"I love you, Yahweh, my strength"* (Psalm 18:1). The verb is racham, a word for deep, tender affection; in its usual form it means to have compassion. Here it runs from the creature up to the Creator. It is not a pledge of allegiance. It is the love you feel in your chest after a lifetime of being carried home when you could not walk.

Then come the names, piled up the way you grab every word you have when one will not do: *"Yahweh is my rock, my fortress, and my deliverer; my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge; my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my high tower"* (Psalm 18:2). This is not decoration. Each name is the scar of a particular rescue, remembered and named on purpose. A rock for the night the ground gave way. A shield for the day the arrows came. A high tower for the flood.

When trouble closed in — *"The cords of death surrounded me"* (Psalm 18:4), *"The snares of death came on me"* (Psalm 18:5) — David did the thing a drifting soul forgets to do. *"In my distress I called on Yahweh, and cried to my God. He heard my voice out of his temple"* (Psalm 18:6). The cry of a cornered creature of dust went straight into the ear of God. Not because the cry was eloquent. Because God was listening for it. He did not need David to find better words or a calmer voice. A shout from the bottom of a well is still heard at the top.

Here is the cure for cold, dutiful religion, and it is not gritting your teeth to feel more. Dust does not warm itself. Look back across your own life and count the times you were carried, until love rises on its own. *"We love him, because he first loved us"* (1 John 4:19). Affection for God is not something you manufacture on a Tuesday. It is an answer. It comes back to you when you remember what He has already done.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The fullest rescue you will ever count is this: the cords of death wrapped around Christ, and He let them. He went down into death for you and broke out on the third day. Every name David gave God is true of Him. Count that rescue today, and let love answer it.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What specific rescues from your own history could warm cold duty back into love?

◆

DAY 22 · JANUARY 22 · PSALM 18 (VV. 13–25)

He Came Down Into the Waters

> *"He sent from on high. He took me. He drew me out of many waters."*
> **— PSALM 18:16**

The middle of Psalm 18 is one of the most dramatic rescue scenes in Scripture. *"Then the earth shook and trembled"* (Psalm 18:7). *"He bowed the heavens also, and came down. Thick darkness was under his feet"* (Psalm 18:9). Thunder, hail, coals of fire, lightning. The whole created order heaves — and the entire upheaval is aimed at one thing: *"He sent from on high. He took me. He drew me out of many waters"* (Psalm 18:16).

Sit with the scale, because your heart needs it. All of heaven moved for one soul in over its head. There is a quiet assumption that God bestirs Himself for great causes and important people, and that ordinary dust merits a sigh at most. Psalm 18 says God split the sky to pull one sinking person out of the flood. You are not too small for that. Smallness is not what keeps a drowning person from being rescued. Only refusing the hand does that. Pride says you are not worth the trouble. Grace says the trouble has already been taken, and gladly.

Then comes the reason, the line a dusty soul can hardly believe: *"He brought me out also into a large place. He delivered me, because he delighted in me"* (Psalm 18:19). Not because David was useful, though he was. Not because he was strong. Not because he had earned it or impressed the Rescuer. Because God delighted in him. The whole storm was affection, not obligation. The large place at the end of it is the opposite of the narrow pit he was pulled from. Room to breathe. Room to stand. Room to turn around and see who pulled you out.

This is the same delight the Father spoke over Jesus at the Jordan, and the same delight Zephaniah promised to God's people: *"He will rejoice over you with joy. He will calm you in his love. He will rejoice over you with singing"* (Zephaniah 3:17). And God came down farther than David knew. The Son bowed the heavens all the way into your dust, down into the deep waters of death itself, to draw you out and set you in a large place.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God bowed the heavens and came down in Christ. At the cross the deep waters of judgment closed over Him, and on the third day He came up out of them. He did it because He delights in you. Let yourself be drawn out today, into the large place He has made.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you believe God delights in you — not your usefulness, you — enough to come down into the waters Himself?

◆

DAY 23 · JANUARY 23 · PSALM 18 (VV. 26–38)

His Gentleness Made Me Great

> *"You have also given me the shield of your salvation. Your right hand sustains me. Your gentleness has made me great."*
> — PSALM 18:35

Now the psalm shifts from rescue to strength. The God who pulled David out of the deep sets him on his feet and steadies them: *"He makes my feet like deer's feet, and sets me on my high places"* (Psalm 18:33). The deliverance did not stop at the shoreline. It kept going until the rescued one could stand, and walk, and climb ground that would have broken an ankle the week before.

But the line that should melt a hard-driving heart is tucked in the middle: *"You have also given me the shield of your salvation. Your right hand sustains me. Your gentleness has made me great"* (Psalm 18:35). Not God's severity. His gentleness. Many people assume God grows them mainly through pressure and the hard hand, so they live braced for the next blow. David says what actually made him great was the gentle hand. He had known the hard years. He had run from Saul and hidden in caves. Looking back, what stood out was not the pressure but the patience of God.

This is the heartbeat of how God deals with His own. Isaiah describes the Servant this way: *"He won't break a bruised reed. He won't quench a dimly burning wick"* (Isaiah 42:3). And the Shepherd: *"He will gather the lambs in his arm, and carry them in his bosom"* (Isaiah 40:11). The LORD is not standing over your weakness with a stick. He is kneeling beside it with a splint and a steady hand. A bruised reed is not thrown on the fire, though it would be easier to replace it. It is tied to a stake until it can stand.

He knows your weakness from the inside. Christ took on the frailty of dust Himself, *"one who has been in all points tempted like we are, yet without sin"* (Hebrews 4:15). The same gentleness that bore with His stumbling disciples — Peter sinking in the waves, Thomas demanding proof — now stoops to steady your feet. God does not drag you out of the pit and leave you in the mud. He lifts you, sets you on the high places, and walks beside you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was bruised so the bruised reed would not be broken. He took the hard hand of judgment at the cross so that only His gentleness would ever reach you. He rose, and He still deals gently with the weak. Stop bracing for the blow. Let His gentleness make you great.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you bracing for God's harshness, when His actual posture toward your weakness is gentleness?

◆

DAY 24 · JANUARY 24 · PSALM 18 (VV. 39–50)

The LORD Lives — Dead Rocks and a Living One

"Yahweh lives! Blessed be my rock."
— PSALM 18:46

Psalm 18 ends in victory, but borrowed victory, and David is careful to say so. *"For you will light my lamp, Yahweh. My God will light up my darkness"* (Psalm 18:28). *"The God who arms me with strength, and makes my way perfect"* (Psalm 18:32). The strength is real. It was never self-made. Dust does not arm itself, and it does not light its own lamp. Whatever David could do, he could do because God kept lighting the lamp. He leaped walls and ran through a troop, he says, but only *"By my God"* (Psalm 18:29). Every step of strength had a source outside him, the way a lamp's flame has a source in the oil.

That is the humility of a soul revived long enough to stop grabbing credit. Early on, God's help feels like a boost to your own competence. Mature faith turns it around. Whatever competence you have is itself on loan. Paul puts the question that ends every boast: *"And what do you have that you didn't receive?"* (1 Corinthians 4:7). Forget that, and gifts turn into idols. Remember it, and every good day becomes a reason to give thanks instead of a reason to be proud.

Then the psalm rises into worship: *"Yahweh lives! Blessed be my rock"* (Psalm 18:46). Most people stand on dead rocks — reputation, a bank balance, the proven ability to keep the plates spinning one more month. Each one is dust with a good name. None of them can catch you when you fall, and none will outlast you. A rock that does not live cannot hold someone who is dying. Ask anyone who has watched their savings, their health, or their good name disappear in one bad year.

"Yahweh lives." Your other foundations are real but lifeless. The living God is the only ground still standing on the far side of the grave. Paul named that rock: *"the rock was Christ"* (1 Corinthians 10:4). And Christ named Himself: *"I was dead, and behold, I am alive forever and ever"* (Revelation 1:18). The psalm closes with mercy that reaches past David: *"loving kindness to his anointed, to David and to his offspring, forever more"* (Psalm 18:50).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the living Rock. He was dead and laid in a rock-cut tomb, and the tomb could not hold Him. He lives forever and holds the keys of death. Step off whatever dead rock you have been standing on and put your weight on Him. He will still be standing when everything else is dust.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What dead rock — reputation, money, competence — are you standing on that needs to give way to the living Christ?

◆

DAY 25 · JANUARY 25 · PSALM 19

The Word That Revives

“Yahweh’s law is perfect, restoring the soul.”
— PSALM 19:7

Psalm 19 has two halves that look unrelated until you sit with them. First the sky: *“The heavens declare the glory of God. The expanse shows his handiwork”* (Psalm 19:1). Every sunrise is a sermon without words, preached to everyone alive. *“Day after day they pour out speech, and night after night they display knowledge”* (Psalm 19:2). Then, halfway through, the psalm turns from the sky to the page: *“Yahweh’s law is perfect, restoring the soul”* (Psalm 19:7). Two books, one Author, and you need both of them.

The sky tells you God is great. Only the Word tells you what He has done about your sin. The sun can warm your face, but it cannot forgive you, and the stars cannot tell you your name. That is why the psalm does not stop at creation. The Hebrew behind *“restoring”* is shuv, to turn back or bring back. It is a different verb from the one in Psalm 119:25, which is chayah, to live or to be made alive. Different words, same work. The Word brings the soul back, and the Word makes the soul live.

Watch how David piles up what the Word does. It restores the soul, makes wise the simple, rejoices the heart, enlightens the eyes (Psalm 19:7–8). And watch how he tastes it: *“They are more to be desired than gold, yes, than much fine gold, sweeter also than honey and the extract of the honeycomb”* (Psalm 19:10). That is not someone doing a devotional duty. That is someone who has found the thing that keeps them alive and cannot stop talking about it.

Many people read the Bible, when they read it at all, as a chore to check off or a quarry to mine for facts. Psalm 19 invites a different posture: come to the Word the way parched ground takes rain. Ezekiel stood in a valley of dry bones, and nothing happened until the Word was spoken: *“You dry bones, hear Yahweh’s word”* (Ezekiel 37:4). Then breath came. And the psalm ends with the only right response, a prayer for mercy from the One who is *“my rock, and my redeemer”* (Psalm 19:14).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

You cannot restore your own soul any more than dry bones can stand up by themselves. The Word that restores became flesh. Christ kept the perfect law you broke, died under its curse, and rose to breathe life into you. Open the Book today as someone being raised.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you come to Scripture to finish a duty, or as dry ground coming to rain?

◆

DAY 26 · JANUARY 26 · PSALM 20

Chariots of Dust

> *"Some trust in chariots, and some in horses, but we trust in the name of Yahweh our God."*
> — PSALM 20:7

Psalm 20 is a blessing spoken over a king on the eve of conflict, and it draws a line everyone stands on one side of: *"Some trust in chariots, and some in horses, but we trust in the name of Yahweh our God"* (Psalm 20:7). Two foundations. One is the visible machinery of strength you can count, polish, and park in the yard. The other is the unseen name of God. The difference between them only shows when the ground gets rough. On a paved road the two look about the same. In a muddy field after a week of rain, you find out which one you were really trusting.

Be honest about your chariots. They are not bronze and wheels. They are your savings, your skills, your backup plans, your contacts, the reputation of someone who always has it handled. None of those things is evil. A chariot is a fine thing to own, and a fool to ride into trouble without one. But they are made of the ground, and leaning the full weight of your soul on them is the dust of worldliness — trusting what the earth can make to do what only God can do.

The psalm does not call the chariots useless, only unequal to the load: *"They are bowed down and fallen, but we rise up, and stand upright"* (Psalm 20:8). When real trouble comes — and it comes for everyone eventually — the chariots tip over in the mud. The diagnosis does not care about the retirement account. The layoff does not read the résumé. The one still standing in the wreckage is the one who trusted the name.

Jeremiah gives the same picture with a tree: *"Blessed is the man who trusts in Yahweh, and whose confidence is in Yahweh. For he will be as a tree planted by the waters"* (Jeremiah 17:7–8). Your chariots will fail not because God is stingy but because they were never built to carry a soul. Only the name can. The name the whole Bible leans on at last is Jesus, and *"whoever will call on the name of the Lord will be saved"* (Romans 10:13).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did not ride into Jerusalem in a chariot. He came on a borrowed donkey, went to a cross, and was buried with nothing. Then God raised Him and gave Him the name above every name. Trust that name today. Everything else you lean on will tip over in the mud.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What chariot are you leaning on harder than you would admit out loud?

◆

DAY 27 · JANUARY 27 · PSALM 21

Joy in the Giver

> *"For you make him most blessed forever. You make him glad with joy in your presence."*
> — PSALM 21:6

The king rejoices, and the psalm is careful about what he rejoices in. *"The king rejoices in your strength, Yahweh! How greatly he rejoices in your salvation!"* (Psalm 21:1). There is a list of gifts — the heart's desire granted, the crown of fine gold, the long life. But the gladness under all of it is this: *"You make him glad with joy in your presence"* (Psalm 21:6). The gifts were real. The joy came from the face behind them.

That is the test the human heart keeps failing. You chase God's gifts and treat His presence like wrapping paper — torn off, glanced at, thrown aside on the way to the thing you actually wanted. You want the blessing more than the One who blesses. Then you sit among the opened boxes, a little empty, and cannot work out why the thing you wanted so badly did not do what you hoped it would. The gift was good. It was never meant to be the point. A letter from someone you love matters because of whose handwriting is on it, not because of the paper.

A reviving soul is learning to turn it around. The gifts are good: *"For you meet him with the blessings of goodness"* (Psalm 21:3). But they are arrows, every one, pointing back up the shaft to the Giver. James says it plainly: *"Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights"* (James 1:17). The paycheck, the friend, the quiet evening, the healed back — each one is a signpost, and signposts are for reading, not for living under.

Once the joy of God's presence becomes the gladness under all your other gladness, the gifts fall into place. You enjoy them more and grip them less. You stop asking them to be God for you, which they never could. And the psalm's own reason holds the whole thing together: *"For the king trusts in Yahweh. Through the loving kindness of the Most High, he shall not be moved"* (Psalm 21:7). The king is steady because his joy is anchored somewhere the gifts cannot reach or take away.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God gave the costliest gift there is — His own Son — and the Son gave Himself on the cross to bring you into God's presence. Christ rose and now lives where there is fullness of joy. Thank Him for today's gifts. Then look past them to the Giver.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you been chasing God's gifts more than you have wanted God Himself?

◆

DAY 28 · JANUARY 28 · PSALM 22 (VV. 1–10)

Forsaken in the Dust

> *"My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why are you so far from helping me, and from the words of my groaning?"*
> — PSALM 22:1

These are the words Jesus cried from the cross (Matthew 27:46). But long before they were His, they were David's — the cry of someone so far down that God felt gone. *"My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why are you so far from helping me, and from the words of my groaning?"* (Psalm 22:1). Day and night he prays, and nothing comes back: *"My God, I cry in the daytime, but you don't answer"* (Psalm 22:2).

That should change how you hold your darkest hours. The feeling of being forsaken is not proof that you have fallen out of God's family. It is a feeling His own beloved Son knew to the bottom. When that black tide rises in you, you are not on foreign ground. You are walking ground Christ walked first, and walked all the way through to the other side, where the morning was waiting. The worst night you have had is not a place He has never been. He knows the smell of that ground and the weight of that silence, and He did not walk it pretending.

Notice the thread of faith even inside the cry. David still says *"my God."* And he reaches back into the long history of being held: *"Our fathers trusted in you. They trusted, and you delivered them"* (Psalm 22:4). Then further back, to his own first breath: *"You are my God since my mother bore me"* (Psalm 22:10). Even forsaken, even pressed toward the dust, he grips the record of a God who has never yet let go. Memory becomes a handhold when feeling gives way.

Here is the deepest comfort buried in the horror, and it is the heart of this whole year. Christ went down into the dust of death forsaken so that you never finally will be. *"He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree"* (1 Peter 2:24). He entered your dust at the manger, carried your curse at the cross, and was abandoned there in your place. The forsakenness you fear has been carried to the bottom by Someone else. God will not leave you, not in the night and not at the end.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

On the cross Christ was forsaken so you would be kept. He cried these words into the dark at the ninth hour, and on the third day the Father answered with an empty tomb. Now He says to you, "I will in no way leave you, neither will I in any way forsake you" (Hebrews 13:5).

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you have felt forsaken, did you know Christ went into that exact darkness ahead of you, and for you?

◆

DAY 29 · JANUARY 29 · PSALM 22 (VV. 11–21)

Laid in the Dust of Death

> *"My strength is dried up like a potsherd. My tongue sticks to the roof of my mouth. You have brought me into the dust of death."*
> — PSALM 22:15

The middle of Psalm 22 is almost unbearably specific. *"I am poured out like water. All my bones are out of joint"* (Psalm 22:14). Then the phrase that names the whole human condition: *"My strength is dried up like a potsherd. My tongue sticks to the roof of my mouth. You have brought me into the dust of death"* (Psalm 22:15). A potsherd is a broken piece of clay pot, baked dry in the sun. That is what a body becomes when the life goes out of it: brittle, light, and ready to crumble.

Then the details that read like an eyewitness account of Golgotha: *"They have pierced my hands and feet"* (Psalm 22:16). *"They divide my garments among them. They cast lots for my clothing"* (Psalm 22:18). A thousand years before Rome built a cross, the songbook of Israel described one. God was not improvising at Calvary. Nothing caught Him by surprise. The suffering that saves you was written into Scripture's hymnal long before the nails were forged.

Death is where all your dust is headed: *"For you are dust, and you shall return to dust"* (Genesis 3:19). It is the deepest of all the kinds of dust, the one no self-improvement touches and no amount of money delays forever. Every cemetery you drive past is a field of it, row after row. But your dust of death is not beyond God's reach, because the Son has been laid there Himself. *"For we don't have a high priest who can't be touched with the feeling of our infirmities"* (Hebrews 4:15).

So when you are poured out — strength dried up, tongue too dry for prayer, sliding toward the ground — you are not crying to a God who watches the collapse from a safe distance. You are crying to the One who lay in the dust of death and came back up out of it. That is why the psalm can turn in the very next breath: *"Save me from the lion's mouth! Yes, you have rescued me from the horns of the wild oxen"* (Psalm 22:21). The rescue is already in view, even from the bottom of the pit.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was brought into the dust of death exactly as this psalm said — pierced, stripped, poured out. He was laid in a tomb. On the third day God raised Him, and "it was not possible that he should be held by it" (Acts 2:24). Your grave is not stronger than His.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What does it do to your fear of death to know Christ lay in that dust for you and walked back out?

◆

DAY 30 · JANUARY 30 · PSALM 22 (VV. 22–31)

Into the Congregation

> *"I will declare your name to my brothers. Among the assembly, I will praise you."*
> — PSALM 22:22

The psalm that began with forsakenness does not end in the dust. It turns, sharply, into praise: *"I will declare your name to my brothers. Among the assembly, I will praise you"* (Psalm 22:22). The one who was poured out like water is standing up now, telling everyone within earshot what God has done. And the reason is given plainly: *"For he has not despised nor abhorred the affliction of the afflicted"* (Psalm 22:24). God heard. God answered.

That turn is the shape of the gospel and the whole point of Psalm 119:25. Hebrews puts this exact verse on the lips of the risen Christ: He *"is not ashamed to call them brothers, saying, 'I will declare your name to my brothers'"* (Hebrews 2:11–12). The One who went down into the dust of death came up and gathered a family. If you belong to Him, you are in that family — one of the household He is not ashamed to name. You are not a stray He tolerates. You are family He claims in public, in front of the whole assembly of heaven.

The psalm ends with a phrase that says everything: they will tell a people yet to be born *"for he has done it"* (Psalm 22:31). He has done it. Not you will finish it. Not you might manage it with enough effort. It is done. The work that saves you is not waiting on your next good week. On the cross Jesus said, *"It is finished"* (John 19:30). You do not lift yourself out of the dust. Resurrection grace lifts you, and the lifting has already been secured.

There is a quiet instruction here for anyone still on the ground. The road up runs through the assembly. The one who was forsaken is restored, in part, by standing among God's people and speaking His name out loud. Revival is not finished in private, however much a tired heart would prefer it. Ezekiel's dry bones stood up together, a whole valley at once. Faith grows among others — in a pew, around a kitchen table, in a hospital room where someone reads a psalm aloud to you because you cannot.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The risen Christ stands in the middle of His people and sings the Father's praise. He went down into death alone so that you would never have to come up alone. He is not ashamed of you. Go stand among His family this week and let His name be said out loud.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Who could you stand among and speak God's name with, instead of trying to rise out of the dust alone?

◆

DAY 31 · JANUARY 31 · PSALM 23

The Shepherd in the Valley

> *"Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me. Your rod and your staff, they comfort me."*
> — PSALM 23:4

Everyone knows this psalm, which is why it is easy to read straight past it. So slow down at the turn in the middle. For three verses God is spoken of from a distance: *"Yahweh is my shepherd: I shall lack nothing. He makes me lie down in green pastures. He leads me beside still waters. He restores my soul"* (Psalm 23:1–3). Then the dark valley comes, and the voice changes. David stops talking about God and starts talking to Him, face to face in the dark: *"for you are with me"* (Psalm 23:4).

That change is the whole point. It is in the valley of the shadow of death, not in the green pasture, that belief turns into presence. Comfort here does not come from an explanation of the valley or a way around it. It comes from a Person walking through it beside you. The green pasture taught David things about God. The valley taught him that God was near enough to address, close enough to hear his breathing in the dark.

Look at what comforts him: *"Your rod and your staff, they comfort me"* (Psalm 23:4). A shepherd's tools — one for driving off wolves, one for hooking a stray back by the leg. The Good Shepherd later said, *"I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep"* (John 10:11). And before He left: *"Behold, I am with you always, even to the end of the age"* (Matthew 28:20). He does not send dusty sheep into the dark with a map. He goes with them, a step ahead, close enough to touch.

Many people dread the valley as the place where God will finally be absent. Psalm 23 stakes everything on the opposite. The valley is where He comes closest. The rod and the staff are not back in the meadow. They are here, in His hand, beside you in the dark. And the valley does not go on forever. It runs out at last into a table and a house: *"Surely goodness and loving kindness shall follow me all the days of my life, and I will dwell in Yahweh's house forever"* (Psalm 23:6).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The Shepherd went into the valley of death ahead of His sheep. Christ laid down His life for you, walked all the way through death, and came out the other side alive. Whatever valley you are in this month, He has already walked it. He is with you in it, and He knows the way out.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

In your darkest valley, was God truly absent — or was that, looking back, where the Shepherd came nearest?

◆

DAY 32 · FEBRUARY 1 · PSALM 24

Who Shall Ascend

> *"Who may ascend to Yahweh's hill? Who may stand in his holy place?"*
> — PSALM 24:3

Psalm 24 opens wide: *"The earth is Yahweh's, with its fullness; the world, and those who dwell in it"* (Psalm 24:1). Every acre, every creature, every life you pass on the road belongs to Him. Then the psalm narrows to a question that stops an honest heart cold: *"Who may ascend to Yahweh's hill? Who may stand in his holy place?"* (Psalm 24:3). If the whole earth is His, who is fit to come near to the One who owns it?

The answer is short and it shuts the gate: *"He who has clean hands and a pure heart; who has not lifted up his soul to falsehood, and has not sworn deceitfully"* (Psalm 24:4). Clean hands for what you have done. A pure heart for what you have wanted. No soul lifted up to a lie. Look at your own hands this week — what they reached for, what they typed, what they held back from someone in need. Look at your heart. No one climbs this hill on that record.

But the psalm does not end at the closed gate. It ends with a King arriving: *"Lift up your heads, you gates! Be lifted up, you everlasting doors, and the King of glory will come in"* (Psalm 24:7). Twice the question rings out — *"Who is the King of glory?"* (Psalm 24:8) — and twice the answer comes back. The gates do not open for the climber. They open for the King. The whole psalm turns on who is coming up the road.

Here is the gospel in an old processional. The clean hands and pure heart belong to Jesus. He is the only one who ever walked up that hill on His own record. Paul says the One who ascended *"first descended into the lower parts of the earth"* (Ephesians 4:9). He went down into your dust, down into the grave, and then up through the doors of death. And He did not go up alone. Hebrews says you now have *"boldness to enter into the holy place by the blood of Jesus"* (Hebrews 10:19). You do not climb the hill on your résumé. You come in behind the King.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ climbed the hill outside Jerusalem carrying a cross, with clean hands that were then nailed down. He rose and ascended, and the everlasting doors opened for Him. He went in for you. Stop scrubbing your own hands and walk in behind Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you still trying to scrub your own hands clean enough to ascend, when the King has already gone in for you?

◆

DAY 33 · FEBRUARY 2 · PSALM 25 (VV. 1–11)

The Dust of Old Sins

> *"Remember me according to your loving kindness, for your goodness' sake, Yahweh."*
> — PSALM 25:7

David prays one of the most human prayers in the Bible: *"Don't remember the sins of my youth, nor my transgressions. Remember me according to your loving kindness, for your goodness' sake, Yahweh"* (Psalm 25:7). Old sins have a way of rising like dust when you walk back through a room you thought was clean. A song on the radio. A name in a church directory. A place you drive past. Suddenly you are nineteen again, and ashamed, and the years between seem to count for nothing.

Look at the ground David stands on when he asks. He does not say, forget my sins because they were not that bad. He does not say, forget them because I have made up for them since. He asks God to remember him by a different measure altogether — by God's own loving kindness, for God's own goodness' sake. The appeal is entirely to the character of the One being asked. That is the only appeal that ever works, because it rests on Someone steadier than you.

And what kind of God is that to ask? *"Good and upright is Yahweh, therefore he will instruct sinners in the way"* (Psalm 25:8). Notice the word therefore. Not, therefore He discards sinners. Therefore He teaches them. His goodness is the reason He bends toward people who have failed, not the reason He keeps them away. Later in the same psalm David prays it again, without excuse: *"For your name's sake, Yahweh, pardon my iniquity, for it is great"* (Psalm 25:11). Great sin. Greater name.

This is a freedom many people never let themselves feel. You are not asking God to overlook your past because you have minimized it well enough. You are asking Him to deal with it by His mercy. And He has. *"As far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us"* (Psalm 103:12). Micah says He will *"cast all their sins into the depths of the sea"* (Micah 7:19). The dust of old sins does not get the last word in the room. God's memory of you is shaped by His love, not by your worst year.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ carried the sins of your youth to the cross, every one you remember and every one you have forgotten. God remembered them there, against His Son, so He could remember you by His loving kindness. Christ rose with that verdict settled. Hand Him the old dust again today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What old failure keeps rising like dust that you have never actually handed over to God's mercy?

◆

DAY 34 · FEBRUARY 3 · PSALM 25 (VV. 12–22)

The Friendship of the LORD

> *"The friendship of Yahweh is with those who fear him. He will show them his covenant."*
> — PSALM 25:14

There is a word in Psalm 25 that English struggles to hold: *"The friendship of Yahweh is with those who fear him. He will show them his covenant"* (Psalm 25:14). The Hebrew is sod. It can mean counsel, a council, or the close circle of familiar friends where things are said that are not said in public. It is the word for the kitchen table after the guests have gone home, when the real conversation starts. Not everyone is invited to that table. Those who are know they are trusted.

Sit with how strange that is against what many people assume about God. The picture they carry is a distant authority handing down rules from a height, watching for violations. Psalm 25 says the God who fears nothing invites the ones who fear Him into His confidence. He shows them His covenant. He lets them in on what He is doing, the way a friend tells you the plan before anyone else hears it. The fear of the LORD here is not cringing terror. It is the deep respect that makes closeness safe.

This is the friendship the whole Bible keeps circling. Abraham *"was called the friend of God"* (James 2:23). Moses spoke with God face to face. And Jesus said it to His disciples on the night before He died: *"No longer do I call you servants, for the servant doesn't know what his lord does. But I have called you friends, for everything that I heard from my Father, I have made known to you"* (John 15:15). That was said to eleven ordinary people, and one of them denied Him before morning.

So the psalm prays from inside that nearness: *"Turn to me, and have mercy on me, for I am desolate and afflicted"* (Psalm 25:16). Desolate is a lonely word. It is the empty house, the phone that does not ring, the hospital chair at three in the morning. David does not ask a distant judge for a ruling. He asks a Friend to turn toward him. *"The troubles of my heart are enlarged. Oh bring me out of my distresses"* (Psalm 25:17). That is how friends talk. Plainly, without ceremony, and expecting to be heard.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ called His disciples friends and then laid down His life for them. He was left alone at the end, deserted by the very friends He died for. He rose and came looking for them on the shore. He is not distant. Turn your loneliness toward Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you known God as a Friend who confides in you and turns toward your loneliness — or only as a distant authority?

◆

DAY 35 · FEBRUARY 4 · PSALM 26

Search Me

> *"Examine me, Yahweh, and prove me. Try my heart and my mind."*
> — PSALM 26:2

David invites the inspection most people spend their lives avoiding: *"Examine me, Yahweh, and prove me. Try my heart and my mind"* (Psalm 26:2). This is not the prayer of someone who thinks they are flawless. Later in the same psalm he asks, *"Redeem me, and be merciful to me"* (Psalm 26:11). It is the prayer of someone sure of the One doing the searching — sure enough to open the door and hand Him the keys.

That certainty changes everything. If you believe God searches you to catch you, convict you, and throw you out, you keep the lights low and the inner rooms locked. You sweep the dust under the rug and stand in front of it. You pray around the edges of your life and never through the middle. Fear of being found out turns prayer into a performance, polished and careful and never quite honest, and performance is exhausting, and exhaustion is its own kind of dust.

Watch what makes David's bold prayer possible: *"For your loving kindness is before my eyes. I have walked in your truth"* (Psalm 26:3). He can ask to be searched only because he has God's love in front of his eyes while it happens. The search is not a raid. It is a physician's examination, done by someone who already intends to heal. You let a good doctor press where it hurts because you know why the hand is there. A surgeon who finds the tumor is not your enemy. The search is the beginning of the cure.

A reviving soul learns this change of posture. It stops treating God's examination as a threat to survive and starts welcoming it as a kindness. The psalm ends on level ground: *"My foot stands in an even place. In the congregations I will bless Yahweh"* (Psalm 26:12). Searched, and standing. Known all the way down, and not thrown out. That is what it means to be loved by a God who sees everything. Another psalm prays it the same way: *"Create in me a clean heart, O God. Renew a right spirit within me"* (Psalm 51:10). The search is how the cleaning starts.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was searched more thoroughly than anyone. False witnesses examined Him and found nothing true to accuse. Then He took your record onto Himself at the cross, so God's search of you ends in mercy. He rose. You can unlock every room. The One searching is the One who saved you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What inner room is still locked, its dust swept under the rug, because you fear God searching it?

◆

DAY 36 · FEBRUARY 5 · PSALM 27 (VV. 1–7)

One Thing I Ask

> *"One thing I have asked of Yahweh, that I will seek after: that I may dwell in Yahweh's house all the days of my life, to see Yahweh's beauty, and to inquire in his temple."*
> — PSALM 27:4

Out of everything a hunted king could ask — safety, victory, a quiet night — David narrows the list to one: *"One thing I have asked of Yahweh, that I will seek after: that I may dwell in Yahweh's house all the days of my life, to see Yahweh's beauty, and to inquire in his temple"* (Psalm 27:4). One thing. Not a better plan, not a longer life, not a defeated enemy. To be near God, and to look at Him, for the rest of his life.

Most praying runs the other way. It spreads across a hundred requests — the job, the knee, the kid, the car, the bill — and somewhere far down the list, if at all, sits any desire for God Himself. None of those requests is wrong. Jesus told you plainly to ask. But a soul can pray for years and never once ask for God. It treats Him only as the source of everything it wants and never as the thing it wants.

David is no stranger to fear. This same psalm opens, *"Yahweh is my light and my salvation. Whom shall I fear?"* (Psalm 27:1), and then admits an army may yet camp against him: *"Though an army should encamp against me, my heart shall not fear"* (Psalm 27:3). His one thing is not the request of a comfortable man. It is the request of someone surrounded, who has decided that being near God is better than being safe without Him. And that nearness turns out to be the safety: *"For in the day of trouble, he will keep me secretly in his pavilion"* (Psalm 27:5).

So let your one thing come up to the surface. Under all you are asking God to fix and provide and protect, is there a desire simply to be with Him? To sit in His house? To look? Mary sat at Jesus' feet while the kitchen waited, and He said she had chosen the good part. Start there today, before the list, before the coffee. Ask for the gifts too. But ask for the Giver first, and see what that does to the rest of the list.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the beauty of the LORD made visible. He tore the temple curtain open by His death so you could dwell in God's house all your days. He rose and went ahead to prepare a place for you. Ask for Him first today. He has already made room.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If your prayers were boiled down to one thing, would it be God's earthly gifts — or God Himself?

◆

DAY 37 · FEBRUARY 6 · PSALM 27 (VV. 8–14)

When Father and Mother Forsake

> *"When my father and my mother forsake me, then Yahweh will take me up."*
> — PSALM 27:10

This is one of the tenderest verses in the Psalms, and it reaches a wound many people carry in silence: *"When my father and my mother forsake me, then Yahweh will take me up"* (Psalm 27:10). Some read it and think of a parent who walked out. Some think of a parent who stayed but was never really there. Some think of a father's grave, or a mother's mind slipping away in a care home. The verse has room for all of it. It does not ask you to pretend the first wound was small. It names the worst thing a child can feel and sets God's answer right beside it.

The Hebrew behind *"take me up"* is asaph, a verb for gathering in — the word used for bringing in a harvest or gathering someone into the company of others. Not a roof offered with a sigh. Not grudging tolerance. A deliberate gathering in. Where the first arms failed, the Maker's arms close around the one left standing alone in the yard, and bring that one inside.

Much of how you relate to God was shaped long ago by how you were raised. If love had to be earned then, you may assume, well below conscious thought, that it must be earned now. If a parent's face was hard to read, you may brace for God's moods. If someone left, you may half expect Him to leave too. None of that is the truth about God, however deep it runs. It is the dust of an old house, still settling on new rooms.

Hear the verse as the comfort it was written to be. Jesus said, *"I will not leave you orphans. I will come to you"* (John 14:18). Paul writes, *"because you are children, God sent out the Spirit of his Son into your hearts, crying, 'Abba, Father!'"* (Galatians 4:6). And Jesus told a story about a father who saw his son coming home from a long way off and then *"was moved with compassion, and ran, and fell on his neck, and kissed him"* (Luke 15:20). That is the Father who takes you up. He runs, and He does not wait for the speech.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

On the cross Christ was forsaken by His Father so that you would never be. Every friend fled, and heaven was silent. Then God raised Him and gathered Him home. In Christ you are gathered in too — a child brought inside, never left in the yard again.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

How might the way you were raised be quietly shaping what you assume God's heart toward you is?

◆

DAY 38 · FEBRUARY 7 · PSALM 28

Be Not Deaf to Me

> *"To you, Yahweh, I call. My rock, don't be deaf to me, lest, if you are silent to me, I would become like those who go down into the pit."*
> — PSALM 28:1

David's fear here is a particular one. Not that God will punish him, but that God will go quiet: *"To you, Yahweh, I call. My rock, don't be deaf to me, lest, if you are silent to me, I would become like those who go down into the pit"* (Psalm 28:1). Silence from heaven feels to him like the edge of the grave. A rock that does not answer is just a stone, and a soul leaning on a stone that does not hear is already halfway down the hole.

You may not name it that clearly, but the same dread can run under a drifting life like a low hum. Under the busyness is a fear that you have finally talked God into silence — that the drift, the habit, the long months without real prayer have closed a door you cannot reopen. So you stay busy, because busy is louder than silence. And the longer you stay busy, the more certain the silence feels. Prayer gets shorter. Church gets easier to skip. Scripture stays closed on the nightstand under the car keys.

Then watch the turn, sudden and complete. By verse six David is no longer pleading into the dark: *"Blessed be Yahweh, because he has heard the voice of my petitions"* (Psalm 28:6). And then: *"Yahweh is my strength and my shield. My heart has trusted in him, and I am helped. Therefore my heart greatly rejoices. With my song I will thank him"* (Psalm 28:7). Nothing in the psalm says the trouble ended. What changed is that David knew he had been heard.

That is almost always the shape of it. The silence you dread is often the silence of your own fear, not of God. Through Isaiah God says, *"before they call, I will answer; and while they are yet speaking, I will hear"* (Isaiah 65:24). He was listening before you ever opened your mouth to speak. And the psalm ends with a picture of the God who hears: *"Be their shepherd also, and bear them up forever"* (Psalm 28:9). A shepherd who carries sheep on His shoulders is not a God who has stopped listening.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went down into the pit you fear. On the cross He cried out and heaven did not answer, and He was laid in the grave. On the third day the Father raised Him. Because God answered Christ, He will not be deaf to you. Call today. You are heard.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you been living as though your drift talked God into a silence He never fell into?

◆

DAY 39 · FEBRUARY 8 · PSALM 29

The Voice Over the Waters

"Yahweh's voice is on the waters."
— PSALM 29:3

Seven times in this short psalm the same phrase rolls in like thunder: the voice of the LORD. *"Yahweh's voice is on the waters. The God of glory thunders, even Yahweh on many waters"* (Psalm 29:3). *"Yahweh's voice breaks the cedars"* (Psalm 29:5). *"Yahweh's voice strikes with flashes of lightning"* (Psalm 29:7). *"Yahweh's voice shakes the wilderness"* (Psalm 29:8). It is a storm coming in off the Mediterranean, flattening the forests of Lebanon and rattling the desert to the south.

Anyone who has stood on a porch while a summer storm tears through knows the feeling. The trees bend. The lights flicker. The sound arrives in your chest before your ears have finished hearing it. You are small, and something much larger than you is moving overhead. David looks at that and does not see random weather. He sees a voice, and he knows exactly whose it is. Every crack of thunder is God speaking, and *"In his temple everything says, 'Glory!'"* (Psalm 29:9).

Now set that thundering voice beside the cry of this year: Psalm 119:25 prays, *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). The voice with power to splinter cedars is the same voice that revives a soul stuck in the dirt. That is not a small comfort. If His word can strip a forest bare, it can break whatever has you pinned. Nothing you are stuck under is heavier than a cedar of Lebanon. Not the habit, not the grief, not the fear that wakes you at four in the morning.

Then the psalm lands somewhere you would never predict after all that noise. Its last line is not a thunderclap but calm: *"Yahweh will give strength to his people. Yahweh will bless his people with peace"* (Psalm 29:11). All the unspent power of the storm, turned toward the peace of His people. And before that: *"Yahweh sat enthroned at the Flood. Yes, Yahweh sits as King forever"* (Psalm 29:10). The flood did not move His throne. On the Sea of Galilee the same voice spoke to a real storm: *"Peace! Be still!"* (Mark 4:39). And the wind stopped at once.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ slept in the boat while the storm raged, then stood and spoke, and the sea went flat. At the cross the storm of judgment broke over Him, and He took it to the end. He rose, and His voice now speaks peace to you. Let Him speak it over today's noise.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you hear God's voice mostly as thunder over you, or as the power that brings you peace?

◆

DAY 40 · FEBRUARY 9 · PSALM 30

Joy Comes With the Morning

> *“For his anger is but for a moment. His favor is for a lifetime. Weeping may stay for the night, but joy comes in the morning.”*
> — PSALM 30:5

David has been all the way down, to the edge of the grave, and pulled back up: *“Yahweh, you have brought up my soul from Sheol. You have kept me alive, that I should not go down to the pit”* (Psalm 30:3). This is a psalm written by someone who knows what the bottom feels like. He is not guessing about rescue. He is describing it, still a little out of breath, the way people talk on the far side of a surgery that could have gone the other way.

He even remembers how he argued with God from the edge: *“What profit is there in my destruction, if I go down to the pit? Shall the dust praise you? Shall it declare your truth?”* (Psalm 30:9). It is an honest, almost bargaining prayer. Dust cannot sing. A body in the ground cannot tell anyone what God has done. Keep me alive so I can praise You. God did not rebuke him for asking that way. He answered, and the answer was a life handed back.

Then the line people have held on to in hospital waiting rooms for three thousand years: *“For his anger is but for a moment. His favor is for a lifetime. Weeping may stay for the night, but joy comes in the morning”* (Psalm 30:5). Weeping stays for the night. It is a guest, not an owner of the house. It may be a long night, longer than you thought you could stand. It may be a real guest with real luggage. But it has a checkout time, and morning is not negotiable. God sets the clock, not the grief.

Looking back, David also sees how wrong he had been about himself: *“As for me, I said in my prosperity, ‘I shall never be moved’”* (Psalm 30:6). Then God hid His face and he was shaken. That too was mercy. It sent him back to the only ground that holds. And it ends here: *“You have turned my mourning into dancing for me. You have removed my sackcloth, and clothed me with gladness”* (Psalm 30:11). Not mourning replaced. Mourning turned, the way a field that was plowed under turns green in spring.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ’s night of weeping was the darkest there has ever been — Gethsemane, the cross, the sealed tomb. Then joy came in the morning on the first day of the week, and the stone was rolled away. Because He rose, your night has a morning too. Hold on until it comes.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What night of weeping have you started to believe is permanent?

◆

DAY 41 · FEBRUARY 10 · PSALM 31 (VV. 1–6)

Into Your Hand

> *"Into your hand I commend my spirit. You redeem me, Yahweh, God of truth."*
> — PSALM 31:5

"In you, Yahweh, I take refuge. Let me never be disappointed" (Psalm 31:1). David begins where a hunted soul has to begin — not with a plan but with a Person. He asks God to be *"a strong rock, a house of defense to save me"* (Psalm 31:2). Then he names the trap: *"Pluck me out of the net that they have laid secretly for me"* (Psalm 31:4). Someone has set a snare in the grass, and he cannot see where it is. He can only ask the One who can, and trust that the hand reaching for the snare will find it first.

Then comes the line that would one day be spoken from a cross: *"Into your hand I commend my spirit"* (Psalm 31:5). For David it is a daily handing over. Here is my life, my breath, my next hour. I cannot hold them safely. You hold them. It is the prayer of someone who has stopped pretending to be in control, and found that letting go of the grip is not the same as falling. The hands are open, and Someone else is holding.

The Lord Jesus, dying, made these words almost His last: *"Father, into your hands I commit my spirit!"* (Luke 23:46). The prayer David prayed in trouble, Christ prayed in death. He took a sentence from the hymnbook of Israel and laid His whole life down inside it. Years later Stephen, being stoned, prayed the same way to Christ Himself: *"Lord Jesus, receive my spirit!"* (Acts 7:59). The words have passed from hand to hand down the centuries, and they are yours to pray today.

Notice what David adds: *"You redeem me, Yahweh, God of truth"* (Psalm 31:5). He hands himself over not to a stranger but to a Redeemer — One who has already paid to get him back. That is why letting go is safe. You are not dropping your life into a void. You are placing it in hands that bought it. Whatever you are gripping with white knuckles today — the diagnosis, the child, the job, the future — those hands are steadier than yours, and they have never once dropped anything.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ prayed Psalm 31:5 with His last breath, and the Father received Him. Three days later the Father gave Him back, alive. The hands you commit yourself to are the hands that raised Jesus from the dead. Put the thing you are gripping into them.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What are you still gripping with white knuckles that you could commit into God's hand?

◆

DAY 42 · FEBRUARY 11 · PSALM 31 (VV. 7–15)

My Times Are in Your Hand

> *"My times are in your hand."*
> — PSALM 31:15

David does not pretend he is doing well. *"Have mercy on me, Yahweh, for I am in distress. My eye, my soul, and my body waste away with grief"* (Psalm 31:9). Then, more painfully: *"For my life is spent with sorrow, my years with sighing. My strength fails because of my iniquity. My bones are wasted away"* (Psalm 31:10). Some of this trouble is his own doing, and he says so without dressing it up. Grief and guilt have moved in together and they are wearing him down day by day.

He names the loneliness too: *"I have become utterly contemptible to my neighbors, a horror to my acquaintances. Those who saw me on the street fled from me"* (Psalm 31:11). People cross the road to avoid him. Then the bleakest line in the psalm: *"I am forgotten from their hearts like a dead man. I am like broken pottery"* (Psalm 31:12). Broken pottery is what you sweep up and throw out. It is clay that used to hold something. You may know the feeling — useful once, now set aside, the phone quiet, the invitations stopped.

And yet, from the bottom of it, a few verses on, he says the words that hold everything: *"My times are in your hand"* (Psalm 31:15). Not in the hand of his enemies. Not in the grip of his circumstances. Not even in the hand of his own failures. His times — the hours and seasons and years, the good and the wasted alike — are held by God. The broken pot is still in the Potter's hand.

This is the quiet bedrock of faith: the God who holds your times is the same God who holds your salvation. Another psalm says it plainly: *"Yahweh will fulfill that which concerns me"* (Psalm 138:8). And this same psalm, earlier, has already looked back with thanks: *"You have set my feet in a large place"* (Psalm 31:8). Whatever season you are in, it has not slipped out of His fingers. Neither have you, however far you feel you have fallen. Even the wasted years are in His hand, and He knows what to do with them.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's times were in His Father's hand — the hour of the cross, the three days in the tomb, the morning of the resurrection. Nothing came early or late. Because He rose on time, you can trust the God who holds your calendar too. Your times are in the same hand.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What season are you treating as though it had slipped out of God's hands?

◆

DAY 43 · FEBRUARY 12 · PSALM 31 (VV. 13–18)

Make Your Face Shine

> *"Make your face to shine on your servant. Save me in your loving kindness."*
> — PSALM 31:16

The whispering closes in: *"For I have heard the slander of many, terror on every side, while they conspire together against me, they plot to take away my life"* (Psalm 31:13). David is surrounded by voices that want him gone. Slander is a particular kind of cruelty. You cannot fight it with your hands. It moves through the town ahead of you, and by the time you arrive people have already decided who you are.

But he has already planted his feet: *"But I trust in you, Yahweh. I said, 'You are my God'"* (Psalm 31:14). That small word but is the hinge of faith. The whispering is real. The plot is real. But. There is another fact in the room that outweighs the slander, and David says it out loud, to God, in the first person. Not a general statement about religion. You are my God. Faith is personal, and it speaks. It does not wait until the whispering stops to say what it believes. It says it in the middle of the noise, while the plot is still being hatched in the next room.

His deepest plea is not that the whisperers be silenced, though he asks for that too. It is one thing: *"Make your face to shine on your servant. Save me in your loving kindness"* (Psalm 31:16). He is reaching back to the old blessing the priests spoke over Israel: *"Yahweh make his face to shine on you, and be gracious to you"* (Numbers 6:25). If God's face is turned toward him with favor, the faces of the slanderers lose their power to define him.

That shining face is, in the end, the face of Christ. Paul says God *"has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ"* (2 Corinthians 4:6). When the whispering grows loud, you do not have to win the argument in the town square. You need only look into the face that is turned toward you in grace. The opinions of a crowd cannot outshine that, and the crowd does not get the last word over you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was slandered by many and condemned by false witnesses, and on the cross God's face was turned away from Him. He bore that darkness so the Father's face could shine on you. He rose, and that light does not go out. Look there today, not at the crowd.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you asking mostly for your troubles to be removed, or for the light of God's face?

◆

DAY 44 · FEBRUARY 13 · PSALM 31 (VV. 19–24)

Stored-Up Goodness

> *"Oh how great is your goodness, which you have laid up for those who fear you, which you have worked for those who take refuge in you, before the sons of men!"*
> — PSALM 31:19

After all the distress, David lifts his eyes and almost gasps: *"Oh how great is your goodness, which you have laid up for those who fear you"* (Psalm 31:19). The Hebrew behind *"laid up"* is tsaphan, to hide, to treasure, to store up. It is the word for something put away on purpose and kept safe for later. God has goodness set aside for His people, like grain stored in a barn against winter, like a gift wrapped and waiting in a closet until the day comes.

That changes how you read a hard season. Stored goodness means there is more coming than you can see from here. It is already prepared and waiting. It is already set aside with your name on it. Paul quotes Isaiah: *"Things which an eye didn't see, and an ear didn't hear, which didn't enter into the heart of man, these God has prepared for those who love him"* (1 Corinthians 2:9). The barn is full, even when the field looks bare this year.

And God shelters His own while they wait: *"In the shelter of your presence you will hide them from the plotting of man. You will keep them secretly in a dwelling away from the strife of tongues"* (Psalm 31:20). The same verb idea runs through it — hidden, kept, stored. The goodness is hidden, and so are the people it is for. David even admits his own panic: *"As for me, I said in my haste, 'I am cut off from before your eyes.' Nevertheless you heard the voice of my petitions"* (Psalm 31:22). He thought he was out of sight. He was not.

So the psalm ends as a word passed down to everyone still waiting: *"Be strong, and let your heart take courage, all you who hope in Yahweh"* (Psalm 31:24). That courage is not a feeling you work up. It rests on goodness already stored. You are not waiting on an empty promise or a maybe or a God who might come through. You are waiting on a God who has already filled the barn and is only waiting for the right season to open the doors.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The greatest goodness God ever stored up was Christ, promised for centuries and given at the right time. He was hidden in a tomb for three days and brought out alive. In Him every promise is yes. The goodness laid up for you is as sure as the empty grave.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you believe God has goodness stored up for you that you have not yet seen?

◆

DAY 45 · FEBRUARY 14 · PSALM 32 (VV. 1–6)

The Blessing of a Covered Sin

> *"Blessed is he whose disobedience is forgiven, whose sin is covered."*
> — PSALM 32:1

"Blessed is he whose disobedience is forgiven, whose sin is covered" (Psalm 32:1). David has tasted both sides of this, and he knows which one is blessed. He has carried hidden sin and he has been forgiven. He does not write as a theorist. He writes as someone who has felt the weight come off his back, and who wants you to know there is a way out of the place he was stuck.

First he describes what it was like to hide it: *"When I kept silence, my bones wasted away through my groaning all day long. For day and night your hand was heavy on me. My strength was sapped in the heat of summer"* (Psalm 32:3–4). Unconfessed sin is not neutral. It is a weight that sits on the body. It drains you like August heat. You sleep badly. You snap at people you love. You feel old before your time and cannot quite say why. The secret costs more every week you keep it.

Then the turn, and it is sudden: *"I acknowledged my sin to you. I didn't hide my iniquity. I said, I will confess my transgressions to Yahweh, and you forgave the iniquity of my sin"* (Psalm 32:5). The moment he stopped covering it, God covered it. That is the exchange at the heart of the psalm. You stop hiding, and God hides it for you — not by pretending it never happened, but by dealing with it Himself.

This is the gospel Paul saw here. In Romans 4 he quotes this very psalm to show that righteousness is a gift: *"Blessed are they whose iniquities are forgiven, whose sins are covered. Blessed is the man whom the Lord will by no means charge with sin"* (Romans 4:7–8). The covering is not a blanket thrown over a mess. It is the blood of Christ, which really pays. John promises it plainly: *"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous to forgive us the sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness"* (1 John 1:9). Faithful and righteous. Your confession does not make Him reluctant. It meets a promise He made long before you knelt.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did not cover your sin with a sheet. He carried it into His own body on the cross and paid for it in full. Then He rose, and the debt was gone. You can stop keeping silent. Tell Him what you have been hiding today, and let Him cover it.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What sin have you been keeping silent about, wasting away under its weight?

◆

DAY 46 · FEBRUARY 15 · PSALM 32 (VV. 7–11)

Surrounded by Steadfast Love

> *"Many sorrows come to the wicked, but loving kindness shall surround him who trusts in Yahweh."*
> — PSALM 32:10

Forgiven, David finds that God has become a place to live: *"You are my hiding place. You will preserve me from trouble. You will surround me with songs of deliverance"* (Psalm 32:7). Yesterday he was hiding his sin from God. Today he is hiding in God. That is the whole reversal of the gospel in one turn of a psalm. The one who ran from the light now runs into it, and finds it warm instead of scorching.

Then God Himself speaks, and the voice is tender: *"I will instruct you and teach you in the way which you shall go. I will counsel you with my eye on you"* (Psalm 32:8). This is not the cold stare of a supervisor waiting for a mistake. It is the watchful eye of a parent teaching a child to walk across a busy street, close enough to catch a hand. God does not hand you a map and leave. He walks the road with you and keeps looking.

There is a gentle warning too: *"Don't be like the horse, or like the mule, which have no understanding, who are controlled by bit and bridle, or else they will not come near to you"* (Psalm 32:9). A mule has to be yanked. It will not come unless it is forced. God would rather lead you with a look than drag you with a strap. The bit and bridle are for creatures that will not listen. You have been given ears and a heart that can learn the sound of His voice.

And the promise that crowns the psalm: *"Many sorrows come to the wicked, but loving kindness shall surround him who trusts in Yahweh"* (Psalm 32:10). Not occasionally visits. Not sometimes stops by. Surrounds. The forgiven soul lives inside a ring of God's loving kindness the way a town lives inside its hills. Trouble can still come. Sorrow still comes to the righteous too. But it has to pass through a wall of steadfast love first, and it cannot get out the other side without God's permission. So the psalm ends with a command that sounds like music: *"Be glad in Yahweh, and rejoice, you righteous! Shout for joy, all you who are upright in heart!"* (Psalm 32:11).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was surrounded on the cross by mockers and executioners and the darkness of judgment. He stood inside that ring so you could stand inside a ring of love. He rose, and nothing can separate you from the love of God that is in Him. Live inside it today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you living as one surrounded by steadfast love — or still bracing as though God's eye is against you?

◆

DAY 47 · FEBRUARY 16 · PSALM 33 (VV. 1–7)

He Spoke, and It Was

> *"By Yahweh's word, the heavens were made: all their army by the breath of his mouth."*
> — PSALM 33:6

"Rejoice in Yahweh, you righteous! Praise is fitting for the upright" (Psalm 33:1). The psalm opens with a summons to sing, and not a tired, dutiful singing: *"Sing to him a new song. Play skillfully with a shout of joy!"* (Psalm 33:3). Skill and joy together. Not sloppy, not grim. The way a carpenter whistles over work he knows how to do, and does well, because he loves it.

The reason to sing is the sheer power of God's word: *"By Yahweh's word, the heavens were made: all their army by the breath of his mouth"* (Psalm 33:6). He did not wrestle the universe into shape with His hands. He spoke, and it was there. Every star you can see on a clear night, and the billions you cannot, came out of His mouth like breath on a cold morning. Hebrews says the same: *"the universe has been framed by the word of God, so that what is seen has not been made out of things which are visible"* (Hebrews 11:3).

This is why Psalm 119:25 is no small request: *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). The word that made everything out of nothing is fully able to make life where there is none. If it can hang the stars, it can raise a soul off the floor. You are not asking God to do something hard for Him. You are asking Him to do in you what He did on the first day — speak, and let it be so.

John tells you who that creating Word is: *"All things were made through him. Without him, nothing was made that has been made"* (John 1:3). The voice that spoke the worlds into being took on flesh and walked the roads of Galilee. He spoke to a dead girl and she sat up. He spoke to a man four days in the tomb and he walked out still wrapped in grave clothes. And the psalm even shows Him storing up the oceans: *"He gathers the waters of the sea together as a heap. He lays up the deeps in storehouses"* (Psalm 33:7). That is the voice reading Scripture to you this morning.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The Word who made the heavens became flesh and was silenced on a cross. On the third day the Father spoke Him back to life. Christ now speaks over you with the same power that framed the stars. Open the Book today and let the creating voice make you new.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you come to God's word as mere information — or as the creating voice that can speak new life into you?

◆

DAY 48 · FEBRUARY 17 · PSALM 33 (VV. 8–15)

The Counsel That Stands

> *"The counsel of Yahweh stands fast forever, the thoughts of his heart to all generations."*
> — PSALM 33:11

"Let all the earth fear Yahweh. Let all the inhabitants of the world stand in awe of him" (Psalm 33:8). The psalm widens its gaze from creation to the nations, and what it sees there is a lot of planning. Kings meet. Councils draw up strategies. Companies set five-year goals. Families plot out retirement. And then this: *"Yahweh brings the counsel of the nations to nothing. He makes the thoughts of the peoples to be of no effect"* (Psalm 33:10).

Against all that churning, one thing holds: *"The counsel of Yahweh stands fast forever, the thoughts of his heart to all generations"* (Psalm 33:11). Headlines change every hour. Governments rise and fall. Your own plans for this year may already be in pieces on the floor. But God's plan has not wobbled once. What He purposed before the world began is still what He is doing on this ordinary Tuesday in your kitchen.

That is steadying for a soul that feels the world is spinning out of control. And notice the phrase: the thoughts of His heart. Not merely His decrees but His heart. God's plans are not cold machinery grinding on. They come out of love. The same psalm says, *"Yahweh looks from heaven. He sees all the sons of men"* (Psalm 33:13), and He is the one *"who fashions all of their hearts"* (Psalm 33:15). He made your heart. He knows exactly what He is doing with it.

The heart of that eternal counsel was settled long ago. Paul says God *"chose us in him before the foundation of the world"* (Ephesians 1:4). Before the first star was spoken, before your grandparents were born, before your plans ever fell apart, God had already decided to have a people for Himself in Christ. When your own counsel collapses — and it will, more than once — you can grieve it openly, in tears if need be, and still rest. The plan that matters most has never been in danger. Paul could write it with confidence: *"We know that all things work together for good for those who love God, for those who are called according to his purpose"* (Romans 8:28).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The cross looked like the collapse of every plan — the Messiah dead, the disciples scattered. It was the counsel of God standing fast. On the third day Christ rose, exactly as planned before the foundation of the world. Your collapsed plans are held by that same counsel.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What collapsing plan of your own are you grieving — and could you rest in the counsel of God that stands?

◆

DAY 49 · FEBRUARY 18 · PSALM 33 (VV. 16–22)

Not Saved by the Strength of the Horse

"Our soul has waited for Yahweh. He is our help and our shield."
— PSALM 33:20

The psalm gets pointed about where rescue does not come from: *"There is no king saved by the multitude of an army. A mighty man is not delivered by great strength"* (Psalm 33:16). Then the line about the horse: *"A horse is a vain thing for safety, neither does he deliver any by his great power"* (Psalm 33:17). In David's world the horse was the strongest machine anyone owned. Speed, size, power. It was the pickup truck and the savings account and the pension all at once.

And the psalm says it cannot save you. Not because horses are bad, but because they are too small for the job. You have your own horses. A good job. A paid-off house. Health. A strong back. A reputation for getting things done. Each one is a gift. Each one will fail you if you ask it to carry the weight of your soul. The horse goes lame. The market drops. The back gives out at fifty-five. The strength you trusted is the strength that gets old.

Instead: *"Behold, Yahweh's eye is on those who fear him, on those who hope in his loving kindness, to deliver their soul from death, to keep them alive in famine"* (Psalm 33:18–19). The eye of God is the safety. Not the size of the army. Not the speed of the horse. The watching eye of the One who can raise the dead. That is why the only posture left is waiting: *"Our soul has waited for Yahweh. He is our help and our shield"* (Psalm 33:20). Waiting feels passive to anyone trained to act. It is the hardest work faith does.

The psalm ends with a prayer that doubles as an invitation: *"Let your loving kindness be on us, Yahweh, since we have hoped in you"* (Psalm 33:22). And between the waiting and the prayer is joy: *"For our heart rejoices in him, because we have trusted in his holy name"* (Psalm 33:21). Waiting is not glum. Isaiah promises that *"those who wait for Yahweh will renew their strength"* (Isaiah 40:31). The strength you stop trusting is replaced by a strength you could never have produced.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ rode into Jerusalem on a borrowed donkey, not a war horse, and went to the cross with no army behind Him. He waited in the grave three days. Then God raised Him. Your help is not in your strength. It is in the risen Christ, your help and your shield.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What strength or resource are you leaning on instead of waiting for the LORD?

◆

DAY 50 · FEBRUARY 19 · PSALM 34 (VV. 1–8)

Taste and See

> *"Oh taste and see that Yahweh is good. Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him."*
> — PSALM 34:8

"I will bless Yahweh at all times. His praise will always be in my mouth" (Psalm 34:1). The heading of this psalm ties it to the day David escaped a Philistine king by pretending to be mad, scratching at the gate and letting spit run down his beard. Hardly a proud moment. He had run to the enemy for safety and had to act the fool to get out alive. Out of that humiliation comes one of the most joyful songs in the Bible.

And he wants company in it: *"Oh magnify Yahweh with me. Let's exalt his name together"* (Psalm 34:3). Then he gives the plain testimony: *"I sought Yahweh, and he answered me, and delivered me from all my fears"* (Psalm 34:4). Not some of his fears. All of them. And he points beyond himself to everyone who has done the same: *"They looked to him, and were radiant. Their faces shall never be covered with shame"* (Psalm 34:5). Faces that were hot with embarrassment are now bright.

He looks back at himself at his lowest: *"This poor man cried, and Yahweh heard him, and saved him out of all his troubles"* (Psalm 34:6). This poor man. He does not describe himself as the king or the hero. He describes himself as a beggar with nothing to bring but a cry. And God heard that cry. Then he adds a picture of what surrounds people like that: *"Yahweh's angel encamps around those who fear him, and delivers them"* (Psalm 34:7). A camp pitched around the one who has nothing.

Then the invitation that has fed God's people for three thousand years: *"Oh taste and see that Yahweh is good. Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him"* (Psalm 34:8). You cannot know His goodness from a safe distance, the way you cannot know bread by reading the label. You have to eat. Faith tastes. It comes close, takes what is offered, and finds it good. Jesus said it of Himself: *"I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will not be hungry"* (John 6:35). Come and eat. The table is set, and the bread is free.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the bread you were made to taste. His body was broken on the cross and His blood poured out, and on the third day He rose to feed everyone who comes. You do not have to understand all of it first. Come close today. Taste and see that He is good.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you weighing God's goodness from a distance, or actually tasting it?

◆

DAY 51 · FEBRUARY 20 · PSALM 34 (VV. 8–18)

Near to the Brokenhearted

> *"Yahweh is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit."*
> — PSALM 34:18

"The young lions do lack, and suffer hunger, but those who seek Yahweh shall not lack any good thing" (Psalm 34:10). Even the strong go hungry. A young lion is the picture of power — fast, hungry, built to hunt. And still it comes up empty some nights. Strength does not guarantee a full belly. Seeking God does guarantee that you will never lack anything that is truly good for you. That is a different promise, and a far better one.

Then David turns teacher: *"Come, you children, listen to me. I will teach you the fear of Yahweh"* (Psalm 34:11). The fear of the LORD turns out to be very practical. *"Keep your tongue from evil, and your lips from speaking lies"* (Psalm 34:13). *"Depart from evil, and do good. Seek peace, and pursue it"* (Psalm 34:14). Watch your mouth. Turn from what is wrong. Go after peace like someone chasing a runaway dog — not waiting for it to wander back, but running after it.

Then the verse that has been a pillow for countless aching heads: *"Yahweh is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit"* (Psalm 34:18). Not near to the impressive. Not near to the ones who have it together. Near to the broken. The heart that has cracked under grief, betrayal, failure, or loss is not pushed away by God. It draws Him. And just before that: *"Yahweh's eyes are toward the righteous. His ears listen to their cry"* (Psalm 34:15).

This is the God who became flesh and went looking for exactly such people. In Nazareth Jesus opened the scroll and read, *"The Spirit of the Lord is on me, because he has anointed me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent me to heal the broken hearted"* (Luke 4:18). He spent His days with lepers, widows, tax collectors, and people everyone else crossed the street to avoid. If your heart is broken this morning, you are the kind of person He came for. Your brokenness is not a barrier. It is an address He knows well, and He has walked to that door before.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's own heart was broken in Gethsemane, sorrowful even to death. On the cross His spirit was crushed under the weight of your sin. He rose, and He stays near to the brokenhearted. He is close to you today, closer than the ache.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you believed your brokenness pushes God away?

◆

DAY 52 · FEBRUARY 21 · PSALM 34 (VV. 16–22)

Not One of Them Is Broken

"He protects all of his bones. Not one of them is broken."
— PSALM 34:20

David is honest that the righteous are not spared trouble: *"Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but Yahweh delivers him out of them all"* (Psalm 34:19). Many afflictions. He does not promise an easy road. The life of faith has potholes and washouts and long stretches of mud. Anyone who told you that trusting God would make you immune to hardship was not reading this verse. The promise is not that trouble stays away. It is that God delivers out of all of it.

Then a strange, specific promise: *"He protects all of his bones. Not one of them is broken"* (Psalm 34:20). On its face it is a picture of God's tender, complete care for His own. He keeps every bone. Nothing about you is too small to fall under His watch, not even the small bones of a hand or the ones in your ear. But John saw something more in it. At the cross the Roman guards broke the legs of the two men crucified beside Jesus, but when they came to Him He was already dead, and they did not break His.

John says, *"For these things happened that the Scripture might be fulfilled, 'A bone of him will not be broken'"* (John 19:36). He was thinking of this psalm, and of the Passover lamb, which Israel was commanded to eat whole: *"Do not break any of its bones"* (Exodus 12:46). So this promise of protection runs straight through the body of Christ. He was crushed in your place — *"it pleased Yahweh to bruise him"* (Isaiah 53:10) — and yet kept whole as the true Passover Lamb.

The last verse seals it: *"Yahweh redeems the soul of his servants. None of those who take refuge in him shall be condemned"* (Psalm 34:22). None condemned. Not because they never sinned, but because the Lamb took the condemnation. Paul says it in one line: *"There is therefore now no condemnation to those who are in Christ Jesus"* (Romans 8:1). Many afflictions, yes, and some of them heavy enough to put you on the floor. But not one of them can reach the verdict God has already spoken over you in His Son.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Passover Lamb whose bones were kept whole while His body was crushed for you. He died under condemnation so that you never will. On the third day He rose with the scars still in His hands. In Him there is no condemnation left for you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When afflictions are many, can you rest in the promise that the LORD delivers His own out of them all?

◆

DAY 53 · FEBRUARY 22 · PSALM 35 (VV. 1–7)

Let the LORD Contend

> *"Contend, Yahweh, with those who contend with me. Fight against those who fight against me."*
> — PSALM 35:1

"Contend, Yahweh, with those who contend with me. Fight against those who fight against me" (Psalm 35:1). David is under unjust attack, and his first move is to hand the case to God. He does not open with a counterattack or a plan to get even. He opens by asking Someone else to take up his cause. Then he asks for a word only God can speak: *"Tell my soul, 'I am your salvation'"* (Psalm 35:3). Before any rescue, he wants to hear whose he is.

The attack is real and it is undeserved: *"For without cause they have hidden their net in a pit for me. Without cause they have dug a pit for my soul"* (Psalm 35:7). Twice he says it plainly: without cause. Some trouble you bring on yourself. This is not that. This is the coworker who lies about you to the boss, the relative who rewrites the family story, the neighbor who spreads something false around the church. It is the wound you did nothing to earn.

There is deep wisdom here for anyone who has been wronged. The instinct is to contend for yourself — to nurse the case, rehearse the injury, draft the reply at two in the morning and replay it in the shower. You become prosecutor, judge, and jury, and the trial never ends because you are the only one attending. David lays the whole thing down in God's court instead. He lets the righteous Judge carry it, and in doing so he gets his nights back. Sleep returns when the gavel is in someone else's hand.

This is the same posture the New Testament asks of you: *"Don't seek revenge yourselves, beloved, but give place to God's wrath. For it is written, 'Vengeance belongs to me; I will repay, says the Lord'"* (Romans 12:19). And there is a model deeper than David. Peter says of Christ: *"When he was cursed, he didn't curse back. When he suffered, he didn't threaten, but committed himself to him who judges righteously"* (1 Peter 2:23). He handed His case to the Father all the way to the cross. You can hand yours over too.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was attacked without cause, condemned without cause, and crucified without cause. He did not contend for Himself. He committed Himself to the Father, and the Father raised Him and vindicated Him before the world. Hand Him the injury you keep rehearsing. He will judge rightly.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What injury are you still contending over in your own heart that you could finally hand to God?

◆

DAY 54 · FEBRUARY 23 · PSALM 35 (VV. 8–14)

All My Bones Shall Say

> *"All my bones shall say, 'Yahweh, who is like you, who delivers the poor from him who is too strong for him; yes, the poor and the needy from him who robs him?'"*
> — PSALM 35:10

In the middle of pleading for rescue, David bursts into praise before the rescue has even come: *"My soul shall be joyful in Yahweh. It shall rejoice in his salvation"* (Psalm 35:9). Then a line that uses his whole frame: *"All my bones shall say, 'Yahweh, who is like you?'"* (Psalm 35:10). Not only his mouth. His bones. The praise goes all the way into the skeleton, into the parts of him that ache when the weather turns.

Notice the heart of that praise. God is the One *"who delivers the poor from him who is too strong for him"* (Psalm 35:10). That is the gospel pattern in small. You are not in a fair fight. Sin is stronger than you. Death is stronger than you. The accuser is stronger than you. If the contest were left to your own strength, you would lose every round. The praise is not that God helps the strong get stronger. It is that He rescues the weak from what is too strong for them.

Then David opens his own heart toward the very people now turning on him: *"But as for me, when they were sick, my clothing was sackcloth. I afflicted my soul with fasting"* (Psalm 35:13). He had grieved for them. *"I behaved myself as though it had been my friend or my brother. I bowed down mourning, as one who mourns his mother"* (Psalm 35:14). He prayed for them as family. And they repaid him with evil: *"They reward me evil for good, to the bereaving of my soul"* (Psalm 35:12). That is the bitterest kind of hurt — to be wounded by the ones you prayed for.

This points ahead to the One who loved His enemies all the way to the cross. Over the very people driving the nails, Jesus prayed, *"Father, forgive them, for they don't know what they are doing"* (Luke 23:34). He wore the sackcloth of grief for a city that would reject Him. He wept over Jerusalem. And the bones that cry *"who is like you"* (Psalm 35:10) belong to people rescued by a love that keeps praying for the ones who hurt it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was handed over to those too strong for Him — guards, rulers, death itself — and He let them do their worst. Then God raised Him and broke the power of everything too strong for you. Let your bones say it today: who is like Him?

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you exhausting yourself trying to win a fight you are too weak to win, instead of letting God deliver you?

◆

DAY 55 · FEBRUARY 24 · PSALM 35 (VV. 15–21)

How Long Will You Look On?

> *"Lord, how long will you look on? Rescue my soul from their destruction, my precious life from the lions."*
> — PSALM 35:17

The betrayal deepens. The very people David grieved for now gloat over his fall: *"But in my adversity, they rejoiced, and gathered themselves together"* (Psalm 35:15). They showed up to watch. *"Like the profane mockers in feasts, they gnashed their teeth at me"* (Psalm 35:16). It is the picture of people laughing at a party while someone else's life comes apart. They enjoy it. His pain has become their entertainment. You may know what that is like — the group text that goes quiet when you walk in, the smile that is not friendly, the people who were glad to see you stumble.

So David cries the honest question this book keeps teaching you to pray: *"Lord, how long will you look on? Rescue my soul from their destruction, my precious life from the lions"* (Psalm 35:17). It is the lament of someone who knows God sees and cannot understand why He has not moved yet. He is not accusing God of blindness. He is asking about timing. How long will You watch this before You act? It is a question about the clock, not about whether God is there.

This is faith, not its failure. Someone who truly believed God had abandoned them would not bother to ask how long. The question itself is addressed to Someone still trusted. It is a hand reaching out in the dark, not a fist raised against the sky. And David already sees the end of it: *"I will give you thanks in the great assembly. I will praise you among many people"* (Psalm 35:18). He is asking how long, and promising praise in the same breath.

The God who seemed only to look on was, in Christ, doing far more than watching. He came down into the gnashing and the gloating Himself. Isaiah said He would be *"despised and rejected by men, a man of suffering"* (Isaiah 53:3). At the cross the crowd did exactly what Psalm 35 describes: *"Those who passed by blasphemed him, wagging their heads"* (Matthew 27:39). He was the mocked one at the feast. So when you ask how long, you are asking a God who has stood where you stand, surrounded by laughter, and did not stay there.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ stood in the middle of the mockers. They gnashed their teeth and wagged their heads while He died. God did not merely look on. He raised Him on the third day and put every mocker to silence. Your how long will end the same way.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What how long are you carrying — and will you say it plainly to the God who has stood where you stand?

◆

DAY 56 · FEBRUARY 25 · PSALM 35 (VV. 22–28)

You Have Seen It

> *"You have seen it, Yahweh. Don't keep silent. Lord, don't be far from me."*
> — PSALM 35:22

The psalm turns a corner on a few short words: *"You have seen it, Yahweh. Don't keep silent. Lord, don't be far from me"* (Psalm 35:22). The mockers had said, *"Aha! Aha! Our eye has seen it!"* (Psalm 35:21). They thought they were the only witnesses. David answers: You have seen it too. God was in the room. He saw every sneer and heard every lie. The case is not going unrecorded. Nothing said behind your back was said behind His.

From that certainty he asks God to act: *"Wake up! Rise up to defend me, my God! My Lord, contend for me!"* (Psalm 35:23). And he asks it by the right measure: *"Vindicate me, Yahweh my God, according to your righteousness"* (Psalm 35:24). Not according to his own record, which he knows is mixed. According to God's righteousness. He wants a verdict that rests on something steadier than himself.

Then comes a line worth sitting with: *"Let those who favor my righteous cause shout for joy and be glad. Yes, let them say continually, 'May Yahweh be magnified, who has pleasure in the prosperity of his servant!'"* (Psalm 35:27). God has pleasure in the good of His servant. It is easy to imagine God as reluctant about your good, handing out blessings with a frown, as if each one cost Him something He did not want to give. David says the opposite. God enjoys doing you good. It gives Him pleasure, the way a father enjoys watching a child open a gift he chose carefully.

Hold on to that picture of God. He is not a stingy landlord or a tight-fisted boss. Jesus said there is *"more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents"* (Luke 15:7) than over many who think they need nothing. And Paul asks, *"He who didn't spare his own Son, but delivered him up for us all, how would he not also with him freely give us all things?"* (Romans 8:32). The God who gave His Son is not stingy with anything else. So the psalm ends in praise that will not stop: *"My tongue shall talk about your righteousness and about your praise all day long"* (Psalm 35:28).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the proof that God takes pleasure in your good. The Father did not spare Him but handed Him over for you, and then raised Him with joy on the third day. If God gave you His Son, He is not holding back the rest. Trust His delight in you today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you picture God as reluctant about your good, or as One who delights in it?

◆

DAY 57 · FEBRUARY 26 · PSALM 36 (VV. 1–6)

Steadfast Love to the Heavens

> *"Your loving kindness, Yahweh, is in the heavens. Your faithfulness reaches to the skies."*
> — PSALM 36:5

David begins with a clear look at the inner logic of sin: *"A revelation is within my heart about the disobedience of the wicked: 'There is no fear of God before his eyes'"* (Psalm 36:1). Sin does not usually announce itself. It whispers. It flatters. *"For he flatters himself in his own eyes, too much to detect and hate his sin"* (Psalm 36:2). That is how it works. It tells you that you are the exception, that this one is not so bad, that no one will notice.

Then sin moves from thought to habit: *"He plots iniquity on his bed. He sets himself in a way that is not good. He doesn't abhor evil"* (Psalm 36:4). It starts as a private thought at night and becomes a way of walking in the morning. You know the pattern. What you rehearse in bed, you do by afternoon. What you stop hating, you start excusing. The dust settles one night at a time until the path is worn deep, and you no longer notice you are walking it.

But then the psalm lifts its eyes from the smallness of sin to the size of God, and the contrast is enormous: *"Your loving kindness, Yahweh, is in the heavens. Your faithfulness reaches to the skies"* (Psalm 36:5). Then: *"Your righteousness is like the mountains of God. Your judgments are like a great deep"* (Psalm 36:6). Heavens, skies, mountains, oceans. David runs out of creation trying to measure what God is like, and still the measure falls short.

This is the cure for a soul that has been listening to sin's flattery. Not first to stare harder at the sin, but to look up at the size of God's love. A heart fixed on its own failure shrinks. A heart lifted to the skies of God's mercy is enlarged. Paul prays that you may *"comprehend with all the saints what is the width and length and height and depth, and to know Christ's love which surpasses knowledge"* (Ephesians 3:18–19). And the psalm widens even further: *"Yahweh, you preserve man and animal"* (Psalm 36:6). The God of the skies keeps the sparrow and the stray dog.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The height of God's love was measured on a hill outside Jerusalem, where Christ hung between earth and sky. His love went as deep as the grave and rose higher than the heavens on the third day. Look up from your sin today. His love is bigger than it.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you been staring at your sin instead of looking up at the sky-filling love of God?

◆

DAY 58 · FEBRUARY 27 · PSALM 36 (VV. 7–12)

The Fountain of Life

"For with you is the spring of life. In your light we will see light."
— PSALM 36:9

"How precious is your loving kindness, God! The children of men take refuge under the shadow of your wings" (Psalm 36:7). The picture is a bird again, a mother sheltering her young. The refuge is not a fortress made of stone. It is a body made warm by love. All people, every child of Adam, are invited under it. No one is too far out in the field to be gathered in. The wing is wide, and the shadow reaches farther than you think.

And under the wing there is a feast: *"They shall be abundantly satisfied with the abundance of your house. You will make them drink of the river of your pleasures"* (Psalm 36:8). Not crumbs. Not a ration. Abundance, and a river. God does not hand His people a cup of water and tell them to make it last. He sets them beside a river and tells them to drink. The life He gives is generous, overflowing, more than enough for the thirstiest soul.

Then the well from which it all flows: *"For with you is the spring of life. In your light we will see light"* (Psalm 36:9). Life is not something God hands out from a storehouse, as if He had a limited supply. He is the spring itself. You do not get life from God the way you get groceries from a store. You get it by staying near the source. And light the same way: only in His light do you see anything rightly, including yourself.

The tragedy is how often people walk past the spring. Through Jeremiah God says, *"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the spring of living waters, and cut out cisterns for themselves: broken cisterns that can't hold water"* (Jeremiah 2:13). Dug with sweat, and leaking. Money, approval, pleasure, control — each one dug deep and each one dry by August. Jesus took this very image and made it personal: *"whoever drinks of the water that I will give him will never thirst again; but the water that I will give him will become in him a well of water springing up to eternal life"* (John 4:14). The spring has a name.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the spring of life. He said, "I am the light of the world" (John 8:12), and then He went into the darkness of death for you. On the third day light came out of the tomb. Stop drinking from cracked cisterns. Come to Him and drink.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What broken cisterns have you been drinking from, when the spring of life Himself is offered?

◆

DAY 59 · FEBRUARY 28 · PSALM 37 (VV. 1–7)

Do Not Fret

> *"Trust in Yahweh, and do good. Dwell in the land, and enjoy safe pasture."*
> — PSALM 37:3

Three times in the opening verses the psalm says the same gentle thing: *"Don't fret because of evildoers"* (Psalm 37:1), *"Don't fret because of him who prospers in his way"* (Psalm 37:7), *"Don't fret; it leads only to evildoing"* (Psalm 37:8). It is the counsel of an older man. Later in this psalm David says he has been young and now is old, and he writes like someone who has watched a lot of people burn themselves up worrying about things they could not change.

Fretting is a particular kind of worry. It chews. It goes over the same ground again and again, like a dog on a bone. It watches the cheater get ahead and the liar get promoted and it boils. The psalm says plainly where fretting leads: to evildoing. The soul that frets long enough starts to want revenge, starts to cut corners itself, starts to believe that playing fair is for fools. Fretting is not harmless. It is a slow fire that burns the one who keeps it going, and it never warms anyone.

In place of fretting, the psalm gives a quiet rhythm of trust: *"Trust in Yahweh, and do good. Dwell in the land, and enjoy safe pasture"* (Psalm 37:3). Then: *"Also delight yourself in Yahweh, and he will give you the desires of your heart"* (Psalm 37:4). Notice the order. This is not a vending machine — delight, and get whatever you want. It means that as you delight in God, your desires are reshaped until they line up with what He loves to give.

Then the center of it: *"Commit your way to Yahweh. Trust also in him, and he will do this"* (Psalm 37:5). He will act, in His time and His way. Your job is not to engineer the outcome but to hand over the road and be still: *"Rest in Yahweh, and wait patiently for him"* (Psalm 37:7). Jesus said the same: *"Therefore don't be anxious for tomorrow, for tomorrow will be anxious for itself"* (Matthew 6:34). And Peter: *"casting all your worries on him, because he cares for you"* (1 Peter 5:7). Lay it down. He is not fretting.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did not fret in Gethsemane. He prayed, committed His way to the Father, and walked to the cross. He rested in the tomb, and on the third day God acted. Commit your way to Him today. Then rest. He will do it.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What are you fretting over — and what would it look like to commit that way to the LORD?

◆

DAY 60 · MARCH 1 · PSALM 37 (VV. 8–13)

The Meek Shall Inherit

> *"But the humble shall inherit the land, and shall delight themselves in the abundance of peace."*
> — PSALM 37:11

Psalm 37 keeps coming back to the same quiet instruction: *"Cease from anger, and forsake wrath. Don't fret; it leads only to evildoing"* (Psalm 37:8). Anger at someone else's success feels justified while you are feeling it. The cheater got the promotion. The neighbor who mocks God bought the lake house. The one who lied about you is doing fine. And the anger, left to sit, does not stay anger. It sours into something that starts to look like the very thing you resent.

So David points down the road, past what you can see today: *"For yet a little while, and the wicked will be no more. Yes, though you look for his place, he isn't there"* (Psalm 37:10). Prosperity built on evil has a short lease. One day you drive past the address and the sign is gone. The house is sold. The name is forgotten. *"The Lord will laugh at him, for he sees that his day is coming"* (Psalm 37:13). God is not anxious about the wicked. He can see the end of their road from where He sits.

Then the promise at the center: *"But the humble shall inherit the land, and shall delight themselves in the abundance of peace"* (Psalm 37:11). Not the loud. Not the grasping. The humble. Those who have stopped fighting for their own place and let God give them one. And what they inherit is more than ground. It is peace in abundance, the kind that lets you sleep while someone else is scheming. You cannot buy that with a promotion, and you cannot lose it in a reorganization.

Jesus took this line and put it in the Sermon on the Mount: *"Blessed are the gentle, for they shall inherit the earth"* (Matthew 5:5). And He lived it. He was gentle in a world that mocked gentleness. He did not grab His rights. He let them be taken from Him, all the way to the cross. And God gave Him the whole earth as His inheritance. In Him the humble do inherit. The question is whether you will trade the hot coal of resentment for a share in what He has already won.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was the humblest person who ever lived, and He let the proud nail Him to a cross. They seemed to win. Then God raised Him and gave Him the nations as His inheritance. Lay down your anger today. The land belongs to the humble, and the humble belong to Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where is anger at someone else's success poisoning you — and could you trade it for the peace God gives the humble?

◆

DAY 61 · MARCH 2 · PSALM 37 (VV. 14–20)

Better Is a Little

> *"Better is a little that the righteous has, than the abundance of many wicked."*
> — PSALM 37:16

"The wicked have drawn out the sword, and have bent their bow, to cast down the poor and needy" (Psalm 37:14). The psalm does not pretend the strong are harmless. Some people get ahead by pushing others down. They use the weight they have — money, position, connections — to take what belongs to the weak. You have probably seen it at work, or in a courtroom, or in a family fight over an estate. And then: *"Their sword shall enter into their own heart. Their bows shall be broken"* (Psalm 37:15). What they aimed outward turns inward, and the harm comes home.

Then the line that turns the whole economy upside down: *"Better is a little that the righteous has, than the abundance of many wicked"* (Psalm 37:16). A little, held with God, is worth more than a pile held without Him. That is not the math you are taught. Every ad you see says more is better. Bigger house, newer truck, longer vacation. Psalm 37 says a small table with God at it beats a banquet where He is not welcome.

Proverbs says it the same way: *"Better is little, with the fear of Yahweh, than great treasure with trouble"* (Proverbs 15:16). And Jesus said it sharper: *"Beware! Keep yourselves from covetousness, for a man's life doesn't consist of the abundance of the things which he possesses"* (Luke 12:15). Your life is not your inventory. It is not measured by what fits in the garage. The psalm is not praising poverty. It is telling you where life actually comes from, and it is not the store.

And it tells you what God does with the little: *"For the arms of the wicked shall be broken, but Yahweh upholds the righteous"* (Psalm 37:17). *"In the days of famine they shall be satisfied"* (Psalm 37:19). God holds up the one with little. In hard years the righteous still eat. Paul learned this in a prison cell: *"I have learned in whatever state I am, to be content in it"* (Philippians 4:11). Contentment is not a feeling you wait for. It is a secret learned by someone who has found God enough.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ, though rich, became poor for you — born in a stall, buried in a borrowed tomb. Through His poverty you were made rich. He rose and now owns everything. A little with Him is more than the world with Him missing. Count what you have in Christ today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you measuring your life by what you lack instead of by what you have in God?

◆

DAY 62 · MARCH 3 · PSALM 37 (VV. 21–27)

Though He Fall

> *“Though he stumble, he shall not fall, for Yahweh holds him up with his hand.”*
> — PSALM 37:24

“A man’s steps are established by Yahweh. He delights in his way” (Psalm 37:23). The picture is someone walking a hard road, and God is not only watching the walk. He is setting each step. He likes the way. Not a perfect way, but a way that is His. That alone is worth a long pause. The God of the universe takes pleasure in the ordinary steps of someone who belongs to Him — the walk to the mailbox, the drive to work, the long climb up a hospital stairwell.

Then the promise that has kept a lot of people from giving up: *“Though he stumble, he shall not fall, for Yahweh holds him up with his hand”* (Psalm 37:24). Stumble — yes. The psalm assumes it. Believers trip. They miss a step. They sin, sometimes badly. But stumbling is not the same as falling flat and staying there. The hand that holds you does not let go when your foot slips. It tightens. A parent holding a toddler’s hand on an icy sidewalk does not let go at the first slip. That is when the grip matters most.

You may fear that one stumble in your faith means you are finished. You blew it again. You said the thing, went back to the habit, lost your temper in front of the kids. And a voice says: that is it, you are done. Psalm 37 answers that voice. Jesus answered it too. He told Peter on the night of his denial: *“I prayed for you, that your faith wouldn’t fail. You, when once you have turned again, establish your brothers”* (Luke 22:31–32). Jesus knew Peter would stumble. He had already prayed him back up.

David speaks as an old man here: *“I have been young, and now am old, yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken, nor his children begging for bread”* (Psalm 37:25). A lifetime of watching, and he has not seen God drop one of His own. Jude closes his letter with the same confidence: *“Now to him who is able to keep them from stumbling, and to present you faultless before the presence of his glory in great joy”* (Jude 1:24). The keeping is His. Your stumble is not stronger than His hand.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ fell under the weight of the cross on the road to Golgotha, and He did not stay down. He went all the way to death for you and rose on the third day. He holds you with the same hand that held the nails. Your stumble today does not loosen His grip.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you feared that a stumble in your faith means you are finished?

◆

DAY 63 · MARCH 4 · PSALM 37 (VV. 28–33)

The LORD Loves Justice

> *"For Yahweh loves justice, and doesn't forsake his saints."*
> — PSALM 37:28

"For Yahweh loves justice, and doesn't forsake his saints. They are preserved forever" (Psalm 37:28). Justice and keeping are in the same sentence. God loves what is right, and because He loves what is right, He will not abandon His people. That may surprise you. Many people fear God's justice as the thing that will finally catch them. Psalm 37 treats His justice as the reason He will never leave you. The same love of what is right that condemns evil also keeps faith with His people.

Then the psalm describes the person God keeps: *"The mouth of the righteous talks of wisdom. His tongue speaks justice. The law of his God is in his heart. None of his steps shall slide"* (Psalm 37:30–31). The law is not only on a wall or in a book. It is in the heart. That is why the steps hold. A person whose heart has been changed walks differently, slowly at first, then with more confidence each year, not because of a rule taped to the fridge but because of what has been written inside.

There is danger too: *"The wicked watch the righteous, and seek to kill him"* (Psalm 37:32). Someone is watching for you to fall. And then the reassurance: *"Yahweh will not leave him in his hand, nor condemn him when he is judged"* (Psalm 37:33). The enemy may grab you. He will not keep you. The court may sit. It will not condemn you. You can stand in the dock and know the verdict is already settled in your favor. No new evidence can reopen a case the Judge has closed.

How can a holy God who loves justice refuse to condemn sinners? Only because justice was done somewhere else. Paul asks the question this psalm raises: *"Who could bring a charge against God's chosen ones? It is God who justifies. Who is he who condemns? It is Christ who died, yes rather, who was raised from the dead, who is at the right hand of God, who also makes intercession for us"* (Romans 8:33–34). The justice God loves was satisfied at the cross. That is why it now protects you instead of threatening you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God's love of justice was poured out on Christ at the cross. He took the full verdict against your sin. Then God raised Him and seated Him at His right hand, where He prays for you. Because justice has been done, you will not be condemned when you are judged.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you fear God's justice as a threat, or rest in it as the reason He will never forsake you?

◆

DAY 64 · MARCH 5 · PSALM 37 (VV. 34–40)

Salvation Is From the LORD

> *"But the salvation of the righteous is from Yahweh. He is their stronghold in the time of trouble."*
> — PSALM 37:39

Psalm 37 ends where it began, with waiting: *"Wait for Yahweh, and keep his way, and he will exalt you to inherit the land"* (Psalm 37:34). Wait and keep. Not rush and grab. Not worry and scheme. The psalm has spent forty verses telling you not to fret about the wicked, and it closes by telling you what to do instead. Stay on His road. Let Him lift you when it is time. Waiting is not wasted. It is trust learning to keep still.

Then a scene David has watched with his own eyes: *"I have seen the wicked in great power, spreading himself like a green tree in its native soil. But he passed away, and behold, he was not. Yes, I sought him, but he could not be found"* (Psalm 37:35–36). A big tree, green and spreading. And then a stump. Then not even that. You have seen it too — the name everyone feared ten years ago that no one now remembers. The company that bought out the town and then went bankrupt. The bully who peaked in high school.

Against that, one more line about the righteous: *"Mark the perfect man, and see the upright, for there is a future for the man of peace"* (Psalm 37:37). The wicked have a past. The righteous have a future. It may not look that way on any given Tuesday. The bank account may say otherwise. But the long view belongs to the one who trusts God. And then the sentence that holds it all up: *"But the salvation of the righteous is from Yahweh. He is their stronghold in the time of trouble"* (Psalm 37:39).

Salvation is from the LORD. Not from your planning. Not from your savings, your strategy, or your stubbornness. Jonah learned that in the belly of a fish: *"Salvation belongs to Yahweh"* (Jonah 2:9). And Psalm 37 closes with a promise to those who have stopped trying to save themselves: *"Yahweh helps them and rescues them. He rescues them from the wicked and saves them, because they have taken refuge in him"* (Psalm 37:40). Not because they were strong. Because they ran to Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Salvation is from the LORD, and it has a name. Christ came down to rescue those who could not rescue themselves. He was cut down like a green tree at the cross and rose on the third day with a future no one can take. Take refuge in Him today. Your future is held there.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you trying to secure your own future, or waiting on the LORD whose salvation is sure?

◆

DAY 65 · MARCH 6 · PSALM 38 (VV. 1–7)

The Weight of Sin

> *"For my iniquities have gone over my head. As a heavy burden, they are too heavy for me."*
> — PSALM 38:4

Psalm 38 is one of the hardest prayers in the Bible to read slowly. David is sick, in pain, and he knows why: *"There is no soundness in my flesh because of your indignation, neither is there any health in my bones because of my sin"* (Psalm 38:3). He does not blame the weather or his enemies or bad luck. He names his own sin. Body and soul are both aching, and he connects the two without flinching or excuse.

Then the image that gives the day its name: *"For my iniquities have gone over my head. As a heavy burden, they are too heavy for me"* (Psalm 38:4). Over his head, like water rising past a drowning man. And heavy, like a load he cannot carry even one more step. You may know that weight. It sits on your chest at night. The secret that has grown heavier every year you keep it. The pattern you promised to stop and did not. The guilt you explain to yourself every night and still carry every morning.

He goes on: *"My wounds are loathsome and corrupt because of my foolishness. I am in pain and bowed down greatly. I go mourning all day long"* (Psalm 38:5–6). Bowed down. That is the dust again. The soul pressed toward the ground by the weight of what it has done. There is no attempt to look good here. No spin. Just the plain truth of what sin does when it is left on your back, day after day, until the spine bends under it.

This psalm does not tell you to carry the load better, or to get stronger so it feels lighter. It tells you to bring it. And Scripture tells you where it was finally carried: *"All we like sheep have gone astray. Everyone has turned to his own way; and Yahweh has laid on him the iniquity of us all"* (Isaiah 53:6). On Him. The burden too heavy for you was laid on Christ. Paul says, *"Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law, having become a curse for us"* (Galatians 3:13). Stop explaining your guilt. Hand it over to Him now.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The load that went over your head went over Christ's head at the cross. God laid on Him the iniquity of all His people, and He carried it to the grave. On the third day He rose without it. You do not have to carry your guilt one more step. Put it down at His feet.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What guilt have you been trying to carry or explain away that you could finally lay on Christ?

◆

DAY 66 · MARCH 7 · PSALM 38 (VV. 8–15)

For You, O LORD, Do I Wait

> *"For I hope in you, Yahweh. You will answer, Lord my God."*
> — PSALM 38:15

"I am faint and severely bruised. I have groaned by reason of the anguish of my heart" (Psalm 38:8). David is in pieces, and he says so. Then a line that is a strange comfort: *"Lord, all my desire is before you. My groaning is not hidden from you"* (Psalm 38:9). He has no words left, only groaning, and God hears even that. Paul says the Spirit does the same: *"the Spirit himself makes intercession for us with groanings which can't be uttered"* (Romans 8:26).

Then the loneliness: *"My lovers and my friends stand aloof from my plague. My kinsmen stand far away"* (Psalm 38:11). When you are sick, or ashamed, or both, people drift. They do not mean to. They just do not know what to say, so they say nothing, and the nothing gets loud. The phone stops ringing. The casseroles stop coming. You notice who stays. And while the friends step back, the enemies step forward: *"They also who seek after my life lay snares. Those who seek my hurt speak mischievous things"* (Psalm 38:12).

What does David do? He goes quiet toward people and loud toward God: *"But I, as a deaf man, don't hear. I am as a mute man who doesn't open his mouth"* (Psalm 38:13). He stops defending himself to everyone who has an opinion. He does not argue his case in the town square or on the phone. And then he says why: *"For I hope in you, Yahweh. You will answer, Lord my God"* (Psalm 38:15). He does not need to answer them because God is going to answer him.

That is a hard and freeing thing to learn. You do not have to win every argument about yourself. You do not have to explain your lowest season to every person who misreads it. You can be silent before people because you are not silent before God. And One went before you in that silence: *"He was oppressed, yet when he was afflicted he didn't open his mouth. As a lamb that is led to the slaughter"* (Isaiah 53:7). Christ was silent before His accusers, and the Father answered Him with an empty tomb.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ stood silent before Pilate and Herod and the crowd. He did not defend Himself. His friends stood far away. He waited for His Father to answer, and on the third day the answer came. You can stop defending your case to everyone. The LORD will answer you too.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

In your lowest place, are you exhausting yourself defending your case to others instead of waiting on God?

◆

DAY 67 · MARCH 8 · PSALM 38 (VV. 16–22)

Do Not Forsake Me

"Don't forsake me, Yahweh. My God, don't be far from me."
— PSALM 38:21

The psalm closes with David at the edge: *"For I am ready to fall. My pain is continually before me"* (Psalm 38:17). He is one step from collapse, and he knows it. The pain never leaves his sight. He wakes up to it and goes to bed with it. And he knows people are waiting for him to go down: *"Don't let them gloat over me, or exalt themselves over me when my foot slips"* (Psalm 38:16). Some people would enjoy watching him fall.

Then the clean confession, the turning point of the whole psalm: *"For I will declare my iniquity. I will be sorry for my sin"* (Psalm 38:18). No excuses. No but. No it was not really my fault. He names it plainly, he grieves it, and he says it out loud to God. That is what confession is. Not a performance of guilt, not a long session of self-hatred, but a plain telling of the truth to the only One who can do anything with it.

The enemies are still there: *"But my enemies are vigorous and many. Those who hate me without reason are numerous"* (Psalm 38:19). Confession does not make every problem disappear. But it changes who David is leaning on. And then the last cry: *"Don't forsake me, Yahweh. My God, don't be far from me. Hurry to help me, Lord, my salvation"* (Psalm 38:21–22). A sinner who has just confessed asks God to stay close, and expects that He will. That is the right instinct. Sin makes you want to hide from God. Confession sends you running toward Him.

Notice the last name he gives God: my salvation. Not my judge, though God is judge of all the earth. Not my accuser. My salvation. David has just told God the worst about himself, and he ends by calling God the One who saves him. That is the gospel. You bring your sin to God, and you find not a wall but a Savior. Hebrews says He has promised, *"I will in no way leave you, neither will I in any way forsake you"* (Hebrews 13:5). Confess, and stay close. He is not going anywhere.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

On the cross Christ cried out to a God who seemed far away, and He was forsaken in your place. Because He was forsaken, you never will be. He rose, and He stays near to everyone who brings Him their sin. Confess it plainly today, and find Him close.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you make the clean confession David makes — owning your sin without excuse — and still believe God stays near?

◆

DAY 68 · MARCH 9 · PSALM 39 (VV. 1–6)

A Few Handbreadths

> *"Behold, you have made my days hand widths. My lifetime is as nothing before you."*
> — PSALM 39:5

David starts Psalm 39 by trying to keep his mouth shut: *"I will watch my ways, so that I don't sin with my tongue. I will keep my mouth with a bridle while the wicked is before me"* (Psalm 39:1). He holds it in. He says nothing, *"even from good"* (Psalm 39:2). But silence does not cool him. It heats him up: *"My heart was hot within me. While I meditated, the fire burned"* (Psalm 39:3). Finally the words come out, and they are not what you would expect from an angry man. They are a prayer about how short life is.

"Yahweh, show me my end, what is the measure of my days. Let me know how frail I am" (Psalm 39:4). He asks God to show him his own frailty. Most people spend a great deal of energy avoiding that question. They do not want to know the measure of their days. They would rather not think about the end at all. David asks to see it clearly, because he suspects that seeing it will change how he lives the days he has left.

And God shows him: *"Behold, you have made my days hand widths. My lifetime is as nothing before you"* (Psalm 39:5). A hand width is the span of four fingers laid flat. That is how God measures a human life. Not miles. Not acres. A few hand widths. James says the same thing in a different picture: *"For what is your life? For you are a vapor that appears for a little time, and then vanishes away"* (James 4:14). Breath on a cold window. There, and then gone.

Then the line that should stop a busy person in their tracks: *"Surely every man walks like a shadow. Surely they busy themselves in vain. He heaps up, and doesn't know who shall gather"* (Psalm 39:6). You pile it up — money, projects, plans — and someone else will sort through it after the funeral. That is not meant to depress you. It is meant to wake you. Moses prayed, *"So teach us to count our days, that we may gain a heart of wisdom"* (Psalm 90:12). And David turns to the only sure thing: *"Now, Lord, what do I wait for? My hope is in you"* (Psalm 39:7).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ took on a life of a few hand widths. He lived about thirty-three years and died young on a cross. But death could not hold Him, and He rose with a life that does not end. Your few hand widths are held by the One who has eternity in His hands. Hope in Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What would change if you let yourself reckon plainly with how short your life is?

◆

DAY 69 · MARCH 10 · PSALM 39 (VV. 7–13)

A Passing Guest

> *"Hear my prayer, Yahweh, and give ear to my cry. Don't be silent at my tears. For I am a stranger with you, a foreigner, as all my fathers were."*
> — PSALM 39:12

The second half of Psalm 39 is a prayer from someone who has seen how brief life is and is now asking for mercy: *"Deliver me from all my transgressions. Don't make me the reproach of the foolish"* (Psalm 39:8). He knows his sins. He knows his days are short. He asks God to deal with both. There is no bargaining, no promise to do better next time. Just a plain request from a frail creature to the God who made him.

He also knows that some of what he is suffering comes from God's hand: *"Remove your scourge away from me. I am overcome by the blow of your hand"* (Psalm 39:10). Then a sad and true picture: *"When you rebuke and correct man for iniquity, you consume his wealth like a moth"* (Psalm 39:11). A moth works quietly in the closet. You do not notice until you pull out the coat in November and find holes. That is how fast earthly treasure goes when God lifts His hand from it.

Then the line that names the whole human condition: *"Hear my prayer, Yahweh, and give ear to my cry. Don't be silent at my tears. For I am a stranger with you, a foreigner, as all my fathers were"* (Psalm 39:12). A stranger. A foreigner. Someone passing through. David is a king, and he calls himself a guest. He owns land, and he knows he is only staying the night. That is not despair. It is honesty about what this life is, and it frees him to hold it with an open hand.

Hebrews says the faithful all lived that way: *"These all died in faith, not having received the promises, but having seen them and embraced them from afar, and having confessed that they were strangers and pilgrims on the earth"* (Hebrews 11:13). Peter calls believers *"foreigners and pilgrims"* (1 Peter 2:11). And Paul says where home really is: *"For our citizenship is in heaven, from where we also wait for a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ"* (Philippians 3:20). You are a guest here. That is why you do not have to sink every root into ground you will leave.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was a stranger in His own world — born away from home, with nowhere to lay His head, rejected by His own people. He died outside the city gate and rose to prepare a place for you. Hold this world loosely today. A room is ready in His Father's house.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where have you been sinking permanent roots into passing ground, forgetting you are a guest here?

◆

DAY 70 · MARCH 11 · PSALM 40 (VV. 1–6)

Out of the Miry Bog

> *“He brought me up also out of a horrible pit, out of the miry clay. He set my feet on a rock, and gave me a firm place to stand.”*
> — PSALM 40:2

“I waited patiently for Yahweh. He turned to me, and heard my cry” (Psalm 40:1). The psalm opens after the waiting is over. David has been stuck, and he waited, and God turned toward him. Notice the order. David did not climb out and then thank God. He waited, and God came. The rescue started with God bending down toward a voice coming out of the mud.

Then the picture: *“He brought me up also out of a horrible pit, out of the miry clay. He set my feet on a rock, and gave me a firm place to stand”* (Psalm 40:2). If you have ever been stuck in deep mud, you know the problem. Every move makes it worse. You push with one leg and the other sinks. You grab at the sides and the sides come with you. Effort does not get you out of a bog. It buries you deeper. The only way out is a hand from above, pulling, stronger than the suction of the mud.

That is where many people live spiritually. Trying harder. Promising more. Thrashing in the clay and sinking further each time. The habit gets stronger the more you fight it alone. The guilt gets heavier the more you try to pay it off yourself. Psalm 40 does not tell you to climb better. It tells you who pulled David out. And then it tells you what God did next: He put his feet on rock. Not on a slightly firmer patch of mud. On rock.

And there is a song at the end of it: *“He has put a new song in my mouth, even praise to our God. Many shall see it, and fear, and shall trust in Yahweh”* (Psalm 40:3). The rescue becomes a testimony. Other people stuck in their own pits hear the song and start to hope. David cannot stop counting what God has done: *“Many, Yahweh, my God, are the wonderful works which you have done, and your thoughts which are toward us”* (Psalm 40:5). God’s thoughts toward you are more than you can count. The hand that reached into the clay was moved by them.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went down into the deepest pit there is — the grave — and the Father drew Him up on the third day and set Him on the rock of resurrection. Now He reaches down for you. Stop thrashing. Take His hand. He will set your feet on a firm place and give you a new song.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you exhausting yourself trying to climb out of a bog by your own effort?

◆

DAY 71 · MARCH 12 · PSALM 40 (VV. 7–11)

Your Law Within My Heart

"I delight to do your will, my God. Yes, your law is within my heart."
— PSALM 40:8

In the middle of Psalm 40 comes a surprising line about sacrifice: *"Sacrifice and offering you didn't desire. You have opened my ears. You have not required burnt offering and sin offering"* (Psalm 40:6). David lived under the law of Moses, with its altar and its animals. And yet he says God was never finally after the animals. He was after something else. He wanted an opened ear and a willing heart.

Then the words that the New Testament hears on the lips of Jesus: *"Then I said, 'Behold, I have come. It is written about me in the book in the scroll. I delight to do your will, my God. Yes, your law is within my heart'"* (Psalm 40:7–8). Hebrews quotes this passage directly and puts it in the mouth of Christ coming into the world: *"You didn't desire sacrifice and offering, but you prepared a body for me"* (Hebrews 10:5). The perfect obedience God always wanted finally walked the earth in a human body.

That changes how you read the call to obey. Much obedience is outward. You do the right thing because you are told to, or because someone is watching, or because you are afraid of what happens if you do not. It is compliance. It keeps the rules on the outside of you, like a fence around a yard you would leave if the gate were open. David describes something deeper: a law written inside, a will that delights in what God wants. And he is honest that it starts with God opening his ears, not with David opening them himself.

God promised to do that very thing for His people through Jeremiah: *"I will put my law in their inward parts, and I will write it in their heart"* (Jeremiah 31:33). And through Ezekiel: *"I will also give you a new heart, and I will put a new spirit within you. I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you a heart of flesh"* (Ezekiel 36:26). You cannot carve that heart yourself. You ask for it. And the One who delighted to do God's will gives it to you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the only one who ever delighted to do God's will all the way down. He obeyed to the point of death on a cross, and God raised Him. Now He writes His law on the hearts of His people by His Spirit. Ask Him today for a heart that delights instead of complies.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is your obedience mostly outward compliance — or are you asking God to write His law on your heart?

◆

DAY 72 · MARCH 13 · PSALM 40 (VV. 12–17)

The LORD Takes Thought for Me

> *"But I am poor and needy. May the Lord think about me. You are my help and my deliverer. Don't delay, my God."*
> — PSALM 40:17

The end of Psalm 40 sounds very different from the beginning. The song of rescue is still there, but the trouble has come back: *"For innumerable evils have surrounded me. My iniquities have overtaken me, so that I am not able to look up. They are more than the hairs of my head. My heart has failed me"* (Psalm 40:12). That is what real life with God looks like. You are pulled out of one pit and later you feel the mud around your ankles again. It is not a sign you were never rescued. It is a sign you are still a creature of dust in a world of mud.

David does not pretend otherwise. He does not say, I was rescued once, so I should be fine forever. He prays again: *"Be pleased, Yahweh, to deliver me. Hurry to help me, Yahweh"* (Psalm 40:13). There is no shame in needing God again. The rescue in verse 2 was real. The need in verse 12 is real too. A believer is not someone who needed God once. A believer is someone who keeps needing Him every day and keeps coming back.

Then the psalm holds two truths side by side: *"But I am poor and needy. May the Lord think about me"* (Psalm 40:17). Poor and needy. That is an honest description of where David stands. And yet God thinks about him. Both are true at once. You are genuinely poor before God — no merit, no bargaining chip, nothing to bring to the table. And you are genuinely thought of by God — remembered, considered, held in His mind.

Most people want to pick one, because holding both feels like a contradiction. Either they feel needy and assume God has forgotten them, or they feel remembered and forget how needy they are. Psalm 40 refuses to split them. Paul writes, *"My God will supply every need of yours according to his riches in glory in Christ Jesus"* (Philippians 4:19). Every need. Out of His riches, not your account. And the last line is a prayer you can pray today without polish: *"You are my help and my deliverer. Don't delay, my God"* (Psalm 40:17).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ became poor and needy for you, hungry in the wilderness and thirsty on the cross. The Father thought about Him in the grave and raised Him on the third day. In Christ the Lord thinks about you too. Bring your need to Him again today. He has not grown tired of you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you hold both truths at once — that you are poor and needy, and that the Lord thinks about you?

◆

DAY 73 · MARCH 14 · PSALM 41 (VV. 1–6)

Blessed Is the One Who Considers the Poor

> *"Blessed is he who considers the poor. Yahweh will deliver him in the day of evil."*
> — PSALM 41:1

"Blessed is he who considers the poor. Yahweh will deliver him in the day of evil" (Psalm 41:1). The word considers means more than noticing. It means to pay attention, to think it through, to give the matter real thought. It is the difference between driving past someone in need and stopping to ask what they actually need. The blessing goes to the one who stops. Stopping is costly. It breaks your schedule and puts someone else's trouble in your hands. But it is the way God Himself moves.

The poor in your life may not look poor. They may be the widow at church who has not had a real conversation in a week. The coworker going through a divorce. The teenager down the street with no father at home. The friend in the hospital whose visitors have stopped coming. Considering the poor means seeing them first, which is harder than it sounds in a busy week, and then letting what you see cost you something — time, attention, money, a Saturday afternoon.

And the psalm says God returns the favor: *"Yahweh will sustain him on his sickbed, and restore him from his bed of illness"* (Psalm 41:3). The one who sat by someone else's bed finds God sitting by theirs. That is not a transaction, as if kindness buys health. It is a picture of how God treats people who reflect His own heart. And then David turns to his own need, plainly: *"Yahweh, have mercy on me! Heal me, for I have sinned against you"* (Psalm 41:4). The helper is also a sinner who needs help.

Jesus told a story about the end of the age, when the King says to the righteous, *"because you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me"* (Matthew 25:40). Considering the poor is considering Christ. And Christ first considered you: *"For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sakes he became poor, that you through his poverty might become rich"* (2 Corinthians 8:9). You were the poor one He stopped for, lying by the road with nothing to offer.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ considered you when you had nothing. He left heaven's riches, became poor, and died on a cross to make you rich. He rose, and He still stops for the needy. Let His kindness move you toward someone in need today. You were once the one He stopped for.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Whom has God placed in your path as the poor to consider — and have you remembered Christ first considered you?

◆

DAY 74 · MARCH 15 · PSALM 41 (VV. 7–13)

Even My Close Friend

> *“Yes, my own familiar friend, in whom I trusted, who ate bread with me, has lifted up his heel against me.”*
> — PSALM 41:9

Psalm 41 turns from kindness to betrayal. David is sick, and people are circling: *“My enemies speak evil against me: ‘When will he die, and his name perish?’”* (Psalm 41:5). Visitors come to his bedside with false sympathy and leave to spread rumors: *“If he comes to see me, he speaks falsehood. His heart gathers iniquity to itself. When he goes abroad, he tells it”* (Psalm 41:6). It is a sick room full of people waiting for bad news, and enjoying the wait more than they should. David can hear them whispering in the hall.

Then the deepest cut: *“Yes, my own familiar friend, in whom I trusted, who ate bread with me, has lifted up his heel against me”* (Psalm 41:9). Not a stranger. A friend. Someone who sat at his table and shared his bread. Lifting the heel is the motion of a horse kicking, or someone stepping on you as they walk away. The person you trusted most is the one who turned and kicked.

You may carry a betrayal like that. A spouse who left. A business partner who cleaned out the account. A friend who told your secret. A pastor who used you. Betrayal by a friend hurts in a way enemy attacks never do, because it comes from inside the circle. It makes you doubt your own judgment. It makes you wary of every new friendship. And it can sit in the chest for years, festering, until the wound shapes how you see everyone. You stop trusting. You keep people at arm’s length. You decide never to be caught that way again.

Jesus quoted this very verse about Judas: *“He who eats bread with me has lifted up his heel against me”* (John 13:18). He knew exactly what this felt like. Judas ate the Passover with Him and then led the guards to the garden. And when Judas came close, Jesus asked him, *“Judas, do you betray the Son of Man with a kiss?”* (Luke 22:48). The One who was betrayed by a friend understands yours. You can bring it to Him. He has walked that road, and He is the friend who will never lift His heel against you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was betrayed by a friend who ate bread with Him, and He went to the cross for the very people who abandoned Him. He rose and came back to them with peace instead of blame. Bring Him the betrayal you are still nursing. He knows the wound, and He can heal it.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What betrayal are you still nursing — and could you bring it to the Christ who was betrayed too?

◆

DAY 75 · MARCH 16 · PSALM 42 (VV. 1–6)

As the Deer Pants

> *"As the deer pants for the water brooks, so my soul pants after you, God."*
> — PSALM 42:1

"As the deer pants for the water brooks, so my soul pants after you, God" (Psalm 42:1). Picture a deer in a dry summer, the creek beds cracked, its tongue hanging out, searching for water. That is thirst you can see. And that is how the psalmist describes his longing for God. *"My soul thirsts for God, for the living God. When shall I come and appear before God?"* (Psalm 42:2). It is not a gentle wish or a passing mood. It is a desperate need.

And he is in a dry place: *"My tears have been my food day and night, while they continually ask me, 'Where is your God?'"* (Psalm 42:3). He is far from the temple, far from the crowds he once led in worship. He remembers how it used to be: *"how I used to go with the crowd, and led them to God's house, with the voice of joy and praise"* (Psalm 42:4). Memories of better days can be a comfort. They can also be a torment, when you cannot see how to get back there.

Then he does something unusual. He starts talking to himself: *"Why are you in despair, my soul? Why are you disturbed within me? Hope in God! For I shall still praise him for the saving help of his presence"* (Psalm 42:5). He does not just listen to his feelings. He answers them. He questions his own sadness and points it toward God. That is a skill worth learning. Your heart will tell you many things in a dry season. Not all of them are true, and you do not have to believe the ones that are lies.

Most people let their downcast heart do all the talking. It says you are forgotten. It says it will always be like this. It says God has moved on. The psalmist talks back. He preaches to himself. And he does it without pretending the thirst is gone. He is still panting, still dry, still in tears. But he tells his soul where water is. Jesus stood in Jerusalem and said it plainly: *"If anyone is thirsty, let him come to me and drink!"* (John 7:37).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ cried out from the cross that He was thirsty, and drank the bitter cup of judgment so that you could drink living water. He rose, and He still calls the thirsty to come. Talk back to your downcast heart today. Tell it where the water is, and go.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

In a dry season, are you only listening to your downcast heart — or learning to speak to it?

◆

DAY 76 · MARCH 17 · PSALM 42 (VV. 7–11)

Deep Calls to Deep

> *"Deep calls to deep at the noise of your waterfalls. All your waves and your billows have swept over me."*
> — PSALM 42:7

The psalmist is still far from home, somewhere near the headwaters of the Jordan: *"My God, my soul is in despair within me. Therefore I remember you from the land of the Jordan, the heights of Hermon, from the hill Mizar"* (Psalm 42:6). Up in that country the snowmelt comes crashing down off the mountain. The noise is everywhere. And the sound of the water becomes the sound of his own trouble.

"Deep calls to deep at the noise of your waterfalls. All your waves and your billows have swept over me" (Psalm 42:7). Notice the word your. Your waterfalls. Your waves. Your billows. He does not say the waves of bad luck or the billows of an unfair world. He says they belong to God. The trouble crashing over him is not outside God's reach. It is God's own water. That is both terrifying and steadying. Terrifying, because God has allowed it. Steadying, because the sea that covers him is still God's sea.

Jonah prayed nearly the same words from the belly of the fish: *"For you threw me into the depths, in the heart of the seas. The flood was all around me. All your waves and your billows passed over me"* (Jonah 2:3). The deep places of Scripture are full of people praying from under the water. And God heard each one. Then the psalm finds a thread of hope inside the flood: *"Yahweh will command his loving kindness in the daytime. In the night his song shall be with me: a prayer to the God of my life"* (Psalm 42:8).

Even in the flood he keeps speaking. He asks the hard question out loud: *"I will ask God, my rock, 'Why have you forgotten me? Why do I go mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?'"* (Psalm 42:9). He calls God his rock while asking why God has forgotten him. That is faith under water. It does not stop talking. It keeps addressing God even when it cannot feel Him. And it ends where the first half ended, preaching to itself: *"Why are you in despair, my soul? Why are you disturbed within me? Hope in God!"* (Psalm 42:11).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

All God's waves and billows went over Christ at the cross. He went down into the deep of judgment and death so that the flood over you would never be the end. On the third day He came up out of the depths. Keep speaking to Him under the water. He has been there.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When the waves crash over you, can you keep speaking even your why to the God you still call your rock?

◆

DAY 77 · MARCH 18 · PSALM 43

Send Out Your Light

> *"Oh, send out your light and your truth. Let them lead me. Let them bring me to your holy hill, to your tents."*
> — PSALM 43:3

Psalm 43 picks up where 42 left off. The same refrain closes both, and they read naturally as one prayer in two parts, spoken by the same tired voice. It opens with a plea for justice: *"Vindicate me, God, and plead my cause against an ungodly nation. Oh, deliver me from deceitful and wicked men"* (Psalm 43:1). The psalmist is surrounded by people who lie. He cannot win the argument with them. He asks God to take his side. That is not weakness. It is knowing which court actually matters.

Then the honest question again: *"For you are the God of my strength. Why have you rejected me? Why do I go mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?"* (Psalm 43:2). He calls God his strength and asks why he feels rejected in the same breath. Faith does not always feel strong, and it does not have to. Sometimes it is a hand gripping a rope in the dark, still holding on while asking why the rope feels slack, and refusing to let go anyway.

And then the request that turns the psalm: *"Oh, send out your light and your truth. Let them lead me. Let them bring me to your holy hill, to your tents"* (Psalm 43:3). He does not ask for a map. He asks for light and truth to go ahead of him like guides on a mountain trail. You cannot find your own way back to God in the dark. You need Him to send something out to meet you and lead you home.

God did more than send light and truth. He sent His Son, who said, *"I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father, except through me"* (John 14:6). John calls Him *"The true light that enlightens everyone"* (John 1:9). The light the psalmist asked for has a face. And where does it lead? To the altar: *"Then I will go to the altar of God, to God, my exceeding joy"* (Psalm 43:4). Not just to safety, though it brings that. To joy. The road out of the dark ends in the presence of the God who is your exceeding joy.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the light and truth God sent out. He walked into the darkness of the cross to lead you out of yours, and rose on the third day as the way to the Father. Ask Him today to go ahead of you. He knows the road to God's hill because He made it.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where do you need God to send light ahead of you — and have you remembered that the Light has a name?

◆

DAY 78 · MARCH 19 · PSALM 44 (VV. 1–6)

Not by Their Own Sword

> *"For they didn't get the land in possession by their own sword, neither did their own arm save them; but your right hand, your arm, and the light of your face, because you were favorable to them."*
> — PSALM 44:3

Psalm 44 begins with memory: *"We have heard with our ears, God; our fathers have told us what work you did in their days, in the days of old"* (Psalm 44:1). Stories passed down at the table. Grandparents telling what God had done. The conquest of the land, the rescue from enemies, the faithfulness of God across generations. Every family of faith has stories like these, and they matter more than people think. The answered prayer in the hospital. The job that came the week the money ran out. The grandparent who never stopped praying for a wandering child.

And the point of the old stories is clear: *"For they didn't get the land in possession by their own sword, neither did their own arm save them; but your right hand, your arm, and the light of your face, because you were favorable to them"* (Psalm 44:3). Not their sword. Not their own arm or strength. God's right hand and the light of His face. The victory was not earned. It was given, because God was favorable. That word should land on you. God's favor is the reason, not your strength or skill.

Then the psalmist takes the lesson personally: *"For I will not trust in my bow, neither shall my sword save me"* (Psalm 44:6). Your bow and sword may be different. Your work ethic. Your track record. Your knowledge of the Bible. Your reputation at church. Your ability to fix things. None of those are bad. But it is easy to slide from using them to trusting them, and from trusting them to quietly believing you earned your standing with God.

Paul puts it in one sentence: *"for by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works, that no one would boast"* (Ephesians 2:8–9). Not of yourselves. The land was given. Salvation is given. And so the psalm can say: *"In God we have made our boast all day long, we will give thanks to your name forever"* (Psalm 44:8). If you must boast, boast in Him alone. He did the work. You received it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did not win your salvation with a sword. He won it with nail-pierced hands and a crown of thorns. The victory was entirely His, and God raised Him to prove it. Put down your bow today. Boast in what He has done, not in what you can do.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where have you begun quietly trusting your own effort or performance instead of God's favor?

◆

DAY 79 · MARCH 20 · PSALM 44 (VV. 7–13)

Yet You Have Rejected Us

> *"But now you rejected us, and brought us to dishonor, and don't go out with our armies."*
> — PSALM 44:9

After the memory of victory comes a shock: *"But now you rejected us, and brought us to dishonor, and don't go out with our armies"* (Psalm 44:9). The same people who told the old stories are now losing. *"You make us turn back from the adversary. Those who hate us take plunder for themselves"* (Psalm 44:10). God was with their fathers. Now He seems to have stepped away. And they do not know why. There is no sin they can point to, no idol they have set up, no clear reason for the defeat.

The losses pile up: *"You have made us like sheep for food, and have scattered us among the nations. You sell your people for nothing, and have gained nothing from their sale"* (Psalm 44:11–12). That is a bitter line. God sold His people and got nothing for them. It feels like being thrown away. *"You make us a reproach to our neighbors, a scoffing and a derision to those who are around us"* (Psalm 44:13). The neighbors are laughing, and the people of God have no answer to give them.

What makes Psalm 44 so unusual is that the psalmist does not blame himself. There is no confession of sin here, because he does not know of any. He is suffering, and he cannot explain it. That is a real kind of suffering many people know. The child with cancer. The faithful worker laid off. The widow whose husband was killed by a drunk driver. Not every hardship is punishment. Some is simply unexplained, and Scripture gives you words to bring it to God without pretending to understand.

That is the gift of a psalm like this. It lets you say the unexplainable thing out loud, in God's presence, without turning it into a theology lesson. It also points ahead. Paul quotes a later verse of this very psalm in Romans 8: *"Even as it is written, 'For your sake we are killed all day long. We were accounted as sheep for the slaughter.' No, in all these things, we are more than conquerors through him who loved us"* (Romans 8:36–37). The suffering is real. So is the love that holds you inside it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ suffered without cause — sold for thirty pieces of silver, mocked by His neighbors, led like a sheep to the slaughter. He did not deserve it. God raised Him, and now nothing can separate you from His love. Bring Him the suffering you cannot explain.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you carrying a suffering you cannot explain — and can you bring that honest lament to God?

◆

DAY 80 · MARCH 21 · PSALM 44 (VV. 14–20)

Our Heart Has Not Turned Back

> *"Our heart has not turned back, neither have our steps strayed from your path"*
> — PSALM 44:18

In the middle of their suffering, God's people say something remarkable: *"All this has come on us, yet we haven't forgotten you. We haven't been false to your covenant"* (Psalm 44:17). They have been crushed. They are being mocked. And they have not walked away. *"Our heart has not turned back, neither have our steps strayed from your path"* (Psalm 44:18). They have held on to God in the dark, without answers, without relief, without any sign that holding on is working.

That is not self-righteousness. It is the simple fact that they are still here. Suffering often pushes people away from God. Pain says, if God really loved you, this would not be happening. The easy road is to drift. To stop praying. To stop going to church. To let the bitterness set in and quietly close the door. The psalmist knows that temptation, and he says they have not given in to it.

Look at what they are holding on through: *"though you have crushed us in the haunt of jackals, and covered us with the shadow of death"* (Psalm 44:19). Crushed. Covered with the shadow of death. And still their hearts have not turned back. Where does that kind of endurance come from? Not from their own strength. If it did, it would have failed long ago. It comes from the God who keeps His people even when He seems far away. Faithfulness in the dark is itself a gift. You did not manufacture it. It was given to you, the way rain is given to a field that did nothing to deserve it.

And the psalm knows that God sees the heart: *"won't God search this out? For he knows the secrets of the heart"* (Psalm 44:21). He knows whether you have stayed. He knows how hard it has been. He sees every step you took toward Him when every feeling said turn back. Not one of those steps was wasted. Jesus said of His sheep, *"They will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand"* (John 10:28). If you are still here, it is because His hand has been holding you. Trust that grip to keep holding.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's heart never turned back. He set His face toward Jerusalem and kept walking to the cross when every voice told Him to stop. He rose, and now He holds His sheep in His hand. If you are still holding on in the dark, it is because He is holding you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When suffering tempts you to drift, will you trust the grace that has kept you to keep you still?

◆

DAY 81 · MARCH 22 · PSALM 44 (VV. 21–26)

Awake, O Lord

> *"For our soul is bowed down to the dust. Our body clings to the earth."*
> — PSALM 44:25

The psalm ends with a cry that sounds almost rude: *"Wake up! Why do you sleep, Lord? Arise! Don't reject us forever"* (Psalm 44:23). God's people tell God to wake up. They feel as if He has been asleep through their suffering. And the Bible keeps this prayer. It does not edit it into something more polite. That tells you something about the kind of honesty God welcomes from people who are hurting. He would rather hear you shout than watch you go silent. A shout is still addressed to Him. Silence has often given up.

"Why do you hide your face, and forget our affliction and our oppression?" (Psalm 44:24). Then the line that sounds the theme of this whole book: *"For our soul is bowed down to the dust. Our body clings to the earth"* (Psalm 44:25). Bowed down to the dust. Clinging to the earth. It is almost the same picture as Psalm 119:25: *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). Face down, unable to rise, pressed into the ground. This is the dust of humiliation, when you have been brought so low that standing up seems impossible.

What do they ask for? Not a reward for faithfulness. Not what they have earned. They have just said their hearts did not turn back, but they do not plead their record. They plead God's love: *"Rise up to help us. Redeem us for your loving kindness' sake"* (Psalm 44:26). For your loving kindness' sake. That is the only ground anyone can stand on before God. Not what you have done. What He is, and what He has always been.

That is the right instinct when you are pressed flat. You may want to earn your rescue — pray harder, try harder, prove you deserve help. But the psalm teaches you to plead the character of God instead. On the Sea of Galilee the disciples woke Jesus with nearly the same complaint: *"Teacher, don't you care that we are dying?"* (Mark 4:38). He did care. He stood up and calmed the storm. The One who seemed asleep was the One who could save them. He had been in the boat with them the whole time.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was bowed down to the dust in Gethsemane and laid in the earth of a tomb. He rose on the third day, and God redeemed Him for His loving kindness' sake. Plead that same love today. You do not need to earn your rescue. He has already risen to help you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you are pressed flat, do you try to earn your rescue — or plead God's loving kindness?

◆

DAY 82 · MARCH 23 · PSALM 45 (VV. 1–6)

The King in His Beauty

> *"You are the most excellent of the sons of men. Grace has anointed your lips, therefore God has blessed you forever."*
> — PSALM 45:2

Psalm 45 is a royal wedding song. The heading calls it a love song, and the poet cannot contain himself: *"My heart overflows with a noble theme. I recite my verses for the king. My tongue is like the pen of a skillful writer"* (Psalm 45:1). He is writing about a king on his wedding day. And everything about the king is glorious. You can almost hear the crowd outside the palace, the music, the trumpets, the people craning to see.

"You are the most excellent of the sons of men. Grace has anointed your lips, therefore God has blessed you forever" (Psalm 45:2). The most excellent. Grace on his lips. When he speaks, kindness comes out. Then the king rides out *"on behalf of truth, humility, and righteousness"* (Psalm 45:4). Not for conquest. For truth, humility, and righteousness. That is a king worth following. Most kings ride out for their own glory. This one rides out for what is right, and for the humble.

Then the psalm says something no human king could bear: *"Your throne, God, is forever and ever. A scepter of equity is the scepter of your kingdom"* (Psalm 45:6). It calls the king God. Hebrews quotes these exact verses and says they are about Jesus: *"But of the Son he says, 'Your throne, O God, is forever and ever. The scepter of uprightness is the scepter of your Kingdom'"* (Hebrews 1:8). This wedding song is finally about Christ. He is the King whose lips are full of grace and whose throne lasts forever.

So what do you do with a psalm like this? You look. You do not ask for anything at first. You simply behold the King. Most prayer runs straight to requests — help me, fix this, give me that. Psalm 45 invites you to stop and stare at the beauty of the One you are praying to. The words He spoke were full of grace. *"Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest"* (Matthew 11:28). Spend a few minutes today just looking at Him. Read one of the Gospels and watch what He does. Watch how He treats people. That is your King.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The most excellent of the sons of men let Himself be beaten until His face was hard to recognize. Christ wore thorns for a crown so He could wear glory forever. He rose, and His throne will never end. Look at Him today before you ask Him for anything.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When did you last simply behold the beauty of Christ the King, without asking Him for something?

◆

DAY 83 · MARCH 24 · PSALM 45 (VV. 7–11)

The King Desires Your Beauty

"So the king will desire your beauty, honor him, for he is your lord."
— PSALM 45:11

The wedding song turns from the king to the bride: *"Listen, daughter, consider, and turn your ear. Forget your own people, and also your father's house"* (Psalm 45:10). She is leaving her family to join the king. She has to let go of the old house to be fully his. That is the cost of a wedding. Something is left behind for something better to begin. Anyone who has stood at a wedding knows the mix of joy and loss on the faces of the parents.

Scripture uses this picture for God's people. The church is the bride, and Christ is the bridegroom. Paul wrote to the Corinthians, *"For I married you to one husband, that I might present you as a pure virgin to Christ"* (2 Corinthians 11:2). And to the Ephesians he described how *"Christ also loved the assembly, and gave himself up for it"* (Ephesians 5:25). You are part of that bride. The call to forget the father's house is a call to every believer, man or woman, young or old.

What is your father's house? It may be an old way of life you keep going back to. An allegiance that competes with Christ. A habit, a grudge, a way of seeing yourself that was formed long before you knew Him. It may be good things held too tightly — family traditions, comforts, plans. The bride cannot cling to her old home and fully belong to the king. Neither can you. A divided heart is not ready for a wedding.

And then the line that changes everything: *"So the king will desire your beauty, honor him, for he is your lord"* (Psalm 45:11). The king desires her. He wants her. She is not a political arrangement he puts up with. She is wanted. That is how Christ sees His people. Isaiah says, *"As a bridegroom rejoices over his bride, so your God will rejoice over you"* (Isaiah 62:5). He does not tolerate you. He delights in you. That is hard to believe on a bad day, when you look at yourself and see mostly dust. But His eyes are not your eyes. He sees the bride He is making. Letting go of the old house is not a loss. It is a homecoming.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ left His Father's house to win His bride. He gave Himself up for her at the cross and rose to present her without spot or wrinkle. He desires you. Let go of whatever old house you are still clutching. The King is waiting, and He rejoices over you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What old allegiance or lesser love are you still clutching, when the King desires you?

◆

DAY 84 · MARCH 25 · PSALM 45 (VV. 12–17)

Led with Joy and Gladness

> *"With gladness and rejoicing they shall be led. They shall enter into the king's palace."*
> — PSALM 45:15

The wedding song reaches its procession. The bride is brought to the king, dressed in her finest: *"The princess inside is all glorious. Her clothing is interwoven with gold. She shall be led to the king in embroidered work"* (Psalm 45:13–14). Gold thread, embroidered cloth, a slow walk down the hall toward the throne room. Others come with gifts: *"The daughter of Tyre comes with a gift. The rich among the people entreat your favor"* (Psalm 45:12). Everyone wants to be near this wedding, and no one wants to miss the procession.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"With gladness and rejoicing they shall be led. They shall enter into the king's palace"* (Psalm 45:15). Notice the word led. The bride does not find her own way to the palace. She does not have to fight through a crowd or guess which door is right. She is led, and she is led with gladness. The walk itself is joy, because of who is waiting at the end of it.

That is a picture of the Christian life most people forget. They feel it as a trudge. Up early, to work, home tired, bills, worries, a few minutes of prayer squeezed in before sleep. Week after week, the same road. Psalm 45 says the road is going somewhere. You are being led toward a King who is waiting for you, and the end of the road is a wedding feast. John saw it: *"Let's rejoice and be exceedingly glad, and let's give the glory to him. For the wedding of the Lamb has come"* (Revelation 19:7).

And the psalm ends with a promise about the future: *"I will make your name to be remembered in all generations. Therefore the peoples shall give you thanks forever and ever"* (Psalm 45:17). The King's name lasts. The wedding is not a single afternoon that ends with cleanup. It is the beginning of a forever. Hebrews says Jesus endured the cross *"for the joy that was set before him"* (Hebrews 12:2). Part of that joy was you, being led into His house. The trudge is not the whole story. The procession is.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ walked the hard road to the cross for the joy set before Him, and part of that joy was bringing you home. He rose and went ahead to prepare the palace. You are being led there with gladness. Lift your eyes from the trudge today. The wedding is coming.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Does your life feel like a trudge toward nothing — or like being led, with joy, toward the King?

◆

DAY 85 · MARCH 26 · PSALM 46 (VV. 1–6)

A Very Present Help

> *"God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble."*
> — PSALM 46:1

"God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble" (Psalm 46:1). Martin Luther built a famous hymn on this psalm, and many people have held on to it in the worst week of their lives. A refuge is a place to run to. Strength is what you do not have on your own. And a very present help is not a help that arrives after the trouble is over. It is a help standing in the middle of the trouble with you. Present tense. Not a memory of help, not a promise of help someday, but help here, now, in the room where the bad news arrived.

Then the psalm imagines the worst: *"Therefore we won't be afraid, though the earth changes, though the mountains are shaken into the heart of the seas; though its waters roar and are troubled, though the mountains tremble with their swelling"* (Psalm 46:2–3). Mountains are the most solid thing people know. They are what you measure everything else against. And the psalm pictures them sliding into the ocean. The things you thought could never move are moving, and nothing you do can stop them.

You may have a mountain like that. A marriage you thought was rock solid. A body that always worked. A job you had for twenty years. A church that was always there. Then one phone call, one test result, one meeting, and the mountain slides into the sea. The ground you stood on is not there anymore. Psalm 46 does not say that will never happen. It says you do not have to be afraid when it does.

Why not? Because there is something steadier than mountains: *"There is a river, the streams of which make the city of God glad, the holy place of the tents of the Most High. God is within her. She shall not be moved. God will help her at dawn"* (Psalm 46:4–5). The mountains move. The city of God does not, because God is within her. And then the refrain that holds the psalm: *"Yahweh of Armies is with us. The God of Jacob is our refuge"* (Psalm 46:7). He is with you while the mountain falls.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

When the earth shook at the cross and the rocks split, Christ was dying for you. He went into the ground and came out on the third day, and the earth shook again. He is your very present help. When your mountain slides into the sea, He is standing in the water with you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What mountain in your life feels like it is sliding into the sea — and can you find refuge in God there?

◆

DAY 86 · MARCH 27 · PSALM 46 (VV. 7–11)

Be Still and Know

> *"Be still, and know that I am God."*
> **— PSALM 46:10**

Psalm 46 moves from the shaking earth to the raging nations: *"The nations raged. The kingdoms were moved. He lifted his voice and the earth melted"* (Psalm 46:6). Governments rise and fall. Wars start. Headlines scream. And all God has to do is speak, and the earth melts like wax. The noise of the nations is real, but it is not the loudest voice in the room. God's voice is, and it does not need a microphone.

Then an invitation: *"Come, see Yahweh's works, what desolations he has made in the earth. He makes wars cease to the end of the earth. He breaks the bow, and shatters the spear. He burns the chariots in the fire"* (Psalm 46:8–9). God is not only in the business of shaking things. He also ends wars. He breaks the bow. He burns the chariots. The tools of human violence end up in His fire. The psalm looks forward to a day when the fighting stops for good.

And then God Himself speaks: *"Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations. I will be exalted in the earth"* (Psalm 46:10). Be still. The word is not mainly about quiet time or a calm morning routine. It is closer to stop. Let go. Drop your hands. It is spoken to people who are striving — scrambling to hold everything together, afraid that if they stop for a moment it will all collapse. God says, stop. I am God. You are not. That is not a rebuke. It is relief, offered to people who have been carrying a weight that was never theirs to carry.

That is one of the hardest commands in Scripture for busy, capable people. You are used to holding things together. You fix. You plan. You stay up late solving problems. Some of that is good stewardship. But underneath it there can be a fear that if you let go, everything falls. Psalm 46 says God is already exalted. He does not need your striving to stay on His throne. Jesus said, *"Take my yoke upon you, and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart; and you will find rest for your souls"* (Matthew 11:29).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was still before His accusers and still on the cross, and in that stillness He won everything. He let go of His life into the Father's hands, and the Father raised Him. You can let go of what you are holding together today. Be still. He is God, and you are held.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What are you striving to hold together, afraid it will collapse if you stop?

◆

DAY 87 · MARCH 28 · PSALM 47 (VV. 1–4)

Clap Your Hands

> *"Oh clap your hands, all you nations. Shout to God with the voice of triumph!"*
> — PSALM 47:1

"Oh clap your hands, all you nations. Shout to God with the voice of triumph!" (Psalm 47:1). Some people are uncomfortable with a verse like this. Clapping. Shouting. It sounds noisy, maybe a little undignified. But the psalm is not asking for a performance. It is asking for a response that matches what God has done. When a team wins a championship, nobody tells the fans to sit quietly. Joy makes noise. It always has.

And the reason for the noise: *"For Yahweh Most High is awesome. He is a great King over all the earth"* (Psalm 47:2). Not a local god. Not a tribal deity limited to one hill. The King over all the earth. Every nation, every people, every language is under His rule. That is why the psalm calls all the nations to clap. The praise is not just for Israel, and it never was. It is for everyone, because God is King of everyone.

Then a line about inheritance: *"He chooses our inheritance for us, the glory of Jacob whom he loved"* (Psalm 47:4). God picks the inheritance. His people do not have to scramble for a place. He chooses it for them out of love. Jacob was the younger son, the one who did not deserve the blessing, the schemer. And God loved him. The inheritance is a gift chosen by love, not a prize won by merit.

Many believers have let their worship grow muted. You stand in church and mouth the words. You think about lunch during the hymn. You would never clap or shout because someone might look at you. Some of that is just temperament, and God does not require everyone to be loud. But some of it is that the wonder has faded. Psalm 47 invites you to remember who God is and what He has done until the response comes back. Revelation pictures the nations singing a new song: *"You are worthy to take the book and to open its seals: for you were killed, and bought us for God with your blood out of every tribe, language, people, and nation"* (Revelation 5:9). That is worth a shout, loud enough to be heard.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was killed and with His blood bought people from every nation for God. He rose and now reigns as King over all the earth. That is reason enough to clap your hands. Let the wonder of what He has done come back to you today, and let it make some noise.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Has your worship grown muted and self-conscious — and what would it look like to let joy rise?

◆

DAY 88 · MARCH 29 · PSALM 47 (VV. 5–9)

God Has Gone Up

> *"God has gone up with a shout, Yahweh with the sound of a trumpet."*
> — PSALM 47:5

"God has gone up with a shout, Yahweh with the sound of a trumpet" (Psalm 47:5). The picture is a king going up to his throne after a victory. The trumpets sound. The crowd shouts. He climbs the steps and takes his seat. In ancient Israel this may have been sung as the ark of the covenant was carried up to Jerusalem. The presence of God going up the hill, with music and noise. People lined the road. Children ran ahead. Priests carried the ark on their shoulders, and the whole city came out to watch the King go up.

Then four times in a single verse: *"Sing praises to God! Sing praises! Sing praises to our King! Sing praises!"* (Psalm 47:6). And the reason: *"For God is the King of all the earth. Sing praises with understanding"* (Psalm 47:7). With understanding. This is not mindless noise. It is praise that knows what it is praising. You sing because you understand who has taken the throne, and what it cost Him to get there.

The Church has long read this psalm on the day Christ ascended. Forty days after the resurrection, Jesus led His disciples out and *"as they were looking, he was taken up, and a cloud received him out of their sight"* (Acts 1:9). God went up. And Paul says where He went: God *"raised him from the dead and made him to sit at his right hand in the heavenly places, far above all rule, authority, power, dominion, and every name that is named"* (Ephesians 1:20–21). The ascended King is on the throne right now.

That changes how you see the world. It is easy to live as though everything is running loose — wars, elections, economies, diseases, all spinning without anyone in control. Psalm 47 says the opposite: *"God reigns over the nations. God sits on his holy throne"* (Psalm 47:8). Not someday. Now. The world is not out of control. It is under the rule of a King who died and rose and went up. You are His subject. Live like it today — not anxious, not frantic, but steady, because the throne is occupied.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went up with a shout. He ascended from the Mount of Olives and sat down at the Father's right hand, far above every power. The throne is not empty. The King who died for you reigns over the nations right now. Live today as His subject, steady and unafraid.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you live as though the world were running loose — or as a subject of the ascended King?

◆

DAY 89 · MARCH 30 · PSALM 48 (VV. 1–7)

The City of the Great King

> *"Great is Yahweh, and greatly to be praised, in the city of our God, in his holy mountain."*
> — PSALM 48:1

"Great is Yahweh, and greatly to be praised, in the city of our God, in his holy mountain" (Psalm 48:1). Psalm 48 is a song about Jerusalem, the city God chose. And it sings about the city the way people sing about home: *"Beautiful in elevation, the joy of the whole earth, is Mount Zion, on the north sides, the city of the great King"* (Psalm 48:2). High on the hill, lovely to look at, the place where God made His name dwell.

But the city is not safe because of its walls. The psalm is clear about that: *"God has shown himself in her citadels as a refuge"* (Psalm 48:3). The citadels are strong, but God is what makes them a refuge. Without Him, they are just stone. The psalm remembers a time when kings came against the city: *"For, behold, the kings assembled themselves, they passed by together. They saw it, then they were amazed. They were dismayed. They hurried away"* (Psalm 48:4–5). They saw something and ran. Whatever they saw when they looked at that city, it was not what they expected. They came to conquer and left trembling.

"Trembling took hold of them there, pain, as of a woman in travail. With the east wind, you break the ships of Tarshish" (Psalm 48:6–7). The great ships of Tarshish were the largest vessels of the ancient world, the pride of the sea. God breaks them with a wind. The kings had armies and fleets. The city had God. And God was enough, as He always is.

You may be trusting your own walls for security. A good income. A solid house. Locks on every door. Insurance. A reputation. None of those are bad. But they are not what makes you safe. Hebrews says believers have already come to a better city: *"But you have come to Mount Zion, and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem"* (Hebrews 12:22). John saw it coming down: *"I saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared like a bride adorned for her husband"* (Revelation 21:2). That city cannot fall, because God lives in it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ died outside the walls of Jerusalem so you could enter the city that cannot fall. He rose and is building the New Jerusalem, where God will dwell with His people. Your walls will not hold forever. His city will. Put your trust there today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you trusting your own walls for security, when the city that cannot fall is open to you?

◆

DAY 90 · MARCH 31 · PSALM 48 (VV. 8–14)

This Is God, Our God Forever

"For this God is our God forever and ever. He will be our guide even to death."

— PSALM 48:14

The second half of Psalm 48 turns from the attack to the aftermath: *"As we have heard, so we have seen, in the city of Yahweh of Armies, in the city of our God. God will establish it forever"* (Psalm 48:8). They had heard the stories of God's faithfulness from their parents. Now they have seen it with their own eyes. The old stories turned out to be true. That is a moment every believer longs for: the day the promise and the experience finally meet.

So they go to worship: *"We have thought about your loving kindness, God, in the middle of your temple"* (Psalm 48:9). They think about it. They do not just feel grateful for a moment and move on. They sit in God's house and turn His kindness over in their minds, the way you might turn a smooth stone over in your hand. Meditation is not emptying the mind. It is filling it with what God has done and staying there long enough for it to sink in.

Then an unusual instruction: *"Walk about Zion, and go around her. Number its towers. Notice her bulwarks. Consider her palaces, that you may tell it to the next generation"* (Psalm 48:12–13). Walk the walls. Count the towers. Look at what God has preserved. And then tell your children. That is something you can do with your own life. Walk around it. Count the times God has been faithful. The rescue in your twenties. The provision in the lean year. The answered prayer you almost forgot. Write them down, and tell someone younger.

And the psalm ends with the sentence that holds all of it: *"For this God is our God forever and ever. He will be our guide even to death"* (Psalm 48:14). Forever and ever. Not until you mess up again. Not until you get old and useless. Forever. And He will guide you even to death — through the last valley, all the way to the end. Hebrews says it plainly: *"Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today, and forever"* (Hebrews 13:8). The God who guided your grandparents is the God who will walk you home.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the guide who has already walked through death and come out the other side. He went into the grave and rose on the third day, and He will lead you through your own last valley. This God is your God forever. Count His faithfulness today, and tell it to someone younger.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What evidence of God's faithfulness in your own life could you walk around, number, and tell?

◆

DAY 91 · APRIL 1 · PSALM 49 (VV. 1–7)

No Ransom Anyone Can Pay

> *"none of them can by any means redeem his brother, nor give God a ransom for him."*
> — PSALM 49:7

Psalm 49 opens like a teacher calling a whole room to attention: *"Hear this, all you peoples. Listen, all you inhabitants of the world, both low and high, rich and poor together"* (Psalm 49:1–2). Low and high. Rich and poor. Nobody is left out of this lesson. It is for the CEO and the night janitor, the farmer with a thousand acres and the renter behind on the bill. Whatever your bank balance, this psalm is talking to you.

Then the question that drives it: *"Why should I fear in the days of evil, when iniquity at my heels surrounds me?"* (Psalm 49:5). Why should I be afraid? The psalmist names the people who make others afraid: *"Those who trust in their wealth, and boast in the multitude of their riches"* (Psalm 49:6). Everyone has met them. The ones who can buy their way out of trouble. The ones with the best lawyers, the biggest houses, the right friends. They seem untouchable. And it is easy to feel small next to them.

But the psalm points to the one thing money cannot buy: *"none of them can by any means redeem his brother, nor give God a ransom for him"* (Psalm 49:7). Not one. All the wealth in the world cannot purchase another person's life back from death. *"For the redemption of their life is costly, no payment is ever enough"* (Psalm 49:8). No account is large enough. No investment pays out that far. Death sends the same bill to everyone, and no one can cover it for anyone else.

That should take the fear out of wealth and power. Whatever they seem to secure, they cannot secure the one thing that matters. Jesus asked, *"For what will it profit a man, if he gains the whole world, and forfeits his life?"* (Matthew 16:26). And then He did what no rich man could do. He paid the ransom Himself: *"For the Son of Man also came not to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many"* (Mark 10:45). Peter says you were redeemed *"not with corruptible things, with silver or gold"* (1 Peter 1:18), but *"with precious blood, as of a lamb without blemish or spot, the blood of Christ"* (1 Peter 1:19). The price no one could pay has been paid.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

No payment is ever enough — except one. Christ gave His life as a ransom for many, paying with His own blood what all the gold on earth could never buy. Then God raised Him to show the ransom was accepted. You do not need to fear the rich. You have been bought by Someone richer.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you intimidated by what wealth and power seem to secure, forgetting what they can never buy?

◆

DAY 92 · APRIL 2 · PSALM 49 (VV. 8–13)

The Folly of the Confident

> *"But man, despite his riches, doesn't endure. He is like the animals that perish."*
> — PSALM 49:12

Psalm 49 keeps pressing on the same nerve: *"For he sees that wise men die; likewise the fool and the senseless perish, and leave their wealth to others"* (Psalm 49:10). Wise people die. Foolish people die. And both leave their money behind for someone else to spend. The estate sale comes for everyone. Strangers walk through the house, pick up the dishes, haggle over the tools. A lifetime of gathering, sorted into boxes in a weekend and hauled off in a rented truck.

And yet people live as though it will not happen to them: *"Their inward thought is that their houses will endure forever, and their dwelling places to all generations. They name their lands after themselves"* (Psalm 49:11). They put their names on buildings and streets and farms. They plan as though they will always be there to enjoy it. It is not malice. It is a kind of forgetting, common to almost everyone. The mind simply refuses to picture the world going on without you.

Then the line that brings it all down to earth: *"But man, despite his riches, doesn't endure. He is like the animals that perish"* (Psalm 49:12). Like the animals. That is hard to hear. All the pomp, all the honor, all the name on the gate — and in the end the body goes back to the ground the same way a deer's does in the woods. *"This is the destiny of those who are foolish, and of those who approve their sayings"* (Psalm 49:13). The crowd that applauds the confident man walks the same road he does.

Jesus told a parable about exactly this. A rich farmer had a great harvest and decided to build bigger barns and take it easy. *"But God said to him, 'You foolish one, tonight your soul is required of you. The things which you have prepared—whose will they be?' So is he who lays up treasure for himself, and is not rich toward God"* (Luke 12:20–21). The question is not whether you will leave it all behind. You will. The question is whether you are rich toward God. That kind of wealth goes with you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ owned nothing at His death but the clothes the guards gambled for. He was buried in a borrowed grave. Yet He rose, and now everything belongs to Him. He makes the poor rich toward God. Loosen your grip on whatever pomp you are trusting today, and hold on to Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What pomp or position are you quietly trusting to anchor you — and is it making you rich toward God?

◆

DAY 93 · APRIL 3 · PSALM 49 (VV. 14–20)

God Will Ransom My Soul

> *"But God will redeem my soul from the power of Sheol, for he will receive me."*
>
> — PSALM 49:15

Psalm 49 paints death as a shepherd: *"They are appointed as a flock for Sheol. Death shall be their shepherd"* (Psalm 49:14). It is one of the darkest pictures in the Bible. Death herding people like sheep into the grave, one after another, rich and poor, proud and humble. *"Their beauty shall decay in Sheol, far from their mansion"* (Psalm 49:14). Whatever looked impressive above ground rots below it.

If the psalm stopped there, it would be the bleakest sermon ever preached. But it does not stop there. One verse turns the whole thing over: *"But God will redeem my soul from the power of Sheol, for he will receive me"* (Psalm 49:15). After all that talk about no ransom being enough, the psalmist says God will pay it. What no human could buy, God will redeem. And then the tender line: He will receive me. Death is not the last hand to hold the psalmist. God's is.

That changes how you face death. It is easy to feel it as being swallowed by darkness — the end of everything, the lights going out. And for those who trust in riches, the psalm says it is: *"he shall go to the generation of his fathers. They shall never see the light"* (Psalm 49:19). But for those whom God redeems, death becomes a doorway. Someone is on the other side, waiting to receive you. Jesus said it plainly: *"I will come again, and will receive you to myself; that where I am, you may be there also"* (John 14:3).

So the psalm can say: *"Don't be afraid when a man is made rich, when the glory of his house is increased; for when he dies he will carry nothing away"* (Psalm 49:16–17). The rich do not take it with them. But you, if you belong to God, do not go empty-handed. You go to Him. Hebrews says Christ came *"that through death he might bring to nothing him who had the power of death, that is, the devil, and might deliver all of them who through fear of death were all their lifetime subject to bondage"* (Hebrews 2:14–15). The fear can let go.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was received into death so you would be received into life. He went into Sheol's territory and broke its power from the inside, rising on the third day. Death is no longer your shepherd. He is. When your time comes, He will be there to receive you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Does the thought of death feel like being swallowed by darkness — or like being received by God?

◆

DAY 94 · APRIL 4 · PSALM 50 (VV. 1–8)

The God Who Speaks

> *"Our God comes, and does not keep silent. A fire devours before him. It is very stormy around him."*
> — PSALM 50:3

Psalm 50 begins with God calling the whole earth to court: *"The Mighty One, God, Yahweh, speaks, and calls the earth from sunrise to sunset"* (Psalm 50:1). Three names stacked together, and then a summons that reaches from one horizon to the other. Then He appears: *"Out of Zion, the perfection of beauty, God shines out"* (Psalm 50:2). He does not slip in quietly. He shines.

"Our God comes, and does not keep silent. A fire devours before him. It is very stormy around him" (Psalm 50:3). Fire and storm. This is the God of Sinai, the mountain wrapped in smoke and thunder. Hebrews says it bluntly: *"for our God is a consuming fire"* (Hebrews 12:29). Many people have tamed God in their minds. They picture a kindly old man who never says anything hard. Psalm 50 says He does not keep silent, and when He speaks, the ground shakes. That is not a God you can put on a shelf and take down when convenient.

And who is He calling to account? Not the pagans. His own people: *"Gather my saints together to me, those who have made a covenant with me by sacrifice"* (Psalm 50:5). The ones who show up at worship. The ones who bring their offerings. And He says something surprising: *"I don't rebuke you for your sacrifices. Your burnt offerings are continually before me"* (Psalm 50:8). They are doing all the right things. The altar is busy. The services are full. That is not the problem. On the outside, everything looks healthy. The calendar is full of church events. The giving is steady. The words are right.

The problem is that the faith has become machinery. The offerings keep going up while the heart has wandered off. You can keep every outward habit going — church, tithe, small group, the quiet time checked off — and still be far from God. The gears turn, and no one is home. Psalm 50 is God showing up at the machine and speaking into it. That is mercy, not threat. A God who stays silent while you drift is not loving you. A God who comes in fire to call you back is.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The God who comes in fire came in flesh. Christ stood in the temple and drove out the machinery that had replaced worship, and then He went to the cross to open the way back to the Father. He rose, and He still speaks. Listen to Him today, and come back from the machinery to the heart.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Has your faith become machinery — keeping up the habits while your heart has wandered?

◆

DAY 95 · APRIL 5 · PSALM 50 (VV. 9–15)

Call Upon Me

> *"Call on me in the day of trouble. I will deliver you, and you will honor me."*
>
> — PSALM 50:15

God speaks to His people in Psalm 50 about their sacrifices, and the tone is almost amused: *"I have no need for a bull from your stall, nor male goats from your pens. For every animal of the forest is mine, and the livestock on a thousand hills"* (Psalm 50:9–10). The cattle on a thousand hills. He owns all of them. You cannot give God a cow He does not already have. You cannot add to the inventory of the One who made every creature.

"I know all the birds of the mountains. The wild animals of the field are mine. If I were hungry, I would not tell you, for the world is mine, and all that is in it" (Psalm 50:11–12). That is a striking line. If God were hungry, He would not need to ask you for lunch. He has no needs. Paul told the philosophers in Athens the same thing: God *"isn't served by men's hands, as though he needed anything, seeing he himself gives to all life and breath, and all things"* (Acts 17:25).

Many people approach God as though they must supply something to Him. They bring their good behavior, their service record, their giving, as if God were a business that would go under without their contribution. Psalm 50 turns that upside down. God is not short on anything. He is not waiting for your offering to balance His books. So what does He want? *"Offer to God the sacrifice of thanksgiving. Pay your vows to the Most High"* (Psalm 50:14). Thanks. A grateful heart. The only thing you can give Him that He does not already own is your trust.

Then the invitation: *"Call on me in the day of trouble. I will deliver you, and you will honor me"* (Psalm 50:15). That is the deal. Not, impress me and I might help. Call on me. Bring me your trouble. I will deliver you, and the deliverance itself will honor me. God is honored when you need Him and come. Hebrews says, *"Let's therefore draw near with boldness to the throne of grace, that we may receive mercy and may find grace for help in time of need"* (Hebrews 4:16). The needy who call are the ones who glorify Him most.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God needed nothing, so He gave everything. Christ came not to be served but to serve, and gave Himself on the cross for people who had nothing to offer. He rose, and He still invites you to call. Bring Him your trouble today. That is the offering He wants.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you approach God as though you must supply something to Him — or as one invited to call on Him in need?

◆

DAY 96 · APRIL 6 · PSALM 50 (VV. 16–23)

You Thought I Was Like You

> *"You have done these things, and I kept silent. You thought that I was just like you."*
> — PSALM 50:21

The last part of Psalm 50 turns sharp. God speaks to people who know the words of faith but do not live them: *"What right do you have to declare my statutes, that you have taken my covenant on your lips, since you hate instruction, and throw my words behind you?"* (Psalm 50:16–17). They recite Scripture. They talk about God's covenant. And then they toss His words over their shoulder like trash.

God names the specifics: *"When you saw a thief, you consented with him, and have participated with adulterers. You give your mouth to evil. Your tongue frames deceit"* (Psalm 50:18–19). Then closer to home: *"You sit and speak against your brother. You slander your own mother's son"* (Psalm 50:20). Gossip about family. Winking at theft. Looking the other way at unfaithfulness. These are not people outside the church, far from the faith. They are inside it, holding hymnals and singing along.

Then the line that should make every comfortable believer sit up: *"You have done these things, and I kept silent. You thought that I was just like you"* (Psalm 50:21). God was patient. He did not strike them down right away. And they took His patience as approval. They decided God must share their standards — that He did not mind, because nothing bad happened. That is one of the most dangerous mistakes a person can make. Paul warns about it: *"do you despise the riches of his goodness, forbearance, and patience, not knowing that the goodness of God leads you to repentance?"* (Romans 2:4).

God's silence is not agreement, however long it lasts. It is mercy, giving time to turn. Peter says, *"The Lord is not slow concerning his promise, as some count slowness; but he is patient with us, not wishing that anyone should perish, but that all should come to repentance"* (2 Peter 3:9). And the psalm ends with a door left open: *"Whoever offers the sacrifice of thanksgiving glorifies me, and prepares his way so that I will show God's salvation to him"* (Psalm 50:23). Even after the rebuke, salvation is offered. God does not expose you to crush you. He exposes you to save you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God's patience with you was purchased. Christ bore the full rebuke against sin at the cross, so that the silence of heaven toward you could be mercy and not neglect. He rose, and His kindness still leads to repentance. Stop assuming God is like you. Turn to Him while He waits.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you quietly assumed God shares your standards because He has been patient with you?

◆

DAY 97 · APRIL 7 · PSALM 51 (VV. 1–6)

Have Mercy on Me

"Have mercy on me, God, according to your loving kindness."
— PSALM 51:1

Psalm 51 has a heading that tells you exactly when it was written: after the prophet Nathan came to David, after David had taken Bathsheba and arranged her husband's death. Nathan told him a story and then said, *"You are the man"* (2 Samuel 12:7). And David broke. This psalm is what came out of him. It is the most honest confession in the Bible, written by a king who had lost every right to ask for anything.

He starts where he must: *"Have mercy on me, God, according to your loving kindness. According to the multitude of your tender mercies, blot out my transgressions"* (Psalm 51:1). Not according to his record. Not according to his good deeds or his years of service. According to God's loving kindness and tender mercies. He has nothing to plead but God's own character, and he knows it. He does not even try to bargain. That is the only ground anyone ever has, king or beggar, then or now.

Then he asks for cleansing: *"Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity. Cleanse me from my sin. For I know my transgressions. My sin is constantly before me"* (Psalm 51:2–3). He sees it. He cannot stop seeing it. And he goes deeper than the deed: *"Behold, I was born in iniquity. My mother conceived me in sin"* (Psalm 51:5). David is not making an excuse. He is saying the problem is not just what he did. It is who he is. The adultery and the murder came out of a heart that was bent from the start.

That is the difference between managing sin and confessing it. Many people treat sin as surface behavior — a bad habit to cut back on, a slip to avoid next time. David sees it as a condition of the heart that only God can heal. And he knows who he has really sinned against: *"Against you, and you only, I have sinned, and done that which is evil in your sight"* (Psalm 51:4). The tax collector in Jesus' story prayed the same way: *"God, be merciful to me, a sinner!"* (Luke 18:13). Jesus said that man went home justified.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

David asked God to blot out his transgressions, and God did it at the cross. Christ took David's sin and yours into His own body and paid for every one. He rose, and the record is clean. You do not have to manage your sin. Confess it to the One who has already blotted it out.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you treat your sin as surface behavior to manage, or — like David — as a heart only God can heal?

◆

DAY 98 · APRIL 8 · PSALM 51 (VV. 7–13)

Create in Me a Clean Heart

> *"Create in me a clean heart, O God. Renew a right spirit within me."*
> **— PSALM 51:10**

David keeps praying: *"Purify me with hyssop, and I will be clean. Wash me, and I will be whiter than snow"* (Psalm 51:7). Hyssop was the plant the priests used to sprinkle blood and water in the old cleansing rituals. David reaches for the oldest picture of purification he knows. And he is confident: wash me, and I will be clean. Not partly clean. Not mostly clean. Whiter than snow.

Then he asks for joy to come back: *"Let me hear joy and gladness, that the bones which you have broken may rejoice"* (Psalm 51:8). Bones God has broken. The guilt has been crushing him, and he knows God's hand has been heavy on him. But he does not ask God to leave him alone. He asks God to heal what He has broken, and to make the broken bones dance. *"Hide your face from my sins, and blot out all of my iniquities"* (Psalm 51:9).

And then the request at the center of the psalm: *"Create in me a clean heart, O God. Renew a right spirit within me"* (Psalm 51:10). Create. That is the word used in Genesis for God making the heavens and the earth out of nothing. David is not asking God to touch up his old heart or improve it. He is asking for a new one, made from scratch, by God's own hand. He knows his heart cannot be repaired, however hard he tries. It has to be replaced.

That is what God promised through Ezekiel: *"I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you will be clean. I will cleanse you from all your filthiness, and from all your idols"* (Ezekiel 36:25). And Jesus told Nicodemus it is the only way: *"unless one is born anew, he can't see God's Kingdom"* (John 3:3). Paul says it has happened to everyone in Christ: *"Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old things have passed away. Behold, all things have become new"* (2 Corinthians 5:17). You cannot improve your way into a clean heart. You ask God to create one. And He does: *"Restore to me the joy of your salvation"* (Psalm 51:12).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The blood of Christ is better than hyssop. It cleanses the conscience and makes you whiter than snow. He died to wash you and rose to give you a new heart by His Spirit. Stop trying to improve the old heart today. Ask Him to create a clean one in you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you trying to improve a heart that needs to be created new?

◆

DAY 99 · APRIL 9 · PSALM 51 (VV. 14–19)

A Broken and Contrite Heart

> *"The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit. O God, you will not despise a broken and contrite heart."*
> — PSALM 51:17

The end of Psalm 51 moves from confession to what comes after. David has asked for a clean heart. Now he asks for a clean mouth: *"Deliver me from the guilt of bloodshed, O God, the God of my salvation. My tongue will sing aloud of your righteousness"* (Psalm 51:14). Notice that he names the bloodshed. He does not soften it. He had a man killed, and he says so. And then he expects to sing. Forgiven people sing.

"Lord, open my lips. My mouth will declare your praise" (Psalm 51:15). He cannot even open his own mouth to praise. God has to do it. That is how deep the guilt had sealed him shut. Then he says something about sacrifice that would have surprised his priests: *"For you don't delight in sacrifice, or else I would give it. You have no pleasure in burnt offering"* (Psalm 51:16). There was no animal for adultery and murder. No offering could cover it. David knew he could not buy his way back.

So what does God want? *"The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit. O God, you will not despise a broken and contrite heart"* (Psalm 51:17). A broken spirit. A crushed heart. That is the offering. Not a cleaned-up life brought as proof. Not a list of good deeds to balance the scale. Just the honest wreckage of a heart that knows it has sinned and has nowhere else to go. God does not despise that. He receives it.

Many people believe they must clean themselves up before they come to God. Get a few weeks of good behavior under their belt. Stop the habit first. Then pray. Psalm 51 says the opposite. Come broken. Come as you are, crushed and contrite. That is not an obstacle to God's welcome. It is the very thing He asks for. Hebrews says the blood of Christ cleanses *"your conscience from dead works to serve the living God"* (Hebrews 9:14). And Paul says God saved *"not by works of righteousness which we did ourselves, but according to his mercy"* (Titus 3:5). You do not bring a clean heart to God. You bring a broken one, and He makes it clean.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was the sacrifice God delighted in, offered once on the cross for every broken sinner. Because of Him, God will never despise your broken heart. He rose to receive the contrite. Stop cleaning yourself up before you come. Bring Him the wreckage today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe you must clean yourself up before coming to God, when He asks for a broken heart?

◆

DAY 100 · APRIL 10 · PSALM 52 (VV. 1–4)

Boasting in Evil

> *"Why do you boast of mischief, mighty man? God's loving kindness endures continually."*
> — PSALM 52:1

Psalm 52 has a heading that ties it to Doeg the Edomite, who told King Saul where David had been hiding and then killed the priests who had helped him. It is a psalm about a man with a high position and a poisonous mouth. And it opens with a question thrown in his face: *"Why do you boast of mischief, mighty man? God's loving kindness endures continually"* (Psalm 52:1). You brag about the harm you do? God's kindness outlasts you.

Then the description of his tongue: *"Your tongue plots destruction, like a sharp razor, working deceitfully"* (Psalm 52:2). A razor. Sharp, quick, and able to cut deep before you even feel it. Words do that. A rumor, a cutting remark, a lie told at the right moment to the right person. James says, *"And the tongue is a fire. The world of iniquity among our members is the tongue, which defiles the whole body"* (James 3:6). One spark can burn down a forest, and one sentence can burn down a reputation that took thirty years to build.

"You love evil more than good, lying rather than speaking the truth. You love all devouring words, you deceitful tongue" (Psalm 52:3–4). Devouring words. Words that eat people up. You have heard them. Maybe you have spoken them. The quick put-down that gets a laugh. The story told about someone who is not in the room. The text message sent in anger. Most people do not think of themselves as Doeg. But most people have used the razor.

The good news is that the same mouth can be redeemed. Paul writes, *"Let no corrupt speech proceed out of your mouth, but only what is good for building others up as the need may be, that it may give grace to those who hear"* (Ephesians 4:29). Grace to those who hear. That is the other use of a tongue. It can cut or it can heal. And notice the line that holds the whole psalm together: God's loving kindness endures continually. Even for those who have used the razor, that kindness is still open, still enduring, still offering a different way to speak.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was cut down by lying tongues — false witnesses, a mocking crowd, a betraying friend. He did not answer with a razor. He answered with silence and then with forgiveness. He rose, and His kindness still endures. Ask Him today to put grace on your tongue instead of a blade.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

How are you using your tongue — to build up, or to cut down?

◆

DAY 101 · APRIL 11 · PSALM 52 (VV. 5–9)

A Green Olive Tree

> *"But as for me, I am like a green olive tree in God's house. I trust in God's loving kindness forever and ever."*
> — PSALM 52:8

After the razor tongue, the psalm announces what God will do to the man who brags about evil: *"God will likewise destroy you forever. He will take you up, and pluck you out of your tent, and root you out of the land of the living"* (Psalm 52:5). Uprooted at last. Pulled out of the ground like a dead tree and thrown aside. The man who seemed so strong turns out to have shallow roots.

And the righteous will see it: *"Behold, this is the man who didn't make God his strength, but trusted in the abundance of his riches, and strengthened himself in his wickedness"* (Psalm 52:7). That is his epitaph. He did not make God his strength. He trusted his money and his own schemes. And when the wind came, he went over. Paul warns the rich in the same way: *"nor have their hope set on the uncertainty of riches, but on the living God"* (1 Timothy 6:17).

Then the contrast: *"But as for me, I am like a green olive tree in God's house. I trust in God's loving kindness forever and ever"* (Psalm 52:8). An olive tree. In that country, olive trees could live for centuries. Their roots go deep into rocky soil. They stay green through dry summers. Some of the trees in Israel today were old when the Romans came. David pictures himself not as a tree that gets uprooted but as one planted in God's house, drawing life from His love.

That is the question for you this morning. Where are your roots? If they are in your money or your reputation or your own strength, they are shallow, and the next storm will find them. If they are in God's loving kindness, they go deep and they hold. Jesus said, *"Remain in me, and I in you. As the branch can't bear fruit by itself unless it remains in the vine, so neither can you, unless you remain in me"* (John 15:4). And David ends with thanks and hope: *"I will give you thanks forever, because you have done it. I will hope in your name, for it is good"* (Psalm 52:9).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was cut down like a tree on Golgotha — uprooted from the land of the living. Then God raised Him, and He became the root from which every believer draws life. Plant yourself in Him today. His loving kindness is the soil that does not dry out.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you drawing your life from God's loving kindness, like a tree in His house, or from shallow soil?

◆

DAY 102 · APRIL 12 · PSALM 53

The Fool Says in His Heart

> *"Every one of them has gone back. They have become filthy together. There is no one who does good, no, not one."*
> — PSALM 53:3

Psalm 53 is almost the same as Psalm 14. Twice the Bible gives you this hard word, as if once might not be enough: *"The fool has said in his heart, 'There is no God.' They are corrupt, and have done abominable iniquity. There is no one who does good"* (Psalm 53:1). The fool in Scripture is not someone with low intelligence. It is someone who lives as if God does not matter, whatever they say with their lips.

"God looks down from heaven on the children of men, to see if there are any who understood, who seek after God" (Psalm 53:2). He is searching for even one. And the report comes back: *"Every one of them has gone back. They have become filthy together. There is no one who does good, no, not one"* (Psalm 53:3). Gone back. Turned around and walked away. Every single one. Paul quotes this in Romans to show that the whole world stands guilty: *"They have all turned away. They have together become unprofitable. There is no one who does good, no, not so much as one"* (Romans 3:12).

It is very easy to read this and think about other people. The atheist on television. The criminal in the news. The neighbor who never goes to church. But the psalm does not let you stand on the sidelines. Every one of them, without exception. That includes the people in the pews. It includes you. The fool says in his heart there is no God — and every time you sin as though God were not watching, some of that fool is speaking in you.

That is not meant to crush you. It is meant to move you out of the category of good people and into the category of rescued people. The psalm ends with a longing: *"Oh that the salvation of Israel would come out of Zion! When God brings back his people from captivity, then Jacob shall rejoice, and Israel shall be glad"* (Psalm 53:6). Salvation from outside. Rescue from Zion. You stop counting yourself among the good, and you start rejoicing among the saved. That is a far better place to stand.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the one who did good — the only one God found when He looked down from heaven. He took the place of the filthy and the turned-back at the cross, and rose to bring His people home from captivity. Stop counting yourself among the good. Rejoice among the rescued.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you still quietly counting yourself among the good people instead of among the rescued?

◆

DAY 103 · APRIL 13 · PSALM 54

By Your Name, Save Me

> *"Save me, God, by your name. Vindicate me in your might."*
> — PSALM 54:1

The heading of Psalm 54 says it was written when the Ziphites went to Saul and told him David was hiding among them. Betrayed again. People David may have trusted, or at least hoped would leave him alone, reported his location to the man trying to kill him. He is hunted, exposed, and running out of places to hide. The wilderness is not as empty as he had hoped. Someone is always watching, and someone is always willing to sell what they see. And he prays: *"Save me, God, by your name. Vindicate me in your might"* (Psalm 54:1).

By your name. In Scripture a name is not just a label. It is who someone is — their character, their reputation, their record. When David asks God to save him by His name, he is asking God to act in keeping with who He is. You promised. You are faithful. You are the God who saves. Act like Yourself. Jesus prayed the same way for His disciples: *"Holy Father, keep them through your name which you have given me"* (John 17:11).

"Hear my prayer, God. Listen to the words of my mouth. For strangers have risen up against me. Violent men have sought after my soul. They haven't set God before them" (Psalm 54:2–3). They have not set God before them. That is the root of their violence. They live as though God is not watching. But David has set God before him, and so his next words are steady: *"Behold, God is my helper. The Lord is the one who sustains my soul"* (Psalm 54:4).

Then something remarkable. David gives thanks for a rescue that has not happened yet: *"I will give thanks to your name, Yahweh, for it is good. For he has delivered me out of all trouble"* (Psalm 54:6–7). He speaks of deliverance in the past tense while still hiding. That is faith. It thanks God for the outcome before the outcome arrives, because it trusts the name. Peter preached that there is one name above all others: *"There is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven that is given among men, by which we must be saved!"* (Acts 4:12).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was handed over by those who should have protected Him. He did not save Himself. He trusted the Father's name, and on the third day the Father vindicated Him by raising Him from the dead. His name saves you now. Thank Him today for a rescue you cannot see yet.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you, like David, give thanks to God's name for a deliverance you cannot see yet?

◆

DAY 104 · APRIL 14 · PSALM 55 (VV. 1–8)

Oh, That I Had Wings

> *“Oh that I had wings like a dove! Then I would fly away, and be at rest.”*
> — PSALM 55:6

Psalm 55 opens with someone at the end of their rope: *“Listen to my prayer, God. Don’t hide yourself from my supplication. Attend to me, and answer me. I am restless in my complaint, and moan”* (Psalm 55:1–2). Restless. Moaning. He cannot settle. And the reason is fear: *“My heart is severely pained within me. The terrors of death have fallen on me. Fearfulness and trembling have come on me. Horror has overwhelmed me”* (Psalm 55:4–5).

Then the wish that almost everyone has felt at some point: *“Oh that I had wings like a dove! Then I would fly away, and be at rest. Behold, then I would wander far off. I would lodge in the wilderness”* (Psalm 55:6–7). Just get out. Leave it all. Find a cabin in the mountains with no phone and no people. Disappear. Change your name. Start over somewhere nobody knows you and nobody needs anything from you. *“I would hurry to a shelter from the stormy wind and storm”* (Psalm 55:8).

You may feel that right now. The marriage is hard. The job is crushing. The church is fighting. The diagnosis is bad. And part of you wants to fly away. That wish is not sinful. David had it, and the Bible keeps it. It is an honest admission that life has become more than you can bear. The question is not whether you feel it. The question is what you do with it. Some people do fly away — into a bottle, into a screen, into an affair, into a new town that turns out to have the same problems.

David does not get wings. He does not fly away. Instead, he brings the wish to God and prays it out. That is the move. Not running from the trouble, but running with the trouble to the One who can carry it. Jesus said, *“Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest”* (Matthew 11:28). The rest David wanted in the wilderness, Christ offers right where you are. You do not need wings. You need Him. And later in this same psalm, David finds the answer: *“As for me, I will call on God. Yahweh will save me”* (Psalm 55:16).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did not fly away from the cross. He could have called legions of angels, but He stayed in the storm and took its full force for you. Then He rose. The rest you long for is in Him, not in escape. Bring Him the wish to fly away today, and find rest where you are.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where do you most want to fly away right now — and could you bring that wish to God?

◆

DAY 105 · APRIL 15 · PSALM 55 (VV. 9–15)

It Was Not an Enemy

> *"But it was you, a man like me, my companion, and my familiar friend."*
> — PSALM 55:13

As Psalm 55 goes on, the reason for David's anguish comes out. It is not just enemies. It is a friend: *"For it was not an enemy who insulted me, then I could have endured it. Neither was it he who hated me who raised himself up against me, then I would have hidden myself from him"* (Psalm 55:12). An enemy, he could handle. You expect enemies to attack. You can brace for them. But this was someone else.

"But it was you, a man like me, my companion, and my familiar friend. We took sweet fellowship together. We walked in God's house with company" (Psalm 55:13–14). A companion. A familiar friend. Someone he worshiped beside. They sat in the same pew, sang the same songs, prayed together. And that person turned on him. David's own trusted counselor Ahithophel once did exactly this, joining Absalom's rebellion (2 Samuel 15:31). Whoever this psalm's friend was, David had let that person close, and closeness is what made the wound so deep.

There is a special pain in being betrayed by someone you worshiped with. It shakes more than the friendship. It shakes your trust in God's people, maybe even in God Himself. You start to wonder who else is pretending. You hold back from new friends. You sit in the back row at church and leave before the last hymn. The betrayal does not stay in one relationship. It spreads like a stain through everything, until even the sweet memories feel spoiled. The years of friendship start to look like years of pretending.

Later in the psalm David describes this kind of friend: *"His mouth was smooth as butter, but his heart was war. His words were softer than oil, yet they were drawn swords"* (Psalm 55:21). Smooth words, sharp heart. Jesus knew this exactly. Judas walked with Him for three years, ate with Him, and then came to the garden: *"Immediately he came to Jesus, and said, 'Hail, Rabbi!' and kissed him"* (Matthew 26:49). A kiss. The sign of friendship used as a signal for arrest. Jesus understands your betrayal from the inside. You can bring it to Him, and He will not be shocked.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was betrayed with a kiss by a man who had shared His bread. He went to the cross for His friends while they ran, and He rose and came back to them with peace. He knows what you carry. Bring Him the friend who turned on you today. He is the Friend who never will.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What betrayal by someone close are you still carrying — and can you bring it to the Christ who was betrayed?

◆

DAY 106 · APRIL 16 · PSALM 55 (VV. 16–23)

Cast Your Burden on the LORD

> *"Cast your burden on Yahweh and he will sustain you. He will never allow the righteous to be moved."*
> — PSALM 55:22

After the anguish and the betrayal, David turns: *"As for me, I will call on God. Yahweh will save me"* (Psalm 55:16). As for me. Whatever the friend did, whatever the enemies are planning, this is what David will do. He will call. And he will call often: *"Evening, morning, and at noon, I will cry out in distress. He will hear my voice"* (Psalm 55:17). Three times a day, the way you eat meals. Prayer becomes the rhythm of his life in trouble, as regular as the clock on the wall and as necessary as bread.

And he is confident he will be heard: *"He has redeemed my soul in peace"* (Psalm 55:18), even *"although there are many who oppose me"* (Psalm 55:18). Peace, while the opposition is still many. God does not always remove the enemies first. Sometimes He gives peace in the middle of them. The storm keeps blowing, and the heart goes still anyway. That is a stranger and better gift than escape.

Then the verse many people have written on cards and taped to refrigerators: *"Cast your burden on Yahweh and he will sustain you. He will never allow the righteous to be moved"* (Psalm 55:22). Cast. Not set down gently. Throw it. Heave it off your shoulders onto His. The burden may be grief, worry, guilt, a person you cannot fix, a situation you cannot change. Whatever it is, the instruction is the same. Throw it on Him, and do not go back to pick it up again when the worry starts at three in the morning.

Peter quoted this idea: *"casting all your worries on him, because he cares for you"* (1 Peter 5:7). Because He cares for you. That is the reason it works. You are not throwing your burden into the void. You are throwing it to Someone who wants to catch it. And notice the promise is not that the burden disappears. It is that He will sustain you. He will hold you up while you carry what remains. The psalm ends with a plain statement of trust that you can borrow today: *"but I will trust in you"* (Psalm 55:23).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ carried the heaviest burden ever carried — the sin of the world — up a hill on His own back. He bore it all the way to death and rose without it. Your burden is not too heavy for Him. Throw it on Him today. He cares for you, and He will hold you up.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What burden are you straining to carry yourself that you could cast on the LORD?

◆

DAY 107 · APRIL 17 · PSALM 56 (VV. 1–6)

When I Am Afraid

"When I am afraid, I will put my trust in you."
— PSALM 56:3

The heading of Psalm 56 places David in Gath, in the hands of the Philistines — the same city where he once pretended to be mad to escape. He is surrounded and outnumbered: *"Be merciful to me, God, for man wants to swallow me up. All day long, he attacks and oppresses me"* (Psalm 56:1). All day long. There is no break in the pressure. *"My enemies want to swallow me up all day long, for they are many who fight proudly against me"* (Psalm 56:2).

Then one of the simplest and most honest lines in the Psalms: *"When I am afraid, I will put my trust in you"* (Psalm 56:3). Notice what it does not say. It does not say, I will never be afraid. It does not say, real believers do not feel fear. It says when. David expects to be afraid. Fear is going to come. The question is what he will do when it arrives. And his answer is: trust.

That is freeing for anyone who feels guilty about being afraid. You may think fear means your faith has failed. You lie awake worried about money, a child, a scan result, and you think a stronger believer would feel calm. But David, a man after God's own heart, says plainly that he gets afraid. Faith is not the absence of fear. It is what you do with the fear when it shows up. You turn toward God with it instead of turning inward.

Then he says it again, stronger: *"In God, I praise his word. In God, I put my trust. I will not be afraid. What can flesh do to me?"* (Psalm 56:4). Now he moves from when I am afraid to I will not be afraid. Trust has done its work. The fear is still possible, but it is no longer in charge. What can flesh do to me? People can do a great deal. They can hurt, slander, even kill. But they cannot touch what God holds. Hebrews picks up the same confidence: *"The Lord is my helper. I will not fear. What can man do to me?"* (Hebrews 13:6). Do not wait to feel unafraid before you trust. Trust in the middle of the rush of fear, and let the fear lose its grip.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was afraid in Gethsemane, so troubled that His sweat fell like blood. He did not pretend otherwise. He trusted the Father with the fear and walked to the cross. He rose, and now He holds you when you are afraid. Turn the next wave of fear into a prayer of trust.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What if, instead of waiting to feel unafraid, you treated the next rush of fear as a call to trust?

◆

DAY 108 · APRIL 18 · PSALM 56 (VV. 7–13)

My Tears in Your Bottle

> *"You count my wanderings. You put my tears into your container. Aren't they in your book?"*
> — PSALM 56:8

David is still in danger in the second half of Psalm 56. His words are twisted, his steps are watched: *"All day long they twist my words. All their thoughts are against me for evil. They conspire and lurk, watching my steps. They are eager to take my life"* (Psalm 56:5–6). And then, in the middle of all that, he says one of the tenderest things anyone has ever said to God.

"You count my wanderings. You put my tears into your container. Aren't they in your book?" (Psalm 56:8). God counts his wanderings — every restless night, every move from hiding place to hiding place, every step of the long years on the run. And God keeps his tears. Not one is wasted. Not one falls unseen. They are collected, kept, and written down. That is how closely God pays attention to sorrow.

Many people feel that their sorrow is invisible. They cry in the car where no one can see. They grieve quietly for years after a loss everyone else has moved on from. They carry a sadness no one asks about. Psalm 56 says none of that is lost. God has a container for your tears and a book where they are recorded. Jesus said, *"But the very hairs of your head are all counted. Therefore don't be afraid. You are of more value than many sparrows"* (Luke 12:7). If He counts hairs, He counts tears.

And the psalm moves from that tenderness to confidence: *"Then my enemies shall turn back in the day that I call. I know this: that God is for me"* (Psalm 56:9). God is for me. That is the conclusion David draws from the tears in the bottle. A God who keeps your tears is not against you. Paul draws the same conclusion: *"If God is for us, who can be against us?"* (Romans 8:31). And the last line looks forward: *"For you have delivered my soul from death, and prevented my feet from falling, that I may walk before God in the light of the living"* (Psalm 56:13). One day the container will be emptied, because *"God will wipe away every tear from their eyes"* (Revelation 7:17).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ wept at Lazarus's tomb and over Jerusalem, and His own tears fell in Gethsemane. He knows what grief is. He died and rose so that one day He would wipe every tear from your eyes. Until then He keeps them all. Your sorrow is not invisible to Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Does your sorrow feel invisible — and how does it change things to know God keeps every tear?

◆

DAY 109 · APRIL 19 · PSALM 57 (VV. 1–6)

In the Shadow of Your Wings

> *“Yes, in the shadow of your wings, I will take refuge, until disaster has passed.”*
> — PSALM 57:1

The heading of Psalm 57 places David in the cave, hiding from Saul. Caves were good hiding places — thick stone walls, narrow entrances, darkness that could swallow a person. Men who were tired and hunted had slept in caves like that for generations. And David was grateful for them. But listen to where he actually says his safety is: *“Be merciful to me, God, be merciful to me, for my soul takes refuge in you. Yes, in the shadow of your wings, I will take refuge, until disaster has passed”* (Psalm 57:1).

He is surrounded by stone, and he talks about wings. The walls of the cave are not his real refuge. God is. The cave could fall. Saul could find the entrance. The stone walls would not save him then. But the shadow of God’s wings is a shelter no army can storm. Ruth found the same refuge when she came to Israel as a stranger: Boaz blessed her as one who had come *“under whose wings you have come to take refuge”* (Ruth 2:12).

Notice also the phrase until disaster has passed. David does not pretend the disaster is not real. He does not say it will never come. He says he will take refuge until it passes. Storms pass. Seasons change. Even the long night in a cave ends. And while he waits, he prays to a God who acts: *“I cry out to God Most High, to God who accomplishes my requests for me”* (Psalm 57:2). Then: *“He will send from heaven, and save me”* (Psalm 57:3).

The danger is real: *“My soul is among lions. I lie among those who are set on fire, even the sons of men, whose teeth are spears and arrows, and their tongue a sharp sword”* (Psalm 57:4). That is how it feels to be surrounded by people who want you gone. But even there, in the middle of the lions, David lifts his eyes: *“Be exalted, God, above the heavens! Let your glory be above all the earth!”* (Psalm 57:5). You may be in a cave right now. Do not trust the stone walls. Trust the wings above them.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ spread His arms on the cross like wings and took the disaster that would have fallen on you. He was laid in a cave-tomb behind a stone, and He came out alive. You are sheltered under those outstretched arms. Stay there until this disaster passes. It will.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What cave are you in right now — and are you trusting the stone walls or the shadow of God’s wings?

◆

DAY 110 · APRIL 20 · PSALM 57 (VV. 7–11)

My Heart Is Steadfast

> *"My heart is steadfast, God. My heart is steadfast. I will sing, yes, I will sing praises."*
> — PSALM 57:7

Still in the cave, still surrounded, David says something that sounds almost impossible: *"My heart is steadfast, God. My heart is steadfast. I will sing, yes, I will sing praises"* (Psalm 57:7). Steadfast. Fixed. Settled. Not wobbling back and forth with every rumor and every noise at the mouth of the cave. He says it twice, as if to make sure his own heart hears it. Sometimes you have to tell your heart the truth more than once before it believes you.

Where does that kind of steadiness come from? Not from his circumstances. Those have not changed. Saul is still hunting him. The lions are still around. It comes from where his heart is fixed. A ship in a storm does not stay put because the sea is calm. It stays put because the anchor is set in something that does not move. A steadfast heart is not a heart that has no trouble. It is a heart anchored to something that does not move. Isaiah says, *"You will keep whoever's mind is steadfast in perfect peace, because he trusts in you"* (Isaiah 26:3).

Then David does something wonderful. He decides to wake up the morning: *"Wake up, my glory! Wake up, lute and harp! I will wake up the dawn"* (Psalm 57:8). He will not wait for the sun to rise before he sings. He will sing until the sun comes up. That is faith praising in the dark, before the light arrives, because it trusts the light is coming. And his song will not stay in the cave: *"I will give thanks to you, Lord, among the peoples. I will sing praises to you among the nations"* (Psalm 57:9).

The reason for the song: *"For your great loving kindness reaches to the heavens, and your truth to the skies"* (Psalm 57:10). God's love is bigger than the cave. It reaches higher than the danger. You may not feel steadfast this morning. Your heart may be swinging from fear to hope and back again every hour. But steadfastness is not a feeling you wait for. It is a fixing of the heart on God's love, said out loud, even twice if necessary. And then the singing starts, even in the dark.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's heart was steadfast all the way to the cross. He set His face toward Jerusalem and did not turn back. In the dark of the tomb He waited, and at dawn on the third day God raised Him. Fix your heart on Him today. Then sing before the sun comes up.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What would it take for your heart to be steadfast in God right now, before the circumstances change?

◆

DAY 111 · APRIL 21 · PSALM 58 (VV. 1–6)

Do You Decree What Is Right?

> *"Do you indeed speak righteousness, silent ones? Do you judge blamelessly, you sons of men?"*
> — PSALM 58:1

Psalm 58 is a hard psalm. It is aimed at corrupt rulers and unjust judges, and it does not soften its words: *"Do you indeed speak righteousness, silent ones? Do you judge blamelessly, you sons of men?"* (Psalm 58:1). The people who are supposed to protect the weak are the ones crushing them. The courts are bent. The officials are bought. And those who should speak up for justice stay silent.

"No, in your heart you plot injustice. You measure out the violence of your hands in the earth" (Psalm 58:2). They plan it. They measure it out. It is not an accident. Then the psalm describes how deep the corruption goes: *"The wicked go astray from the womb. They are wayward as soon as they are born, speaking lies"* (Psalm 58:3). And they will not listen to anyone: *"Their poison is like the poison of a snake, like a deaf cobra that stops its ear"* (Psalm 58:4).

You have probably felt the outrage this psalm expresses. The abuser who walked free on a technicality. The company that poisoned a town and paid a small fine. The official who took bribes and retired with a pension. The strong who bend the rules and never pay. That outrage is not wrong. God shares it. He is not neutral about the oppression of the weak. He sees every rigged scale and every bribed judge, and it angers Him far more than it angers you. The psalm gives you words to bring it to Him instead of letting it eat you from the inside or turning it into revenge.

And the psalm prays fiercely: *"Break their teeth, God, in their mouth"* (Psalm 58:6). It is not polite. But notice who is asked to act. Not the psalmist. God. The anger is handed over. Paul gives the same instruction: *"Don't seek revenge yourselves, beloved, but give place to God's wrath"* (Romans 12:19). When injustice leaves you helpless and outraged, you are not left without recourse. You can bring it to the Judge of all the earth, who will set it right. And you can trust that He will do it better than you ever could.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was condemned by corrupt judges who knew He was innocent. He did not take revenge. He handed His cause to the Father, and the Father overturned that verdict by raising Him from the dead. Bring Him the injustice that is burning in you today. He will judge rightly.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What injustice has left you feeling helpless and outraged — and can you bring it to God?

◆

DAY 112 · APRIL 22 · PSALM 58 (VV. 7–11)

Surely There Is a Reward

> *"Most certainly there is a reward for the righteous. Most certainly there is a God who judges the earth."*
> — PSALM 58:11

The second half of Psalm 58 prays that the wicked will vanish: *"Let them vanish like water that flows away. When they draw the bow, let their arrows be made blunt. Let them be like a snail which melts and passes away"* (Psalm 58:7–8). Water soaking into dry ground. Arrows that fall harmless. A snail drying up in the sun. These are pictures of evil losing its power and disappearing. The psalmist wants injustice to end, and he says so to God, without dressing up the wish in softer words.

Some of the images that follow are hard to read. The psalm speaks of the righteous rejoicing when vengeance comes (Psalm 58:10). It is honest about the longing for justice that rises in people who have watched the wicked prosper for years. Scripture does not hide that longing. It brings it into the open and gives it to God. But it is God's vengeance, not the psalmist's. He prays it. He does not carry it out himself, and neither should you.

Then the conclusion the whole psalm drives toward: *"Most certainly there is a reward for the righteous. Most certainly there is a God who judges the earth"* (Psalm 58:11). That is the line to hold on to. When wrong seems to pay and right seems to cost, this verse says the accounts are not closed. There is a reward. There is a Judge, and He sees. What looks like a world without justice is a world where justice has not yet been fully revealed.

That should keep you from giving up on doing right. Paul writes, *"Let's not be weary in doing good, for we will reap in due season, if we don't give up"* (Galatians 6:9). In due season. Not always right away. The honest worker may be passed over. The faithful spouse may be left. The one who refuses the bribe may lose the contract. But there is a God who judges the earth, and *"it is a righteous thing with God to repay affliction to those who afflict you, and to give relief to you who are afflicted"* (2 Thessalonians 1:6–7). Keep doing right. The reward is certain.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did right every day of His life, and it cost Him everything — rejection, mockery, a cross. It looked as though wrong had paid. Then God raised Him and gave Him the name above every name. Keep doing right today. The God who rewarded Him sees you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you tempted to give up doing right because wrong seems to pay?

◆

DAY 113 · APRIL 23 · PSALM 59 (VV. 1–6)

Deliver Me from My Enemies

> *"Deliver me from my enemies, my God. Set me on high from those who rise up against me."*
> — PSALM 59:1

The heading of Psalm 59 says it was written when Saul sent men to watch David's house to kill him. His wife Michal helped him escape through a window. Imagine it: men outside in the dark, waiting for you to come out the door. That is the setting of this prayer: *"Deliver me from my enemies, my God. Set me on high from those who rise up against me"* (Psalm 59:1).

Then David says something important about why he is being hunted: *"For, behold, they lie in wait for my soul. The mighty gather themselves together against me, not for my disobedience, nor for my sin, Yahweh. I have done no wrong, yet they are ready to attack me"* (Psalm 59:3–4). Not for my sin. This is not suffering David brought on himself. It came from other people's wrong. That is a different kind of pain, and it needs a different kind of prayer. Not a prayer of confession, but a prayer of lament and a cry for rescue from the One who sees what was done.

Some suffering is the fruit of your own choices, and it calls for confession. But some suffering is simply inflicted — by an abusive parent, a dishonest partner, a cruel boss, a drunk driver. You did nothing to deserve it. And if you try to confess your way out of it, you will only add false guilt to real pain. Psalm 59 gives you permission to say plainly: I did not cause this. Someone else did. God, deliver me.

The enemies are described like a pack of dogs: *"They return at evening, howling like dogs, and prowl around the city"* (Psalm 59:6). They think no one is watching: *"For, they say, who hears us?"* (Psalm 59:7). But God hears. *"But you, Yahweh, laugh at them"* (Psalm 59:8). The prowling dogs are not as strong as they think. And Jesus knew what it was to suffer for no wrong of His own. The thief on the cross said of Him: *"this man has done nothing wrong"* (Luke 23:41). He understands suffering that is not your fault, and He does not ask you to pretend it was.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ suffered for no sin of His own. Men waited for Him in the dark of Gethsemane, and He did nothing to deserve their violence. He bore it, died, and rose. He understands the suffering others have inflicted on you. Bring it to Him plainly today, without false guilt.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you carrying a suffering that came from others' wrong, not your own — and have you brought it to God as that?

◆

DAY 114 · APRIL 24 · PSALM 59 (VV. 7–11)

O My Strength, I Will Watch for You

"Oh, my Strength, I watch for you, for God is my high tower."
— PSALM 59:9

The men outside David's house keep circling. Psalm 59 describes them again: *"Behold, they spew with their mouth. Swords are in their lips"* (Psalm 59:7). Their words cut. They are confident no one will hold them to account. And they prowl at night, around and around, the way a pack of stray dogs circles a farmhouse looking for a way in. If you have ever lain awake listening to something outside the window, you know the feeling.

But David has a different place to put his eyes: *"But you, Yahweh, laugh at them. You scoff at all the nations"* (Psalm 59:8). The threats that keep David awake do not frighten God at all. He is not nervous about the dogs. And so David makes a choice about where he will watch: *"Oh, my Strength, I watch for you, for God is my high tower"* (Psalm 59:9). Not, I watch the dogs. I watch for You. The same eyes, pointed in a different direction, and the whole night changes.

That is a decision you face many times a day. You can watch the threats. Check the news again. Scroll the account balance again. Replay the conversation again. Watch every move of the person who is against you. Or you can watch for God. Look for His help, His timing, His hand. Both kinds of watching take energy. One leaves you more afraid. The other leaves you steadier, because it fixes your eyes on the high tower instead of the low ground where the dogs are.

And David believes God will go ahead of him: *"My God will go before me with his loving kindness"* (Psalm 59:10). God's love walks out the door first, ahead of him. Before David faces the danger, God's kindness is already there. Then a strange request: *"Don't kill them, or my people may forget"* (Psalm 59:11). He wants God's justice to be seen and remembered, not just done quickly. He is thinking about what others will learn. Even in danger, David is thinking about God's glory, not only his own escape. Paul says in Christ *"we are more than conquerors through him who loved us"* (Romans 8:37).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ kept watch in Gethsemane while His friends slept and His enemies came with torches. He did not watch the threat. He watched for His Father, and He went to the cross trusting Him. On the third day the Father answered. Turn your eyes from the prowling threats to Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you watching anxiously at the threats prowling around you — or watching for God?

◆

DAY 115 · APRIL 25 · PSALM 59 (VV. 12–17)

I Will Sing of Your Strength

> *"But I will sing of your strength. Yes, I will sing aloud of your loving kindness in the morning."*
> — PSALM 59:16

Psalm 59 repeats its picture of the prowling enemies one more time: *"At evening let them return. Let them howl like a dog, and go around the city. They shall wander up and down for food, and wait all night if they aren't satisfied"* (Psalm 59:14–15). Night after night they come back. They are restless and hungry and never satisfied. Evil is like that. It does not rest, and it is never satisfied for long. It keeps circling, looking for something to consume.

Then comes the turn, and it is all about morning: *"But I will sing of your strength. Yes, I will sing aloud of your loving kindness in the morning. For you have been my high tower, a refuge in the day of my distress"* (Psalm 59:16). The dogs howl at night. David sings in the morning. The darkness belongs to the prowlers, but the dawn belongs to God, and David plans to meet it with a song. He does not wait to see how the day goes before deciding whether to praise. He decides the night before.

Many people dread the morning. The alarm goes off and the weight lands before your feet hit the floor. The meeting you have been dreading. The appointment. The conversation. The first day back after the funeral. Psalm 59 does not deny that mornings can be hard. But it teaches you to start them differently — not with the howling of the night still in your ears, but with a song about God's strength and love.

And the song is not based on feelings. It is based on history: *"For you have been my high tower"* (Psalm 59:16). Have been. David looks back at all the times God held him up and lets that past faithfulness shape how he meets the new day. Lamentations says God's mercies *"are new every morning. Great is your faithfulness"* (Lamentations 3:23). Then the psalm ends with the line that sums up everything: *"To you, my strength, I will sing praises. For God is my high tower, the God of my mercy"* (Psalm 59:17). The God of my mercy. Begin tomorrow morning with that name on your lips.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The darkest night in history ended on a morning. The women came to the tomb at dawn and found it empty, because Christ had risen. Every morning since has belonged to Him. Whatever morning you dread, meet it singing of His strength. The tomb is still empty.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What dreaded morning are you facing — and can you begin to sing of God's strength before it arrives?

◆

DAY 116 · APRIL 26 · PSALM 60 (VV. 1–6)

You Have Made Us Drink

> *"You have shown your people hard things. You have made us drink the wine that makes us stagger."*
> — PSALM 60:3

Psalm 60 begins with defeat: *"God, you have rejected us. You have broken us down. You have been angry. Restore us, again"* (Psalm 60:1). The heading connects it to a time of war, when the nation took a heavy blow. And the psalmist does not blame bad luck or poor strategy. He says God has done this: *"You have broken us down"* (Psalm 60:1). That is a hard thing to say, and a hard thing to hear. Most people would rather blame anyone but God. The psalmist goes straight to the One in charge.

Then he describes it like an earthquake: *"You have made the land tremble. You have torn it. Mend its fractures, for it quakes"* (Psalm 60:2). The ground itself is cracked. Nothing feels stable. And then this: *"You have shown your people hard things. You have made us drink the wine that makes us stagger"* (Psalm 60:3). Hard things. A cup that makes them stumble like someone who has had too much to drink. Their legs will not hold them.

You may know that kind of providence. The loss that came out of nowhere. The diagnosis. The child who walked away from the faith. The business that failed after you prayed over every decision. You believe God is sovereign, and so you know this hard thing passed through His hands. That does not make it easier. Sometimes it makes it harder. But the psalm shows you what to do with it. You bring it to Him and ask Him to restore. You do not have to understand it first. You only have to bring it.

And notice the hope tucked into the hard words: *"You have given a banner to those who fear you"* (Psalm 60:4). A banner. A flag to rally around. Even in defeat, God gives His people something to gather under. Then: *"So that your beloved may be delivered, save with your right hand, and answer us"* (Psalm 60:5). Your beloved. They are staggering, but they are still beloved. Jesus drank the cup of staggering too. In Gethsemane He prayed, *"Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done"* (Luke 22:42). He drank it all.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ drank the cup that makes people stagger — the full cup of God's wrath against sin. He drained it on the cross so you would never have to. Then He rose. The hard providence you are drinking now is not that cup. It is a cup He has already sweetened. Bring it to Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What hard providence has left you staggering — and will you bring it to the God who calls you beloved?

◆

DAY 117 · APRIL 27 · PSALM 60 (VV. 7–12)

With God We Shall Do Valiantly

> *"Through God we will do valiantly, for it is he who will tread down our adversaries."*
> — PSALM 60:12

In the second half of Psalm 60, God Himself speaks from His sanctuary, naming one region after another as His own: *"Gilead is mine, and Manasseh is mine. Ephraim also is the defense of my head. Judah is my scepter"* (Psalm 60:7). Then the nations around Israel: *"Moab is my wash basin. I will throw my sandal on Edom"* (Psalm 60:8). Moab is a basin to wash His feet in. Edom is where He tosses His shoes. Even the enemy nations belong to Him. Nothing on the map is outside His reach, including the places that have hurt you most.

Then the question that comes after defeat: *"Who will bring me into the strong city? Who has led me to Edom? Haven't you, God, rejected us? You don't go out with our armies, God"* (Psalm 60:9–10). They lost because God was not with them. And they know it. That honesty matters. They do not blame the generals or the weather. They admit that they went out without God, and they lost. That kind of admission is the start of every real recovery.

Then the line that God has been burning into them through the loss: *"Give us help against the adversary, for the help of man is vain"* (Psalm 60:11). Vain. Empty. Useless. The help of man cannot save. They had trusted their own strength, and it failed. Sometimes God lets you lose so that you will learn this. The failure is not punishment for its own sake. It is a lesson in where help really comes from. Losses can burn away false confidence the way fire burns away dross.

And then the confidence that rises from the ashes: *"Through God we will do valiantly, for it is he who will tread down our adversaries"* (Psalm 60:12). Through God. Not through themselves. Their courage is real, but it is borrowed. The victory is His. Paul learned the same thing in his weakness: *"My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness"* (2 Corinthians 12:9). You may be in a season of loss right now. Let it teach you where help comes from. Then you will do valiantly, through Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ looked defeated on the cross. His followers scattered, His enemies celebrated. But through that apparent defeat God trod down sin, death, and the devil, and on the third day Christ rose victorious. Your losses are not the end. Through Him you will do valiantly.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What false confidence is God burning away through your losses, to teach you that the help of man is vain?

◆

DAY 118 · APRIL 28 · PSALM 61 (VV. 1–4)

The Rock Higher Than I

> *"From the end of the earth, I will call to you when my heart is overwhelmed. Lead me to the rock that is higher than I."*
> — PSALM 61:2

"Hear my cry, God. Listen to my prayer" (Psalm 61:1). Psalm 61 is short and simple, the prayer of someone far from home. *"From the end of the earth, I will call to you when my heart is overwhelmed"* (Psalm 61:2). The end of the earth. Maybe David was in exile, maybe on the run, maybe just feeling as far from God as a person can feel. Wherever he was, he called from there. Distance did not stop the prayer. There is no place on the map too far from God to call from. A hospital bed, a prison cell, a lonely apartment in a strange city, a barn at midnight — all of them are in range.

Overwhelmed. That word is honest. It is what you feel when there is too much — too much grief, too much pressure, too many problems at once. The heart cannot hold it all. It spills over. And in that moment, David asks for something specific: *"Lead me to the rock that is higher than I"* (Psalm 61:2). Not a rock at his own level. A rock higher than he is. Somewhere he cannot climb on his own.

Most people look for refuge at their own level. A manageable fix. A plan they can carry out. A friend who can help. A new strategy. None of those are bad. But when the heart is overwhelmed, a refuge at your own level will be overwhelmed too. You need something higher than yourself, higher than the flood, higher than the problem. And you need someone to lead you there, because you cannot get there alone. A drowning person does not climb a cliff. Someone has to reach down.

David remembers that God has been that rock before: *"For you have been a refuge for me, a strong tower from the enemy"* (Psalm 61:3). He has been there before. And Paul says who the Rock is: *"they drank of a spiritual rock that followed them, and the rock was Christ"* (1 Corinthians 10:4). The Rock higher than you came down to your level so He could lift you to His. When your heart is overwhelmed today, do not look for a fix at your own height. Ask Him to lead you up to the Rock.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Rock higher than you, and He came all the way down to the end of the earth to find you. He went lower still, into the grave, and rose to lift you up. When your heart is overwhelmed today, ask Him to lead you to Himself.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you looking for a refuge at your own level, when you need the Rock that is higher than you?

◆

DAY 119 · APRIL 29 · PSALM 61 (VV. 4–8)

The Shelter of Your Wings

> *"I will dwell in your tent forever. I will take refuge in the shelter of your wings."*
> — PSALM 61:4

Psalm 61 moves from a cry for help to a longing for home: *"I will dwell in your tent forever. I will take refuge in the shelter of your wings"* (Psalm 61:4). Forever. Not just for this crisis. Not just until things settle down. David wants to live in God's presence permanently. The tent is the tabernacle, the place where God met His people. David wants to move in and never leave. He is not looking for a weekend retreat. He is looking for an address.

That is a deeper longing than many prayers reach. A lot of prayer is about passing troubles — get me through this week, fix this problem, heal this sickness. Those are good prayers, and God hears them. But Psalm 61 goes further. It wants God Himself, not just His help. It wants a home with Him, not just a rescue from Him. The difference is like the difference between calling a friend when your truck breaks down and wanting to sit on their porch every evening.

And David knows God has given him a place: *"For you, God, have heard my vows. You have given me the heritage of those who fear your name"* (Psalm 61:5). A heritage. An inheritance. Something passed down and kept. He belongs to the family of those who fear God, and that belonging is not up for grabs. No enemy can take it away. Then the psalm prays for the king: *"You will prolong the king's life. His years will be for generations. He shall be enthroned in God's presence forever"* (Psalm 61:6–7).

Read that last line again: enthroned in God's presence forever. No human king lives that long. But one King does. Christ sits at the Father's right hand, enthroned forever, and His people dwell with Him. Revelation says, *"Behold, God's dwelling is with people, and he will dwell with them, and they will be his people"* (Revelation 21:3). The tent David longed for is the presence of Christ. So the psalm closes with a promise of daily faithfulness: *"So I will sing praise to your name forever, that I may fulfill my vows daily"* (Psalm 61:8). Forever, and also daily.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the King enthroned in God's presence forever. He died outside the city and rose to bring you into the Father's house to stay. You do not have to visit God only in crisis. You can dwell with Him. Move in today, and stay.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is your longing for God mostly for His help in passing troubles — or for His presence forever?

◆

DAY 120 · APRIL 30 · PSALM 62 (VV. 1–6)

For God Alone My Soul Waits

“My soul rests in God alone. My salvation is from him.”
— PSALM 62:1

“My soul rests in God alone. My salvation is from him” (Psalm 62:1). One word carries the whole verse: alone. Not God plus my savings. Not God plus my health. Not God plus my good reputation. God alone. David says his soul rests there, and only there. That is a hard thing to say and mean, because most people rest on God and a few other things besides, just in case.

Then he says it again: *“He alone is my rock, my salvation, and my fortress. I will never be greatly shaken”* (Psalm 62:2). Notice the word greatly. David does not claim he will never be shaken at all. He will be. Life shakes everyone. Grief shakes. Illness shakes. Betrayal shakes. Getting older shakes. But he will not be greatly shaken, because his foundation is not in the things that move. It is in the God who does not.

And the trouble is real: *“How long will you assault a man? Would all of you throw him down, like a leaning wall, like a tottering fence?”* (Psalm 62:3). That is a vivid picture, and a painful one. A fence leaning in the wind. A wall that looks like it is about to fall over. The enemies see David that way — weak, wobbling, ready to push over. *“They fully intend to throw him down from his lofty place. They delight in lies. They bless with their mouth, but they curse inwardly”* (Psalm 62:4).

Then David talks to his own soul: *“My soul, wait in silence for God alone, for my expectation is from him”* (Psalm 62:5). Wait in silence. Stop arguing with yourself. Stop scheming at night. Stop reaching for the backup plan. My expectation is from Him. That is a call to let go of every lesser security you have been resting on alongside God. You may keep your savings and your plans, and use them well. God gave them. But your soul rests in Him alone. And then the refrain comes back, stronger: *“He alone is my rock and my salvation, my fortress. I will not be shaken”* (Psalm 62:6). This time, not even greatly. Just not shaken.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ rested in the Father alone. On the cross every other support was stripped away — friends, reputation, life itself — and He trusted the Father still. God raised Him. Let go of the lesser things you lean on today. Rest your soul in God alone, through Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What lesser securities are you resting on alongside God — and what would it mean to rest in Him alone?

◆

DAY 121 · MAY 1 · PSALM 62 (VV. 7–12)

Pour Out Your Heart

> *"Trust in him at all times, you people. Pour out your heart before him. God is a refuge for us."*
> — PSALM 62:8

The second half of Psalm 62 turns from David's own soul to everyone listening: *"Trust in him at all times, you people. Pour out your heart before him. God is a refuge for us"* (Psalm 62:8). At all times. Not only when things are calm, and not only when they fall apart. Every day, every season, the same trust. And the way into that trust is surprising. Not tidy prayers. Not careful words. Pour out your heart.

Pouring is not neat. When you pour out a bucket, everything goes — the clean water and the mud at the bottom. That is what David invites you to do with God. Tell Him the fear. Tell Him the anger. Tell Him the thing you are ashamed to admit you feel. Lamentations uses the same picture: *"Pour out your heart like water before the face of the Lord"* (Lamentations 2:19). God is not shocked by what comes out. He is a refuge, and a refuge is a place where you can stop pretending.

Then the psalm weighs everything else people trust: *"Surely men of low degree are just a breath, and men of high degree are a lie. In the balances they will go up. They are together lighter than a breath"* (Psalm 62:9). Put every human being on a scale — the poor and the important together — and the scale barely moves. Lighter than a breath. No person, however impressive, can carry the weight of your soul. And then a warning about money: *"If riches increase, don't set your heart on them"* (Psalm 62:10). Enjoy it if it comes. Do not lean on it.

The psalm ends with two things David has heard from God: *"God has spoken once; twice I have heard this, that power belongs to God. Also to you, Lord, belongs loving kindness"* (Psalm 62:11–12). Power and love. Both belong to God. A God with power but no love would be frightening. A God with love but no power would be useless in a crisis. The God of Psalm 62 has both. That is why you can pour out your heart to Him. He is strong enough to do something with what you pour, and kind enough to want to.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

In Gethsemane Christ poured out His heart to the Father with loud cries and tears, and He was heard. He then poured out His life on the cross for you, and rose. He knows what it is to empty yourself before God. Pour out your heart to Him today, mud and all.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What have you been holding back from God that you need to pour out before Him?

◆

DAY 122 · MAY 2 · PSALM 63 (VV. 1–6)

My Soul Thirsts for You

> *"God, you are my God. I will earnestly seek you. My soul thirsts for you."*
> **— PSALM 63:1**

The heading of Psalm 63 places David in the wilderness of Judah. Dry hills, no shade, a sun that bleaches the rocks white. And out of that place comes one of the most intense prayers in the Bible: *"God, you are my God. I will earnestly seek you. My soul thirsts for you. My flesh longs for you, in a dry and weary land, where there is no water"* (Psalm 63:1). His body is thirsty. His soul is thirstier.

Notice how it opens: you are my God. Not a god. Not the God of other people. Mine. David's faith is personal before it is anything else. And because God is his, David seeks Him earnestly. The word suggests early, eager searching — like someone up before dawn going to the well. He does not wait for God to show up. He goes looking, because the thirst will not let him sit still.

Then he remembers better days: *"So I have seen you in the sanctuary, watching your power and your glory"* (Psalm 63:2). He has tasted God before, in worship, among the people. Now he is far away, and the memory makes him thirstier. And then a line that turns everything around: *"Because your loving kindness is better than life, my lips shall praise you"* (Psalm 63:3). Better than life. Not just better than comfort or success. Better than staying alive. If David had to choose between God's love and breathing, he would choose the love.

That is a strange thing to say in a desert, where staying alive is the main concern. But it is the key to satisfaction: *"My soul shall be satisfied as with the richest food"* (Psalm 63:5). Satisfied in a wilderness. Not because the wilderness changed, but because God is enough. And David keeps seeking Him even at night: *"when I remember you on my bed, and think about you in the night watches"* (Psalm 63:6). Jesus promised that kind of satisfaction to a thirsty woman at a well: *"whoever drinks of the water that I will give him will never thirst again"* (John 4:14). The desert can be the place where you finally drink.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ thirsted on the cross so that your thirst could be answered forever. He went into the dry land of death and came out on the third day as the spring of living water. His love is better than life. Seek Him early today, and drink.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What would it look like to seek God earnestly in your own dry and weary land?

◆

DAY 123 · MAY 3 · PSALM 63 (VV. 7–11)

My Soul Clings to You

"My soul stays close to you. Your right hand holds me up."
— PSALM 63:8

"For you have been my help. I will rejoice in the shadow of your wings" (Psalm 63:7). David is still in the wilderness, but now he is singing. He remembers that God has helped him before, and that memory becomes a shelter. The shadow of the wings again — the picture of a bird covering its young. In a land with no shade, God is the shade.

Then the line that connects this psalm to the thesis of this whole year: *"My soul stays close to you. Your right hand holds me up"* (Psalm 63:8). The Hebrew verb behind *"stays close"* is davaq, to cling, to stick, to cleave. It is the same verb Psalm 119:25 uses for the soul that clings to the dust: *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). Here the soul clings to God instead.

That is the whole movement of revival in one word. The same soul that once clung to the dirt now clings to God. The grip has not changed. The object has. The same hands that once held on to the dirt now hold on to the hem of His robe, the way a frightened child holds a parent's coat in a crowd. Before, you held on to what could not save you — the habit, the comfort, the old way of thinking. Now you hold on to the One who can. Ruth did this with Naomi: *"but Ruth stayed with her"* (Ruth 1:14). She would not let go. That is how a revived soul holds on to God.

And look at the second half of the verse: your right hand holds me up. You cling to God, but God is also holding you. Your grip may be weak. Some days it barely holds. But the right hand of God does not depend on how tightly you hold. Jesus said, *"He who comes to me I will in no way throw out"* (John 6:37). The clinging is real, and it matters. But underneath your clinging is His holding. When your fingers slip, His do not. And the psalm ends with confidence: *"But the king shall rejoice in God"* (Psalm 63:11).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The soul that clung to the dust now clings to Christ, because Christ came down into the dust to be held onto. He was laid in the ground and rose with a grip death could not break. Hold on to Him today. When your grip weakens, His right hand holds you up.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What does your soul cling to most often — and what would it mean to cling to God instead?

◆

DAY 124 · MAY 4 · PSALM 64 (VV. 1–5)

Hide Me from the Secret Plots

> *"Hide me from the conspiracy of the wicked, from the noisy crowd of the ones doing evil"*
> — PSALM 64:2

"Hear my voice, God, in my complaint. Preserve my life from fear of the enemy" (Psalm 64:1). David is not only afraid of enemies. He is afraid of the fear. Fear itself has become a threat. It is keeping him up. It is draining him. He asks God to protect him from that, too. You may know the feeling. Sometimes the worry is worse than the thing you are worried about. It wakes you at night, tightens your chest at work, and follows you into every conversation until you cannot remember what peace felt like.

Then he asks to be hidden: *"Hide me from the conspiracy of the wicked, from the noisy crowd of the ones doing evil"* (Psalm 64:2). A conspiracy is quiet. A crowd is loud. Both are coming at him. Some enemies plot behind closed doors. Others shout in the street. Either way, David cannot defend himself against all of them. He needs a hiding place, and he asks God to be it. Not a wall he builds, not an alliance he forms, but God Himself, close enough to cover him.

And look at what the enemies use: *"who sharpen their tongue like a sword, and aim their arrows, deadly words"* (Psalm 64:3). Deadly words. That is the attack. Not swords and arrows of metal, but tongues and words. Gossip, slander, lies, half-truths told to the right people. James says, *"nobody can tame the tongue. It is a restless evil, full of deadly poison"* (James 3:8). Words can wreck a reputation, a marriage, a church, a career. And they fly from hiding places: *"to shoot innocent men from ambushes"* (Psalm 64:4).

The worst part is how confident the plotters are: *"They encourage themselves in evil plans. They talk about laying snares secretly. They say, 'Who will see them?'"* (Psalm 64:5). Who will see? They are sure no one is watching. They are wrong. God sees every whispered plan and every poisoned word. You may be the target of words like that right now. You do not have to fight them all yourself. You can ask God to hide you, and He sees what they think is hidden.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was the target of a conspiracy — leaders meeting in secret, false witnesses rehearsing their lies. He did not hide from it. He let it take Him to the cross, and then God raised Him and exposed every plot. Ask Him to hide you today from the words aimed at you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What words aimed at you have been keeping you afraid — and will you ask God to hide you?

◆

DAY 125 · MAY 5 · PSALM 64 (VV. 6–10)

God Shoots His Arrow

> *"But God will shoot at them. They will be suddenly struck down with an arrow."*
> — PSALM 64:7

The plotters in Psalm 64 think they have it all worked out: *"They plot injustice, saying, 'We have made a perfect plan!' Surely man's mind and heart are cunning"* (Psalm 64:6). A perfect plan. Every detail covered. No way it can fail, they think. You have probably met people who think that way — the ones who always seem to get away with it, who have an answer for every question and a lawyer for every problem.

Then one word changes everything: *"But God will shoot at them. They will be suddenly struck down with an arrow"* (Psalm 64:7). But God. They shot their arrows of words from ambush. Now God shoots His. Their arrows were aimed at the innocent. His are aimed at the guilty. And notice the word suddenly. They shot suddenly at the innocent (Psalm 64:4). Now they are struck suddenly themselves. What they did comes back on them in the same shape.

Then this: *"Their own tongues shall ruin them"* (Psalm 64:8). The tool they used becomes the thing that brings them down. Proverbs says it plainly: *"Whoever digs a pit shall fall into it. Whoever rolls a stone, it will come back on him"* (Proverbs 26:27). The book of Esther tells the story of Haman, who built a gallows for Mordecai: *"So they hanged Haman on the gallows that he had prepared for Mordecai"* (Esther 7:10). God has a way of turning evil back on itself, often in the very shape it was meant to take.

And the result is not just justice. It is worship: *"All mankind shall be afraid. They shall declare the work of God, and shall wisely ponder what he has done. The righteous shall be glad in Yahweh, and shall take refuge in him"* (Psalm 64:9–10). People see what God did and stop to think about it. The righteous do not gloat. They take refuge. They are glad in the LORD, not in the downfall of their enemies. That is the right response when God acts. You do not have to shoot back. God will, in His own time and His own way. Your job is to hide in Him and rejoice in Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The plotters thought they had a perfect plan when they crucified Christ. God turned it upside down. The cross they built to destroy Him became the place where sin and death were destroyed, and on the third day He rose. You do not have to shoot back. Take refuge in Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you tempted to shoot back at those who wronged you, instead of trusting God to act?

◆

DAY 126 · MAY 6 · PSALM 65 (VV. 1–6)

You Atone for Our Transgressions

"Sins overwhelmed me, but you atoned for our transgressions."
— PSALM 65:3

Psalm 65 is a song of thanksgiving, and it starts in a quiet place: *"Praise waits for you, God, in Zion. Vows shall be performed to you"* (Psalm 65:1). Praise waits. It is ready, sitting in the temple, waiting to rise. Then: *"You who hear prayer, all men will come to you"* (Psalm 65:2). God hears prayer. That is His nature, and it has never changed. And because He hears, people from everywhere come to Him.

Then the honest confession at the heart of the psalm: *"Sins overwhelmed me, but you atoned for our transgressions"* (Psalm 65:3). Overwhelmed. That is the right word for what sin does. It piles up until it is over your head. You cannot see over it. You cannot dig out from under it. Every attempt to fix it adds more weight. And then: but you. The same turn that runs through the whole Bible. Sin overwhelmed. God atoned. The weight that crushed you was lifted by Someone else's hands.

To atone means to cover, to make amends, to pay what is owed so that the relationship can be restored. The psalmist could not do that for himself. God did it. In the old covenant God gave the sacrifices as the way. Hebrews says, *"apart from shedding of blood there is no remission"* (Hebrews 9:22). And in the new covenant the sacrifice is Christ Himself. John writes, *"the blood of Jesus Christ, his Son, cleanses us from all sin"* (1 John 1:7). All sin. The overwhelming pile has been dealt with.

Then the psalm speaks of the joy of being brought near: *"Blessed is the one whom you choose and cause to come near, that he may live in your courts"* (Psalm 65:4). You choose. You cause to come near. God is the one who draws people in. Paul says God *"chose us in him before the foundation of the world"* (Ephesians 1:4). You did not climb into God's courts. He brought you in. And the psalm says what happens there: *"We will be filled with the goodness of your house"* (Psalm 65:4). Overwhelmed by sin, then filled with goodness. That is the gospel in one psalm.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Your sins overwhelmed you, and Christ took the full weight of them at the cross. He atoned for your transgressions with His own blood. On the third day He rose, and the pile is gone. You have been brought near. Live today in the goodness of His house.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have your sins felt overwhelming — and have you let yourself believe God has atoned for them?

◆

DAY 127 · MAY 7 · PSALM 65 (VV. 7–13)

The Year Crowned with Goodness

> *"You crown the year with your bounty. Your carts overflow with abundance."*
> — PSALM 65:11

The second half of Psalm 65 moves from the temple to the fields. It is one of the great harvest songs of Scripture: *"You visit the earth, and water it. You greatly enrich it. The river of God is full of water. You provide them grain, for so you have ordained it"* (Psalm 65:9). God waters the earth. He enriches it. He provides grain. Every harvest is His work before it is the farmer's work. The farmer plows and plants, but he cannot make one drop of rain or one seed sprout.

Look at how close the psalm gets to the ground: *"You drench its furrows. You level its ridges. You soften it with showers. You bless it with a crop"* (Psalm 65:10). Anyone who has worked a garden knows those words. The hard clay that needs rain. The furrows that crack in a dry spell. The relief when the shower comes and the dirt goes dark and soft. God is described as a farmer tending His field, working the soil with His own hands.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"You crown the year with your bounty. Your carts overflow with abundance"* (Psalm 65:11). The year is crowned. Like a king at a coronation, the year is given a crown of good things. And the carts are so full they spill over. Wherever God's wagon wheels go, the ground is left richer. Even the wild places share in it: *"The wilderness grasslands overflow. The hills are clothed with gladness"* (Psalm 65:12).

It is easy to forget where food comes from. You buy it in a store, wrapped in plastic, and never think about the rain that grew it or the God who sent the rain. Paul told a crowd that God *"didn't leave himself without witness, in that he did good and gave you rains from the sky and fruitful seasons, filling our hearts with food and gladness"* (Acts 14:17). Every meal is a witness. Every harvest is a sermon. And the psalm ends with the whole valley singing: *"They shout for joy! They also sing"* (Psalm 65:13). Give thanks today for the next thing you eat. It came from His cart.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the grain of wheat that fell into the ground and died, and then rose to bear much fruit. Through Him God has crowned your year with a goodness no drought can take away. Thank Him today for the food on your table, and for the Bread of Life who gives it meaning.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where have you stopped noticing God's bounty in the ordinary things of your life?

◆

DAY 128 · MAY 8 · PSALM 66 (VV. 1–7)

Come and See What God Has Done

> *"Come, and see God's deeds— awesome work on behalf of the children of men."*
> — PSALM 66:5

Psalm 66 opens with a call to the whole planet: *"Make a joyful shout to God, all the earth! Sing to the glory of his name! Offer glory and praise!"* (Psalm 66:1–2). All the earth. Not just Israel. Not just the people in the temple. Everyone, everywhere. The praise of God is meant to be global. And the psalm even gives the words: *"Tell God, 'How awesome are your deeds!'"* (Psalm 66:3).

Then an invitation: *"Come, and see God's deeds— awesome work on behalf of the children of men"* (Psalm 66:5). Come and see. Faith is not just believing something you have been told, though it starts there. It is looking at what God has actually done. And the psalm points to one deed in particular: *"He turned the sea into dry land. They went through the river on foot. There, we rejoiced in him"* (Psalm 66:6). The Red Sea. The Jordan. Water parting so the people could walk through on dry ground.

Exodus tells it: *"The children of Israel went into the middle of the sea on the dry ground, and the waters were a wall to them on their right hand, and on their left"* (Exodus 14:22). Walls of water on either side, and a path down the middle. That is what God does. He makes a way where there is no way. He opens paths through things that should drown you. And He does it on behalf of the children of men — for people, for you.

Then the psalm says who is in charge: *"He rules by his might forever. His eyes watch the nations"* (Psalm 66:7). The God who opened the sea still rules. He still watches. The same power that split the water is at work now, though usually more quietly. Come and see. Look back at your own life. Where did God open a path you could not have made? Where did He bring you through water that should have closed over you? Those are His deeds too. Tell Him how awesome they are. Then tell someone else, because the psalm is not only a prayer. It is an invitation to bring others to see.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The greatest deed God ever did was opening a path through death itself. Christ went down into the grave like Israel into the sea, and came up on the other side alive. Because He passed through, you will too. Come and see what God has done in Him, and praise Him for it today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where in your own life has God opened a path through water that should have drowned you?

◆

DAY 129 · MAY 9 · PSALM 66 (VV. 8–13)

You Have Kept Us Among the Living

> *"who preserves our life among the living, and doesn't allow our feet to be moved."*
> — PSALM 66:9

"Praise our God, you peoples! Make the sound of his praise heard" (Psalm 66:8). The psalm calls the nations to praise again, and then says why: God is the one *"who preserves our life among the living, and doesn't allow our feet to be moved"* (Psalm 66:9). Still alive. Still standing. That is the first reason to praise. It sounds small until you remember everything that could have ended you and did not.

Then the psalm says something that does not sound like praise at first: *"For you, God, have tested us. You have refined us, as silver is refined"* (Psalm 66:10). Refining silver is hot work. The ore is crushed and melted, and the impurities rise to the surface and are skimmed away. Over and over, until the metal is pure. Malachi pictures God the same way: *"he will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver"* (Malachi 3:3). The refiner sits close to the fire. He does not walk away. He watches until he can see his own face in the silver.

And the psalm does not soften what the refining felt like: *"You brought us into prison. You laid a burden on our backs. You allowed men to ride over our heads. We went through fire and through water"* (Psalm 66:11–12). Prison. Burdens. People trampling them. Fire and flood. That is not a gentle season. You may be in one now. The heat is real. The weight is real. And you may wonder whether God has lost track of you in the furnace.

But listen to how the verse ends: *"but you brought us to the place of abundance"* (Psalm 66:12). Through fire and water, and out the other side into abundance. The fire was not the destination. Isaiah gives the promise: *"When you pass through the waters, I will be with you, and through the rivers, they will not overflow you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be burned"* (Isaiah 43:2). Peter says the testing proves *"your faith, which is more precious than gold that perishes even though it is tested by fire"* (1 Peter 1:7). The refiner knows exactly how long to leave the silver in. He is bringing you through.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went through the fire of God's judgment and the waters of death, and the Father brought Him out into the abundance of resurrection life. He walks with you through your fire now. You will not be consumed. The Refiner is watching, and the place of abundance is ahead.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What fire or flood are you passing through — and can you trust that God is bringing you to abundance?

◆

DAY 130 · MAY 10 · PSALM 66 (VV. 14–20)

God Has Listened

> *"But most certainly, God has listened. He has heard the voice of my prayer."*
> — PSALM 66:19

Psalm 66 turns from the voice of the whole people to the voice of one person in its last verses. The psalmist has a personal story to tell: *"Come and hear, all you who fear God. I will declare what he has done for my soul"* (Psalm 66:16). Earlier the invitation was come and see. Now it is come and hear. He wants to tell you what God did for him, one person to another, the way you might stop a neighbor in the driveway to tell them some news.

"I cried to him with my mouth. He was extolled with my tongue" (Psalm 66:17). He prayed, and he praised in the same breath. Then a sobering line: *"If I cherished sin in my heart, the Lord wouldn't have listened"* (Psalm 66:18). Cherished. Held close. Treasured. Not sin that you struggle with and hate, but sin you keep and love and refuse to give up. That kind of sin puts a wall between you and God. Proverbs says it straight: *"He who conceals his sins doesn't prosper, but whoever confesses and renounces them finds mercy"* (Proverbs 28:13).

That is a warning, but it is not the end. The psalmist did not cherish his sin. He brought it to God. And so: *"But most certainly, God has listened. He has heard the voice of my prayer"* (Psalm 66:19). Most certainly. There is no doubt in his voice. God listened. God heard. The prayer did not bounce off the ceiling or disappear into silence. It reached the ear of God, and God answered.

The psalm ends with a blessing that holds two things together: *"Blessed be God, who has not turned away my prayer, nor his loving kindness from me"* (Psalm 66:20). His prayer and God's love were both kept close. God did not turn away either one. John writes with the same confidence: *"This is the boldness which we have toward him, that if we ask anything according to his will, he listens to us"* (1 John 5:14). He listens. If you have been praying and wondering whether anyone hears, let this psalm settle it. God listens. And if something you are holding close is in the way, let it go. He has not turned away His love.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ prayed in Gethsemane with loud crying and tears, and He was heard. Because the Father listened to His Son, He listens to everyone who comes through Him. Let go of whatever sin you are cherishing, and pray. God has not turned away His love from you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is there a sin you are cherishing that you need to release — and do you believe God listens when you pray?

◆

DAY 131 · MAY 11 · PSALM 67

That Your Way May Be Known

"May God be merciful to us, bless us, and cause his face to shine on us."
— PSALM 67:1

Psalm 67 begins with words that echo the old priestly blessing: *"May God be merciful to us, bless us, and cause his face to shine on us"* (Psalm 67:1). Israel's priests spoke a blessing over the people: *"Yahweh bless you, and keep you. Yahweh make his face to shine on you, and be gracious to you"* (Numbers 6:24–25). This psalm takes that blessing and turns it into a prayer — a request for mercy, for blessing, and for the light of God's face.

But the next line tells you why they want the blessing: *"That your way may be known on earth, and your salvation among all nations"* (Psalm 67:2). That. The blessing is not the end. It has a purpose. God's people want to be blessed so that the whole world will know Him. A blessing kept to yourself is only half of what God intended. Abraham was told the same thing long before: he was blessed so that all the families of the earth would be blessed through him. The light shines on you so that it can shine through you to others.

Many people pray for blessing as if it ended at their own front door. Bless my family. Bless my job. Bless my health. All good prayers. But Psalm 67 widens the circle: *"Let the peoples praise you, God. Let all the peoples praise you. Oh let the nations be glad and sing for joy"* (Psalm 67:3–4). The psalm cannot stop thinking about the nations. Every people, every language, every corner of the map. God's blessing on Israel was meant to spill over to everyone.

Jesus sent His disciples out with the same purpose: *"Go and make disciples of all nations"* (Matthew 28:19). And John saw where it ends: *"a great multitude, which no man could count, out of every nation and of all tribes, peoples, and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb"* (Revelation 7:9). The psalm closes: *"God will bless us. All the ends of the earth shall fear him"* (Psalm 67:7). You are blessed so that others may know. Think today about who in your life does not yet know His way, and how His blessing on you might reach them.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God's face shone on the world in the face of Jesus Christ. He died for people from every nation and rose to send His good news to the ends of the earth. His blessing on you was never meant to stop with you. Let it reach someone today who does not yet know His way.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you asking God to bless you for your own sake — or so that His way may be known through you?

◆

DAY 132 · MAY 12 · PSALM 68 (VV. 1–7)

Father of the Fatherless

> *"A father of the fatherless, and a defender of the widows, is God in his holy habitation."*
> — PSALM 68:5

Psalm 68 opens like a procession, God marching out ahead of His people: *"Let God arise! Let his enemies be scattered! Let them who hate him also flee before him"* (Psalm 68:1). These are the words Israel sang when the ark of the covenant set out in the wilderness. God going ahead, enemies scattering like smoke in the wind: *"As smoke is driven away, so drive them away"* (Psalm 68:2).

Then the psalm calls for praise: *"Sing to God! Sing praises to his name! Extol him who rides on the clouds"* (Psalm 68:4). He rides on the clouds. He is high and mighty, King of the heavens. And then, right after that picture of majesty, the psalm tells you who this great God cares about: *"A father of the fatherless, and a defender of the widows, is God in his holy habitation"* (Psalm 68:5). The One who rides the clouds stoops down to the orphan and the widow.

That is the character of God. His greatness does not make Him distant. It makes Him able to help the people no one else will help. The fatherless child whose dad walked out or died. The widow alone in a house too quiet. God says He is their father and their defender. James says, *"Pure religion and undefiled before our God and Father is this: to visit the fatherless and widows in their affliction"* (James 1:27). God does it first. His people follow. When a church brings a meal to a widow or sits with a child whose father is gone, it is acting like its Father.

Then the next line: *"God sets the lonely in families. He brings out the prisoners with singing"* (Psalm 68:6). The lonely in families. That is what the church is meant to be — a family for people who have none. If you are lonely today, this verse is for you. God has a place for you among His people. And if you are not lonely, look around. Someone near you is. Jesus promised His followers, *"I will not leave you orphans. I will come to you"* (John 14:18). The God who rides the clouds has room at His table for every orphan.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ, the eternal Son, was cut off on the cross so that orphans could be adopted. Through Him God has predestined people for adoption as His children. He rose, and now He sets the lonely in families. If you are lonely today, you have a Father. Find your place among His people.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where do you feel fatherless or alone — and who near you needs to be set in God's family?

◆

DAY 133 · MAY 13 · PSALM 68 (VV. 8–14)

You Provided for the Needy

> *"Your congregation lived therein. You, God, prepared your goodness for the poor."*
> — PSALM 68:10

Psalm 68 remembers the wilderness years, when God led His people from Egypt to the promised land: *"The earth trembled. The sky also poured down rain at the presence of the God of Sinai"* (Psalm 68:8). Sinai shook when God came down. The sky opened. And then the rain kept coming, not as judgment but as gift: *"You, God, sent a plentiful rain. You confirmed your inheritance when it was weary"* (Psalm 68:9).

Weary. God's people were weary in the wilderness. Forty years of walking, complaining, failing, starting again. And God did not leave them in their weariness. He did not wait for them to deserve help. They had grumbled about the manna, longed for Egypt, built a golden calf. Still the rain came. He sent rain. He strengthened what was tired. That is how He treats His people still. When you are worn out from the long road, He does not lecture you. He sends rain. It may come as a friend's phone call, a verse that lands at the right moment, a night of good sleep, a door opening you did not expect.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Your congregation lived therein. You, God, prepared your goodness for the poor"* (Psalm 68:10). Prepared. God planned ahead. Before His people arrived, He had already made ready what they would need. His goodness was waiting for them. And notice who it was for: the poor. Not the rich, who could take care of themselves. The ones with nothing. God sets the table for those who cannot set their own, and He does not ask them to pay at the door.

That runs through the whole Bible. Mary sang it when she was carrying Jesus: *"He has filled the hungry with good things. He has sent the rich away empty"* (Luke 1:53). And Jesus said it to His disciples: *"Blessed are you who are poor, God's Kingdom is yours"* (Luke 6:20). If you feel poor today — in money, in strength, in faith — this verse is for you. God has already prepared His goodness for you. You do not have to earn it or find it. You only have to come and receive what He has made ready.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ became poor so that you could be made rich in Him. He went into the wilderness of the cross for you and rose to prepare a place where the poor are filled with good things. His goodness is already waiting. Come to Him today with empty hands.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe God has already prepared His goodness for you, even in your poverty?

◆

DAY 134 · MAY 14 · PSALM 68 (VV. 15–21)

He Leads Out the Prisoners

> *"You have ascended on high. You have led away captives."*
> — PSALM 68:18

Psalm 68 pictures God going up to Zion in victory, like a king returning from war with his captives and treasure: *"The chariots of God are tens of thousands and thousands of thousands. The Lord is among them, from Sinai, into the sanctuary"* (Psalm 68:17). Then the line Paul would later quote about Jesus: *"You have ascended on high. You have led away captives. You have received gifts among people, yes, among the rebellious also"* (Psalm 68:18).

Paul reads this as a picture of Christ's ascension: *"Therefore he says, 'When he ascended on high, he led captivity captive, and gave gifts to people'"* (Ephesians 4:8). Jesus went up in triumph. He led captivity captive — He took the powers that held people in chains and put them in chains instead. And He gave gifts to His people from the spoils of His victory. Colossians says, *"Having stripped the principalities and the powers, he made a show of them openly, triumphing over them in it"* (Colossians 2:15). The cross that looked like defeat was the place of victory.

And notice who receives the gifts: *"yes, among the rebellious also"* (Psalm 68:18). Even the rebellious. Not only the faithful and the good. The ones who fought against Him. The ones who ran from Him. They receive gifts too, so *"that Yah God might dwell there"* (Psalm 68:18). God wants to live among rebels made new. That is good news if you have ever felt you rebelled too long or ran too far. There is no distance from God that His gifts cannot cross.

Then the psalm turns to praise: *"Blessed be the Lord, who daily bears our burdens, even the God who is our salvation"* (Psalm 68:19). Daily. Every single day He carries what you cannot. *"God is to us a God of deliverance. To Yahweh, the Lord, belongs escape from death"* (Psalm 68:20). Escape from death belongs to Him. Jesus said, *"I was dead, and behold, I am alive forever and ever. Amen. I have the keys of Death and of Hades"* (Revelation 1:18). He holds the keys. He leads the prisoners out, and no door He opens can be locked again.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ ascended on high after breaking the power of death, and He led the captives out behind Him. He gives gifts even to the rebellious, and He carries your burdens every day. Whatever has held you captive, He holds its keys. Follow Him out today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What still holds you captive — and do you believe the ascended Christ has already led it captive?

◆

DAY 135 · MAY 15 · PSALM 68 (VV. 22–28)

Summon Your Power, O God

> *"Your God has commanded your strength. Strengthen, God, that which you have done for us."*
> — PSALM 68:28

The middle of Psalm 68 holds some of the fiercest language in the Psalms. God promises to bring His people back *"from the depths of the sea"* (Psalm 68:22), and the images of judgment on His enemies that follow are hard to read. Scripture does not hide that God will one day bring justice on everything that opposes Him. But the psalm does not stay there. It turns to a procession. The point of the judgment is not destruction for its own sake. It is the clearing of the road so that God's people can come home and worship. Every enemy scattered is a path opened for the King and those who follow Him.

"They have seen your processions, God, even the processions of my God, my King, into the sanctuary" (Psalm 68:24). A parade into the temple. And the psalm describes it like a festival: *"The singers went before, the minstrels followed after, among the ladies playing with tambourines"* (Psalm 68:25). Music, singing, tambourines. The whole community following their King into His house. Then the call: *"Bless God in the congregations"* (Psalm 68:26).

And look at who is in the line: *"There is little Benjamin, their ruler, the princes of Judah, their council, the princes of Zebulun, and the princes of Naphtali"* (Psalm 68:27). Little Benjamin, the smallest tribe, at the front. The great tribe of Judah behind. Northern tribes and southern tribes together. Small and large, near and far, all walking in the same procession. God's people are not one kind of person. They are every kind, gathered behind one King. Your church should look like that too — old and young, rich and poor, the ones who sing loud and the ones who barely whisper, all walking the same direction.

Then the prayer: *"Your God has commanded your strength. Strengthen, God, that which you have done for us"* (Psalm 68:28). God commands strength. He gives it. And then the people ask Him to finish what He started. Strengthen what You have done. That is a good prayer for anyone who has seen God begin something and fears it will fall apart. Paul prayed to the God *"who is able to do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think"* (Ephesians 3:20). What God starts, He is able to strengthen.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the King at the head of the procession, and He has made room for little Benjamin and great Judah alike. He died to gather a people from every kind and rose to lead them into His Father's house. Ask Him today to strengthen what He has already begun in you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What has God begun in you that you need to ask Him to strengthen?

◆

DAY 136 · MAY 16 · PSALM 68 (VV. 29–35)

He Gives Power to His People

> *"You are awesome, God, in your sanctuaries. The God of Israel gives strength and power to his people. Praise be to God!"*
> — PSALM 68:35

Psalm 68 ends with the whole world joining the song. Kings bring gifts: *"Because of your temple at Jerusalem, kings shall bring presents to you"* (Psalm 68:29). Nations that once fought God come with open hands: *"Princes shall come out of Egypt. Ethiopia shall hurry to stretch out her hands to God"* (Psalm 68:31). Egypt, the old oppressor. Ethiopia, far to the south. All of them coming to worship.

"Sing to God, you kingdoms of the earth! Sing praises to the Lord!" (Psalm 68:32). That is the end of the story the Bible tells. Not one nation saved and the rest left behind, but people from everywhere singing to the same God. The magi came from the east to worship Jesus: *"Opening their treasures, they offered to him gifts: gold, frankincense, and myrrh"* (Matthew 2:11). That was the beginning of Psalm 68's promise coming true, a few foreigners on camels kneeling in a small house in Bethlehem.

Then the psalm lifts its eyes to the sky: *"To him who rides on the heaven of heavens, which are of old; behold, he utters his voice, a mighty voice"* (Psalm 68:33). He rides on the oldest heavens. When He speaks, His voice is mighty. And then: *"Ascribe strength to God! His excellency is over Israel, his strength is in the skies"* (Psalm 68:34). All strength belongs to Him. None of it is self-made. The strongest arm on earth is borrowed, and the breath that moves it can be taken back in a moment.

And the last line tells you what God does with all that strength: *"You are awesome, God, in your sanctuaries. The God of Israel gives strength and power to his people. Praise be to God!"* (Psalm 68:35). He gives it. The God of the heavens does not hoard His strength. He hands it to His people. You may feel weak today. Tired, drained, empty. The psalm does not tell you to dig deeper. It tells you that strength is a gift from the God who has all of it. Paul knew this: *"I can do all things through Christ, who strengthens me"* (Philippians 4:13). Ask for it. He gives.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was crucified in weakness and raised in power, and now He gives that strength to His people. The God who rides the heavens hands His strength to the weak. You do not have to manufacture it today. Ask the risen Christ for strength, and receive it.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you trying to manufacture strength, instead of receiving it as God's gift?

◆

DAY 137 · MAY 17 · PSALM 69 (VV. 1–6)

The Waters Have Come Up

"Save me, God, for the waters have come up to my neck!"
— PSALM 69:1

Psalm 69 is quoted again and again in the New Testament, and it begins underwater: *"Save me, God, for the waters have come up to my neck!"* (Psalm 69:1). Up to the neck. One more inch and there is no more air. Then: *"I sink in deep mire, where there is no foothold. I have come into deep waters, where the floods overflow me"* (Psalm 69:2). No foothold. Nothing solid to stand on. Every step sinks deeper.

And he is exhausted from crying for help: *"I am weary with my crying. My throat is dry. My eyes fail looking for my God"* (Psalm 69:3). He has called so long that his voice is gone. He has looked so long that his eyes ache. You may know that kind of prayer — the one you have prayed every night for months, the one that seems to go nowhere, until you are almost too tired to pray it again.

The reason for the flood is people: *"Those who hate me without a cause are more than the hairs of my head"* (Psalm 69:4). Without a cause. He did not provoke them. They hate him anyway. Jesus quoted this line about Himself on the night He was betrayed: they hated Him without a cause. And then the psalmist adds a strange detail: *"I have to restore what I didn't take away"* (Psalm 69:4). He is paying for something he did not steal. That is exactly what Christ did at the cross. He paid back what He never took.

But this psalmist is honest that he is not sinless: *"God, you know my foolishness. My sins aren't hidden from you"* (Psalm 69:5). That is the difference between David and Jesus. David suffered partly for his own sin. Jesus suffered entirely for the sins of others, yours included. And David prays for the people watching him: *"Don't let those who wait for you be shamed through me"* (Psalm 69:6). He does not want his collapse to discourage anyone else. Even with the water at his neck, he is thinking of others. And he is still calling. That is the point. When the water rises, keep calling. God hears from the deep.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went into the deepest water there is. He was hated without a cause and paid back what He never took, all the way to the cross. The flood closed over Him, and on the third day He came up. When the water reaches your neck, call to Him. He knows the deep.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What water has risen to your neck — and are you still calling, even when your voice is tired?

◆

DAY 138 · MAY 18 · PSALM 69 (VV. 7–12)

Zeal for Your House

> *"For the zeal of your house consumes me. The reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me."*
> — PSALM 69:9

The psalmist is suffering, and he says why: *"Because for your sake, I have borne reproach. Shame has covered my face"* (Psalm 69:7). For Your sake. He is not being mocked for doing wrong. He is being mocked for loving God. And it has cost him at home too: *"I have become a stranger to my brothers, an alien to my mother's children"* (Psalm 69:8). His own family treats him like an outsider. Faith has made him strange to the people who knew him best. Holidays are tense. Conversations go quiet when he walks into the kitchen.

Then the line the disciples remembered when Jesus cleared the temple: *"For the zeal of your house consumes me. The reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me"* (Psalm 69:9). When Jesus made a whip and drove out the money changers, *"His disciples remembered that it was written, 'Zeal for your house will eat me up'"* (John 2:17). Jesus cared so much about God's house that it consumed Him. It led Him to the cross.

And Paul quotes the second half of the verse: *"For even Christ didn't please himself. But, as it is written, 'The reproaches of those who reproached you fell on me'"* (Romans 15:3). The insults aimed at God landed on Jesus. He took them. Every curse thrown at heaven, every sneer at the Father, fell on the Son. He stood between God and the anger of the world, and let it hit Him, the way a man steps in front of a blow meant for someone he loves.

That changes how you think about being mocked for your faith. It is not pleasant. The psalmist did not enjoy it: *"When I wept and I fasted, that was to my reproach. When I made sackcloth my clothing, I became a byword to them"* (Psalm 69:10–11). Even his grief was mocked. *"Those who sit in the gate talk about me. I am the song of the drunkards"* (Psalm 69:12). The leaders gossiped. The drunks made up songs. But if you are mocked for loving God, you are standing where Christ stood. The reproaches that fall on you fell on Him first. You are in good company.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was consumed by zeal for His Father's house, and it led Him to the cross. He let every insult aimed at God land on Him. Then the Father raised Him and honored Him above all. If you are mocked for loving God today, you are standing where He stood.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Has love for God cost you anything with the people around you — and can you see Christ standing there with you?

◆

DAY 139 · MAY 19 · PSALM 69 (VV. 13–18)

Answer Me in Your Steadfast Love

> *"Answer me, Yahweh, for your loving kindness is good. According to the multitude of your tender mercies, turn to me."*
> — PSALM 69:16

In the middle of the mockery, the psalmist turns to God: *"But as for me, my prayer is to you, Yahweh, in an acceptable time"* (Psalm 69:13). But as for me. Whatever everyone else is saying, this is what he will do. He will pray. And he asks God to answer by His own character: *"God, in the abundance of your loving kindness, answer me in the truth of your salvation"* (Psalm 69:13).

Then the cry for rescue, still from the water: *"Deliver me out of the mire, and don't let me sink. Let me be delivered from those who hate me, and out of the deep waters. Don't let the flood waters overwhelm me, neither let the deep swallow me up. Don't let the pit shut its mouth on me"* (Psalm 69:14–15). The pit like a mouth, about to close. The deep like a throat, about to swallow. He is begging not to be eaten by the dark. Anyone who has lain awake at three in the morning with a fear too big to name knows that prayer.

And then he gives God his reason: *"Answer me, Yahweh, for your loving kindness is good. According to the multitude of your tender mercies, turn to me"* (Psalm 69:16). For Your loving kindness is good. He does not say, answer me because I deserve it. He says, answer me because You are good. That is the only reason that works. Your merit runs out. God's mercy does not. And there is a multitude of it — more tender mercies than he can count, more than enough for this night and every night after it.

"Don't hide your face from your servant, for I am in distress. Answer me speedily! Draw near to my soul and redeem it" (Psalm 69:17–18). Draw near. He wants God close. Not just rescue from a distance, but presence. Hebrews says Jesus, *"in the days of his flesh, having offered up prayers and petitions with strong crying and tears to him who was able to save him from death, and having been heard"* (Hebrews 5:7). Christ prayed like this, and He was heard. Pray it today. Answer me, because You are good.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ prayed with strong crying and tears to the One who could save Him from death, and He was heard. The pit did not keep its mouth shut on Him. He rose. Ask God to answer you today, not because of what you have done, but because His loving kindness is good.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you asking God to answer you on the basis of your merit — or on the basis of His goodness?

◆

DAY 140 · MAY 20 · PSALM 69 (VV. 19–24)

Reproaches Have Broken My Heart

> *“Reproach has broken my heart, and I am full of heaviness. I looked for some to take pity, but there was none; for comforters, but I found none.”*
> — PSALM 69:20

“You know my reproach, my shame, and my dishonor. My adversaries are all before you” (Psalm 69:19). The psalmist knows God sees all of it. Every insult, every shameful moment, every person who turned on him. Nothing is hidden. And then he tells God what it has done to him: *“Reproach has broken my heart, and I am full of heaviness”* (Psalm 69:20). A broken heart. A heavy chest. Words do that. They can break what no fist could reach, and the break can last for years.

Then the loneliest line in the psalm: *“I looked for some to take pity, but there was none; for comforters, but I found none”* (Psalm 69:20). He looked around for someone to sit with him. No one. He searched for a friend to say, I am sorry this is happening. No one came. That is one of the hardest kinds of suffering — not only the pain itself, but having no one to share it with. The hospital room with no visitors. The funeral where people say the wrong things. The phone that never rings after the news spreads.

Then a detail the Gospels saw fulfilled at the cross: *“They also gave me poison for my food. In my thirst, they gave me vinegar to drink”* (Psalm 69:21). Matthew writes that at Golgotha *“they gave him sour wine to drink mixed with gall”* (Matthew 27:34). And John records that Jesus said He was thirsty, and *“they put a sponge full of the vinegar on hyssop, and held it at his mouth”* (John 19:28–29). The comforter He looked for did not come. The friends had fled. And His enemies gave Him vinegar.

The psalm then turns to harsh prayers against the enemies (Psalm 69:22–24), which Paul later applied to those who rejected the Messiah (Romans 11:9–10). They are words of judgment, prayed by a sufferer and left in God’s hands. But hold on to the line before them. Christ knew what it was to look for comfort and find none. Because He was alone, you never have to be. If you are looking for a comforter today and cannot find one, He is the one who came.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ looked for comforters on the cross and found none. His friends had fled, and His enemies gave Him vinegar. He was alone so you would never be. He rose, and He sends His Spirit, the Comforter, to stay with you. If no one else has come, He has.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you been looking for comfort and finding none — and have you let Christ be the One who comes?

◆

DAY 141 · MAY 21 · PSALM 69 (VV. 25–30)

I Will Praise God with a Song

> *"I will praise the name of God with a song, and will magnify him with thanksgiving."*
> — PSALM 69:30

Psalm 69 continues its prayers against the enemies: *"Let their habitation be desolate. Let no one dwell in their tents"* (Psalm 69:25). Then the reason: *"For they persecute him whom you have wounded. They tell of the sorrow of those whom you have hurt"* (Psalm 69:26). They kick a man when he is down. They gossip about the grief of people already suffering. And the psalmist asks God to deal with them. These are hard words, and the psalm does not apologize for them. Scripture keeps them so that sufferers have somewhere to put the anger.

How should you read prayers like this? They are not instructions to curse people. Jesus said, *"love your enemies, bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who mistreat you and persecute you"* (Matthew 5:44). The imprecatory psalms are something different. They are cries for justice handed to God. The sufferer does not take revenge. He asks the Judge of all the earth to act. And in Christ, the justice they ask for fell first on Him at the cross, so that even enemies could be forgiven.

Then the psalm turns, sharply: *"But I am in pain and distress. Let your salvation, God, protect me"* (Psalm 69:29). Still in pain. Still distressed. Nothing has changed outside. And yet the next line is a song: *"I will praise the name of God with a song, and will magnify him with thanksgiving"* (Psalm 69:30). From pain to praise in one breath. Not because the pain is gone, but because God's salvation is sure, and he has decided to trust it before he can see it.

That is one of the deep patterns of the Psalms. Lament leads to praise, not by skipping the hurt but by walking through it to the God on the other side. The psalmist does not wait for everything to be fixed before he sings. He sings from inside the distress. You can do that too. Your circumstances may not change today. But you can magnify God with thanksgiving in the middle of them, because His salvation does not depend on how today goes. Sing anyway.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ sang a hymn with His disciples on the night He was betrayed, and then walked out to Gethsemane. He bore the justice the psalms cry out for, so that even enemies can be forgiven. He rose. You can sing from inside your distress today, because His salvation is sure.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you praise God with a song while you are still in pain — not after, but now?

◆

DAY 142 · MAY 22 · PSALM 69 (VV. 31–36)

The LORD Hears the Needy

> *"For Yahweh hears the needy, and doesn't despise his captive people."*
> — PSALM 69:33

Psalm 69 ends in a very different place from where it started. It began with water at the neck. It ends with praise that fills the earth. And between them is a line about what God values: *"It will please Yahweh better than an ox, or a bull that has horns and hoofs"* (Psalm 69:31). Thanksgiving pleases God more than the biggest animal sacrifice. A grateful heart is worth more to Him than a prize bull. You cannot buy His favor, but you can thank Him for what He has already given, and that thanks delights Him.

Then the psalm thinks about everyone watching: *"The humble have seen it, and are glad. You who seek after God, let your heart live"* (Psalm 69:32). The humble see what God did for the sufferer, and they are encouraged. Let your heart live. That is what testimony does. When someone is rescued, others who are struggling see it and find hope. Your story of God's faithfulness may be what keeps someone else's heart alive. Do not keep it to yourself.

And then the line that gives this day its name: *"For Yahweh hears the needy, and doesn't despise his captive people"* (Psalm 69:33). He hears the needy. He does not despise His people in their captivity. Whatever has you bound — a habit, a grief, a circumstance you cannot escape — God has not turned His face away in disgust. He hears. He does not look down on you for being trapped. He comes to set you free. Isaiah prophesied of the Messiah: He has been sent *"to proclaim liberty to the captives"* (Isaiah 61:1).

The psalm ends by widening to the whole creation: *"Let heaven and earth praise him; the seas, and everything that moves therein!"* (Psalm 69:34). Then a promise about the future: *"For God will save Zion, and build the cities of Judah"* (Psalm 69:35). And the last line: *"Those who love his name shall dwell therein"* (Psalm 69:36). From the depths of the water to dwelling in the city of God. That is the path of every soul God rescues. Water to the neck, and then a home. He hears the needy. He is hearing you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ proclaimed liberty to the captives in Nazareth, and then He went to the cross to purchase it. He rose, and He does not despise His captive people. Whatever binds you today, He hears you. Let your heart live. The One who came up out of the deep is coming for you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe the LORD hears you in your need and does not despise you in your captivity?

◆

DAY 143 · MAY 23 · PSALM 70

Make Haste to Help Me

> *"Hurry, God, to deliver me. Come quickly to help me, Yahweh."*
> — PSALM 70:1

Psalm 70 is only five verses long, and it is almost entirely urgent: *"Hurry, God, to deliver me. Come quickly to help me, Yahweh"* (Psalm 70:1). No long introduction. No careful theology. Just hurry. It is the prayer of someone who has no time left, no energy for long speeches, and no doubt about where help has to come from. Almost the same words appear at the end of Psalm 40. This psalm takes that ending and makes it a whole prayer on its own.

There is something freeing about a prayer like this. Many people think prayers need to be long and polished to be heard. But some of the most honest prayers in Scripture are short. Hurry. Help. Come quickly. When the car is spinning on ice, you do not pray a paragraph. You pray a word. And God hears the short prayers too. He does not measure your faith by the length of your sentences. A child who falls off a bike does not explain the physics of the fall. The child just cries for a parent, and the parent comes running. Peter, sinking in the water, cried out only, *"Lord, save me!"* (Matthew 14:30), and Jesus reached out His hand and caught him.

Then the psalm asks God to turn back the enemies: *"Let them be disappointed and confounded who seek my soul. Let those who desire my ruin be turned back in disgrace"* (Psalm 70:2). And the mockers: *"Let them be turned because of their shame who say, 'Aha! Aha!'"* (Psalm 70:3). Aha. The sound of someone enjoying your trouble. The psalmist asks God to silence it.

But the psalm does not end on the enemies. It ends on two groups of people. First, everyone who seeks God: *"Let all those who seek you rejoice and be glad in you. Let those who love your salvation continually say, 'Let God be exalted!'"* (Psalm 70:4). Then himself: *"But I am poor and needy. Come to me quickly, God. You are my help and my deliverer. Yahweh, don't delay"* (Psalm 70:5). Poor and needy, and asking God not to wait. That is a prayer you can pray today. You do not need many words. You need the right One to pray them to.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ heard the short prayers. The thief on the cross said only, remember me, and Jesus promised him paradise that very day. He died and rose to be the help of the poor and needy. If all you have today is one word, pray it. He is not delayed.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What short, urgent prayer do you need to pray today, trusting that God hears it?

◆

DAY 144 · MAY 24 · PSALM 71 (VV. 1–6)

From Before My Birth

> *"I have relied on you from the womb. You are he who took me out of my mother's womb. I will always praise you."*
> — PSALM 71:6

Psalm 71 is the prayer of someone who has walked with God a long time. You can hear it in the way the psalmist looks back: *"For you are my hope, Lord Yahweh, my confidence from my youth"* (Psalm 71:5). From my youth. Not a new believer, but someone who has trusted God for decades. And the prayer opens with refuge: *"In you, Yahweh, I take refuge. Never let me be disappointed"* (Psalm 71:1).

He asks God to be a place he can always go: *"Be to me a rock of refuge to which I may always go"* (Psalm 71:3). Always. Not only in emergencies. A rock he can return to again and again, day after day, year after year. That is the kind of relationship with God that grows over a lifetime. Not a crisis hotline, but a home you keep coming back to, the way you return to the same chair by the same window every morning with your coffee.

Then he goes back even further than youth: *"I have relied on you from the womb. You are he who took me out of my mother's womb. I will always praise you"* (Psalm 71:6). Before he could speak, before he could choose, before he even knew God's name, God was holding him. Another psalm says it the same way: *"For you formed my inmost being. You knit me together in my mother's womb"* (Psalm 139:13). God did not start caring for you when you started caring about Him. He was there first, and He has never left.

That should steady you. Your life with God did not begin with your decision. It began with His. Jeremiah heard God say: *"Before I formed you in the womb, I knew you"* (Jeremiah 1:5). Before your first breath, God knew you. Before your first prayer, God was holding you. Every day since has been held by the same hands. If you look back over your life and see mostly failure and wandering, look again. Underneath all of it, from the womb until now, God has been faithful. You can rely on Him today because He has carried you since before you knew Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was carried in the womb of a young mother in Nazareth, and the Father held Him from birth to the cross and beyond the grave. The same God has held you since before your first breath. Rely on Him today. He has never once let you go.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you look back over your life, can you see God's hand holding you from the very beginning?

◆

DAY 145 · MAY 25 · PSALM 71 (VV. 7–12)

Do Not Cast Me Off

> *"Don't reject me in my old age. Don't forsake me when my strength fails."*
> — PSALM 71:9

Psalm 71 is one of the few psalms that speaks plainly about getting old. The psalmist has lived a long life with God, and now his body is slowing down. He is afraid: *"Don't reject me in my old age. Don't forsake me when my strength fails"* (Psalm 71:9). When my strength fails. Not if. He knows it is coming. The knees, the eyes, the memory, the steady hands. One by one they start to go, and there is nothing he can do to stop it.

That fear is real, and many people carry it quietly. Will I be a burden? Will anyone visit? Will I still matter when I cannot do what I used to? Will God still want me when I have nothing left to give Him? The world tends to value people by what they produce. When you stop producing, it is easy to feel you have stopped counting. The psalmist brings that fear straight to God, without dressing it up as something braver.

And the fear is not only about his body. His enemies are watching: *"For my enemies talk about me. Those who watch for my soul conspire together, saying, 'God has forsaken him. Pursue and take him, for no one will rescue him'"* (Psalm 71:10–11). They see him growing weak and decide God must be done with him. An old man, alone, easy prey. And so he prays: *"God, don't be far from me. My God, hurry to help me"* (Psalm 71:12).

God answered that fear long ago through Isaiah: *"Even to old age I am he, and even to gray hairs I will carry you. I have made, and I will bear. Yes, I will carry, and will deliver"* (Isaiah 46:4). Even to gray hairs. God does not retire from caring for you when you retire from work. He does not drop you when your strength fails. He carried you as a child, and He will carry you as an old man or woman. And the psalmist already knows his strength is not the point: *"I am a marvel to many, but you are my strong refuge"* (Psalm 71:7). The refuge does not age.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did not grow old, but He grew weak — beaten, stripped, unable even to carry His own cross. The Father did not forsake Him in His weakness. He raised Him. In Christ, God will carry you to the very end, even to gray hairs. Your failing strength does not loosen His hold.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you afraid of growing weak and useless — and can you trust God to carry you even to gray hairs?

◆

DAY 146 · MAY 26 · PSALM 71 (VV. 13–18)

I Will Hope Continually

"But I will always hope, and will add to all of your praise."
— PSALM 71:14

The enemies of Psalm 71 are still talking, and the psalmist asks God to deal with them: *"Let my accusers be disappointed and consumed. Let them be covered with disgrace and scorn who want to harm me"* (Psalm 71:13). Then a turn that is one of the most moving in the Psalms: *"But I will always hope, and will add to all of your praise"* (Psalm 71:14). But I. Whatever they say, whatever they plan, he will keep hoping. And he will keep adding to God's praise.

Add to all of your praise. That is a striking phrase. He has been praising God for a lifetime, and now, in old age, he plans to add more. Not to coast on old praise. Not to retire from worship. To keep piling up new reasons to thank God, one on top of another, until the end. Hope in old age is not just hanging on. It is growing, like an old oak that keeps putting out new leaves every spring.

"My mouth will tell about your righteousness, and of your salvation all day, though I don't know its full measure" (Psalm 71:15). He will talk about God's salvation all day long, and he admits he does not even know the full measure of it. After a whole life, he has not reached the bottom of God's goodness. There is always more. That is why hope can keep growing even as the body shrinks. The thing you hope in has no end.

Then he looks back again: *"God, you have taught me from my youth. Until now, I have declared your wondrous works"* (Psalm 71:17). Taught from youth. Declaring until now. And he asks for one more thing: *"Yes, even when I am old and gray-haired, God, don't forsake me, until I have declared your strength to the next generation"* (Psalm 71:18). He wants to stay long enough to tell the young ones. That is the great work of old age — passing on the story. Paul said near the end of his life, *"I have kept the faith. From now on, the crown of righteousness is stored up for me"* (2 Timothy 4:7–8).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's hope never failed, even on the cross, where He entrusted Himself to the Father with His last breath. He rose, and now His people can hope always, at every age. Keep adding to God's praise today. There is no bottom to His goodness, and there is a crown waiting.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you coasting on old praise — or adding to it, and passing it on to the next generation?

◆

DAY 147 · MAY 27 · PSALM 71 (VV. 19–24)

You Will Revive Me Again

> *"You, who have shown us many and bitter troubles, you will let me live. You will bring us up again from the depths of the earth."*
> — PSALM 71:20

The end of Psalm 71 looks up: *"Your righteousness also, God, reaches to the heavens; you have done great things. God, who is like you?"* (Psalm 71:19). Who is like You? After a long life, the psalmist still cannot find anyone to compare with God. And then he says something honest about that life: *"You, who have shown us many and bitter troubles, you will let me live"* (Psalm 71:20).

Many and bitter troubles. God showed them to him. He does not pretend his life was easy, or that the troubles came from somewhere outside God's hand. They were many, and they were bitter. But in the same breath: you will let me live. The Hebrew verb behind *"let me live"* is chayah, the same verb Psalm 119:25 uses when it prays, *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). The God who showed him bitter troubles is the God who revives, and He does both with the same hand.

Then a line that reaches all the way to resurrection: *"You will bring us up again from the depths of the earth"* (Psalm 71:20). The depths of the earth. That is the grave. The psalmist believes God will bring His people up from there. Not just out of hard times, but out of death itself. That is the dust-to-glory arc of this whole book. Dust, depths, and then up again. Paul says God *"made us alive together with Christ"* (Ephesians 2:5) and *"raised us up with him"* (Ephesians 2:6).

And so the psalm ends in music: *"Increase my honor and comfort me again"* (Psalm 71:21). Comfort me again, one more time. He has been comforted before, and he asks for it once more. Then the harp and the lyre: *"I will also praise you with the harp for your faithfulness, my God. I sing praises to you with the lyre, Holy One of Israel"* (Psalm 71:22). And finally: *"My lips shall shout for joy! My soul, which you have redeemed, sings praises to you!"* (Psalm 71:23). Many and bitter troubles, and then a redeemed soul singing. That is the shape of a life in God's hands.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was shown the most bitter trouble of all, and God brought Him up from the depths of the earth on the third day. His resurrection is the promise that you will be brought up too. Whatever bitter troubles you have seen, the God who raised Jesus will revive you again.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you see God's hand in your many and bitter troubles — and trust Him to bring you up again?

◆

DAY 148 · MAY 28 · PSALM 72 (VV. 1–7)

He Shall Defend the Cause of the Poor

> *"He will judge the poor of the people. He will save the children of the needy, and will break the oppressor in pieces."*
> — PSALM 72:4

Psalm 72 is a prayer for the king. Its heading connects it to Solomon, and it begins: *"God, give the king your justice; your righteousness to the royal son"* (Psalm 72:1). The people want a king who rules with God's own justice, not his own. *"He will judge your people with righteousness, and your poor with justice"* (Psalm 72:2). A good king is measured by how he treats the poor. Anyone can be kind to the rich. They can repay you. The test of a ruler is whether he cares for people who can give him nothing.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"He will judge the poor of the people. He will save the children of the needy, and will break the oppressor in pieces"* (Psalm 72:4). Three things a good king does. He judges fairly for the poor. He saves the children of the needy. And he breaks the oppressor. He does not just feel sorry for the weak. He acts. He crushes the ones who crush them, and He does not ask the weak to pay for their own defense.

No king of Israel ever fully lived up to this psalm. Solomon started well and ended badly. The kings after him were often worse. But the prayer kept being prayed, and it kept pointing ahead to a King who would. Isaiah described Him: *"but he will judge the poor with righteousness, and decide with equity for the humble of the earth"* (Isaiah 11:4). That is Jesus. He is the King Psalm 72 was longing for.

And look at how He comes: *"He will come down like rain on the mown grass, as showers that water the earth"* (Psalm 72:6). Like rain on a field just cut. Gentle, refreshing, bringing new growth to what was mowed down. That is how Christ comes to the poor and the crushed. Not with a whip but with rain. *"In his days, the righteous shall flourish, and abundance of peace, until the moon is no more"* (Psalm 72:7). If you feel mown down today — cut low, stripped bare — the King comes to you like rain. He defends the cause of the poor, and He will not forget yours.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the King of Psalm 72. He came down like rain on mown grass, healing the poor and confronting the proud. He was broken on the cross for the needy and rose to rule with justice forever. If you feel cut down today, the King comes to you like rain.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you see Christ as the King who defends the cause of the poor — including your cause?

◆

DAY 149 · MAY 29 · PSALM 72 (VV. 8–14)

Precious Is Their Blood in His Sight

> *"He will redeem their soul from oppression and violence. Their blood will be precious in his sight."*
> — PSALM 72:14

Psalm 72 keeps describing the King it longs for, and His reign gets bigger with every verse: *"He shall have dominion also from sea to sea, from the River to the ends of the earth"* (Psalm 72:8). Sea to sea. River to the ends of the earth. Not a small kingdom. A kingdom over everything, with no border it cannot cross. *"Yes, all kings shall fall down before him. All nations shall serve him"* (Psalm 72:11).

But the reason the nations bow is not His army. It is His care for the weak: *"For he will deliver the needy when he cries; the poor, who has no helper"* (Psalm 72:12). The poor with no helper. That is the person nobody else will stand up for. No lawyer. No family. No connections. No one returns their calls. No one shows up at their hearing. And this King hears their cry and delivers them. *"He will have pity on the poor and needy. He will save the souls of the needy"* (Psalm 72:13).

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"He will redeem their soul from oppression and violence. Their blood will be precious in his sight"* (Psalm 72:14). Precious. The blood of the poor is cheap to the world. People who are trafficked, abused, forgotten, discarded — the world treats their lives as worth little. This King says their blood is precious. He counts every life. He notices every loss. Not one is cheap to Him — not the unborn, not the elderly, not the addict, not the prisoner, not the refugee in a camp no one visits.

That tells you something about how Christ sees you. You may feel small, overlooked, worth little to the people around you. But to the King, your life is precious. He proved it in the most costly way possible. He did not only count your blood as precious. He gave His own. Peter says you were redeemed *"with precious blood, as of a lamb without blemish or spot, the blood of Christ"* (1 Peter 1:19). The poor have a helper. The needy have a King. And their blood, and yours, is precious in His sight.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ counts your life precious because He gave His own life for it. His blood was poured out on the cross to redeem the needy from oppression and violence, and He rose to reign over every nation. You are not cheap to Him. You were bought with His blood.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe your life is precious in God's sight, even when the world treats it as cheap?

◆

DAY 150 · MAY 30 · PSALM 72 (VV. 14–20)

Blessed Be His Glorious Name Forever

> *"Blessed be his glorious name forever! Let the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and amen."*
> — PSALM 72:19

Psalm 72 ends the second book of the Psalms, and it ends with a vision of the King's name lasting forever: *"His name endures forever. His name continues as long as the sun. Men shall be blessed by him. All nations will call him blessed"* (Psalm 72:17). As long as the sun. Every other king's name fades. Statues crumble, palaces fall, and history books forget them within a few generations. This King's name keeps going, and it grows louder every century instead of quieter.

And the people pray for Him continually: *"They shall live, and to him shall be given of the gold of Sheba. Men shall pray for him continually. They shall bless him all day long"* (Psalm 72:15). Then a picture of the land under His rule: *"Abundance of grain shall be throughout the land. Its fruit sways like Lebanon"* (Psalm 72:16). Fields full of wheat swaying in the wind, all the way up to the mountaintops. That is what the earth looks like when the right King reigns. No hunger, no famine, no empty barns. The whole land rich with His goodness.

Then the doxology that closes the book: *"Praise be to Yahweh God, the God of Israel, who alone does marvelous deeds. Blessed be his glorious name forever! Let the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and amen"* (Psalm 72:18–19). Let the whole earth be filled. Not just one temple in Jerusalem. Not just one city. The whole earth, full of the glory of God. Habakkuk saw the same day: *"For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of Yahweh's glory, as the waters cover the sea"* (Habakkuk 2:14).

And then a quiet line at the very end: *"This ends the prayers by David, the son of Jesse"* (Psalm 72:20). David's prayers end with a longing for a King greater than himself, whose glory would fill the earth. That King came. Isaiah said of Him: *"Of the increase of his government and of peace there shall be no end"* (Isaiah 9:7). Today, wherever you are, His name is enduring. His glory is spreading. Say amen with the psalm, twice if you need to: Amen and amen.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's name endures as long as the sun because He was raised from the dead and seated at the Father's right hand. His glory is filling the earth one heart at a time, and one day it will cover everything as water covers the sea. Bless His name today. Amen and amen.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is your life adding to the glory of Christ's name as it fills the earth?

◆

DAY 151 · MAY 31 · PSALM 73 (VV. 1–7)

My Feet Had Almost Stumbled

> *"But as for me, my feet were almost gone. My steps had nearly slipped."*
> — PSALM 73:2

Psalm 73 begins with a statement of faith: *"Surely God is good to Israel, to those who are pure in heart"* (Psalm 73:1). And then, right away, a confession: *"But as for me, my feet were almost gone. My steps had nearly slipped"* (Psalm 73:2). He believes God is good. And he almost lost his footing anyway. The psalmist is Asaph, a worship leader, a man who led the choirs. And he nearly fell away. Leaders slip too. Nobody is too far along in the faith to feel the ground shift.

Why? He tells you: *"For I was envious of the arrogant, when I saw the prosperity of the wicked"* (Psalm 73:3). Envy. He looked at people who did not care about God and saw that they were doing well. Better than he was. They had money, health, ease. *"For there are no struggles in their death, but their strength is firm. They are free from burdens of men, neither are they plagued like other men"* (Psalm 73:4–5). They did not seem to suffer at all.

You may know this exact feeling. The neighbor who never goes to church has the nicer house. The coworker who cheats gets the promotion. The family that laughs at faith seems happier than yours. And you start to wonder: what is the point? Why bother living for God if the people who ignore Him do better? That question does not come from unbelief. It is not the question of a skeptic standing outside the faith. It comes from a believer looking at the world and feeling cheated.

And Asaph describes those prosperous people plainly: *"Therefore pride is like a chain around their neck. Violence covers them like a garment"* (Psalm 73:6). They wear their pride like jewelry. *"They scoff and speak with malice. In arrogance, they threaten oppression"* (Psalm 73:8). But he has not yet seen the end of their story. That comes later in the psalm. For now, notice this: he almost slipped, but he did not fall. Something held him. Jude says God is *"able to keep them from stumbling"* (Jude 1:24). Even when your feet are almost gone, He is holding on.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's feet were nailed to a cross while the arrogant prospered and mocked Him. It looked as though they had won. On the third day God raised Him and turned every boast to silence. When envy makes your feet slip, look at Him. He is holding you, and the end of the story is His.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where has envy of those who ignore God made your steps nearly slip?

◆

DAY 152 · JUNE 1 · PSALM 73 (VV. 8–14)

All in Vain?

> *"Surely I have cleansed my heart in vain, and washed my hands in innocence"*
> — PSALM 73:13

Asaph keeps staring at the people who ignore God, and the more he looks, the worse he feels. They talk as if they own the sky: *"They have set their mouth in the heavens. Their tongue walks through the earth"* (Psalm 73:9). They mock the very idea that God is paying attention: *"They say, 'How does God know? Is there knowledge in the Most High?'"* (Psalm 73:11). And nothing bad happens to them. *"Behold, these are the wicked. Being always at ease, they increase in riches"* (Psalm 73:12). Always at ease. Always getting richer.

Then comes the bitter conclusion he almost reaches: *"Surely I have cleansed my heart in vain, and washed my hands in innocence"* (Psalm 73:13). In vain. All of it for nothing. The prayers, the honesty, the sins he resisted, the money he gave, the Sundays he showed up when he did not feel like it. What good did any of it do? The people who did none of it are living better than he is. It feels like he has been played for a fool.

And his own life seems to prove it: *"For all day long I have been plagued, and punished every morning"* (Psalm 73:14). Every morning, something new goes wrong. He tries to live right and gets hit. They live wrong and get rewarded. You may know that exact arithmetic. You stayed faithful in a marriage that got harder. You told the truth and lost the sale. You kept a clean conscience and watched someone without one pass you by. And a voice whispers: what was the point?

That is one of the most honest moments in the Psalms, and the Bible keeps it on purpose. God does not hide the question. He lets a worship leader say it out loud. The question is not a sin. But it is not the end of the psalm either. Asaph has not yet seen the whole picture. He is looking at the middle of the story and judging it as if it were the end. Tomorrow's verses will show what changed his mind. For now, if you are asking whether faithfulness has been in vain, know that you are in good company — and that the psalm does not leave you there.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

It looked like Christ's faithfulness was in vain. He kept His hands clean and His heart pure, and He was nailed to a cross while His enemies laughed. On the third day God answered the question forever. Faithfulness to Him is never wasted. The empty tomb says so.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you been tempted to think your faithfulness to God has been in vain?

◆

DAY 153 · JUNE 2 · PSALM 73 (VV. 15–21)

Until I Went Into the Sanctuary

"until I entered God's sanctuary, and considered their latter end."
— PSALM 73:17

Asaph almost said something he would have regretted: *"If I had said, 'I will speak thus'; behold, I would have betrayed the generation of your children"* (Psalm 73:15). He held his tongue. He did not broadcast his doubt to everyone around him. He knew that if he, a leader of worship, announced that faith was pointless, he would drag others down with him. That restraint is worth noticing. Not every doubt needs to be posted for the world. Some questions belong first in God's presence.

But holding it in did not solve it: *"When I tried to understand this, it was too painful for me"* (Psalm 73:16). He thought and thought, and it only hurt more. The problem would not resolve in his own head. You may know that feeling too. You lie awake running the same questions in circles, and the circles only get tighter. Thinking harder does not get you out. Sometimes it only digs the rut deeper.

Then the turn that changes everything: *"until I entered God's sanctuary, and considered their latter end"* (Psalm 73:17). Until. He went to worship. He stood in God's presence. And there, for the first time, he saw the end of the story. Not the middle, where the wicked prosper. The end, where they do not. *"Surely you set them in slippery places. You throw them down to destruction. How they are suddenly destroyed!"* (Psalm 73:18–19). The ground they stood on was ice the whole time.

That is why worship matters so much when your faith is shaking. In God's presence you see what you cannot see from your kitchen table — the long view, the final outcome, the way God measures things. Hebrews tells believers not to forsake *"our own assembling together"* (Hebrews 10:25). Coming together with God's people is not just a habit. It is how your perspective gets reset. Jesus told of a rich man who had everything in this life and a poor man named Lazarus who had nothing. After death, Abraham said, *"But here he is now comforted, and you are in anguish"* (Luke 16:25). The end of the story changes everything. Go where you can see it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the sanctuary where everything comes into focus. In Him you see the end of the story — the cross that looked like defeat turned into victory, the grave turned into an empty tomb. Come into His presence today, and let Him show you the latter end.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you are troubled by the prosperity of the wicked, do you bring it into God's presence to see their end?

◆

DAY 154 · JUNE 3 · PSALM 73 (VV. 22–28)

Whom Have I in Heaven But You?

> *"Whom do I have in heaven? There is no one on earth whom I desire besides you."*
> — PSALM 73:25

After the sanctuary, Asaph looks back at himself with embarrassment: *"For my soul was grieved. I was embittered in my heart. I was so senseless and ignorant. I was a brute beast before you"* (Psalm 73:21–22). Like an animal. Bitter, confused, reacting without thinking. He is honest about how foolish his envy made him. That kind of honesty is the beginning of healing, and it is rarer than it should be. You cannot climb out of a pit you will not admit you fell into.

And then the most tender word in the psalm: *"Nevertheless, I am continually with you. You have held my right hand"* (Psalm 73:23). Nevertheless. Even while he was a brute beast, even while he was bitter, God was holding his hand. He did not let go during the envy. He did not wait for Asaph to straighten out. The hand that held him at the start held him all the way through. That is why his feet only almost slipped. Someone else had hold of him.

Then hope for the whole road ahead: *"You will guide me with your counsel, and afterward receive me to glory"* (Psalm 73:24). Guide now. Glory later. The road with God has a destination, and it is glory. And then the line that may be the high point of the whole Psalter: *"Whom do I have in heaven? There is no one on earth whom I desire besides you"* (Psalm 73:25). Not money. Not ease. Not what the wicked had. Not even a long, comfortable life. God Himself.

That is where envy ends. Not by getting what the wicked have, but by realizing you have something far better. *"My flesh and my heart fails, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever"* (Psalm 73:26). The body will fail. The heart will give out one day. But God will still be your portion. Paul said, *"For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain"* (Philippians 1:21). And Asaph ends: *"But it is good for me to come close to God"* (Psalm 73:28). Whatever the wicked have, they do not have Him. And you do.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ held your right hand even when you were bitter and senseless. He took your envy and foolishness to the cross and rose to be your portion forever. Whatever others have, you have Him. Tell Him today: there is no one on earth I desire besides You.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you truly say there is no one on earth you desire besides God?

◆

DAY 155 · JUNE 4 · PSALM 74 (VV. 1–8)

Remember Your Congregation

> *"Remember your congregation, which you purchased of old, which you have redeemed to be the tribe of your inheritance"*
> — PSALM 74:2

Psalm 74 is a lament over ruins. The temple has been destroyed: *"God, why have you rejected us forever? Why does your anger smolder against the sheep of your pasture?"* (Psalm 74:1). The psalmist describes it like an eyewitness: *"They behaved like men wielding axes, cutting through a thicket of trees. Now they break all its carved work down with hatchet and hammers. They have burned your sanctuary to the ground"* (Psalm 74:5–7).

Axes and hammers on the carved wood. Fire in the holy place. Everything fine and holy smashed and burned. Generations of work gone in an afternoon. That is how it feels when something you loved and built for God falls apart. A church that split. A ministry that collapsed. A family that broke. You stand in the ruins and wonder how God could let it happen. The psalmist does not pretend otherwise. He describes the wreckage in detail. He wants God to see exactly what has been lost, board by board.

But then he asks God to remember: *"Remember your congregation, which you purchased of old, which you have redeemed to be the tribe of your inheritance"* (Psalm 74:2). Purchased. Redeemed. God paid for these people. They belong to Him. The psalmist does not appeal to how good the people are. He appeals to what God has already invested in them. You do not throw away something you paid dearly for. You do not walk away from a house you mortgaged everything to buy, even when the storm takes the roof.

Paul uses that same language about the church: *"the assembly of the Lord and God which he purchased with his own blood"* (Acts 20:28). Purchased with His own blood. If God paid that price, He will not abandon what He bought. Peter calls God's people *"a people for God's own possession"* (1 Peter 2:9). And then the psalmist asks God to come and look at the damage: *"Lift up your feet to the perpetual ruins"* (Psalm 74:3). Come walk through the rubble with your people. That is a prayer you can pray over whatever has fallen in your life. God, remember what You purchased. Come see the ruins.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ purchased His people with His own blood on the cross. He let His own body — the true temple — be destroyed, and raised it again in three days. He will not abandon what He paid for. Ask Him today to remember you and to walk through your ruins.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What has been reduced to ruins in your life — and will you ask God to remember what He purchased?

◆

DAY 156 · JUNE 5 · PSALM 74 (VV. 9–15)

Yet God My King Is From of Old

> *"Yet God is my King of old, working salvation throughout the earth."*
> — PSALM 74:12

The psalmist keeps describing the silence after the destruction: *"We see no miraculous signs. There is no longer any prophet, neither is there among us anyone who knows how long"* (Psalm 74:9). No signs. No prophet. No one with an answer. That is a lonely kind of darkness — not just suffering, but suffering with no explanation and no end date. Then the cry: *"How long, God, shall the adversary reproach? Shall the enemy blaspheme your name forever?"* (Psalm 74:10).

He even asks God why He is holding back: *"Why do you draw back your hand, even your right hand? Take it from your chest and consume them!"* (Psalm 74:11). It sounds as though God is standing with His arms folded, watching. The psalmist begs Him to act. Many people feel this when God seems inactive — as if He has His hands in His pockets while everything burns. The prayers go up, and nothing seems to come back down. The ruins stay ruins another week, another month.

Then one word turns the whole psalm: *"Yet God is my King of old, working salvation throughout the earth"* (Psalm 74:12). Yet. In spite of the ruins, in spite of the silence, God is still King. He was King before the temple was built and He is King after it burned. And He has been working salvation the whole time. The psalmist starts to list what God has done: *"You divided the sea by your strength. You broke the heads of the sea monsters in the waters"* (Psalm 74:13).

"You broke the heads of Leviathan in pieces" (Psalm 74:14). In the ancient world the sea monster was a picture of chaos and evil. God crushed it. He tamed the chaos. The sea that terrified sailors and the monsters it was said to hide are nothing to Him. And Revelation shows the final victory: *"The great dragon was thrown down, the old serpent, he who is called the devil and Satan"* (Revelation 12:9). When your world looks ruined and God seems silent, remember: He is King of old. He has crushed the chaos before, and He will do it again. The ruins are not the end of the story.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ crushed the head of the serpent at the cross, just as God promised in the garden. It looked like chaos had won when He died, but on the third day He rose as King. He is still working salvation throughout the earth. Say it today: yet God is my King.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When everything looks ruined and God seems silent, can you still say, 'Yet God is my King'?

◆

DAY 157 · JUNE 6 · PSALM 74 (VV. 16–23)

Have Regard for the Covenant

> *"Honor your covenant, for haunts of violence fill the dark places of the earth."*
> — PSALM 74:20

The psalmist turns from the past to the present, and from the sea to the calendar: *"The day is yours, the night is also yours. You have prepared the light and the sun. You have set all the boundaries of the earth. You have made summer and winter"* (Psalm 74:16–17). Day and night, summer and winter. The steady rhythm of creation is God's doing. If He keeps the seasons on schedule, He has not lost control of history. The sun came up this morning right on time.

Then he asks God to remember the insults: *"Remember this, that the enemy has mocked you, Yahweh. Foolish people have blasphemed your name"* (Psalm 74:18). And he asks for protection for God's weak and vulnerable people: *"Don't deliver the soul of your dove to wild beasts. Don't forget the life of your poor forever"* (Psalm 74:19). A dove among wild animals. Small, defenseless, surrounded. That is how God's people feel sometimes in a hostile world.

Then the plea that gives this day its name: *"Honor your covenant, for haunts of violence fill the dark places of the earth"* (Psalm 74:20). The covenant. God had bound Himself by promise to His people. The psalmist reminds God of His own word. That is not disrespect. It is faith, the kind that holds God to His word because it trusts His word. When you pray God's promises back to Him, you are saying: I believe You meant what You said. And the darkness around you makes the promise more precious, not less.

In the new covenant the promise is sealed in blood. On the night He was betrayed, Jesus took the cup and said, *"This cup is the new covenant in my blood, which is poured out for you"* (Luke 22:20). And Hebrews describes it: *"I will put my laws into their mind, I will also write them on their heart. I will be their God, and they will be my people"* (Hebrews 8:10). When the dark places of the earth are full of violence, pray the covenant. God will not break a promise sealed with His Son's blood. The psalm ends: *"Arise, God! Plead your own cause"* (Psalm 74:22).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ sealed the new covenant with His own blood on the cross. God bound Himself to you with the life of His Son, and raised Him to prove the promise holds. When the world grows dark today, pray that covenant back to God. He will honor it.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When the world seems full of darkness and violence, do you pray God's covenant promises back to Him?

◆

DAY 158 · JUNE 7 · PSALM 75 (VV. 1–5)

God Is the Judge

> *"When I choose the appointed time, I will judge blamelessly."*
> — PSALM 75:2

Psalm 75 opens with thanks: *"We give thanks to you, God. We give thanks, for your Name is near. Men tell about your wondrous works"* (Psalm 75:1). Your name is near. God is not far away. Then, suddenly, God Himself speaks: *"When I choose the appointed time, I will judge blamelessly"* (Psalm 75:2). He has a time picked out. He is not late. He is not distracted. When the moment He has chosen arrives, He will judge, and He will do it perfectly.

That speaks straight to the impatience in many hearts. You want justice now. You want the wrong punished and the right rewarded today. And when it does not happen, you wonder if God is paying attention. Psalm 75 says He has an appointed time. Not your time. His. And His timing is never careless. And when He acts, He will judge blamelessly — no mistakes, no unfair verdicts, nothing left out. Every hidden wrong will be brought out. Every quiet faithfulness will be noticed. No judge on earth can promise that.

And God holds everything steady while He waits: *"The earth and all its inhabitants quake. I firmly hold its pillars"* (Psalm 75:3). The world shakes. People panic. Nations rise and fall. But God holds up the pillars. Hannah sang the same truth: *"For the pillars of the earth are Yahweh's. He has set the world on them"* (1 Samuel 2:8). Nothing is falling apart that God is not holding together. That is true of the nations, and it is true of your own small corner of the world.

Then God speaks to the proud: *"I said to the arrogant, 'Don't boast!' I said to the wicked, 'Don't lift up the horn. Don't lift up your horn on high. Don't speak with a stiff neck'"* (Psalm 75:4–5). The horn was a symbol of strength, like a bull tossing its head. God tells the proud to put their horns down. Their strength is borrowed, and their time is short. Jesus said, *"For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, and whoever humbles himself will be exalted"* (Luke 14:11). Wait for God's appointed time. He will not miss it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ came at the appointed time, and He went to the cross at the hour the Father chose. The judgment fell on Him, perfectly and blamelessly, so that the time of judgment for you would be a time of mercy. He rose, and He holds the pillars of the earth. Wait for His time.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you impatient for God to act now — and can you trust His appointed time?

◆

DAY 159 · JUNE 8 · PSALM 75 (VV. 6–10)

It Is God Who Executes Judgment

"But God is the judge. He puts down one, and lifts up another."
— PSALM 75:7

Psalm 75 makes a point about promotion that every ambitious heart needs to hear: *"For neither from the east, nor from the west, nor yet from the south, comes exaltation"* (Psalm 75:6). Not from any direction on the compass. Advancement does not come from the right connections, the right school, the right boss, or the right move. Those may be the tools. They are not the source, however much they look like it.

"But God is the judge. He puts down one, and lifts up another" (Psalm 75:7). He puts down. He lifts up. The rise and fall of people is in His hands. That is humbling if you have been climbing on your own strength. It is comforting if you have been passed over. The ones who seem to be on top are not there forever. The ones who seem stuck at the bottom are not forgotten. God decides who goes up and who comes down, and He makes no mistakes.

Hannah prayed it centuries before: *"Yahweh makes poor and makes rich. He brings low, he also lifts up. He raises up the poor out of the dust"* (1 Samuel 2:7–8). Out of the dust. That is the whole story of this year. God lifts people from the dust. James says, *"Humble yourselves in the sight of the Lord, and he will exalt you"* (James 4:10). Not exalt yourself. Humble yourself, and let Him do the lifting.

Then the psalm mentions a cup: *"For in Yahweh's hand there is a cup, full of foaming wine mixed with spices. He pours it out. Indeed the wicked of the earth drink and drink it to its very dregs"* (Psalm 75:8). That is the cup of judgment. And here is the gospel: Jesus drank it. In Gethsemane He prayed, *"My Father, if this cup can't pass away from me unless I drink it, your desire be done"* (Matthew 26:42). He drank the cup the wicked deserved, all the way to the dregs, so that you could be lifted up instead of put down. The psalm ends: *"But I will declare this forever: I will sing praises to the God of Jacob"* (Psalm 75:9).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ drank the cup of judgment to its very dregs on the cross. He was put down so that you could be lifted up. On the third day God exalted Him above every name. Stop climbing on your own strength today. Humble yourself before Him, and let Him lift you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you seeking exaltation from the east or west — your own efforts — instead of from God?

◆

DAY 160 · JUNE 9 · PSALM 76 (VV. 1–6)

There He Broke the Weapons of War

> *"There he broke the flaming arrows of the bow, the shield, and the sword"*
> — PSALM 76:3

Psalm 76 celebrates a rescue at Jerusalem: *"In Judah, God is known. His name is great in Israel. His tabernacle is also in Salem; His dwelling place in Zion"* (Psalm 76:1–2). Salem is the old name for Jerusalem, the city of peace, the place where Abraham met Melchizedek. And right there, where God made His dwelling, He did something remarkable: *"There he broke the flaming arrows of the bow, the shield, and the sword, and the weapons of war"* (Psalm 76:3).

Scripture records a night like that in Hezekiah's day, when an Assyrian army camped outside Jerusalem was struck down before a blow was struck (2 Kings 19:35). Whatever this psalm's exact occasion, the picture is clear. The enemy came with everything they had — flaming arrows, shields, swords. And God broke them. Not the defenders of Jerusalem. God. The tools of violence lay snapped on the ground like kindling, and the city slept safe.

"Valiant men lie plundered, they have slept their last sleep. None of the men of war can lift their hands" (Psalm 76:5). The strongest fighters are helpless. Their hands will not even rise. *"At your rebuke, God of Jacob, both chariot and horse are cast into a dead sleep"* (Psalm 76:6). One word from God, and the chariots stop. That is how strong He is. He does not need to raise His voice twice. Human force, however terrifying, is nothing before His rebuke. The largest army in the world is a pile of dry leaves to Him.

The prophets saw a day when God would end all such violence for good: *"They shall beat their swords into plowshares, and their spears into pruning hooks. Nation shall not lift up sword against nation, neither shall they learn war any more"* (Isaiah 2:4). Swords turned into farm tools. Spears bent into hooks for pruning vines. That is the direction history is moving under God's rule. You may be facing something that feels like an army — a threat too big, a problem too heavy, an opponent too strong. Psalm 76 says God can snap it like a stick. And one day He will put an end to every instrument of harm forever.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

At the cross every instrument of harm was turned on Christ — nails, spear, mockery, death itself. He let them do their worst, and then He broke their power by rising from the dead. One day He will end all violence forever. Whatever army stands against you, He has already won.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What threat feels like an army against you — and can you trust God to break its power?

◆

DAY 161 · JUNE 10 · PSALM 76 (VV. 7–12)

You Save the Humble of the Earth

"when God arose to judgment, to save all the afflicted ones of the earth."
— PSALM 76:9

Psalm 76 turns from the broken army to the God who broke it: *"You, even you, are to be feared. Who can stand in your sight when you are angry?"* (Psalm 76:7). That is a sobering question. No one can stand against Him. Not the strongest army, not the proudest king, not the richest nation. When God rises in judgment, everything else goes quiet: *"You pronounced judgment from heaven. The earth feared, and was silent"* (Psalm 76:8).

But look at why God rises: *"when God arose to judgment, to save all the afflicted ones of the earth"* (Psalm 76:9). To save. His judgment has a purpose. It is not random anger. It is rescue for the afflicted, the crushed, the lowly. When God judges, He is standing up for the people the proud have trampled. His justice is good news, not bad news, for anyone who has been on the losing end of the world's injustice.

Then a surprising line: *"Surely the wrath of man praises you"* (Psalm 76:10). Even human anger ends up serving God. The rage of the nations, the fury of the enemy, the plotting of the wicked — God turns it into praise. The cross is the clearest example. The anger of men nailed Jesus to the wood, and God used that very anger to accomplish the salvation of the world. Nothing done against God can finally defeat Him, however loud or cruel it is. He uses it, the way a farmer uses manure to grow a crop. The worst thing the world can throw becomes fertilizer for His purposes.

So the psalm ends with an invitation: *"Make vows to Yahweh your God, and fulfill them! Let all of his neighbors bring presents to him who is to be feared"* (Psalm 76:11). Bring gifts. Keep your promises. Honor Him. *"He will cut off the spirit of princes. He is feared by the kings of the earth"* (Psalm 76:12). The kings fear Him. The afflicted are saved by Him. Jesus said, *"Blessed are the gentle, for they shall inherit the earth"* (Matthew 5:5). If you feel small and trampled today, the God who makes kings tremble has risen to save you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God arose in judgment at the cross, but the judgment fell on His own Son, so that the afflicted could be saved. The wrath of man crucified Christ, and God turned it into the praise of the whole world. On the third day He rose. The God who makes kings tremble has risen for you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you see God's judgment as a threat — or as His rising to save the afflicted, including you?

◆

DAY 162 · JUNE 11 · PSALM 77 (VV. 1–7)

Has God Forgotten to Be Gracious?

"Will the Lord reject us forever? Will he be favorable no more?"
— PSALM 77:7

Psalm 77 opens with a sleepless night: *"My cry goes to God! Indeed, I cry to God for help, and for him to listen to me. In the day of my trouble I sought the Lord. My hand was stretched out in the night, and didn't get tired. My soul refused to be comforted"* (Psalm 77:1–2). Hands stretched out all night. A soul that will not be comforted. You may have had nights like that — reaching for God in the dark and feeling nothing.

"I remember God, and I groan. I complain, and my spirit is overwhelmed" (Psalm 77:3). Strange. Remembering God makes him groan. Not because God is bad, but because God feels so far away from where he is. The memory of better days with God makes the present darkness worse. *"You hold my eyelids open. I am so troubled that I can't speak"* (Psalm 77:4). He cannot sleep, and he cannot find words. Prayer has become a groan without a sentence attached.

Then the questions spill out, one after another: *"Will the Lord reject us forever? Will he be favorable no more? Has his loving kindness vanished forever? Does his promise fail for generations? Has God forgotten to be gracious? Has he, in anger, withheld his compassion?"* (Psalm 77:7–9). Six questions in a row. Every one of them a fear he has been carrying alone in the dark. Has God given up? Has His love run out? Has He forgotten how to be kind to me?

Those are frightening questions. And the Bible lets you ask them. It does not punish the psalmist for wondering. It records the questions in full, because people of faith ask them. But notice: every question has an obvious answer, and the psalmist knows it. No, the Lord will not reject forever. No, His loving kindness has not vanished. No, God has not forgotten to be gracious. The questions are the sound of faith crying out in the dark — and in the next verses, faith will remember. Isaiah gives God's answer plainly: *"Can a woman forget her nursing child? … Yes, these may forget, yet I will not forget you!"* (Isaiah 49:15).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ asked the question for real on the cross: My God, why have you forsaken me? He was rejected so you never will be. God has not forgotten to be gracious to you. On the third day He answered with an empty tomb. Bring Him your sleepless questions tonight.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Has your trouble made you wonder whether God has forgotten to be gracious to you?

◆

DAY 163 · JUNE 12 · PSALM 77 (VV. 8–13)

I Will Remember

"I will remember Yah's deeds; for I will remember your wonders of old."
— PSALM 77:11

Psalm 77 turns on a single decision: *"Then I thought, 'I will appeal to this: the years of the right hand of the Most High'"* (Psalm 77:10). He stops staring at his feelings and decides to look at God's record. The right hand of the Most High. The years of His faithfulness. He will appeal to history instead of mood. That is a choice, not a feeling. And it changes everything that follows. Feelings rise and fall like a creek after rain. God's record does not move.

"I will remember Yah's deeds; for I will remember your wonders of old" (Psalm 77:11). Remember. Twice in one verse. Memory is a lifeline in despair. When you cannot feel God, you can remember what He has done. The psalmist does not wait for his emotions to recover before he acts. He goes back to the facts of God's faithfulness, and he holds on to them.

"I will also meditate on all your work, and consider your doings" (Psalm 77:12). Meditate. Consider. Slow down and think about it carefully, without hurrying. Not a quick glance at the past, but a long look. What did God do for your grandparents? For your church? For you, ten years ago, in that hard season you thought would never end? Write it down. Say it out loud, to yourself and to someone else. Turn it over in your mind until it sinks in. Keep a notebook of answered prayers if you have to. When the dark nights come, you will want that list within reach.

And the remembering leads to worship: *"Your way, God, is in the sanctuary. What god is great like God? You are the God who does wonders. You have made your strength known among the peoples"* (Psalm 77:13–14). The same person who could not sleep for groaning is now asking, who is like You? Nothing in his circumstances changed. What changed was where he looked, and that was enough to change the night. Paul says nothing *"will be able to separate us from God's love which is in Christ Jesus our Lord"* (Romans 8:39). Remember that today. Let memory hold you when feelings cannot.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The greatest wonder of old is the cross and the empty tomb. When you cannot feel God, remember that Christ died for you and rose again. That fact does not change with your mood. Meditate on it today. Let the memory of what He has done hold you up.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What specific deeds of God from your own past could you meditate on when present feelings fail?

◆

DAY 164 · JUNE 13 · PSALM 77 (VV. 14–20)

Your Way Was Through the Sea

"Your way was through the sea; your paths through the great waters."
— PSALM 77:19

The psalmist now remembers the greatest rescue in Israel's history: *"You have redeemed your people with your arm, the sons of Jacob and Joseph"* (Psalm 77:15). And then he paints the scene at the Red Sea like a storm: *"The waters saw you, God. The waters saw you, and they writhed. The depths also convulsed"* (Psalm 77:16). The water itself trembled when God came near. It twisted and shook like something afraid.

"The clouds poured out water. The skies resounded with thunder. Your arrows also flashed around. The voice of your thunder was in the whirlwind. The lightnings lit up the world. The earth trembled and shook" (Psalm 77:17–18). Rain, thunder, lightning, earthquake. God came through the sea in a storm, and all of creation reacted. This is not a quiet God tiptoeing through history. This is the Creator marching through the waters, and the whole world knows He is passing by.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Your way was through the sea; your paths through the great waters. Your footsteps were not known"* (Psalm 77:19). Through the sea. Not around it. God's path went straight through the thing that should have drowned His people. And His footsteps were not known. You could not see the path until He made it, step by step. There were no tracks to follow, no trail markers, no signs. Exodus says, *"the children of Israel walked on dry land in the middle of the sea"* (Exodus 14:29). Dry land, in the middle of the sea. Their sandals did not even get muddy.

That is how God often leads. You cannot see His footprints ahead. You stand at the edge of the water, and there is no visible way forward. And then He opens a path where there was none. Your situation may feel like that sea — wide, deep, impossible. God's way may go right through it, not around it. The last verse of the psalm is quiet and tender after all the thunder: *"You led your people like a flock, by the hand of Moses and Aaron"* (Psalm 77:20). Like a flock. Gently. Through the sea, and out the other side.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's path went straight through the sea of death. He went into the grave where no footprints could be seen and came out the other side on the third day. Whatever sea is in front of you, His way may go through it. Follow Him, even when you cannot see the path.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you trust God's way through the sea in front of you, even when His footsteps cannot be seen?

◆

DAY 165 · JUNE 14 · PSALM 78 (VV. 1–6)

We Will Tell the Next Generation

> *"We will not hide them from their children, telling to the generation to come the praises of Yahweh, his strength, and his wondrous deeds that he has done."*
>
> — PSALM 78:4

Psalm 78 is the second longest psalm in the Bible, and it is a history lesson. It begins like a teacher calling the class to order: *"Hear my teaching, my people. Turn your ears to the words of my mouth. I will open my mouth in a parable. I will utter dark sayings of old"* (Psalm 78:1–2). Jesus later fulfilled this very verse when He taught in parables. The psalm is about to tell the story of Israel, and it wants you to listen closely.

Then the reason for telling: *"Which we have heard and known, and our fathers have told us. We will not hide them from their children, telling to the generation to come the praises of Yahweh, his strength, and his wondrous deeds that he has done"* (Psalm 78:3–4). Heard from parents. Passed to children. That is how faith is supposed to travel, hand to hand, — from one generation to the next, at the kitchen table, in the truck, at bedtime.

God commanded it: *"For he established a covenant in Jacob, and appointed a teaching in Israel, which he commanded our fathers, that they should make them known to their children"* (Psalm 78:5). Moses said the same: *"you shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise up"* (Deuteronomy 6:7). Not just on Sunday. All day, in ordinary life, in the middle of the chores and the drives and the meals.

And the chain is meant to keep going: *"that the generation to come might know, even the children who should be born; who should arise and tell their children"* (Psalm 78:6). Children not yet born. Grandchildren. Great-grandchildren. You are one link in that chain. Someone told you, or you would not be reading this. A parent, a pastor, a friend, a stranger with a tract. Paul reminded Timothy of the faith *"which lived first in your grandmother Lois, and your mother Eunice"* (2 Timothy 1:5). Who in the next generation needs to hear what God has done for you? Do not hide it from them.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the center of the story every generation must hear. He died and rose so that the chain of faith could reach children not yet born. You were told about Him by someone. Tell someone younger today. Do not let the story stop with you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Who in the next generation needs to hear from you what God has done?

◆

DAY 166 · JUNE 15 · PSALM 78 (VV. 7–12)

That They Should Set Their Hope in God

"that they might set their hope in God"
— PSALM 78:7

Psalm 78 tells you why the stories must be passed down: *"that they might set their hope in God, and not forget God's deeds, but keep his commandments"* (Psalm 78:7). Three things. Hope in God. Remember His deeds. Keep His commands. And they are connected. The people who remember what God has done are the ones who hope in Him. The ones who hope in Him are the ones who obey. Forgetting breaks the chain.

And the psalm says plainly what it does not want: *"and might not be as their fathers, a stubborn and rebellious generation, a generation that didn't make their hearts loyal, whose spirit was not steadfast with God"* (Psalm 78:8). The past generation was not all heroes. Many were stubborn. Many rebelled. Their hearts were not loyal. The psalm is honest about the failures of the ancestors, so that the children will not repeat them. Family history is not only a list of heroes. It is also a list of warnings.

Then an example: *"The children of Ephraim, being armed and carrying bows, turned back in the day of battle"* (Psalm 78:9). They had everything they needed. They were armed. They were ready. And they ran. Why? *"They didn't keep God's covenant, and refused to walk in his law. They forgot his doings, his wondrous deeds that he had shown them"* (Psalm 78:10–11). They forgot. That is the root of it. Forgetting God's deeds leads to losing heart when it matters most. A worker who forgets why the job matters will quit on the first hard day.

You may be well equipped for the fight of faith — Bibles on the shelf, sermons on your phone, a church down the road. But equipment is not enough. If you forget what God has done, you will turn back when it gets hard. That is why you need to keep remembering. Hebrews says, *"Now faith is assurance of things hoped for, proof of things not seen"* (Hebrews 11:1). Hope is built on memory. *"He did marvelous things in the sight of their fathers"* (Psalm 78:12). Remember them today, so you do not turn back tomorrow when the pressure comes.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ never forgot the Father's works. He set His hope on God all the way to the cross, and did not turn back when the hour came. He rose. Because He stayed, you can stay too. Set your hope on Him today, and do not forget what He has done.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where have you forgotten what God has done, and lost heart because of it?

◆

DAY 167 · JUNE 16 · PSALM 78 (VV. 13–18)

He Led Them with a Cloud

> *“In the daytime he also led them with a cloud, and all night with a light of fire.”*
> — PSALM 78:14

Psalm 78 now tells the wilderness story: *“He split the sea, and caused them to pass through. He made the waters stand as a heap”* (Psalm 78:13). The sea stood up like a wall. And then God did not leave them to find their own way through the desert: *“In the daytime he also led them with a cloud, and all night with a light of fire”* (Psalm 78:14). Day and night, God was visibly with them.

Exodus describes it: *“Yahweh went before them by day in a pillar of cloud, to lead them on their way, and by night in a pillar of fire, to give them light, that they might go by day and by night”* (Exodus 13:21). A cloud in the heat of the day, giving shade and direction. A fire at night, giving light and warmth. God did not hand them a map and wish them well. He walked in front of them the whole way, close enough that they could see Him every time they looked up.

And He provided water in a place with none: *“He split rocks in the wilderness, and gave them drink abundantly as out of the depths. He brought streams also out of the rock, and caused waters to run down like rivers”* (Psalm 78:15–16). Rivers out of rock. Paul says that rock was a picture of Christ (1 Corinthians 10:4). Water from the place where no water should be. That is how God provides for people in the desert.

Then the sad turn: *“Yet they still went on to sin against him, to rebel against the Most High in the desert”* (Psalm 78:17). After all that — the cloud, the fire, the water from the rock — they still rebelled. That should be humbling. People can see God’s faithfulness every day and still drift. You can, too. That is why the guidance is so gracious. He leads anyway. Jesus said, *“I am the light of the world. He who follows me will not walk in the darkness, but will have the light of life”* (John 8:12). Follow the light today, one step at a time, even if you cannot see far ahead.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the light that leads you through the wilderness, day and night. He walked the desert before you, went into the darkness of death, and came out as the light of life. You do not have to find your own way. Follow Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you trying to find your own way, when God has promised to lead you?

◆

DAY 168 · JUNE 17 · PSALM 78 (VV. 19–24)

Can God Spread a Table?

"He rained down manna on them to eat, and gave them food from the sky."
— PSALM 78:23–24

In the desert the people began to test God with a question that sounded like doubt dressed up as curiosity: *"Yes, they spoke against God. They said, 'Can God prepare a table in the wilderness?'"* (Psalm 78:19). Can He? After the sea split. After the cloud and the fire. After the water from the rock. They still wondered whether God could feed them. *"Behold, he struck the rock, so that waters gushed out, and streams overflowed. Can he give bread also? Will he provide meat for his people?"* (Psalm 78:20).

That question made God angry: *"Therefore Yahweh heard, and was angry"* (Psalm 78:21). Why? *"because they didn't believe in God, and didn't trust in his salvation"* (Psalm 78:22). The problem was not hunger. Hunger is not sin. The problem was unbelief. They had seen God provide again and again, and they still assumed He would not do it this time. That is the kind of doubt that insults a faithful Father.

And yet look at what God did next: *"Yet he commanded the skies above, and opened the doors of heaven. He rained down manna on them to eat, and gave them food from the sky"* (Psalm 78:23–24). Yet. After the doubt. After the anger. He fed them anyway. He opened heaven's doors like a barn and let bread fall like rain. *"Man ate the bread of angels. He sent them food to the full"* (Psalm 78:25). Not a ration. Full. Every morning for forty years, on the ground outside the tent, enough for every family in the camp.

Jesus took this story and pointed it at Himself. When the crowd mentioned the manna, He said, *"it wasn't Moses who gave you the bread out of heaven, but my Father gives you the true bread out of heaven. For the bread of God is that which comes down out of heaven, and gives life to the world"* (John 6:32–33). And then: *"I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will not be hungry"* (John 6:35). Can God spread a table in the wilderness? He already has. The table is Christ, and it is set for you today, even in your doubt.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God spread a table in the wilderness when He sent His Son. Christ is the true bread from heaven, broken on the cross and raised on the third day to feed the world. Even when you doubt He can provide, He sets the table anyway. Come and eat today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you asking, 'Can God really provide this time?' — after all He has already done?

◆

DAY 169 · JUNE 18 · PSALM 78 (VV. 25–30)

They Did Not Stop Their Craving

"They didn't turn from their cravings."
— PSALM 78:30

God gave the people what they demanded. They wanted meat, and He sent it: *"He caused the east wind to blow in the sky. By his power he guided the south wind. He also rained meat on them as the dust, winged birds as the sand of the seas"* (Psalm 78:26–27). Birds by the thousands, falling into the camp like dust. *"He let them fall in the middle of their camp, around their habitations"* (Psalm 78:28). They did not even have to walk to get it. It landed at the tent door. All they had to do was reach down and pick it up.

"So they ate, and were well filled. He gave them their own desire" (Psalm 78:29). He gave them their own desire. That sounds like a happy ending. It is not. Sometimes the worst thing God can do is give you exactly what you are craving. When the heart is set on something more than on God, getting it does not satisfy. It exposes. The thing you thought would make you happy shows you how empty you were without God, and how empty you still are with it.

"They didn't turn from their cravings. Their food was yet in their mouths" (Psalm 78:30), when judgment fell. Numbers tells it bluntly: *"While the meat was still between their teeth, before it was chewed, Yahweh's anger burned against the people"* (Numbers 11:33). The craving was the problem. Not hunger, but a demanding, never-satisfied appetite that put their stomachs ahead of their God. They were full, and still they did not turn. A full stomach did not change a hungry heart.

Paul says these stories were written as warnings: *"Now these things were our examples, to the intent we should not lust after evil things, as they also lusted"* (1 Corinthians 10:6). What are you craving? More money, more pleasure, more approval, more control? None of those are evil in themselves. But a craving that will not be satisfied by God becomes an idol. The cure is not to get everything you crave. It is to turn from the craving to the One who actually fills. Jesus said, *"whoever believes in me will never be thirsty"* (John 6:35). Bring Him your appetite today.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was hungry in the wilderness and refused to satisfy Himself by turning stones to bread. He trusted the Father instead. Then He gave His own body as bread for the world, and rose to satisfy every hungry soul. Turn from your cravings to Him today. He fills what nothing else can.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What craving have you refused to turn from, even after it has failed to satisfy you?

◆

DAY 170 · JUNE 19 · PSALM 78 (VV. 31–36)

They Flattered Him with Their Mouths

> *"But they flattered him with their mouth, and lied to him with their tongue."*
> — PSALM 78:36

Psalm 78 keeps telling the sad pattern. Judgment came, and the people responded — for a while: *"For all this they still sinned, and didn't believe in his wondrous works. Therefore he consumed their days in vanity, and their years in terror"* (Psalm 78:32–33). Wasted days. Years full of fear. That is what life becomes when people refuse to trust God even after seeing what He can do. The days pass, and nothing in them lasts. The years go by, and fear is the main thing they remember.

Then they turned to God, or seemed to: *"When he killed them, then they inquired after him. They returned and sought God earnestly. They remembered that God was their rock, the Most High God, their redeemer"* (Psalm 78:34–35). It looked like revival. They sought Him earnestly. They remembered He was their rock. They said all the right things. If you had been standing in the camp, you would have thought the people were finally changing. Tears, confession, promises.

But listen to the next line: *"But they flattered him with their mouth, and lied to him with their tongue. For their heart was not right with him, neither were they faithful in his covenant"* (Psalm 78:36–37). Flattery. They said what God wanted to hear, but their hearts had not changed. It was a foxhole faith — real fear, real words, but no real turning. Once the danger passed, so did the devotion. The words dried up with the tears.

Isaiah described the same thing: *"this people draws near with their mouth and honors me with their lips, but they have removed their heart far from me"* (Isaiah 29:13). And Jesus quoted it to the religious leaders of His day. You can do this too. Pray hard when the diagnosis comes, and forget God when the scan comes back clean. Make promises in a crisis and drop them when it ends. God is not fooled by flattery. He hears the words and sees the heart behind them. He wants the heart. And the gospel is that He gives a new heart to those who cannot change their own. Ask Him today for a heart that means what the mouth says.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ never flattered the Father. His words and His heart were one, all the way to the cross, where He said, Not my will, but Yours. He rose to give you a heart like His. Stop flattering God with words alone. Ask Him today for a heart that is truly His.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are your prayers more flattery than faith — words without a heart that has turned?

◆

DAY 171 · JUNE 20 · PSALM 78 (VV. 37–42)

He, Being Compassionate, Atoned

"But he, being merciful, forgave iniquity, and didn't destroy them."
— PSALM 78:38

After all the flattery and lies, the psalm says something startling: *"But he, being merciful, forgave iniquity, and didn't destroy them. Yes, many times he turned his anger away, and didn't stir up all his wrath"* (Psalm 78:38). Merciful. Forgiving. Holding back. The people deserved to be wiped out, and God kept forgiving. Many times. Not once, not twice, but over and over through forty years of rebellion. Every morning the manna still fell. Every night the fire still burned over the camp. Mercy kept showing up on schedule.

Why? The next verse gives the reason: *"He remembered that they were but flesh, a wind that passes away, and doesn't come again"* (Psalm 78:39). He remembered they were dust. Weak. Temporary. A breath of wind that blows past and is gone. Another psalm says it the same way: *"For he knows how we are made. He remembers that we are dust"* (Psalm 103:14). God does not expect from dust what only He can do. He knows your frame, every weak joint and tired bone of it.

That is not an excuse for sin. The psalm does not say God shrugged and let it go. It says He forgave. Forgiveness takes sin seriously enough to deal with it. But it also means God does not hold your weakness against you the way you might fear. Lamentations says, *"It is because of Yahweh's loving kindnesses that we are not consumed, because his compassion doesn't fail"* (Lamentations 3:22). Not consumed. Every morning you wake up still standing is evidence of His mercy. You did not earn the sunrise. He gave it anyway.

And yet the psalm also grieves: *"How often they rebelled against him in the wilderness, and grieved him in the desert!"* (Psalm 78:40). Rebellion grieves God. It hurts Him, the way a child's rebellion hurts a parent. Paul says, *"Don't grieve the Holy Spirit of God"* (Ephesians 4:30). The God who forgives also feels the wound of your rebellion. So the right response to mercy is not more rebellion. It is gratitude, and a turning toward the One who has forgiven you many times. He remembers you are dust. Remember that He is merciful.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God's mercy to dust found its fullest form at the cross. Christ bore the wrath God held back from His people so many times, and on the third day He rose. In Him God remembers you are dust and forgives. Thank Him for His mercy today, and turn toward Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you rest in the God who forgives again and again, because He remembers you are dust?

◆

DAY 172 · JUNE 21 · PSALM 78 (VV. 42–48)

They Did Not Remember His Power

> *"They didn't remember his hand, nor the day when he redeemed them from the adversary"*
> — PSALM 78:42

The heart of Israel's problem, according to Psalm 78, was forgetfulness: *"They turned again and tempted God, and provoked the Holy One of Israel. They didn't remember his hand, nor the day when he redeemed them from the adversary"* (Psalm 78:41–42). They forgot. Not the facts — they could probably have recited the story. They forgot in the way that matters: their hearts stopped being shaped by it. A story you can recite but no longer feel is a story you have forgotten.

So the psalm reminds them. It goes back to Egypt and walks through the plagues one by one: *"how he set his signs in Egypt, his wonders in the field of Zoan, he turned their rivers into blood, and their streams, so that they could not drink"* (Psalm 78:43–44). The Nile, Egypt's lifeline, turned to blood. Then the flies and the frogs: *"He sent among them swarms of flies, which devoured them; and frogs, which destroyed them"* (Psalm 78:45).

Then the crops: *"He gave also their increase to the caterpillar, and their labor to the locust. He destroyed their vines with hail, their sycamore fig trees with frost"* (Psalm 78:46–47). Everything Egypt depended on — water, food, livestock — God struck down to set His people free. *"He gave over their livestock also to the hail, and their flocks to hot thunderbolts"* (Psalm 78:48). He took apart the whole economy of the world's greatest empire to rescue a nation of slaves. No price was too high for Him to pay to get His people out. Pharaoh learned that the hard way, plague by plague.

That was the day of redemption, and they forgot it. You have a day of redemption too. The cross is the day God redeemed you from the adversary, not with plagues but with the blood of His Son. Paul says, *"Christ, our Passover, has been sacrificed in our place"* (1 Corinthians 5:7). Have you forgotten it? Not the facts, but the power of it — the way it should shape how you see God, trust God, and live for God every day. Remember His hand today. Remember the day He set you free.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Passover Lamb, sacrificed on the day God redeemed you from the adversary. He went through death so that death would pass over you, and on the third day He rose. Do not forget His hand. Remember today the day He set you free.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you forgotten the day of your redemption — not the facts, but its power to shape your heart?

◆

DAY 173 · JUNE 22 · PSALM 78 (VV. 49–54)

He Led Out His People Like Sheep

> *"But he led out his own people like sheep, and guided them in the wilderness like a flock."*
> — PSALM 78:52

The plagues ended with the worst one: *"He threw on them the fierceness of his anger, wrath, indignation, and trouble, and a band of angels of evil"* (Psalm 78:49). Then the night of the Passover: *"He made a path for his anger. He didn't spare their soul from death, but gave their life over to the pestilence, and struck all the firstborn in Egypt"* (Psalm 78:50–51). It was a terrible night. Judgment fell on every house without the blood on the doorframe.

And then the turn: *"But he led out his own people like sheep, and guided them in the wilderness like a flock"* (Psalm 78:52). The same God who judged Egypt led Israel out gently. Like sheep. Not like troops on parade, not like prisoners driven, but like a flock following a shepherd. That is the tenderness inside the terror of the exodus. God was fierce toward the oppressor and gentle toward the oppressed. The same hand that struck Egypt carried Israel, the way a shepherd's staff can drive off a wolf and then lift a lamb out of a ditch.

"He led them safely, so that they weren't afraid, but the sea overwhelmed their enemies" (Psalm 78:53). Safely. Without fear of the pursuit. The sea that drowned Pharaoh's army was a road for God's people. *"He brought them to the border of his sanctuary, to this mountain, which his right hand had taken"* (Psalm 78:54). He did not just get them out of Egypt. He brought them all the way to His holy mountain. The rescue had a destination, and the destination was God's own house.

Isaiah says the LORD *"will feed his flock like a shepherd. He will gather the lambs in his arm, and carry them in his bosom"* (Isaiah 40:11). And Jesus said, *"I am the good shepherd. I know my own, and I'm known by my own"* (John 10:14). The Shepherd who led Israel through the sea leads you now. You may be in a wilderness season. He has not left you there to wander. He is guiding you like a flock, gently, toward His own mountain. Follow His voice, even when the path is unfamiliar.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Good Shepherd who laid down His life for the sheep. He went through the night of judgment so it would pass over you, and on the third day the God of peace brought Him back from the dead. He is leading you now, gently, toward home. Follow Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you trust the Shepherd to lead you safely through your wilderness, without fear?

◆

DAY 174 · JUNE 23 · PSALM 78 (VV. 55–60)

They Provoked Him to Anger

> *"Yet they tempted and rebelled against the Most High God, and didn't keep his testimonies"*
> — PSALM 78:56

God brought His people into the land He promised: *"He also drove out the nations before them, allotted them for an inheritance by line, and made the tribes of Israel to dwell in their tents"* (Psalm 78:55). Every tribe got its portion. Every family got its field. The promise made to Abraham centuries earlier came true. They were home. Fields to plow, wells to draw from, vineyards to plant. Everything God had promised, laid out before them.

And then, in the land of blessing: *"Yet they tempted and rebelled against the Most High God, and didn't keep his testimonies, but turned back, and dealt treacherously like their fathers. They were twisted like a deceitful bow"* (Psalm 78:56–57). A deceitful bow. You aim it at the target, and it twists in your hand and shoots somewhere else. That is what Israel was like. God aimed them at faithfulness, and they veered off toward idols.

"For they provoked him to anger with their high places, and moved him to jealousy with their engraved images" (Psalm 78:58). High places and carved images. They worshiped other gods in the very land the true God had given them. That is what provokes God most — not weakness, but betrayal. Giving His gifts to someone else. Anyone who has given a spouse a home and found it handed to a rival would understand that anger. Using the field He gave you to build an altar to a rival.

You may not carve idols, but the heart still twists like a bow. God gives you good things — a family, a job, health, a home — and the heart starts loving the gifts more than the Giver. The land becomes the god, slowly and quietly, without anyone noticing. Jesus said to a church that had drifted: *"But I have this against you, that you left your first love. Remember therefore from where you have fallen, and repent"* (Revelation 2:4–5). Remember. Repent. Come back home. The same God who gave you the land is calling you back to Himself. Hebrews warns, *"exhort one another day by day, so long as it is called 'today'"* (Hebrews 3:13). Today is still open.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ never twisted like a deceitful bow. He went straight to the cross, aimed at the Father's will, and did not veer. He rose to straighten crooked hearts. Where your heart has turned to the gifts instead of the Giver, bring it back to Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where have God's good gifts become rivals to God Himself in your heart?

◆

DAY 175 · JUNE 24 · PSALM 78 (VV. 61–66)

Then the Lord Awoke

"Then the Lord awakened as one out of sleep"
— PSALM 78:65

Israel's unfaithfulness had a terrible cost: *"When God heard this, he was angry, and greatly abhorred Israel, so that he abandoned the tent of Shiloh, the tent which he placed among men"* (Psalm 78:59–60). Shiloh was where the tabernacle stood for generations. And God left it. *"and delivered his strength into captivity, his glory into the adversary's hand"* (Psalm 78:61). The ark of the covenant was captured by the Philistines.

First Samuel tells that story. A woman gave birth that day and named her son Ichabod, *"saying, 'The glory has departed from Israel!' because God's ark was taken"* (1 Samuel 4:21). The glory departed. That is the worst thing that can happen to God's people — not losing a war, but losing God's presence. The psalm does not soften it: *"Fire devoured their young men. Their virgins had no wedding song. Their priests fell"* (Psalm 78:63–64).

It looked like the end. God had abandoned His people, and everyone could see it. The neighbors laughed. The enemies celebrated. The faithful who were left wondered if there was any point in praying. The ark was gone. The priests were dead, and Shiloh lay empty. And then the most surprising verse in the psalm: *"Then the Lord awakened as one out of sleep, like a mighty man who shouts by reason of wine"* (Psalm 78:65). Like someone waking from sleep. Like a strong man roused, shouting. God was not dead. He had only seemed asleep. The long silence was not absence. And He rose up and struck His enemies.

"He struck his adversaries backward. He put them to a perpetual reproach" (Psalm 78:66). The God who seemed to have abandoned His people woke and saved them. That is a picture of the resurrection. On Friday, it looked as if God had left. The glory had departed. The Son was dead. By Saturday, everything was silent. And then on Sunday, the Lord awoke. The angel said, *"He is not here, for he has risen, just like he said"* (Matthew 28:6). If God seems asleep in your life right now, wait. He wakes. He has never stayed asleep for long, and He never truly slept at all.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

On the cross it looked as if the glory had departed and God had abandoned His Son. The tomb was sealed and silent. Then on the third day the Lord awoke, and Christ rose and put His enemies to shame forever. If God seems asleep to you today, wait. He wakes.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where does God seem asleep in your life — and can you wait for the day He awakens?

◆

DAY 176 · JUNE 25 · PSALM 78 (VV. 67–72)

He Chose David His Servant

> *"So he was their shepherd according to the integrity of his heart, and guided them by the skillfulness of his hands."*
> — PSALM 78:72

Psalm 78 has been a long, sad history of rebellion. Generation after generation, the people forgot God, tested Him, flattered Him, and turned back. And after all of it, the psalm ends not with despair but with a choice God made: *"Moreover he rejected the tent of Joseph, and didn't choose the tribe of Ephraim, But chose the tribe of Judah, Mount Zion which he loved"* (Psalm 78:67–68). God did not give up. He chose again.

And He chose a person: *"He also chose David his servant, and took him from the sheepfolds"* (Psalm 78:70). From the sheepfolds. Not from the palace or the army or the school of the prophets. From the back field, where the youngest son was keeping the sheep while the older sons were presented to Samuel. When Samuel asked if there were any more sons, Jesse said, *"There remains yet the youngest. Behold, he is keeping the sheep"* (1 Samuel 16:11). The forgotten boy in the field was God's choice.

"from following the ewes that have their young, he brought him to be the shepherd of Jacob, his people, and Israel, his inheritance" (Psalm 78:71). He went from caring for nursing sheep to caring for a nation. The skills were the same. Patience. Gentleness. Protection. Watching over the weak. And David led well: *"So he was their shepherd according to the integrity of his heart, and guided them by the skillfulness of his hands"* (Psalm 78:72). A good heart and skilled hands.

But David was not the end of the story. He failed too, badly. The psalm looks past him to a greater Shepherd. Ezekiel prophesied, *"I will set up one shepherd over them, and he will feed them, even my servant David"* (Ezekiel 34:23) — written long after David had died. That Shepherd is Jesus, the Son of David: *"I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep"* (John 10:11). After all the rebellion of Psalm 78, God's answer is a Shepherd who will not fail. You may feel like the long list of failures in this psalm. God's answer to you is the same. He has chosen a Shepherd for you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

After all Israel's rebellion, God chose a shepherd from the sheepfolds. After all your rebellion, He sent Christ, His own Son, the Good Shepherd who laid down His life for the sheep and was brought back from the dead. He leads you with a true heart and skillful hands. Follow Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

After a long history of failure, can you trust the Good Shepherd God has chosen for you?

◆

DAY 177 · JUNE 26 · PSALM 79 (VV. 1–6)

How Long, O LORD?

> *"How long, Yahweh? Will you be angry forever? Will your jealousy burn like fire?"*
> — PSALM 79:5

Psalm 79 is a lament after Jerusalem has fallen. It opens with a scene of horror: *"God, the nations have come into your inheritance. They have defiled your holy temple. They have laid Jerusalem in heaps"* (Psalm 79:1). The holy city is a pile of rubble, stones scattered where homes and gates once stood. The temple is defiled. And the dead lie unburied: *"They have shed their blood like water around Jerusalem. There was no one to bury them"* (Psalm 79:3).

Then the shame of it: *"We have become a reproach to our neighbors, a scoffing and derision to those who are around us"* (Psalm 79:4). The surrounding nations laugh. God's people, who were supposed to be a light to the world, have become a punchline. That kind of humiliation stings in a particular way. It is not only the loss. It is being mocked for the loss, and having the mockery aimed at your God.

Then the question that echoes through the Psalms: *"How long, Yahweh? Will you be angry forever? Will your jealousy burn like fire?"* (Psalm 79:5). The psalmist knows the destruction came partly because of the people's sin. He does not deny it. Later he will ask for forgiveness. But he wants to know how long God's anger will last. Will this ever end? Is there any limit to the fire? Will the children grow up in the rubble too? Those are honest questions from people who know they deserve discipline and are begging for it to stop.

The saints in Revelation ask nearly the same thing: *"How long, Master, the holy and true, until you judge and avenge our blood on those who dwell on the earth?"* (Revelation 6:10). How long is a prayer God's people have prayed through every age. And the answer always comes in God's time. You may be living in the ruins of something — a broken home, a failed dream, the consequences of your own sin. You are allowed to ask how long. God will not shame you for the question. And the cross is the proof that His anger toward His people has an end. It was poured out there, in full.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God's jealous fire burned to its end at the cross, where Christ took the full anger His people deserved. That is why your how long has an answer. On the third day He rose, and the fire was spent. Ask Him your question today. The anger has a limit, and it was reached in Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What ruins are you living in — and can you bring your how long to God without shame?

◆

DAY 178 · JUNE 27 · PSALM 79 (VV. 7–13)

For Your Name's Sake

> *"Help us, God of our salvation, for the glory of your name. Deliver us, and forgive our sins, for your name's sake."*
> — PSALM 79:9

The psalmist confesses that the disaster is not only the enemy's fault: *"Don't hold the iniquities of our forefathers against us. Let your tender mercies speedily meet us, for we are in desperate need"* (Psalm 79:8). Desperate need. That is where the prayer begins. Not with a claim of innocence, but with an admission of guilt — the sins of the fathers and their own sins too. They have nothing to offer God but their need. No sacrifices left, no temple, no king. Just an empty-handed cry.

Then the plea that gives this day its name: *"Help us, God of our salvation, for the glory of your name. Deliver us, and forgive our sins, for your name's sake"* (Psalm 79:9). For Your name's sake. Twice in one verse. The psalmist does not ask God to save them because they deserve it. He asks God to save them because God's own name is at stake. Your reputation, Lord. Your glory. If You save Your people, the world will see who You are.

That is one of the deepest prayers a sinner can pray. It does not rest on your merit. It rests on God's character. Ezekiel heard God say it plainly: *"I don't do this for your sake, house of Israel, but for my holy name"* (Ezekiel 36:22). And David sang it in the Shepherd psalm: *"He guides me in the paths of righteousness for his name's sake"* (Psalm 23:3). When you have nothing else to plead, and that day comes for everyone, plead His name. He will not let it be dishonored, not ever.

The psalm asks God to act so the nations will stop mocking: *"Why should the nations say, 'Where is their God?'"* (Psalm 79:10). And it ends with a promise of praise: *"So we, your people and sheep of your pasture, will give you thanks forever. We will praise you forever, to all generations"* (Psalm 79:13). Forgiven sheep give thanks forever. Jesus taught His disciples to pray the same priority: *"Our Father in heaven, may your name be kept holy"* (Matthew 6:9). Before your needs, His name. And when you pray that way, your needs are safe in His hands.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God forgave His people for His name's sake at the cross, where the name of Jesus was lifted up over the world. He rose, and now every knee will bow at that name. When you have nothing to plead, plead His name today. He will not let it be dishonored, and He will not let you go.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you come to God in need, do you plead your merit — or the glory of His name?

◆

DAY 179 · JUNE 28 · PSALM 80 (VV. 1–6)

Restore Us, O God

"Turn us again, God. Cause your face to shine, and we will be saved."
— PSALM 80:3

Psalm 80 calls on God as a shepherd: *"Hear us, Shepherd of Israel, you who lead Joseph like a flock, you who sit above the cherubim, shine out"* (Psalm 80:1). The Shepherd who sits enthroned above the angels. Then a cry for Him to wake up and come: *"Before Ephraim and Benjamin and Manasseh, stir up your might! Come to save us!"* (Psalm 80:2). The northern tribes are in trouble, and they need their Shepherd to come.

Then the refrain that will repeat three times through the psalm: *"Turn us again, God. Cause your face to shine, and we will be saved"* (Psalm 80:3). The Hebrew behind *"turn us again"* is shuv, the word for turning back, returning, restoring. They are asking God to do the turning. They cannot turn themselves, however hard they try. They need God to bring them back. And the result will be His face shining on them — and salvation.

That is important. Many people think revival begins with their own effort to turn back to God. Try harder. Pray more. Get serious. But this psalm asks God to turn them. The turning is His work before it is theirs. You cannot even repent without His help. That is not an excuse to sit still. It is a reason to pray, and to keep praying until the turning comes. Ask Him to turn you, and He will.

The psalm is honest about how bad things are: *"Yahweh God of Armies, how long will you be angry against the prayer of your people? You have fed them with the bread of tears, and given them tears to drink in large measure"* (Psalm 80:4–5). Bread of tears. Tears to drink. That is a hard diet, and they have been eating it a long time. And the neighbors laugh: *"Our enemies laugh among themselves"* (Psalm 80:6). And yet the refrain keeps coming back: turn, shine, save. It is the prayer of the prodigal before he even starts home. And the father in Jesus' story saw his son coming *"while he was still far off"* (Luke 15:20) and ran to meet him. God is ready to turn you. Ask.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the face of God shining on a world fed with tears. He turned toward the cross so that you could be turned back to God, and on the third day He rose with that light on His face. Ask Him to turn you today. You cannot do it alone, and you do not have to.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you trying to turn yourself back to God, or asking Him to turn you and shine His face on you?

◆

DAY 180 · JUNE 29 · PSALM 80 (VV. 7–13)

The Vine You Brought Out of Egypt

"You brought a vine out of Egypt. You drove out the nations, and planted it."

— PSALM 80:8

Psalm 80 tells Israel's story with a picture: *"You brought a vine out of Egypt. You drove out the nations, and planted it"* (Psalm 80:8). Israel was a vine God dug up in Egypt and replanted in the promised land. Then He tended it: *"You cleared the ground for it. It took deep root, and filled the land"* (Psalm 80:9). He pulled the weeds. He cleared the rocks. The vine grew roots deep into the soil.

And it grew huge: *"The mountains were covered with its shadow. Its boughs were like God's cedars. It sent out its branches to the sea, its shoots to the River"* (Psalm 80:10–11). Shade on the mountains. Branches stretching from the sea to the Euphrates. That was Israel at its height under David and Solomon. A vine so big it looked like a forest. All of it God's planting, God's work, God's care. Israel did not grow itself. Every acre was given, every root was watered by His hand.

Then the question: *"Why have you broken down its walls, so that all those who pass by the way pluck it? The boar out of the wood ravages it. The wild animals of the field feed on it"* (Psalm 80:12–13). The wall around the vineyard is broken. Strangers walk in and pick the grapes. Wild pigs root it up. The vine God planted is being stripped bare, and the psalmist cannot understand why the Gardener would allow it. Isaiah sang a song about the same vineyard: *"He looked for it to yield grapes, but it yielded wild grapes"* (Isaiah 5:2).

Jesus took this image and made it about Himself: *"I am the true vine, and my Father is the farmer. Every branch in me that doesn't bear fruit, he takes away. Every branch that bears fruit, he prunes, that it may bear more fruit"* (John 15:1–2). The true vine. Where Israel failed to bear good fruit, Christ succeeded. And you are a branch in Him. You may feel stripped bare right now — walls broken, life ravaged. The Farmer has not abandoned His vine. If He is pruning, it is for more fruit. Stay in the Vine.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the true vine God planted, cut down at the cross and raised to life on the third day. Every branch in Him bears fruit. If you feel stripped bare or pruned today, the Farmer is tending you, not abandoning you. Stay connected to Him. The fruit is coming.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you feel stripped bare or pruned — and can you trust that you are a branch in the true Vine?

◆

DAY 181 · JUNE 30 · PSALM 80 (VV. 14–19)

Give Us Life Again

> *"So we will not turn away from you. Revive us, and we will call on your name."*
> — PSALM 80:18

Psalm 80 ends with the vine burned and cut: *"It's burned with fire. It's cut down. They perish at your rebuke"* (Psalm 80:16). Then the psalmist prays for someone specific: *"Let your hand be on the man of your right hand, on the son of man whom you made strong for yourself"* (Psalm 80:17). The man of Your right hand. The son of man. Israel needed a king God would strengthen and set beside Him, someone who could do what the people could not.

That phrase, son of man, became the title Jesus used for Himself more than any other. Daniel saw *"one like a son of man"* (Daniel 7:13) coming with the clouds, and *"Dominion was given him, and glory, and a kingdom"* (Daniel 7:14). Stephen, as he died, cried, *"Behold, I see the heavens opened, and the Son of Man standing at the right hand of God!"* (Acts 7:56). The man at God's right hand is Jesus. The prayer of Psalm 80 was answered in Him.

Then the line that brings this whole year's theme into focus: *"So we will not turn away from you. Revive us, and we will call on your name"* (Psalm 80:18). Revive. The Hebrew verb is chayah, the same verb Psalm 119:25 uses: *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). The vine is burned. The people are in the dust. And they ask God to give them life again. That is what revival is. Not a better program. Not a stronger effort. Life from the dead, given by the only One who has it to give.

And the psalm closes with the refrain one more time: *"Turn us again, Yahweh God of Armies. Cause your face to shine, and we will be saved"* (Psalm 80:19). Turn, shine, save. Three times through the psalm, and this last one uses God's covenant name. Hosea had the same hope: *"After two days he will revive us. On the third day he will raise us up, and we will live before him"* (Hosea 6:2). On the third day. Revival is not wishful thinking. It has a date in history, and an empty tomb to prove it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

On the third day God revived His Son and raised Him up, the true Son of Man at His right hand. That resurrection is the source of every revival. If you are burned and cut down today, ask Him to give you life again. He raised Christ. He can raise you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you asking God to revive you — not to improve you, but to give you life again?

◆

DAY 182 · JULY 1 · PSALM 81 (VV. 1–10)

Open Your Mouth Wide

"Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it."
— PSALM 81:10

Psalm 81 opens with a festival: *"Sing aloud to God, our strength! Make a joyful shout to the God of Jacob! Raise a song, and bring here the tambourine, the pleasant lyre with the harp. Blow the trumpet at the New Moon, at the full moon, on our feast day"* (Psalm 81:1–3). Music, noise, celebration. God's people gathered to remember what He had done. And then, in the middle of the song, God Himself begins to speak.

He reminds them of the rescue: *"I removed his shoulder from the burden. His hands were freed from the basket"* (Psalm 81:6). In Egypt the Israelites hauled bricks and clay in baskets on their backs. God lifted that load off their shoulders. *"You called in trouble, and I delivered you. I answered you in the secret place of thunder"* (Psalm 81:7). They cried out, and He came. That is the history God wants His people to remember when they sing.

Then the invitation that gives this day its name: *"I am Yahweh, your God, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt. Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it"* (Psalm 81:10). Picture a nest of baby birds, beaks stretched open as far as they will go when the parent arrives. That is the posture God asks for. Not a polite nibble. Not a small, careful request. Open wide. Ask big, and ask boldly. Expect Him to fill it. A baby bird does not apologize for being hungry. It simply opens and waits for what the parent brings.

Why would God say that? Because of who He is: the God who brought you out of Egypt. If He could break the chains of the world's greatest empire, He can fill whatever emptiness you bring Him today. Many people pray small because they expect little. They keep their mouths half-shut, afraid to ask too much. Paul says God *"is able to do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think"* (Ephesians 3:20). And Jesus said, *"Ask, and it will be given you"* (Matthew 7:7). Open your mouth wide. The One who freed your hands from the basket wants to fill you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the bread God gives to fill hungry mouths. He said, "I am the living bread which came down out of heaven" (John 6:51), and He gave His flesh on the cross for the life of the world. He rose to feed you forever. Open your mouth wide today. He will fill it.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you asking God for small things because you expect little, when He invites you to open wide?

◆

DAY 183 · JULY 2 · PSALM 81 (VV. 9–16)

Oh, That My People Would Listen

> *"Oh that my people would listen to me, that Israel would walk in my ways!"*
> — PSALM 81:13

The second half of Psalm 81 turns sorrowful. God had invited His people to open their mouths wide. And they refused: *"But my people didn't listen to my voice. Israel desired none of me"* (Psalm 81:11). None of me. Not a little, not a portion. They wanted nothing of Him. The God who had freed them from slavery was turned away like a salesman at the door.

And so God did something terrible: *"So I let them go after the stubbornness of their hearts, that they might walk in their own counsels"* (Psalm 81:12). He let them go. He gave them what they wanted — their own way. Paul describes the same judgment in Romans: *"Therefore God also gave them up in the lusts of their hearts"* (Romans 1:24). One of the most frightening things God can do is stop resisting your stubbornness and let you have it. The road you insisted on becomes the road you are stuck on, and every mile of it is lonelier than the last.

But listen to the heart of God in the next line: *"Oh that my people would listen to me, that Israel would walk in my ways!"* (Psalm 81:13). Oh that. It is a sigh. A longing. God is not glad to let them go. He grieves it. That is the same grief Jesus spoke over Jerusalem: *"How often I would have gathered your children together, even as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, and you would not!"* (Matthew 23:37). You would not. God wanted to. His people refused.

Then God says what He would have done: *"I would soon subdue their enemies, and turn my hand against their adversaries"* (Psalm 81:14). And more: *"But he would have also fed them with the finest of the wheat. I will satisfy you with honey out of the rock"* (Psalm 81:16). The finest wheat. Honey from the rock. That is what was waiting for them if they had only listened. It is still waiting for you. God is not calling you to a hard, joyless life. He is calling you to the best food there is. Listen to His voice today.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the voice God sends with longing to a people who would not listen. He wept over Jerusalem, went to the cross for the very ones who refused Him, and rose to call them back. The finest wheat and honey from the rock are still offered. Listen to Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you walking in your own counsel, refusing the finest wheat God longs to give you?

◆

DAY 184 · JULY 3 · PSALM 82

God Stands in the Council

> *"Defend the weak, the poor, and the fatherless. Maintain the rights of the poor and oppressed."*
> — PSALM 82:3

Psalm 82 pictures God holding court: *"God presides in the great assembly. He judges among the gods"* (Psalm 82:1). The gods here are the judges and rulers of the earth, the ones given authority to decide cases and protect the weak. And God has called them in to answer for how they have used that power. His first question is sharp: *"How long will you judge unjustly, and show partiality to the wicked?"* (Psalm 82:2).

They have been taking sides with the wrong people. Favoring the rich. Protecting the guilty. And God tells them what their job actually was: *"Defend the weak, the poor, and the fatherless. Maintain the rights of the poor and oppressed. Rescue the weak and needy. Deliver them out of the hand of the wicked"* (Psalm 82:3–4). That is what authority is for. Not personal gain. Not protecting friends. Standing up for the people who cannot stand up for themselves. The orphan with no advocate. The widow cheated out of her land. The worker paid less than he earned.

Isaiah said the same: *"Learn to do well. Seek justice. Relieve the oppressed. Defend the fatherless. Plead for the widow"* (Isaiah 1:17). And Micah: *"What does Yahweh require of you, but to act justly, to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God?"* (Micah 6:8). You may not be a judge or a ruler, but you have some kind of authority. As a parent. A supervisor. A teacher. A neighbor with a little more than the next one. God asks the same question of you: how are you using it?

Then a sobering word to the mighty: *"I said, 'You are gods, all of you are sons of the Most High. Nevertheless you shall die like men, and fall like one of the rulers'"* (Psalm 82:6–7). However high their position, they will die like everyone else. The robe comes off at the grave. Jesus quoted this very line (John 10:34). And the psalm ends with a prayer for the true Judge to take His seat: *"Arise, God, judge the earth, for you inherit all of the nations"* (Psalm 82:8). That Judge has come. He defends the weak. Follow Him in it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Judge who finally defends the weak. He took the side of the poor, the fatherless, and the outcast, and He was condemned by unjust judges for it. On the third day God raised Him, and now He will judge the earth in righteousness. Use whatever authority you have to defend the weak today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

How are you using the authority you have — to defend the weak, or to protect yourself?

◆

DAY 185 · JULY 4 · PSALM 83 (VV. 1–6)

O God, Do Not Keep Silence

"God, don't keep silent. Don't keep silent, and don't be still, God."
— PSALM 83:1

Psalm 83 is a cry from a nation surrounded. It opens with three requests in a single breath: *"God, don't keep silent. Don't keep silent, and don't be still, God"* (Psalm 83:1). Do not be silent. Do not be still. The psalmist is begging God to speak and act, because the danger is real and close. When everything around you is loud with threat, God's silence feels unbearable. The enemy is shouting. Your own fears are shouting. And heaven seems to say nothing at all. You may have prayed like this in a hospital hallway or a lawyer's office or at a kitchen table late at night.

And the threat is described in detail: *"For, behold, your enemies are stirred up. Those who hate you have lifted up their heads. They conspire with cunning against your people. They plot against your cherished ones"* (Psalm 83:2–3). Notice two things. The psalmist calls them Your enemies — not just Israel's. An attack on God's people is an attack on God. And he calls God's people Your cherished ones. Hidden, treasured, protected. That is how God sees His own.

The plan of the enemies is total: *"'Come,' they say, 'let's destroy them as a nation, that the name of Israel may be remembered no more'"* (Psalm 83:4). Wipe them out. Erase the name. And the list of conspirators is long: Edom, the Ishmaelites, Moab, the Hagrites, Gebal, Ammon, Amalek, Philistia, Tyre, and Assyria (Psalm 83:6–8). Ten nations, one goal. It is the kind of list that makes you feel outnumbered. Every border has an enemy on it. Every direction you look, someone wants you gone.

You may feel outnumbered right now. Not by nations, but by pressures, critics, temptations, or circumstances that all seem to point the same direction. And God seems quiet, as though He has stepped out of the room. The psalm gives you words for that moment. Do not be silent. Do not be still. That prayer is not a lack of faith. It is faith calling on the only One who can answer. And remember what you are to Him: cherished. Hidden away like treasure. The enemies conspire against God's cherished ones, and that is exactly why they cannot win.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The nations conspired against God's Anointed, and they nailed Him to a cross. It looked as though they had erased His name. Then God spoke on the third day, and Christ rose. His name is now above every name. You are cherished in Him. When God seems silent, call on Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where do you feel outnumbered and surrounded — and can you trust that you are God's cherished one?

◆

DAY 186 · JULY 5 · PSALM 83 (VV. 7–12)

Do to Them as You Did Before

> *"Do to them as you did to Midian"*
> — PSALM 83:9

Psalm 83 does something you should learn to do in your own prayers. It reaches back into history and asks God to do again what He has done before: *"Do to them as you did to Midian, as to Sisera, as to Jabin, at the river Kishon"* (Psalm 83:9). Midian. Sisera. Jabin. Old names, but not dead ones. These were names from the book of Judges, stories every Israelite child would have known by heart, told around fires and at dinner tables for generations.

Midian was the enemy that Gideon faced with only three hundred men. God won that day by confusion: *"Yahweh set every man's sword against his fellow and against all the army; and the army fled"* (Judges 7:22). Sisera was the commander of a Canaanite army with nine hundred iron chariots. God won that day too: *"Yahweh confused Sisera, all his chariots, and all his army"* (Judges 4:15). Both times Israel was weak. Both times God won. Neither victory came from Israel's strength. Gideon's men held torches and trumpets, not much else. Deborah and Barak faced iron chariots on foot.

"Make their nobles like Oreb and Zeeb, yes, all their princes like Zebah and Zalmunna, who said, 'Let's take possession of God's pasture lands'" (Psalm 83:11–12). More names from the Gideon story. Princes who thought they could take what belonged to God. They were wrong. The psalmist is saying: You did it before, Lord. Do it again, here, now, in this trouble. That is a sturdy way to pray, grounded not in wishful thinking but in God's actual record.

You have your own Midians and Siseras. Times God came through when you were weak and outnumbered. The job you got when you had no money. The sickness He brought you through. The marriage He saved. The addiction He broke. Use those memories in your prayers. Lord, You did it then. Do it again now. That is not bargaining. It is faith remembering, and memory is one of faith's strongest muscles. And the deepest example of all is the cross, where God defeated sin and death when His Son looked weakest. If He did that, He can do this.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The cross is God's greatest Midian. When Christ looked weakest, God defeated sin, death, and the devil, and on the third day raised Him. Remind God today of what He has done before, and ask Him to do it again. The God of the empty tomb has not changed.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What past deliverances of God could you name in prayer, asking Him to do it again?

◆

DAY 187 · JULY 6 · PSALM 83 (VV. 13–18)

That They May Know Your Name

> *"that they may know that you alone, whose name is Yahweh, are the Most High over all the earth."*
> — PSALM 83:18

Psalm 83 ends with fierce prayers against the enemies: *"My God, make them like tumbleweed, like chaff before the wind. As the fire that burns the forest, as the flame that sets the mountains on fire, so pursue them with your tempest, and terrify them with your storm"* (Psalm 83:13–15). Tumbleweed. Chaff. Fire in the forest. Storm on the mountains. It is the language of total defeat.

But watch where the prayer goes next. It is not only about destruction. It has a purpose: *"Fill their faces with confusion, that they may seek your name, Yahweh"* (Psalm 83:16). That they may seek Your name. Even in the middle of praying for the enemy's defeat, the psalmist hopes the enemy will turn to God. The shame is meant to lead them to seek the LORD. That is a remarkable turn in an imprecatory psalm. Even the harshest prayer in this psalm leaves the door open.

And the final goal: *"that they may know that you alone, whose name is Yahweh, are the Most High over all the earth"* (Psalm 83:18). The point of the whole conflict is not Israel's victory. It is God's name being known. That changes how you pray about your enemies. Your goal is not to win. It is for God to be known, by you and by them. You can ask God to stop them, to frustrate their plans, to bring their schemes to nothing — and also to bring them to Himself. Paul says, *"Don't seek revenge yourselves, beloved, but give place to God's wrath"* (Romans 12:19).

The day is coming when everyone will know His name. Paul writes, *"that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of those in heaven, those on earth, and those under the earth, and that every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord"* (Philippians 2:10–11). Every knee. Friends and enemies alike, without exception. Some will bow in joy, some in defeat. Pray today, by name if you can, that the people who oppose you will be among those who seek His name before that day. That is the deepest victory there is — an enemy turned into family.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ prayed for His enemies from the cross, and some of the very people who shouted for His death later sought His name. God raised Him so that every knee will bow. Pray today that your enemies will seek His name. The best victory is an enemy made a friend.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you pray not only for your enemies' plans to fail, but for them to seek God's name?

◆

DAY 188 · JULY 7 · PSALM 84 (VV. 1–6)

My Soul Longs for the Courts of the LORD

"My soul longs, and even faints for the courts of Yahweh."
— PSALM 84:2

Psalm 84 is a song of longing. It opens with a sigh: *"How lovely are your dwellings, Yahweh of Armies!"* (Psalm 84:1). The psalmist is thinking about the temple, the place where God met His people. And he is not there. He is far away, and the longing aches: *"My soul longs, and even faints for the courts of Yahweh. My heart and my flesh cry out for the living God"* (Psalm 84:2).

Faints. That is how deep the longing goes. His whole being — soul, heart, flesh — cries out for God. Not for the building, but for the living God who dwells there. The stones and gold were never the point. Many people long for many things. A better job. A bigger house. A quieter life. This psalmist longs for God Himself with the kind of intensity most people reserve for food when they are starving. Jesus said, *"Blessed are those who hunger and thirst after righteousness, for they shall be filled"* (Matthew 5:6).

Then a tender detail: *"Yes, the sparrow has found a home, and the swallow a nest for herself, where she may have her young, near your altars, Yahweh of Armies, my King, and my God"* (Psalm 84:3). Birds nesting in the temple courts. Small, ordinary birds, building their nests right next to God's altar. The psalmist envies them. They get to live where he longs to be. Even the smallest creatures find a home near God. A sparrow is worth almost nothing in the market, and it nests by the altar without anyone chasing it away.

"Blessed are those who dwell in your house. They are always praising you" (Psalm 84:4). That is the blessing. Not wealth, not fame — nearness to God. And here is the good news for you. In Christ you do not have to travel to a building to be near God. Jesus said the hour has come *"when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth"* (John 4:23). And Hebrews says, *"But you have come to Mount Zion, and to the city of the living God"* (Hebrews 12:22). The sparrow found a home near God. So can you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the temple where God dwells, and through His death the way into God's presence was opened. The curtain tore from top to bottom. He rose, and now the sparrow and the swallow and you have a home near Him. Let your heart cry out for the living God today. He has made room.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Does your heart long for God Himself — or mainly for what He might give you?

◆

DAY 189 · JULY 8 · PSALM 84 (VV. 7–12)

Better Is a Day in Your Courts

> *"For a day in your courts is better than a thousand."*
> — PSALM 84:10

Psalm 84 describes the pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem: *"Blessed are those whose strength is in you, who have set their hearts on a pilgrimage"* (Psalm 84:5). They have set their hearts on the road. And the road is not easy: *"Passing through the valley of Weeping, they make it a place of springs. Yes, the autumn rain covers it with blessings"* (Psalm 84:6). The valley of Weeping. A dry, sad place. And as they pass through it, it becomes a place of springs.

That is what happens when your heart is set on God. You still pass through the valley of tears. You still walk dry roads. But the valley changes as you go through it. The tears become springs of water. The dry ground gets rain. *"They go from strength to strength. Every one of them appears before God in Zion"* (Psalm 84:7). Not strength to weakness, as you might expect on a long road. Strength to strength. They arrive stronger than they left, though the road was long.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"For a day in your courts is better than a thousand. I would rather be a doorkeeper in the house of my God, than to dwell in the tents of wickedness"* (Psalm 84:10). One day with God beats a thousand without Him. The lowest job in God's house — standing at the door — beats the best seat in the tents of the wicked. That is a radical reordering of values. It turns the usual ladder of success upside down.

Most people would take the comfortable tent over the humble post at the door. Psalm 84 says the door is better, because of who is inside. And then the reason: *"For Yahweh God is a sun and a shield. Yahweh will give grace and glory. He withholds no good thing from those who walk blamelessly"* (Psalm 84:11). Sun and shield. Light and protection. Grace now and glory later. *"Yahweh of Armies, blessed is the man who trusts in you"* (Psalm 84:12). If you are walking through a valley of Weeping today, keep walking toward God. It will become springs.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ walked through the valley of Weeping all the way to Golgotha, and turned the place of death into the spring of life. On the third day He rose. Because of Him, one day in God's presence is better than a thousand elsewhere. Set your heart on the road toward Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you truly believe one day near God is better than a thousand elsewhere?

◆

DAY 190 · JULY 9 · PSALM 85 (VV. 1–6)

Will You Not Revive Us Again?

"Won't you revive us again, that your people may rejoice in you?"
— PSALM 85:6

Psalm 85 begins by remembering a time God turned things around: *"Yahweh, you have been favorable to your land. You have restored the fortunes of Jacob. You have forgiven the iniquity of your people. You have covered all their sin"* (Psalm 85:1–2). Favor. Restoration. Forgiveness. Sin covered. The psalmist looks back to a day when God brought His people home and wiped the slate clean. He remembers it clearly, the way you remember the day a long sickness finally broke.

And he remembers that God's anger turned away: *"You have taken away all your wrath. You have turned from the fierceness of your anger"* (Psalm 85:3). That happened once. And now the people are in trouble again. So the psalmist uses the memory as the ground for a new request: *"Turn us, God of our salvation, and cause your indignation toward us to cease. Will you be angry with us forever? Will you draw out your anger to all generations?"* (Psalm 85:4–5). You did it before. Do it again.

Then the question that sits at the center of this whole year: *"Won't you revive us again, that your people may rejoice in you?"* (Psalm 85:6). Revive again. The Hebrew verb is chayah, the same one Psalm 119:25 uses when it prays, *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). Revival is not a one-time event. God's people need it again and again. The fire burns low. The dust settles. And the prayer goes up once more: give life again.

Notice what revival is for: that your people may rejoice in you. Not rejoice in their own improvement. Not rejoice in a bigger church or a better program. Rejoice in God. That is the mark of real revival — joy in the LORD Himself. You may have known seasons when your faith was warm and alive, and now it feels cold. You are allowed to pray this psalm. Revive me again. The God who did it before has not changed. Paul says God, *"being rich in mercy, for his great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead through our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ"* (Ephesians 2:4–5).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God answered the prayer for revival once and for all when He raised Christ from the dead. Every revival since flows from that empty tomb. If your faith feels cold today, pray it again: revive me. The God who gave His Son life on the third day can give it to you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When your faith has grown cold, do you pray for God to revive you again — or try to warm yourself?

◆

DAY 191 · JULY 10 · PSALM 85 (VV. 7–13)

Steadfast Love and Faithfulness Meet

> *"Mercy and truth meet together. Righteousness and peace have kissed each other."*
> — PSALM 85:10

After asking for revival, the psalmist waits to hear God's answer: *"Show us your loving kindness, Yahweh. Grant us your salvation. I will hear what God, Yahweh, will speak, for he will speak peace to his people, his saints; but let them not turn again to folly"* (Psalm 85:7–8). He listens. And what God speaks is peace. Not a lecture. Not a list of conditions. Peace — with one tender warning: do not go back to the foolishness that brought the trouble.

Then the psalm gives one of the most striking pictures in all of Scripture: *"Mercy and truth meet together. Righteousness and peace have kissed each other"* (Psalm 85:10). Mercy and truth were walking toward each other from opposite ends of the road, and they met. Righteousness and peace, which seem like they should be at odds, embraced. How can that be? In human life those four rarely get along.

Mercy wants to forgive. Truth insists that sin is real and must be dealt with. Peace wants reconciliation. Righteousness demands justice. In most human courts, one has to give way to the other. Either the guilty are punished, or they are let off. Either justice is done, or peace is made. But in God, both happen at once. Where? At the cross. Paul says God sent Christ *"to be an atoning sacrifice"* (Romans 3:25), *"that he might himself be just, and the justifier of him who has faith in Jesus"* (Romans 3:26).

Just and the justifier. Righteousness and peace kissing. That is the gospel. At the cross God's justice against sin was fully satisfied, and God's mercy toward sinners was fully poured out. Neither was compromised. God did not lower His standard to forgive you. He met it Himself. And so the psalm goes on: *"Truth springs out of the earth. Righteousness has looked down from heaven"* (Psalm 85:11). Heaven and earth meet. Then: *"Yes, Yahweh will give that which is good. Our land will yield its increase"* (Psalm 85:12). Because of the cross, you have peace with God. Paul says it in one line: *"Being therefore justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ"* (Romans 5:1).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

At the cross mercy and truth met in the body of Christ. Righteousness was satisfied and peace was made in the same moment, as He bore your sin. He rose on the third day. Rest today in a peace that cost Him everything.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe God's justice and His mercy have both been fully satisfied for you at the cross?

◆

DAY 192 · JULY 11 · PSALM 86 (VV. 1–6)

Incline Your Ear, O LORD

> *"Hear, Yahweh, and answer me, for I am poor and needy."*
> — PSALM 86:1

Psalm 86 is the only psalm in Book Three with David's name in the heading, and it is a prayer of plain need: *"Hear, Yahweh, and answer me, for I am poor and needy"* (Psalm 86:1). Not, hear me because I am strong. Not, answer me because I deserve it. Hear me because I am poor and needy. That is the reason he gives. And it is a good reason. God is drawn to the needy, not to the self-sufficient. The empty hand is the one He fills.

Then a line that might sound odd: *"Preserve my soul, for I am godly"* (Psalm 86:2). David is not boasting. The word points to someone who belongs to God, who has been set apart by His covenant love. He is saying: I am Yours. Keep what belongs to You. And then he says it plainly: *"You, my God, save your servant who trusts in you"* (Psalm 86:2). Servant. Trust. That is the relationship. A servant who trusts his master to protect him.

"Be merciful to me, Lord, for I call to you all day long" (Psalm 86:3). All day long. Not once in the morning and then forgotten. All day. Then: *"Bring joy to the soul of your servant, for to you, Lord, do I lift up my soul"* (Psalm 86:4). Lift up my soul. Like a child holding something up to a parent. Here, take this. Make it glad. David brings his whole inner life to God and asks God to fill it with joy.

And the reason he dares to ask: *"For you, Lord, are good, and ready to forgive, abundant in loving kindness to all those who call on you"* (Psalm 86:5). Good. Ready to forgive. Not reluctant, not slow, not needing to be talked into it. Ready. That is how God waits for you. Like a father at the end of the road who sees his child coming and runs. If you are poor and needy today — and everyone is, whether they admit it or not — you have the best reason in the world to pray. Hear me, LORD. I am poor and needy. He is ready.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ became poor and needy for you, hungry in the wilderness and stripped bare on the cross. He bore your sin so that God could be ready to forgive. He rose, and He stands ready still. Bring your need to Him today. Lift up your soul. He is good.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you come to God as poor and needy — or try to come as someone who has it together?

◆

DAY 193 · JULY 12 · PSALM 86 (VV. 7–11)

Unite My Heart to Fear Your Name

"Make my heart undivided to fear your name."
— PSALM 86:11

David is in trouble, but he is confident: *"In the day of my trouble I will call on you, for you will answer me"* (Psalm 86:7). You will answer. Not maybe. Not if I am lucky. Not someday. He knows God answers. And his confidence comes from who God is: *"There is no one like you among the gods, Lord, nor any deeds like your deeds"* (Psalm 86:8). No one compares. No other god has done what the LORD has done.

Then David looks beyond Israel to the whole world: *"All nations you have made will come and worship before you, Lord. They shall glorify your name. For you are great, and do wondrous things. You are God alone"* (Psalm 86:9–10). All nations. Every people He made will one day bow. David sees a future where the whole earth worships the God of Israel. And in Christ that day has begun. Revelation pictures *"a great multitude, which no man could count, out of every nation"* (Revelation 7:9).

Then comes the prayer that gives this day its name: *"Teach me your way, Yahweh. I will walk in your truth. Make my heart undivided to fear your name"* (Psalm 86:11). Undivided. That is the problem with most hearts. They are split. Part wants God and part wants something else. Part prays and part plots. Part trusts and part worries. Part serves God and part serves the paycheck. A divided heart is pulled in two directions at once, and it cannot walk straight. It zigzags. James says a double-minded person is *"unstable in all his ways"* (James 1:8).

David knows he cannot fix this himself. So he asks God to do it. Make my heart undivided. Gather up the scattered pieces and make it whole. Jesus said the greatest command is to love God *"with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your mind"* (Matthew 22:37). All. Not part. You cannot produce that kind of whole-hearted love by willpower. But you can ask for it. And God answers that prayer. *"I will praise you, Lord my God, with my whole heart"* (Psalm 86:12). The undivided heart becomes the whole-hearted song.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ had an undivided heart. Every part of Him wanted the Father's will, all the way to the cross. He rose to give His people a new heart by His Spirit. Ask Him today to gather up the scattered pieces of your heart and make it whole for God.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where is your heart divided between God and something else — and will you ask Him to make it whole?

◆

DAY 194 · JULY 13 · PSALM 86 (VV. 12–17)

A God Merciful and Gracious

> *"But you, Lord, are a merciful and gracious God, slow to anger, and abundant in loving kindness and truth."*
> — PSALM 86:15

David praises God for a deep rescue: *"For your loving kindness is great toward me. You have delivered my soul from the lowest Sheol"* (Psalm 86:13). The lowest Sheol. The deepest pit. Whatever David had been through, it felt like death, and God brought him out. And still the enemies keep coming: *"God, the proud have risen up against me. A company of violent men have sought after my soul, and they don't hold regard for you before them"* (Psalm 86:14).

Then David reaches for the oldest description of God in the Bible: *"But you, Lord, are a merciful and gracious God, slow to anger, and abundant in loving kindness and truth"* (Psalm 86:15). These are almost exactly the words God spoke about Himself to Moses on Mount Sinai: *"Yahweh! Yahweh, a merciful and gracious God, slow to anger, and abundant in loving kindness and truth"* (Exodus 34:6). David is quoting God back to God. This is who You said You are. Now be that for me. There is no more solid ground to pray from than God's own description of Himself.

Look at each word. Merciful — He feels compassion for the hurting. Gracious — He gives what is not earned. Slow to anger — He has a long fuse, a patience that outlasts your failures. Abundant in loving kindness — not a trickle of love, but a flood. And truth — He is faithful, He keeps His word. That is the character of God. Not a harsh judge looking for an excuse to punish. A merciful, gracious, patient, loving, faithful God.

So David asks: *"Turn to me, and have mercy on me! Give your strength to your servant. Save the son of your servant"* (Psalm 86:16). Turn toward me. And then: *"Show me a sign of your goodness, that those who hate me may see it, and be shamed, because you, Yahweh, have helped me, and comforted me"* (Psalm 86:17). A sign of goodness. Helped and comforted. That is what the God of Exodus 34 does. You may have been picturing God as harsh. Psalm 86 corrects the picture. This is who He is, in His own words.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God showed what He is like most clearly in Christ. On the cross He was merciful to sinners, gracious to the undeserving, patient with those who mocked Him, and abundant in love. He rose as the sign of God's goodness. Look at Jesus today, and see who God really is.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What picture of God are you carrying — and does it match the God of Exodus 34 and Psalm 86?

◆

DAY 195 · JULY 14 · PSALM 87

Glorious Things Are Spoken of You

"Glorious things are spoken about you, city of God."
— PSALM 87:3

Psalm 87 is short and strange, and it holds one of the most hopeful visions in the Old Testament. It begins with God's love for Zion: *"His foundation is in the holy mountains. Yahweh loves the gates of Zion more than all the dwellings of Jacob. Glorious things are spoken about you, city of God"* (Psalm 87:1–3). God loves Jerusalem. It is His city, and great things are said about it.

Then a surprise. God starts listing the nations that will be counted as citizens of Zion: *"I will record Rahab and Babylon among those who acknowledge me. Behold, Philistia, Tyre, and also Ethiopia: 'This one was born there'"* (Psalm 87:4). Rahab is a poetic name for Egypt. Egypt, the old slave master. Babylon, the empire that would destroy Jerusalem. Philistia, the enemy of David. These are Israel's worst enemies, the names that made children shiver in the old stories. And God says they will be enrolled as citizens of His city.

"Yes, of Zion it will be said, 'This one and that one was born in her;' the Most High himself will establish her" (Psalm 87:5). This one and that one. People from every enemy nation, written into the birth register of Zion. That is a picture of the gospel going to the nations. Paul says in Christ *"There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free man, there is neither male nor female; for you are all one in Christ Jesus"* (Galatians 3:28). Former enemies, now fellow citizens, seated at the same table and singing the same songs.

"Yahweh will count, when he writes up the peoples, 'This one was born there'" (Psalm 87:6). God keeps the register Himself. And your name can be in it — not because of where you were physically born, but because you have been born again into His city. Paul says, *"our citizenship is in heaven"* (Philippians 3:20). The psalm ends with music: *"Those who sing as well as those who dance say, 'All my springs are in you'"* (Psalm 87:7). All my springs. Every source of life and joy, found in God's city. Whatever your background, you can be written in.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ opened the city of God to the nations by His blood. Egyptians, Babylonians, Philistines, and you can all be enrolled as citizens through Him. He rose and now keeps the register Himself. If you belong to Him, your name is written there. All your springs are in Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you know that your name is written in the register of God's city — and that all your springs are in Him?

◆

DAY 196 · JULY 15 · PSALM 88 (VV. 1–6)

My Soul Is Full of Troubles

"For my soul is full of troubles. My life draws near to Sheol."
— PSALM 88:3

Psalm 88 is the darkest psalm in the Bible. Most laments turn toward hope by the end. This one does not. It begins with a prayer and ends in darkness. But it does begin with something important: *"Yahweh, the God of my salvation, I have cried day and night before you"* (Psalm 88:1). The God of my salvation. Even in the deepest darkness, the psalmist still calls God his salvation. That one phrase is the thread of faith that holds the whole psalm.

"Let my prayer enter into your presence. Turn your ear to my cry. For my soul is full of troubles. My life draws near to Sheol" (Psalm 88:2–3). Full of troubles. There is no room for anything else. And his life is sliding toward the grave. *"I am counted among those who go down into the pit. I am like a man who has no help"* (Psalm 88:4). No help. Not from friends, not from doctors, not from anyone. He feels like a dead man walking.

"set apart among the dead, like the slain who lie in the grave, whom you remember no more. They are cut off from your hand" (Psalm 88:5). He feels forgotten by God, cut off from His hand. That is a terrifying place to be. And the Bible does not rush him out of it. It lets him stay there and describe it. That is a gift to anyone who has been in that place. You are not the only one. Someone in Scripture felt exactly what you feel, and God kept his prayer in the book.

Why would God keep a psalm with no happy ending? Because some nights do not end quickly. Some depression does not lift in a week. Some grief stays for years. And God wants you to know that you can pray from there. You do not have to fake a happy ending. You can say, my soul is full of troubles, and still call Him the God of my salvation. Paul knew it: *"We are pressed on every side, yet not crushed; perplexed, yet not to despair; pursued, yet not forsaken; struck down, yet not destroyed"* (2 Corinthians 4:8–9).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went into the full darkness of Psalm 88. He was counted among those who go down into the pit, cut off and forsaken on the cross, and laid in the grave. But on the third day the God of salvation raised Him. Your darkest night is not the end. He has been there and come out.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you pray from the darkest place without faking a happy ending — and still call Him the God of your salvation?

◆

DAY 197 · JULY 16 · PSALM 88 (VV. 6–12)

In the Depths of Darkness

> *"You have laid me in the lowest pit, in the darkest depths."*
> — PSALM 88:6

The psalmist goes deeper still: *"You have laid me in the lowest pit, in the darkest depths. Your wrath lies heavily on me. You have afflicted me with all your waves"* (Psalm 88:6–7). He believes God has done this. You have laid me. Your wrath. Your waves. He does not blame chance or the devil or bad luck. He brings his complaint straight to God. That is honest. And it is also faith, because it assumes God is still in control even of the darkness.

Then the loneliness: *"You have taken my friends from me. You have made me an abomination to them. I am confined, and I can't escape"* (Psalm 88:8). Friends gone. Trapped with no way out at all. Many who suffer long illness or deep depression know this exactly. People stop calling. Visits stop. You become someone others avoid, because they do not know what to say. And the room gets smaller and smaller, until the walls seem to press in from every side.

"My eyes are dim from grief. I have called on you daily, Yahweh. I have spread out my hands to you" (Psalm 88:9). Every day he has prayed. Every day he has reached out. And then a string of questions: *"Do you show wonders to the dead? Do the departed spirits rise up and praise you? Is your loving kindness declared in the grave? Or your faithfulness in Destruction? Are your wonders made known in the dark?"* (Psalm 88:10–12). He is asking: If I die, how can I praise You? Save me so I can.

Those questions have an answer the psalmist could not yet see. Yes. God does show wonders to the dead. Yes, the departed will rise. Yes, His loving kindness is declared in the grave — because Jesus went into the grave and came out. At the cross Jesus cried, *"My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?"* (Mark 15:34). He went into the lowest pit, the darkest depths, under the full weight of God's wrath. And on the third day God showed His greatest wonder to the dead. The questions of Psalm 88 were answered in an empty tomb.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Do You show wonders to the dead? Yes. Christ was laid in the lowest pit and raised on the third day. His loving kindness was declared in the grave when the grave could not keep Him. If you are in the darkest depths today, He has been there. And He came out.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe God's loving kindness reaches even the darkest depths — because Christ went there first?

◆

DAY 198 · JULY 17 · PSALM 88 (VV. 13–18)

Darkness My Closest Friend

> *"But to you, Yahweh, I have cried. In the morning, my prayer comes before you."*
> — PSALM 88:13

The last part of Psalm 88 holds one small light: *"But to you, Yahweh, I have cried. In the morning, my prayer comes before you"* (Psalm 88:13). In the morning. Every day he gets up and prays again. Nothing has changed. The darkness is still there. And still, every morning, he comes back to God with his prayer. That is faith at its most stubborn and its most real. Not a feeling of hope, but a habit of turning toward God anyway.

And then the questions continue: *"Yahweh, why do you reject my soul? Why do you hide your face from me?"* (Psalm 88:14). He does not understand. He feels rejected. He feels God has turned His face away. *"I am afflicted and ready to die from my youth up. While I suffer your terrors, I am distracted"* (Psalm 88:15). From his youth. This is not a short trial. It has been going on for most of his life. Some people carry suffering that long — chronic pain, lifelong depression, a disability, a grief that never quite lifts.

"Your fierce wrath has gone over me. Your terrors have cut me off. They came around me like water all day long. They completely engulfed me" (Psalm 88:16–17). Like water all day long. Like drowning without ever reaching the bottom. And then the last line, the darkest ending in the Psalms: *"You have put lover and friend far from me, and my friends into darkness"* (Psalm 88:18). That is where it ends. Darkness. No turn. No praise. No resolution.

Why would God put that in His book? Because the psalmist was still praying when he wrote it. The very act of writing this prayer to God is an act of faith. He addressed it to the God of his salvation (Psalm 88:1). And because the story did not end there. Jesus took the darkness of Psalm 88 into Himself. His friends fled from Him: *"Then all the disciples left him and fled"* (Matthew 26:56). He was put into darkness. And then He rose. The last word of Psalm 88 is darkness. The last word of the gospel is resurrection. Keep praying in the morning.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ ended His life the way Psalm 88 ends — friends gone, darkness all around, a cry to a silent heaven. But His story did not stop there. On the third day, in the morning, God raised Him. Keep bringing your prayer to Him every morning. The darkness is not the last word.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If your prayers feel like Psalm 88, will you keep bringing them to God every morning anyway?

◆

DAY 199 · JULY 18 · PSALM 89 (VV. 1–6)

I Will Sing of Steadfast Love Forever

"I will sing of the loving kindness of Yahweh forever."
— PSALM 89:1

Psalm 89 is a long song about God's promise to David, and it begins with a vow to sing: *"I will sing of the loving kindness of Yahweh forever. With my mouth, I will make known your faithfulness to all generations"* (Psalm 89:1). Loving kindness and faithfulness. Those two words will run through the whole psalm like a pair of threads. God's steady love, and God's reliable promise. The psalmist will sing about both, forever. Not until his voice gives out. Not until the music stops. Forever, as long as there is breath to sing and a God to sing to.

"I indeed declare, 'Love stands firm forever. You established the heavens. Your faithfulness is in them'" (Psalm 89:2). Love stands firm. Not wobbling, not fading, not changing with the seasons. It is built to last forever, like the heavens themselves. You can look up at the sky on any clear night and see the evidence of God's faithfulness. The same stars that shone over David still shine over you, in the same places, on the same schedule, three thousand years later.

Then the psalm remembers the promise: *"I have made a covenant with my chosen one, I have sworn to David, my servant, 'I will establish your offspring forever, and build up your throne to all generations'"* (Psalm 89:3–4). God swore an oath. He promised David that his family would reign forever. That promise is first recorded in 2 Samuel: *"I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever"* (2 Samuel 7:13). Forever. Not for a few generations. Forever.

And the angel told Mary that her son would be the fulfillment: *"The Lord God will give him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over the house of Jacob forever. There will be no end to his Kingdom"* (Luke 1:32–33). Jesus is the Son of David whose throne lasts forever. The loving kindness and faithfulness Psalm 89 sings about found their home in Him. And so the psalm can praise: *"The heavens will praise your wonders, Yahweh, your faithfulness also in the assembly of the holy ones"* (Psalm 89:5). Start your day singing about His faithfulness. It has not failed yet.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God swore to David that his throne would stand forever, and He kept that oath in Christ, the Son of David, who died and rose and now reigns with no end to His kingdom. God's loving kindness and faithfulness have a face. Sing about Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you sing of God's faithfulness — or only speak of it when you need something?

◆

DAY 200 · JULY 19 · PSALM 89 (VV. 7–13)

Who Is Mighty as You?

"Yahweh, God of Armies, who is a mighty one, like you?"
— PSALM 89:8

Psalm 89 pauses to marvel at God's greatness: *"For who in the skies can be compared to Yahweh? Who among the sons of the heavenly beings is like Yahweh, a very awesome God in the council of the holy ones, to be feared above all those who are around him?"* (Psalm 89:6–7). No one in heaven compares. The angels themselves stand in awe. The holy ones fear Him. That is how high He is. Beings who have never sinned, who have seen His face, still bow before Him.

Then the question that gives this day its name: *"Yahweh, God of Armies, who is a mighty one, like you? Yah, your faithfulness is around you"* (Psalm 89:8). Who is mighty like You? No one. And His faithfulness surrounds Him like a robe. Everywhere He goes, faithfulness goes with Him. He cannot be unfaithful any more than the sun can be cold. It is part of who He is. You may meet unfaithfulness in people, in institutions, even in your own heart. You will never meet it in Him.

Then the psalm shows His power over the sea: *"You rule the pride of the sea. When its waves rise up, you calm them"* (Psalm 89:9). The sea in the ancient world was the picture of chaos — wild, uncontrollable, deadly. And God rules it. When the waves rise, He calms them. On the Sea of Galilee the disciples watched Jesus do exactly that, and they asked, *"Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?"* (Mark 4:41). They were asking the question of Psalm 89. The answer was standing in their boat.

"The heavens are yours. The earth also is yours, the world and its fullness. You have founded them. You have created the north and the south" (Psalm 89:11–12). Everything belongs to Him. North and south. Heaven and earth. Paul says of Christ, *"For by him all things were created in the heavens and on the earth"* (Colossians 1:16). The God of Psalm 89 is the God who calmed the storm. Whatever waves are rising in your life today, they are in His hand. *"You have a mighty arm. Your hand is strong"* (Psalm 89:13).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The disciples asked who could calm the sea, and the answer was Christ, asleep in their boat. He later let the waves of judgment break over Him at the cross, and He rose on the third day as Lord of every storm. Whatever waves are rising today, they obey Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What waves are rising in your life today — and do you believe God rules them?

◆

DAY 201 · JULY 20 · PSALM 89 (VV. 14–20)

Blessed Are Those Who Know the Festal Shout

"They walk in the light of your presence, Yahweh."
— PSALM 89:15

Psalm 89 describes the foundation of God's throne: *"Righteousness and justice are the foundation of your throne. Loving kindness and truth go before your face"* (Psalm 89:14). His rule is built on what is right and fair. And in front of Him, like heralds announcing His arrival, go loving kindness and truth. Wherever God goes, love and faithfulness walk ahead. You meet them first. Before you face His holiness, you meet His love.

Then a blessing: *"Blessed are the people who learn to acclaim you. They walk in the light of your presence, Yahweh"* (Psalm 89:15). Learn to acclaim. Praise is learned. It is not always natural. Complaining comes easily. Worry comes easily. Thanksgiving takes practice, like any skill worth having. You have to learn to lift your voice to God, to shout His goodness, to celebrate Him. And the people who learn it walk in the light of His face. They live their ordinary days with His presence shining on them, at work and at home.

"In your name they rejoice all day. In your righteousness, they are exalted" (Psalm 89:16). All day. Not just on Sunday morning, not just when the music is playing. Their joy is in His name from morning to night. And their standing comes from His righteousness, not their own. *"For you are the glory of their strength. In your favor, our horn will be exalted"* (Psalm 89:17). Their strength is not self-made. It is His glory. Their honor is His favor. That is freeing. You do not have to manufacture your own importance. It is given.

Then the psalm turns to the king God chose: *"I have found David, my servant. I have anointed him with my holy oil"* (Psalm 89:20). Paul preached this verse in Antioch and said: *"From this man's offspring, God has brought salvation to Israel according to his promise"* (Acts 13:23). The anointed king points to the Anointed One, Jesus. And Jesus said, *"I am the light of the world. He who follows me will not walk in the darkness, but will have the light of life"* (John 8:12). Learn to praise Him. Walk in His light today, every hour of it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the light of God's presence, crucified in darkness and raised to be the light of life. Learn to acclaim Him today, and walk in His light.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you learning to praise God — to walk in the light of His presence all day long?

◆

DAY 202 · JULY 21 · PSALM 89 (VV. 21–26)

My Faithfulness Shall Be with Him

> *"But my faithfulness and my loving kindness will be with him. In my name, his horn will be exalted."*
> — PSALM 89:24

God's promises to David keep coming in Psalm 89: *"with whom my hand shall be established. My arm will also strengthen him. No enemy will tax him. No wicked man will oppress him"* (Psalm 89:21–22). God's hand on him. God's arm strengthening him. No enemy able to crush him. The king is not strong because of himself. He is strong because God holds him up. Take away God's hand and the strongest king on earth would fall in a day.

"I will beat down his adversaries before him, and strike those who hate him" (Psalm 89:23). God fights for the king. And then the heart of the promise: *"But my faithfulness and my loving kindness will be with him. In my name, his horn will be exalted"* (Psalm 89:24). Faithfulness and loving kindness — the two threads again. They will be with him. Not just around him, but with him, close, every step. Through the hard seasons and the long nights, through success and through failure.

Then a remarkable line: *"He will call to me, 'You are my Father, my God, and the rock of my salvation!'"* (Psalm 89:26). The king calls God his Father. That is close. Intimate. And God accepts it. He does not correct the king or tell him to keep a respectful distance. He welcomes the word. Hebrews applies this kind of language to Jesus: *"I will be to him a Father, and he will be to me a Son"* (Hebrews 1:5). Jesus is the true Son who calls God Father. And because of Him, you can too.

That is the gift of the gospel. The promises God made to His anointed king are now extended to everyone in Christ. God's faithfulness and loving kindness will be with you. Not because you are a king, but because you belong to the King. Paul says, *"For however many are the promises of God, in him is the 'Yes'"* (2 Corinthians 1:20). Every promise God made to David is yes in Jesus. None of them is still waiting. None of them has fallen through. And through Jesus, every one of those promises is yours. Call Him Father today. You have the right.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the anointed King who calls God Father, and God's faithfulness and love have always been with Him, even through the cross. He rose, and now every promise God made is yes in Him. Call God Father today. You belong to the King.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you live as one with whom God's faithfulness and loving kindness go — because you belong to Christ?

◆

DAY 203 · JULY 22 · PSALM 89 (VV. 27–32)

My Steadfast Love I Will Keep

> *"I will keep my loving kindness for him forever more. My covenant will stand firm with him."*
> — PSALM 89:28

God goes further in His promise to David: *"I will also appoint him my firstborn, the highest of the kings of the earth"* (Psalm 89:27). Firstborn. Not the first child born, but the one with the highest rank and the fullest inheritance. The highest of the kings. That is more than any human king ever reached. Solomon was great, but there were greater kings in Egypt and Babylon. This promise reaches higher than any throne on earth. It points to Christ, the firstborn over all creation.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"I will keep my loving kindness for him forever more. My covenant will stand firm with him"* (Psalm 89:28). Forever more. God will not withdraw His love. The covenant will not crack. *"I will also make his offspring endure forever, and his throne as the days of heaven"* (Psalm 89:29). As long as heaven lasts. That is how long the throne will stand. Not a dynasty that fades after a few centuries, like every royal house in history. A throne as lasting as the sky.

But then God addresses a hard question. What if David's children fail? *"If his children forsake my law, and don't walk in my ordinances; if they break my statutes, and don't keep my commandments; then I will punish their sin with the rod, and their iniquity with stripes"* (Psalm 89:30–32). God will discipline them. Sin will have consequences. He does not ignore it. The rod will come. Any parent who loves a child knows why. Letting a child run toward the road is not love. That is the honest truth about God's covenant love. It is not soft on sin.

And yet. The next verse, which you will read tomorrow, says the discipline will not end the love. That is the good news hidden in the hard warning. God disciplines His children because they are His children. He does not throw them out. If you are in a season of correction right now, it is not a sign that God has rejected you. It is a sign that He is keeping His covenant. A father who does not care does not correct. Correction is proof of belonging. Titus calls Him *"God, who can't lie"* (Titus 1:2). His covenant stands firm with you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the firstborn King whose throne lasts as long as heaven. He bore the rod and the stripes that David's children deserved, so that God's loving kindness would never be withdrawn from them. He rose, and the covenant stands firm. You are kept in it today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When God disciplines you, can you trust that His covenant love has not been withdrawn?

◆

DAY 204 · JULY 23 · PSALM 89 (VV. 33–39)

Yet You Have Cast Off

> *"Once I have sworn by my holiness, I will not lie to David."*
> — PSALM 89:35

The promise continues with words of breathtaking firmness: *"But I will not completely take my loving kindness from him, nor allow my faithfulness to fail. I will not break my covenant, nor alter what my lips have uttered"* (Psalm 89:33–34). Even when David's children sin. Even when the rod falls. God will not break His word. He will not change what He said. The covenant is unbreakable from His side.

Then: *"Once I have sworn by my holiness, I will not lie to David"* (Psalm 89:35). Sworn by His holiness, the very center of who He is and always will be. There is nothing higher for God to swear by. Hebrews says God *"interposed with an oath, that by two immutable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie, we may have a strong encouragement"* (Hebrews 6:17–18). Impossible for God to lie. That is the ground under your feet when everything else shakes. People break promises. Companies break contracts. God does not.

"His offspring will endure forever, his throne like the sun before me. It will be established forever like the moon, the faithful witness in the sky" (Psalm 89:36–37). Every time you see the sun rise or the moon hang in the night sky, you are seeing a witness to God's promise. As sure as the moon, the throne will stand. And then — the shock: *"But you have rejected and spurned. You have been angry with your anointed. You have renounced the covenant of your servant. You have defiled his crown in the dust"* (Psalm 89:38–39).

The crown in the dust. The throne that was supposed to last forever looks finished. The psalmist cannot square what God promised with what he sees. That is a real crisis of faith, and Psalm 89 does not hide it. You may know that crisis — God promised, and now everything looks like the promise failed. Hold on. The crown went into the dust, but it did not stay there. The Son of David wore a crown of thorns and was laid in the dust of death. And on the third day God kept His oath. The crown came back up.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God swore by His holiness that David's throne would stand, and then the crown went into the dust when Christ died. It looked like the promise had failed. On the third day God kept His oath and raised Him. When God's promises look broken in your life, remember the empty tomb.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where does it look as though God's promise to you has failed — and can you trust the God who cannot lie?

◆

DAY 205 · JULY 24 · PSALM 89 (VV. 40–46)

How Long, O LORD?

> *"How long, Yahweh? Will you hide yourself forever? Will your wrath burn like fire?"*
> — PSALM 89:46

The psalmist piles up the ruin: *"You have broken down all his hedges. You have brought his strongholds to ruin. All who pass by the way rob him. He has become a reproach to his neighbors"* (Psalm 89:40–41). The walls are down. Strangers walk in and take what they want. The king who was supposed to reign forever has become a joke to the neighbors. People point and laugh at the ruins.

"You have exalted the right hand of his adversaries. You have made all of his enemies rejoice" (Psalm 89:42). The enemies are celebrating. *"You have ended his splendor, and thrown his throne down to the ground. You have shortened the days of his youth. You have covered him with shame"* (Psalm 89:44–45). Splendor gone. Throne on the ground. Youth cut short. Covered with shame. This is the opposite of everything God promised in the first half of the psalm. Read verses 20 through 37 and then read these lines, and you can feel the floor drop out.

Then the cry: *"How long, Yahweh? Will you hide yourself forever? Will your wrath burn like fire?"* (Psalm 89:46). The same question that runs all through the Psalms. How long? The psalmist has God's promise in one hand and God's apparent abandonment in the other, and he cannot hold them together. So he does the only thing he can, the thing faith always does when it cannot see. He brings both to God and asks, how long?

That is the right thing to do when God's promises and your circumstances seem to contradict each other. Do not let go of the promise. Do not pretend the circumstances are fine when they are not. Bring both to God and ask how long. The answer for the psalmist came centuries later, in a stable in Bethlehem and a tomb outside Jerusalem. The broken-down throne was rebuilt by the Son of David who was Himself broken down and raised. Lamentations says, *"This I recall to my mind; therefore I have hope. It is because of Yahweh's loving kindnesses that we are not consumed"* (Lamentations 3:21–22). Hold on until His answer comes. It always does.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's splendor was ended at the cross, His days cut short and covered with shame. Then God answered every how long by raising Him on the third day. Bring Him what you cannot solve.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where do God's promises and your circumstances seem to contradict — and will you bring both to Him?

◆

DAY 206 · JULY 25 · PSALM 89 (VV. 47–52)

Blessed Be the LORD Forever

"Blessed be Yahweh forever more. Amen, and Amen."
— PSALM 89:52

The end of Psalm 89 is still dark. The psalmist reminds God how short life is: *"Remember how short my time is, for what vanity you have created all the children of men!"* (Psalm 89:47). Then the question everyone faces eventually: *"What man is he who shall live and not see death, who shall deliver his soul from the power of Sheol?"* (Psalm 89:48). No one escapes. Every king, every servant, every child born will one day die. Who can rescue a soul from the grave?

Then he holds God to His word: *"Lord, where are your former loving kindnesses, which you swore to David in your faithfulness?"* (Psalm 89:49). Where are they? You promised. You swore an oath. Where is the love You pledged? That is a bold prayer, and a faithful one. It does not let go of the promise even when the promise seems gone. It reminds God of what He said and asks Him to show it.

"Remember, Lord, the reproach of your servants, how I bear in my heart the taunts of all the mighty peoples, with which your enemies have mocked, Yahweh, with which they have mocked the footsteps of your anointed one" (Psalm 89:50–51). The enemies mock the footsteps of the anointed. Everywhere the king walks, they laugh. Read that line in light of Good Friday. The crowds mocked every step Jesus took toward Golgotha. The footsteps of God's Anointed One were jeered all the way to the cross.

And then, with nothing resolved, the psalm ends: *"Blessed be Yahweh forever more. Amen, and Amen"* (Psalm 89:52). Blessed be the LORD. Amen and amen. After all the questions and all the ruins, the psalmist praises anyway. That is not denial. It is trust that refuses to let the darkness have the last word. This verse also closes Book Three of the Psalms. And the answer to the question of verse 48 — who can deliver a soul from the power of Sheol? — came on Easter morning. Christ did. He is the one who lived and saw death, and came out the other side. Bless the LORD today, even before you see the answer.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Who can deliver a soul from the power of the grave? Christ can. The enemies mocked His footsteps to the cross, and He saw death as every person does. Then on the third day He walked out. Bless the LORD today, even with your questions unanswered. Amen, and amen.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you bless the LORD even when your questions are not yet answered?

◆

DAY 207 · JULY 26 · PSALM 90 (VV. 1–6)

Our Dwelling Place in All Generations

"Lord, you have been our dwelling place for all generations."
— PSALM 90:1

Psalm 90 is the only psalm credited to Moses, and it is the oldest voice in the book. It begins with home: *"Lord, you have been our dwelling place for all generations"* (Psalm 90:1). Moses spent forty years wandering in the wilderness with God's people. No house. No land. Tents that went up and came down, over and over. And Moses says God Himself was their home. Not a place. A Person.

Then he goes back before history began: *"Before the mountains were born, before you had formed the earth and the world, even from everlasting to everlasting, you are God"* (Psalm 90:2). Before the mountains. Before the earth. From everlasting to everlasting. God has no beginning and no end. He was God before anything else existed, and He will be God after everything you know is gone. That is the home Moses offers — a dwelling older than the hills.

And then the contrast with human life: *"You turn man to destruction, saying, 'Return, you children of men'"* (Psalm 90:3). Return. To the dust. The word God spoke in Eden: you are dust, and to dust you will return. *"For a thousand years in your sight are just like yesterday when it is past, like a watch in the night"* (Psalm 90:4). A thousand years is nothing to God — a few hours in the night. Peter quotes this: *"one day is with the Lord as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day"* (2 Peter 3:8).

"You sweep them away as they sleep. In the morning they sprout like new grass. In the morning it sprouts and springs up. By evening, it is withered and dry" (Psalm 90:5–6). Grass that sprouts in the morning and dries out by night. That is a human life on God's timescale. Short. Fragile. Easily swept away. But that is why Moses starts where he does. You are grass, but you have a dwelling place that is from everlasting. Your life is short, but your home is eternal. Jesus said, *"we will come to him, and make our home with him"* (John 14:23). The everlasting God makes His home with grass.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The everlasting God made His dwelling with grass when Christ took on flesh. He withered like grass on the cross and was laid in the dust, and on the third day He rose to everlasting life. In Him your short life has an eternal home. Rest in that dwelling today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is God your dwelling place — or have you been trying to make a home in something that will wither?

◆

DAY 208 · JULY 27 · PSALM 90 (VV. 7–11)

The Brevity of Our Days

> *“The days of our years are seventy, or even by reason of strength eighty years”*
> — PSALM 90:10

Moses does not soften the truth about human life: *“For we are consumed in your anger. We are troubled in your wrath. You have set our iniquities before you, our secret sins in the light of your presence”* (Psalm 90:7–8). Secret sins in the light of His face. Nothing hidden. Every sin you thought no one saw is set out in plain view before God. That is part of why life is hard and short. Death came into the world through sin.

“For all our days have passed away in your wrath. We bring our years to an end as a sigh” (Psalm 90:9). As a sigh. That is how a life ends — not with a shout but with a breath let out. And then the line that has been read at countless funerals: *“The days of our years are seventy, or even by reason of strength eighty years; yet their pride is but labor and sorrow, for it passes quickly, and we fly away”* (Psalm 90:10). Seventy years. Eighty if you are strong. And it goes by fast.

Anyone past fifty knows how fast. You blink, and the kids are grown. You blink again, and the grandkids are in school. James asks, *“For what is your life? For you are a vapor that appears for a little time, and then vanishes away”* (James 4:14). A vapor. Breath on a cold morning. And even the best years, Moses says, are full of labor and sorrow. Work and grief. That is the honest summary of most lives, even good ones.

Then a sobering question: *“Who knows the power of your anger, your wrath according to the fear that is due to you?”* (Psalm 90:11). Who understands how serious God’s anger is? Moses is not trying to make you despair. He is trying to make you wise. A life this short cannot be wasted. A God this holy cannot be ignored. And the good news Moses could only glimpse is that God’s anger against sin was poured out on Christ, so that your short life could be filled with His mercy instead. Isaiah says, *“All flesh is like grass... but the word of our God stands forever”* (Isaiah 40:6–8).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ lived about thirty-three years, far short of seventy, and He flew away in the darkness of the cross under the full weight of God’s anger against sin. Then He rose to give short lives an endless future. Your days pass quickly. Spend them with Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you living as though your days were endless — or as one who knows how quickly they pass?

◆

DAY 209 · JULY 28 · PSALM 90 (VV. 12–17)

Teach Us to Number Our Days

> *"So teach us to count our days, that we may gain a heart of wisdom."*
> — PSALM 90:12

After all that honesty about how short life is, Moses prays: *"So teach us to count our days, that we may gain a heart of wisdom"* (Psalm 90:12). Count your days. Not to be morbid, but to be wise. Most people live as though they have unlimited time. They put off the hard conversation, the reconciliation, the prayer, the generosity, the obedience. Someday. Next year. After retirement. When things settle down. Moses says: count them. They are numbered.

A heart of wisdom comes from knowing your days are limited. You stop wasting them on things that do not matter. You spend them on what lasts. Paul says, *"Therefore watch carefully how you walk, not as unwise, but as wise, redeeming the time, because the days are evil"* (Ephesians 5:15–16). Redeeming the time. Buying it back from waste. Every hour is a gift you will not get again, and it is spent whether you use it well or not.

Then Moses prays for mercy: *"Relent, Yahweh! How long? Have compassion on your servants! Satisfy us in the morning with your loving kindness, that we may rejoice and be glad all our days"* (Psalm 90:13–14). Satisfaction in the morning. Start every day with God's love, and the whole day goes differently. Not filled with worry about how few days remain, but filled with joy in the God who gives them. *"Make us glad for as many days as you have afflicted us, for as many years as we have seen evil"* (Psalm 90:15).

And the last request is about the work of your hands: *"Let the favor of the Lord our God be on us. Establish the work of our hands for us. Yes, establish the work of our hands"* (Psalm 90:17). Twice he asks. Establish it. Make it last. Moses knew his own life would end, but he asked God to make his work outlast him. Your work can last too, if it is done for God. Paul says, *"whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord"* (Colossians 3:23). And, *"your labor is not in vain in the Lord"* (1 Corinthians 15:58). Count your days. Then give them all to Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ counted His days. He knew His hour and walked toward it on purpose, spending every day on the Father's work. He died and rose so that the work of your hands could last forever in Him. Count your days today, and give them to Him. Nothing done for Him is wasted.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If you counted your days plainly, what would you stop putting off — and what would you give them to?

◆

DAY 210 · JULY 29 · PSALM 91 (VV. 1–8)

Dwelling in the Secret Place of the Most High

> *"He who dwells in the secret place of the Most High will rest in the shadow of the Almighty."*
> — PSALM 91:1

Psalm 91 is one of the most loved psalms in the Bible, and it begins with a picture of safety: *"He who dwells in the secret place of the Most High will rest in the shadow of the Almighty"* (Psalm 91:1). Dwells. Not visits. Lives there. The secret place of the Most High is not a building. It is a way of life — staying close to God, making Him your home, returning to Him first thing in the morning and last thing at night. And the one who dwells there rests in His shadow, the way a traveler rests under a great tree in the heat of the day.

Then the psalmist speaks for himself: *"I will say of Yahweh, 'He is my refuge and my fortress; my God, in whom I trust'"* (Psalm 91:2). Refuge. Fortress. My God. Personal and certain, with no hedging. And then he turns to you, the reader: *"For he will deliver you from the snare of the fowler, and from the deadly pestilence"* (Psalm 91:3). The fowler set traps for birds. God sees the traps you cannot see and pulls you out.

"He will cover you with his feathers. Under his wings you will take refuge. His faithfulness is your shield and rampart" (Psalm 91:4). Feathers. Wings. That tender picture again. The Almighty, who rules the universe, covers you the way a mother bird covers her chicks. And His faithfulness is your shield — not your own strength or cleverness, but His reliability. *"You shall not be afraid of the terror by night, nor of the arrow that flies by day"* (Psalm 91:5).

Be careful how you hear this psalm. Satan quoted it to Jesus in the wilderness, trying to get Him to throw Himself off the temple and test God (Matthew 4:6). Jesus refused: *"You shall not test the Lord, your God"* (Matthew 4:7). Psalm 91 is not a guarantee that believers will never suffer. Jesus Himself suffered and died. It is a promise that nothing can touch you outside of God's care. Even death, for one who dwells in Him, is not the end. Dwell close today. Rest in His shadow.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ dwelt in the secret place of the Most High, and still He went to the cross. He did not test God to escape it. He trusted Him through it, and the Father raised Him on the third day. In Him you rest under the shadow of the Almighty, even in the valley of death.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you dwell in the shelter of the Most High — or only run there when trouble comes?

◆

DAY 211 · JULY 30 · PSALM 91 (VV. 9–16)

Set Your Love on Him

> *"Because he has set his love on me, therefore I will deliver him. I will set him on high, because he has known my name."*
> — PSALM 91:14

The second half of Psalm 91 repeats the promise of safety: *"Because you have made Yahweh your refuge, and the Most High your dwelling place, no evil shall happen to you, neither shall any plague come near your dwelling"* (Psalm 91:9–10). Then God's care in vivid terms: *"For he will put his angels in charge of you, to guard you in all your ways. They will bear you up in their hands, so that you won't dash your foot against a stone"* (Psalm 91:11–12).

Angels assigned to guard you. Carrying you over the rough places. That is how closely God watches over those who dwell in Him. *"You will tread on the lion and cobra. You will trample the young lion and the serpent underfoot"* (Psalm 91:13). The serpent underfoot. That echoes the first promise in the Bible, in Genesis 3, that the offspring of the woman would crush the serpent's head. Ultimately that victory belongs to Christ, and through Him to those who are His.

Then God Himself speaks, and the tone becomes deeply personal: *"Because he has set his love on me, therefore I will deliver him. I will set him on high, because he has known my name"* (Psalm 91:14). Set his love on Me. Clung to Me. Held on. That is what God responds to. Not perfection, but love that holds fast, even when the grip is weak and shaking. The one who loves God and knows His name is the one God promises to protect.

And the promises pile up: *"He will call on me, and I will answer him. I will be with him in trouble. I will deliver him, and honor him. I will satisfy him with long life, and show him my salvation"* (Psalm 91:15–16). Notice: I will be with him in trouble. Not instead of trouble. Right in the middle of it. God does not promise you a life without trouble. He promises to be in the trouble with you. Jesus said, *"Even as the Father has loved me, I also have loved you. Remain in my love"* (John 15:9). Set your love on Him. Hold fast to Him. He will be with you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ set His love on the Father and held fast all the way to the cross. God was with Him in trouble and delivered Him from death on the third day, setting Him on high. If you hold fast to Him, He promises the same: I will be with you in trouble. Set your love on Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is your love for God holding fast, even in trouble — and do you trust Him to be with you in it?

◆

DAY 212 · JULY 31 · PSALM 92 (VV. 1–8)

It Is Good to Give Thanks

"It is a good thing to give thanks to Yahweh"
— PSALM 92:1

Psalm 92 has a heading that calls it a song for the Sabbath day, and it opens with a simple statement: *"It is a good thing to give thanks to Yahweh, to sing praises to your name, Most High, to proclaim your loving kindness in the morning, and your faithfulness every night"* (Psalm 92:1–2). Good. Not just a duty, not just a habit. Good — for you, for your soul, for the way you see the world. Thanksgiving is good medicine, for a tired heart and a worried mind alike.

Notice the rhythm: loving kindness in the morning, faithfulness every night. Start the day remembering God's love. End the day remembering His faithfulness. Bookend every day with thanks, like two strong posts holding up a fence. In the morning you thank Him for what He will do. At night you thank Him for what He has done. That is a simple pattern, and it can change a life. Paul says, *"In everything give thanks, for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus toward you"* (1 Thessalonians 5:18).

And the psalmist brings instruments: *"with the ten-stringed lute, with the harp, and with the melody of the lyre. For you, Yahweh, have made me glad through your work. I will triumph in the works of your hands"* (Psalm 92:3–4). God has made him glad. Not his circumstances. Not his own achievements. God's work. When you start counting what God has done, joy rises. *"How great are your works, Yahweh! Your thoughts are very deep"* (Psalm 92:5).

Then a note about people who miss all this: *"A senseless man doesn't know, neither does a fool understand this: though the wicked spring up as the grass, and all the evildoers flourish, they will be destroyed forever"* (Psalm 92:6–7). The fool sees the wicked flourishing and thinks they are winning. He does not understand that grass withers. But the one who gives thanks morning and night sees deeper. *"But you, Yahweh, are on high forever more"* (Psalm 92:8). Give thanks today. It is a good thing. Paul tells believers to be *"rooted and built up in him... abounding in it in thanksgiving"* (Colossians 2:7).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ gave thanks on the night He was betrayed, breaking bread and blessing the cup before going to the cross. He rose, and now every morning and every night belong to Him. Bookend your day with thanks today — His loving kindness in the morning, His faithfulness at night.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you bookend your days with thanks — loving kindness in the morning, faithfulness at night?

◆

DAY 213 · AUGUST 1 · PSALM 92 (VV. 9–15)

They Still Bear Fruit in Old Age

"They will still produce fruit in old age."
— PSALM 92:14

Psalm 92 ends with a picture of growth that never stops: *"The righteous shall flourish like the palm tree. He will grow like a cedar in Lebanon"* (Psalm 92:12). Two trees. The palm, tall and straight, bearing dates year after year in desert heat. The cedar of Lebanon, massive and fragrant, living for centuries on the mountainsides. Both are pictures of long, strong, fruitful life. Neither one is a sapling that fades after a season.

And notice where they grow: *"They are planted in Yahweh's house. They will flourish in our God's courts"* (Psalm 92:13). Planted. Not wild seeds that landed by chance, but trees set deliberately in God's own courtyard. Their roots go down into the soil of His presence. That is why they keep growing. A tree is only as healthy as the ground it is rooted in, and these are rooted in God Himself.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"They will still produce fruit in old age. They will be full of sap and green"* (Psalm 92:14). Still. In old age. The world tends to treat old age as a time of winding down, of usefulness fading, of being set aside. Psalm 92 says the opposite. The old believer is full of sap. Still green. Still bearing fruit. The joints may be stiff and the eyes dim, but the life inside is flowing. God promised through Isaiah, *"Even to old age I am he, and even to gray hairs I will carry you"* (Isaiah 46:4).

What kind of fruit does an old saint bear? Not always the fruit of busyness. Often it is the fruit of character: *"love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faith, gentleness, and self-control"* (Galatians 5:22–23). The grandmother who prays every morning for her grandchildren. The old man who has learned to forgive. The widow whose peace steadies a whole church. That fruit grows best over a long life in God's house. And it all points somewhere: *"to show that Yahweh is upright. He is my rock, and there is no unrighteousness in him"* (Psalm 92:15). The fruit of an old life is a witness to a faithful God. Jesus said, *"He who remains in me and I in him bears much fruit"* (John 15:5).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Vine whose life flows into every branch, young or old. He was cut down on the cross and rose to give a life that does not dry up with age. If you are growing older, you are not finished. Stay rooted in Him. The sap is still flowing, and the fruit is still coming.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe your life can still bear fruit in old age, rooted in God's house?

◆

DAY 214 · AUGUST 2 · PSALM 93

The LORD Reigns

> *"Yahweh reigns! He is clothed with majesty!"*
> **— PSALM 93:1**

Psalm 93 is only five verses long, and it opens with a shout: *"Yahweh reigns! He is clothed with majesty! Yahweh is armed with strength. The world also is established. It can't be moved"* (Psalm 93:1). The LORD reigns. Not reigned once. Not will reign someday. Reigns, right now. And He is fully and royally dressed for it — clothed in majesty, wrapped in strength like a king in his royal robes. Because He reigns, the world is steady, even when it does not feel steady to you.

Then a reminder of how long He has been King: *"Your throne is established from long ago. You are from everlasting"* (Psalm 93:2). From long ago. From everlasting. His throne did not appear recently. It has always been there. Every king you have read about in history rose and fell, every one. Pharaoh, Caesar, every president and prime minister. The LORD has been on His throne through all of them, and He will be on it after every one of them is forgotten.

Then the psalm describes the noise of the world: *"The floods have lifted up, Yahweh, the floods have lifted up their voice. The floods lift up their waves"* (Psalm 93:3). The floods roar. In the ancient world rising water was the picture of chaos — the threat of disorder breaking in and sweeping everything away. You know that roar. The news cycle. The market crash. The diagnosis. The family crisis. The waves keep rising, and they are loud.

But listen to the answer: *"Above the voices of many waters, the mighty breakers of the sea, Yahweh on high is mighty"* (Psalm 93:4). Above the waters. Mightier than the breakers. However loud the flood, the LORD is louder. However high the waves, He is higher. On the Sea of Galilee Jesus stood up in a storm and said, *"Peace! Be still!"* (Mark 4:39), and *"The wind ceased, and there was a great calm"* (Mark 4:39). That is what reigning looks like. And the psalm ends with something steady to hold: *"Your statutes stand firm. Holiness adorns your house, Yahweh, forever more"* (Psalm 93:5). His word does not move with the waves.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ stood in the storm and the sea obeyed Him. At the cross the floods of judgment rose over Him, and on the third day He rose above them, reigning forever. Whatever is roaring in your life today, the LORD on high is mightier. He reigns. Rest in that.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What floods are roaring in your life — and do you believe the LORD on high is mightier than they are?

◆

DAY 215 · AUGUST 3 · PSALM 94 (VV. 1–8)

O LORD, God of Vengeance

> *"Yahweh, you God to whom vengeance belongs, you God to whom vengeance belongs, shine out."*
> — PSALM 94:1

Psalm 94 opens with a word that makes some readers uncomfortable: *"Yahweh, you God to whom vengeance belongs, you God to whom vengeance belongs, shine out"* (Psalm 94:1). Vengeance. Twice. It sounds harsh to modern ears. But listen to what the psalmist means. He is not asking for permission to get even. He is asking God to step in, because justice belongs to God and the world has none. The courts have failed. The rich have bought their way out. Only God is left. *"Rise up, you judge of the earth. Pay back the proud what they deserve"* (Psalm 94:2).

Then the question that runs through the Psalms: *"Yahweh, how long will the wicked, how long will the wicked triumph?"* (Psalm 94:3). How long. The wicked are winning, and they are loud about it: *"They pour out arrogant words. All the evildoers boast"* (Psalm 94:4). And they are cruel to the weakest people of all: *"They break your people in pieces, Yahweh, and afflict your heritage. They kill the widow and the alien, and murder the fatherless"* (Psalm 94:5–6).

The widow. The foreigner. The orphan. The people with no one to stand up for them. That is who the wicked crush first. And they think no one is watching: *"They say, 'Yah will not see, neither will Jacob's God consider'"* (Psalm 94:7). God does not see. God does not care. That is the lie that lets cruelty flourish. The psalmist answers it with blunt words: *"Consider, you senseless among the people; you fools, when will you be wise?"* (Psalm 94:8).

There is real comfort in a God to whom vengeance belongs. It means you do not have to carry it. When someone has wronged you or wronged the weak, you can hand it to God. Paul says, *"Don't seek revenge yourselves, beloved, but give place to God's wrath. For it is written, 'Vengeance belongs to me; I will repay, says the Lord'"* (Romans 12:19). God will repay. Not you. That frees you from bitterness and frees you to love. And it means the widow and the orphan are not forgotten. The God of vengeance is the God who sees them.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God's vengeance against sin fell on Christ at the cross, so that sinners could be forgiven and the oppressed could be defended. He rose, and He will judge the earth in righteousness. You do not have to carry the weight of getting even. Hand it to Him today. He sees.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is there a wrong you are trying to avenge yourself, instead of handing it to the God to whom vengeance belongs?

◆

DAY 216 · AUGUST 4 · PSALM 94 (VV. 9–15)

Blessed Is the One You Discipline

> *"Blessed is the man whom you discipline, Yah, and teach out of your law"*
> — PSALM 94:12

Psalm 94 answers the lie that God does not see with a simple argument: *"He who implanted the ear, won't he hear? He who formed the eye, won't he see?"* (Psalm 94:9). The One who made ears can hear. The One who made eyes can see. Of course He sees. He invented seeing. He designed every eye that ever opened. *"He who disciplines the nations, won't he punish? He who teaches man knows. Yahweh knows the thoughts of man, that they are futile"* (Psalm 94:10–11). Nothing is hidden from Him. Not deeds, not even thoughts. Hebrews says, *"There is no creature that is hidden from his sight"* (Hebrews 4:13).

Then the psalm turns to God's own people, and the word changes from punishment to discipline: *"Blessed is the man whom you discipline, Yah, and teach out of your law"* (Psalm 94:12). Blessed. That is surprising. Most people do not feel blessed when God is correcting them. Discipline is uncomfortable. It can hurt. But the psalmist calls it a blessing, because it is the work of a loving teacher, not an angry judge.

Hebrews explains: *"For whom the Lord loves, he disciplines"* (Hebrews 12:6). Discipline is proof of love. A father who never corrects his children is not kind. He is indifferent. And Hebrews goes on: *"All chastening seems for the present to be not joyous but grievous; yet afterward it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it"* (Hebrews 12:11). Not joyous now. Peaceful fruit later. The discipline has a purpose, and the purpose is your good.

And what does the discipline give you? *"that you may give him rest from the days of adversity, until the pit is dug for the wicked"* (Psalm 94:13). Rest. Peace in hard days. And a promise that holds everything up: *"For Yahweh won't reject his people, neither will he forsake his inheritance"* (Psalm 94:14). If God is disciplining you right now, it is not because He has rejected you. It is because He has not. He is teaching you out of His law, shaping you, training you. Receive it. The One who formed your eye is watching you with love.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ bore the punishment you deserved, so that what reaches you now is discipline, not condemnation. He rose, and the Father who raised Him trains His children in love. If God is correcting you today, He has not rejected you. He is shaping you. Receive it from His hand.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If God is disciplining you right now, can you see it as a blessing rather than rejection?

◆

DAY 217 · AUGUST 5 · PSALM 94 (VV. 16–23)

When the Cares of My Heart Are Many

"In the multitude of my thoughts within me, your comforts delight my soul."
— PSALM 94:19

The last part of Psalm 94 asks a lonely question: *"Who will rise up for me against the wicked? Who will stand up for me against the evildoers?"* (Psalm 94:16). Who will stand with me? The psalmist looks around and sees no one. And then he answers his own question: *"Unless Yahweh had been my help, my soul would have soon lived in silence"* (Psalm 94:17). The silence is the grave. Without God, he would already be dead and buried.

Then a moment of panic and rescue: *"When I said, 'My foot is slipping!' Your loving kindness, Yahweh, held me up"* (Psalm 94:18). He felt himself going down, fast. He cried out. And God's loving kindness caught him. Many people know that moment — the instant when you feel the ground give way and you are sure you are about to fall. And then something holds. That something has a name: God's loving kindness.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"In the multitude of my thoughts within me, your comforts delight my soul"* (Psalm 94:19). The multitude of thoughts. Anxious thoughts. Racing thoughts. The kind that spin at three in the morning — what if, what if, what if. The psalmist had a head full of them. And in the middle of all that noise, God's comforts reached his soul and delighted it. Not removed the thoughts. Comforted the soul inside them, the way a parent's hand on a child's back quiets a nightmare.

Paul gives the same remedy: *"In nothing be anxious, but in everything, by prayer and petition with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your thoughts in Christ Jesus"* (Philippians 4:6–7). Guard your thoughts. When your mind is crowded with worry, bring the worries to God one by one. Peter says, *"casting all your worries on him, because he cares for you"* (1 Peter 5:7). And the psalm ends steady: *"But Yahweh has been my high tower, my God, the rock of my refuge"* (Psalm 94:22). Let His comfort reach you in the crowd of your thoughts today.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ brought His crowded, sorrowful thoughts to the Father in Gethsemane, then went to the cross and rose so God's peace could guard your mind. Let His comfort reach you tonight.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When anxious thoughts multiply within you, where do you look for comfort?

◆

DAY 218 · AUGUST 6 · PSALM 95 (VV. 1–6)

Come, Let Us Worship

"Oh come, let's worship and bow down."
— PSALM 95:6

Psalm 95 begins with an invitation to sing: *"Oh come, let's sing to Yahweh. Let's shout aloud to the rock of our salvation! Let's come before his presence with thanksgiving. Let's extol him with songs!"* (Psalm 95:1–2). Come. Sing. Shout. Give thanks. This is the kind of psalm that has opened Christian worship for centuries. It does not invite you to a quiet, private moment. It invites you into a crowd lifting their voices together.

And the reason for the shouting is the size of God: *"For Yahweh is a great God, a great King above all gods. In his hand are the deep places of the earth. The heights of the mountains are also his. The sea is his, and he made it. His hands formed the dry land"* (Psalm 95:3–5). The deep caves and the high peaks. The ocean and the dry ground. All of it in His hand. All of it made by Him. You cannot go anywhere that is not His territory.

Then the invitation changes posture: *"Oh come, let's worship and bow down. Let's kneel before Yahweh, our Maker"* (Psalm 95:6). From shouting to kneeling. From loud praise to bowed heads. Both are worship, and both are needed. The God who deserves the shout also deserves the bowed knee. And the reason for kneeling is personal: He is your Maker. Not only the Maker of mountains and seas, but the Maker of you. He formed you. You belong to Him before you belong to anyone else, before family, employer, or nation.

Then the tender line: *"for he is our God. We are the people of his pasture, and the sheep in his care"* (Psalm 95:7). Sheep in His care. The great King of the mountains is also a shepherd who knows His flock. That is why you can kneel without fear. You are not bowing to a tyrant. You are kneeling before the One who made you and cares for you. Jesus said, *"I am the good shepherd. I know my own, and I'm known by my own"* (John 10:14). Come and worship today. Shout, and then kneel. He is your Maker and your Shepherd.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Maker who knelt to wash His disciples' feet, and then laid down His life for the sheep. He rose, and every knee will bow to Him. Come and worship Him today — with your voice, and with your knees. He made you, and He cares for you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Does your worship ever move from singing to kneeling — from praise to humble surrender before your Maker?

◆

DAY 219 · AUGUST 7 · PSALM 95 (VV. 7–11)

Today, If You Hear His Voice

"Today, oh that you would hear his voice!"
— PSALM 95:7–8

Psalm 95 turns from worship to warning, and the turn happens in the middle of a single verse: *"for he is our God. We are the people of his pasture, and the sheep in his care. Today, oh that you would hear his voice!"* (Psalm 95:7). Today. Not tomorrow. Not someday when life slows down. Today. God is speaking now, and the question is whether you are listening. It is easy to assume there will always be more time to respond, another Sunday, another season. Psalm 95 does not make that promise. It speaks about today because today is the only day you actually have.

Then the warning: *"Don't harden your heart, as at Meribah, as in the day of Massah in the wilderness, when your fathers tempted me, tested me, and saw my work"* (Psalm 95:8–9). Meribah and Massah were places in the wilderness where Israel quarreled with God over water. They had seen the plagues. They had walked through the sea. And still they doubted. They had seen God's work and they hardened their hearts anyway. Seeing is not the same as believing. A heart can watch miracles and stay stone cold.

The result was tragic: *"Forty long years I was grieved with that generation, and said, 'It is a people that errs in their heart. They have not known my ways.' Therefore I swore in my wrath, 'They won't enter into my rest'"* (Psalm 95:10–11). They missed the rest. A whole generation died in the wilderness because their hearts were hard. They came so close to the promised land and never entered it.

Hebrews takes this psalm and applies it directly to believers: *"Today if you will hear his voice, don't harden your hearts"* (Hebrews 3:7–8). And then: *"exhort one another day by day, so long as it is called 'today', lest any one of you be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin"* (Hebrews 3:13). Hearts harden slowly. One ignored prompting. One small compromise. One more excuse. Like clay left out in the sun, a little drier each day, until it cracks when you try to shape it. But the door is still open: *"There remains therefore a Sabbath rest for the people of God"* (Hebrews 4:9). Today, listen. Do not let your heart grow hard. The rest is still waiting.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is God's voice spoken today, calling you into His rest. He entered the hard wilderness of the cross for people with hard hearts, and rose to soften them by His Spirit. Today, if you hear His voice, do not harden your heart. His rest is still open to you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is there a place where your heart has been slowly hardening toward God's voice?

◆

DAY 220 · AUGUST 8 · PSALM 96 (VV. 1–6)

Sing a New Song

> *“Sing to Yahweh a new song! Sing to Yahweh, all the earth.”*
> — PSALM 96:1

Psalm 96 calls the whole world to sing: *“Sing to Yahweh a new song! Sing to Yahweh, all the earth. Sing to Yahweh! Bless his name! Proclaim his salvation from day to day!”* (Psalm 96:1–2). Three times: sing to the LORD. And it is a new song. Not the same tired words repeated without thought. Something fresh, because God keeps doing fresh things. His mercies are new every morning, so the songs should be new too.

And the song is not only for God’s people. It is for everyone: *“Declare his glory among the nations, his marvelous works among all the peoples”* (Psalm 96:3). Among the nations. The psalm is missionary. It wants every people group on earth to hear about God. That is not a New Testament idea added later. It is right here in the Psalms. God’s plan was always for the whole world to know Him. Abraham was blessed so that all the families of the earth would be blessed.

Then the reason the nations should listen: *“For Yahweh is great, and greatly to be praised! He is to be feared above all gods. For all the gods of the peoples are idols, but Yahweh made the heavens”* (Psalm 96:4–5). The other gods are idols — made things, empty things. The LORD made the heavens. That is the difference between every false god and the true one. Idols are made by people. God made the people. An idol cannot hear you or help you, however much it costs. *“Honor and majesty are before him. Strength and beauty are in his sanctuary”* (Psalm 96:6).

Revelation shows where this new song is heading: *“They sang a new song, saying, ‘You are worthy to take the book and to open its seals: for you were killed, and bought us for God with your blood out of every tribe, language, people, and nation’”* (Revelation 5:9). That is the new song. The song of the Lamb who was killed and bought people from every nation. You are invited to sing it today. Not an old, worn-out song. A new one, because Christ’s mercy to you is new this morning. Proclaim His salvation from day to day.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The new song is about Christ, the Lamb who was killed and bought people from every nation with His blood. He rose, and the song will never end. His mercy to you is new today. Sing a new song to Him, and tell someone else what He has done.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Has your praise grown stale and repetitive — and what new song could you sing for what God is doing now?

◆

DAY 221 · AUGUST 9 · PSALM 96 (VV. 7–13)

He Comes to Judge the Earth

"He will judge the world with righteousness, the peoples with his truth."
— PSALM 96:13

Psalm 96 calls all the families of the nations to bring something to God: *"Ascribe to Yahweh, you families of nations, ascribe to Yahweh glory and strength. Ascribe to Yahweh the glory due to his name. Bring an offering, and come into his courts"* (Psalm 96:7–8). Ascribe means to give credit, to acknowledge. Say out loud that glory and strength belong to Him. Give Him the honor His name deserves. Then come into His courts with an offering in your hands.

"Worship Yahweh in holy array. Tremble before him, all the earth" (Psalm 96:9). Holy array — dressed for worship, the way you would dress for an audience with a king. And tremble. Not with terror, but with the deep awe that comes from standing before Someone infinitely greater than you. Then a message for the nations: *"Say among the nations, 'Yahweh reigns.' The world is also established. It can't be moved. He will judge the peoples with equity"* (Psalm 96:10).

And then all creation joins in: *"Let the heavens be glad, and let the earth rejoice. Let the sea roar, and its fullness! Let the field and all that is in it exult! Then all the trees of the woods shall sing for joy"* (Psalm 96:11–12). The trees singing. The sea roaring. The fields celebrating. Why? *"before Yahweh; for he comes, for he comes to judge the earth"* (Psalm 96:13). He is coming. And creation is glad about it.

That may surprise you. Most people think of judgment as something to dread. But creation rejoices at the coming of the Judge, because His judgment will set everything right. Paul says, *"the creation itself also will be delivered from the bondage of decay into the liberty of the glory of the children of God"* (Romans 8:21). The ruined world will be restored. *"He will judge the world with righteousness, the peoples with his truth"* (Psalm 96:13). And who is the Judge? Paul told the Athenians God *"has appointed a day in which he will judge the world in righteousness by the man whom he has ordained; of which he has given assurance to all men, in that he has raised him from the dead"* (Acts 17:31). The Judge is the risen Christ. For those who are His, that is good news.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The Judge who is coming is the same Christ who was judged in your place on the cross. God raised Him from the dead as proof that He will set the world right. Creation sings at His coming, and so can you. Ascribe to Him the glory due His name today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you dread the coming of the Judge — or can you sing with creation because the Judge is your Savior?

◆

DAY 222 · AUGUST 10 · PSALM 97 (VV. 1–6)

The LORD Reigns, Let the Earth Rejoice

> *"Yahweh reigns! Let the earth rejoice! Let the multitude of islands be glad!"*
> — PSALM 97:1

Psalm 97 starts the same way as Psalm 93: *"Yahweh reigns! Let the earth rejoice! Let the multitude of islands be glad!"* (Psalm 97:1). The LORD reigns, and the right response is joy. Not anxiety, not grudging submission. Rejoicing. Even the distant islands, far out at the edges of the known world, are invited to be glad. God's reign is good news for every corner of the map. Some people hear that God is in charge and feel trapped, as if a strict boss had taken over. The psalm hears it as the best news there is. A good King is on the throne, and He will not be overthrown.

Then the psalm describes what His reign looks like, and it is awesome: *"Clouds and darkness are around him. Righteousness and justice are the foundation of his throne"* (Psalm 97:2). Clouds and darkness — the same picture as Mount Sinai, where God came down in thick cloud. He is mysterious, hidden, beyond full understanding. And yet His throne rests on righteousness and justice. You cannot see all of God, but you can know His throne is built on what is right. When life feels like walking in fog, that is enough to steady your feet.

"A fire goes before him, and burns up his adversaries on every side. His lightning lights up the world. The earth sees, and trembles" (Psalm 97:3–4). Fire and lightning. The whole earth trembling. *"The mountains melt like wax at the presence of Yahweh, at the presence of the Lord of the whole earth"* (Psalm 97:5). Mountains melting like candle wax. That is how solid things become when they stand near God. Nothing can stay hard in His presence, not even a stubborn heart.

"The heavens declare his righteousness. All the peoples have seen his glory" (Psalm 97:6). All the peoples. Everyone. You may wonder why a reign this fierce should make the earth rejoice. Because the fire burns up His enemies, not His people. Because His justice will finally set the world right. Because the darkness around Him hides a throne of righteousness. Revelation hears the great multitude shout: *"Hallelujah! For the Lord our God, the Almighty, reigns!"* (Revelation 19:6). That is the right response. The King is good. Rejoice that He reigns.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the King whose throne rests on righteousness and justice. He walked into the darkness of the cross, where justice was done for your sin, and He rose on the third day to reign. Mountains melt before Him. Your fears can too. Rejoice today that He reigns.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you rejoice that the LORD reigns — or only tolerate it when things are going your way?

◆

DAY 223 · AUGUST 11 · PSALM 97 (VV. 7–12)

Light Is Sown for the Righteous

> *"Light is sown for the righteous, and gladness for the upright in heart."*
> — PSALM 97:11

Psalm 97 turns from the King's fire to the people who worship idols: *"Let all them be shamed who serve engraved images, who boast in their idols. Worship him, all you gods!"* (Psalm 97:7). Carved idols. Statues. Things made with human hands and given worship that belongs to God alone. They will be put to shame. And even whatever powers those idols represent are commanded to bow to the true God.

Then joy breaks out among God's people: *"Zion heard and was glad. The daughters of Judah rejoiced because of your judgments, Yahweh. For you, Yahweh, are most high above all the earth. You are exalted far above all gods"* (Psalm 97:8–9). Most high. Far above. No contest. And then a command that might surprise you: *"You who love Yahweh, hate evil!"* (Psalm 97:10). Love God, hate evil. The two go together, like two sides of the same coin. You cannot love the One who is holy and be fond of what destroys His world.

And He protects those who love Him: *"He preserves the souls of his saints. He delivers them out of the hand of the wicked"* (Psalm 97:10). Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Light is sown for the righteous, and gladness for the upright in heart"* (Psalm 97:11). Sown. Like seeds planted in a field. The light is not always visible yet. It has been planted. It is under the ground, growing. One day it will break through, the way green shoots push up through a winter field.

That is a word for anyone walking in a dark season. You may not see the light yet. You may feel as if you have done what is right and gotten nothing for it. Psalm 97 says the light has been sown. It is coming up. God planted it, and seeds planted by God always come up in their time. John says, *"God is light, and in him is no darkness at all"* (1 John 1:5). The psalm ends: *"Be glad in Yahweh, you righteous people! Give thanks to his holy Name"* (Psalm 97:12). Give thanks for the light that is sown, even before you see it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was sown like a seed in the dark ground of a tomb, and on the third day the light broke through. Because He rose, light is sown for you too, even in the darkest season. It is coming up. Give thanks today for the light you cannot see yet.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

In a dark season, can you trust that light has been sown for you, even before you see it?

◆

DAY 224 · AUGUST 12 · PSALM 98 (VV. 1–4)

The LORD Has Made Known His Salvation

"Yahweh has made known his salvation."
— PSALM 98:2

Psalm 98 begins like Psalm 96, with a new song: *"Sing to Yahweh a new song, for he has done marvelous things! His right hand and his holy arm have worked salvation for him"* (Psalm 98:1). His right hand. His holy arm. God did the saving Himself. Not with help, not with the cooperation of the strong, but by His own arm. No one assisted Him at the cross. That is the reason for the song. He has done marvelous things.

Then the salvation goes public: *"Yahweh has made known his salvation. He has openly shown his righteousness in the sight of the nations"* (Psalm 98:2). Openly. Not hidden in a corner. Not a secret for a few insiders. God put His salvation on display for every nation to see. That is how the gospel works. It is not a private philosophy. It is a public announcement of what God has done, like a herald in the town square.

"He has remembered his loving kindness and his faithfulness toward the house of Israel. All the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God" (Psalm 98:3). He remembered. He kept His promises to Israel, every one. And in keeping them, the whole world got to see. When the old man Simeon held the baby Jesus in the temple, he said, *"for my eyes have seen your salvation, which you have prepared before the face of all peoples; a light for revelation to the nations, and the glory of your people Israel"* (Luke 2:30–32).

That is the salvation Psalm 98 is singing about. It came in a baby, grew into a man, hung on a cross, and walked out of a tomb. And it was made known to the nations. Paul said, *"For I am not ashamed of the Good News of Christ, because it is the power of God for salvation for everyone who believes"* (Romans 1:16). So the psalm says: *"Make a joyful noise to Yahweh, all the earth! Burst out and sing for joy, yes, sing praises!"* (Psalm 98:4). Burst out. Let it overflow. The salvation God has made known is too good to keep quiet.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God's right hand worked salvation through Christ, who was lifted up on a cross before the eyes of the world and raised on the third day. This salvation was not done in a corner. It was made known to the nations. Burst out and sing today. Then make it known to someone else.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you treat the gospel as a private belief, or as a public salvation God wants made known?

◆

DAY 225 · AUGUST 13 · PSALM 98 (VV. 5–9)

Let the Rivers Clap Their Hands

> *"Let the rivers clap their hands. Let the mountains sing for joy together."*
> — PSALM 98:8

Psalm 98 builds a great orchestra: *"Sing praises to Yahweh with the harp, with the harp and the voice of melody. With trumpets and sound of the ram's horn, make a joyful noise before the King, Yahweh"* (Psalm 98:5–6). Harp, voice, trumpet, ram's horn. Every instrument they had. Worship in the Psalms is not quiet and timid, though it has quiet moments too. It is loud, full, and glad, because the King deserves it.

Then creation joins the band: *"Let the sea roar with its fullness; the world, and those who dwell therein"* (Psalm 98:7). The roar of the ocean becomes a sound of praise, wave after wave. And then the most playful picture in the psalm: *"Let the rivers clap their hands. Let the mountains sing for joy together"* (Psalm 98:8). Rivers clapping. Mountains singing. Hills dancing. Isaiah used the same image: *"The mountains and the hills will break out before you into singing; and all the trees of the fields will clap their hands"* (Isaiah 55:12).

Why would creation celebrate? *"Let them sing before Yahweh, for he comes to judge the earth. He will judge the world with righteousness, and the peoples with equity"* (Psalm 98:9). He is coming to set things right. The whole world has been groaning under the weight of sin and death. Creation itself has been broken. Paul says, *"the creation was subjected to vanity, not of its own will"* (Romans 8:20). And when the Judge comes, creation will be set free. No wonder the rivers clap. They have waited a long time for this.

That gives you a different way to look at the world around you. The river running past the bridge. The mountains on the horizon. The ocean at the beach. They are not just scenery. They are waiting for the King, and one day they will sing at His arrival. When you see them, let them remind you to sing too. The King is coming. Everything will be made right. Even the rocks and rivers know it. Jesus said that if His followers were silent, *"the stones would cry out"* (Luke 19:40). Do not leave the singing to the stones.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the King whose coming makes the rivers clap. He went into death and rose on the third day, and creation is waiting for His return to set it free. When you see the mountains or the rivers today, let them remind you: the King is coming. Sing.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you look at creation, do you hear it waiting for the King — and does it move you to sing?

◆

DAY 226 · AUGUST 14 · PSALM 99 (VV. 1–4)

The LORD Our God Is Holy

"Let them praise your great and awesome name. He is Holy!"
— PSALM 99:3

Psalm 99 is a psalm about holiness, and it opens with God on His throne: *"Yahweh reigns! Let the peoples tremble. He sits enthroned among the cherubim. Let the earth be moved"* (Psalm 99:1). Enthroned among the cherubim. That is the picture of the ark of the covenant, where golden angels spread their wings over the mercy seat. God's throne on earth was a box with angel wings and a lid called mercy. The holiest place in Israel had mercy at its center.

"Yahweh is great in Zion. He is high above all the peoples. Let them praise your great and awesome name. He is Holy!" (Psalm 99:2–3). He is holy. That phrase will come three times in this short psalm, like a refrain. Holy means set apart, utterly other, completely pure. There is no one like Him. Not the greatest saint, not the brightest angel. He stands alone, and everything else bows. Isaiah saw the angels around God's throne crying, *"Holy, holy, holy, is Yahweh of Armies! The whole earth is full of his glory!"* (Isaiah 6:3).

Then a surprising line about the King's character: *"The King's strength also loves justice. You establish equity. You execute justice and righteousness in Jacob"* (Psalm 99:4). His strength loves justice. That is not how strength usually works in this world. Strong people often love control, or money, or comfort. God's strength is aimed at justice and fairness. He uses His power to make things right, not to serve Himself. That is what makes His holiness good news instead of a threat.

Holiness is not something you can generate. It belongs to God. But He calls His people to share it: *"just as he who called you is holy, you yourselves also be holy in all of your behavior"* (1 Peter 1:15). How? Not by trying harder on your own. By being made holy through Christ, who bore your sin so that God's holiness could welcome you instead of consuming you. The cherubim over the ark looked down on the mercy seat, where blood was sprinkled once a year. Holy and merciful in the same place. That is the God you worship. Praise His great and awesome name today. He is holy.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The holy God made a way for sinners to approach Him at the mercy seat, and that way was fulfilled in Christ, whose blood was shed once for all. He rose, and now you can come near to the Holy One without fear. Praise His awesome name today. He is holy, and He is merciful.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you approach God with a sense of His holiness — and with confidence because of His mercy?

◆

DAY 227 · AUGUST 15 · PSALM 99 (VV. 5–9)

He Answered Them

"You answered them, Yahweh our God."
— PSALM 99:8

Psalm 99 calls again for worship: *"Exalt Yahweh our God. Worship at his footstool. He is Holy!"* (Psalm 99:5). His footstool. The ark was seen as the place where God rested His feet on earth. To worship at His footstool is to bow as low as you can before the King. And then the psalm remembers three great intercessors: *"Moses and Aaron were among his priests, Samuel was among those who call on his name. They called on Yahweh, and he answered them"* (Psalm 99:6).

Moses, Aaron, Samuel. Three people who prayed for Israel when Israel was in trouble. Moses pleaded for the people after the golden calf. Samuel prayed for them when they demanded a king. And God answered. *"He spoke to them in the pillar of cloud. They kept his testimonies, the statute that he gave them"* (Psalm 99:7). God spoke. They listened and obeyed. That is the shape of a living relationship with God — prayer and answer, word and obedience, back and forth over a lifetime.

Then a line that holds two things together: *"You answered them, Yahweh our God. You are a God who forgave them, although you took vengeance for their doings"* (Psalm 99:8). He forgave them. And He disciplined them. Both are true at once, and neither cancels the other. Moses was forgiven, and he still did not enter the promised land because of his disobedience. God's forgiveness does not always remove every consequence. But it always restores the relationship. You are forgiven, even when you still feel the effects of what you did.

That is good news for anyone living with the consequences of past sin. The broken marriage, the lost job, the damaged health, the relationship that will never be the same. God has forgiven you. He has not stopped loving you. The consequences may remain, but the condemnation is gone. John writes, *"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous to forgive us the sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness"* (1 John 1:9). And the psalm ends where it began: *"Exalt Yahweh, our God. Worship at his holy hill, for Yahweh, our God, is holy!"* (Psalm 99:9).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the great Intercessor greater than Moses, Aaron, or Samuel. He prays for you at the Father's right hand, and He bore the full vengeance for your sin on the cross. He rose, and you are forgiven. Even if the consequences remain today, the condemnation is gone.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you living with the consequences of past sin as if you were not yet forgiven?

◆

DAY 228 · AUGUST 16 · PSALM 100

Enter His Gates with Thanksgiving

> *"Enter into his gates with thanksgiving, and into his courts with praise."*
> — PSALM 100:4

Psalm 100 is one of the best-known psalms in the Bible, and it is only five verses long. It begins with a shout: *"Shout for joy to Yahweh, all you lands! Serve Yahweh with gladness. Come before his presence with singing"* (Psalm 100:1–2). Serve with gladness. Not grudgingly. Not as a chore. With gladness. That is a striking command. Most people think of serving as work. Psalm 100 says it should be joy. Not because the tasks are always easy, but because of who you are serving. Washing dishes for someone you love is different from washing dishes for a stranger.

Then the reason: *"Know that Yahweh, he is God. It is he who has made us, and we are his. We are his people, and the sheep of his pasture"* (Psalm 100:3). Know this. He is God. He made you. You did not make yourself. You belong to Him, not to yourself. That truth can feel like a burden to a proud heart, but to a tired one it is pure relief. You do not have to hold your own life together. You are His sheep, and He is your Shepherd. Sheep do not carry the weight of the flock. The shepherd does.

Then the invitation that gives this day its name: *"Enter into his gates with thanksgiving, and into his courts with praise. Give thanks to him, and bless his name"* (Psalm 100:4). The gates and the courts of the temple. You do not enter God's presence with complaints or demands first. You enter with thanks. Thanksgiving is the gate. Praise is the courtyard. That is the way in. Even on a hard day, there is always something to thank Him for, and the thanks opens the door.

And the final reason holds everything up: *"For Yahweh is good. His loving kindness endures forever, his faithfulness to all generations"* (Psalm 100:5). Good. Loving kindness forever. Faithfulness to all generations. That is why you can serve with gladness. That is why you can enter with thanks. Hebrews says believers have *"boldness to enter into the holy place by the blood of Jesus, by the way which he dedicated for us, a new and living way"* (Hebrews 10:19–20). The gates are open. Walk in today with thanksgiving on your lips. He is good.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ opened the gates of God's presence by His blood, a new and living way through the torn veil. He rose, and the courts of God are open to you. Walk in today with thanksgiving. He made you, you are His, and He is good.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you enter God's presence with thanksgiving — or with a list of complaints and demands?

◆

DAY 229 · AUGUST 17 · PSALM 101

I Will Walk with Integrity

> *"I will be careful to live a blameless life. When will you come to me? I will walk within my house with a blameless heart."*
> — PSALM 101:2

Psalm 101 is a king's resolution. Its heading names David, and it reads like a list of promises a ruler makes before taking the throne: *"I will sing of loving kindness and justice. To you, Yahweh, I will sing praises. I will be careful to live a blameless life. When will you come to me? I will walk within my house with a blameless heart"* (Psalm 101:1–2). Within my house. That is the hard place to be blameless — not in public, but at home, where no one is watching.

Anyone can behave well in front of a crowd. The test of character is the kitchen at night, the living room on a bad day, the way you speak to the people who know you best. David resolves to be the same person at home that he is in public. That is integrity: being whole, the same all the way through. And notice the question in the middle: when will you come to me? He knows he needs God to make this possible.

Then the resolutions get specific: *"I will set no vile thing before my eyes. I hate the deeds of faithless men. They will not cling to me"* (Psalm 101:3). No vile thing before my eyes. That is a word for an age of screens. What you look at shapes who you become. And then: *"A perverse heart will be far from me. I will have nothing to do with evil"* (Psalm 101:4). David guards his eyes and his heart, because he knows that what gets in shapes what comes out.

He also chooses his company carefully: *"I will silence whoever secretly slanders his neighbor. I won't tolerate one who is arrogant and conceited. My eyes will be on the faithful of the land, that they may dwell with me"* (Psalm 101:5–6). The people around you matter. Gossip and pride spread. So does faithfulness. Paul says, *"whatever things are true, whatever things are honorable... think about these things"* (Philippians 4:8). David did not keep these vows perfectly. He failed badly. But the resolution points to the King who did keep them — Jesus, who walked blameless in every room of His life, and who gives His people His own righteousness.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the King who walked within His house with a blameless heart, the same in private as in public. He kept every vow David made and then died for every vow David broke. He rose to give you His integrity. Ask Him today to make you whole at home.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you the same person at home that you are in public — and where do you need God to make you whole?

◆

DAY 230 · AUGUST 18 · PSALM 102 (VV. 1–7)

A Prayer of One Afflicted

"Hear my prayer, Yahweh! Let my cry come to you."
— PSALM 102:1

Psalm 102 has one of the most unusual headings in the Psalter. It calls itself a prayer of someone afflicted and overwhelmed, pouring out a complaint before the LORD. It is not tied to a named person or an event. It is offered to anyone who is overwhelmed. That makes it yours whenever you need it, wherever you are. And it begins with urgency: *"Hear my prayer, Yahweh! Let my cry come to you. Don't hide your face from me in the day of my distress. Turn your ear to me. Answer me quickly in the day when I call"* (Psalm 102:1–2).

Then the psalmist describes what affliction has done to his body: *"For my days consume away like smoke. My bones are burned as a torch. My heart is blighted like grass, and withered, for I forget to eat my bread"* (Psalm 102:3–4). Days like smoke. Bones on fire. Heart withered like grass. He forgets to eat. That is what deep distress does. It drains appetite, sleep, and strength. Anyone who has been through grief or depression recognizes this description.

"By reason of the voice of my groaning, my bones stick to my skin" (Psalm 102:5). He is wasting away. Then a series of lonely birds: *"I am like a pelican of the wilderness. I have become as an owl of the waste places. I watch, and have become like a sparrow that is alone on the housetop"* (Psalm 102:6–7). A bird in the wilderness. An owl in the ruins. A sparrow alone on a roof, awake while everyone else sleeps. That is loneliness in pictures, drawn by someone who knew it well.

You may be that sparrow tonight. Awake, alone, watching from the rooftop while the house sleeps. Psalm 102 gives you words. You do not have to find them yourself. The heading says this prayer is for the afflicted when overwhelmed. That is permission. You can pour out your complaint before the LORD. He does not turn away from the sparrow. Jesus said, *"Aren't five sparrows sold for two assaria coins? Not one of them is forgotten by God"* (Luke 12:6). Not one. Not the lonely one on the housetop, either.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was the afflicted one, overwhelmed in Gethsemane and alone on the cross while His friends slept and fled. He poured out His complaint to the Father, and the Father raised Him on the third day. When you are the sparrow alone on the roof tonight, pray this psalm. He does not forget you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you are overwhelmed, do you pour out your complaint to God — or keep it to yourself?

◆

DAY 231 · AUGUST 19 · PSALM 102 (VV. 8–14)

But You, O LORD, Are Enthroned Forever

> *"But you, Yahweh, will remain forever; your renown endures to all generations."*
> — PSALM 102:12

The suffering in Psalm 102 deepens: *"My enemies reproach me all day. Those who are mad at me use my name as a curse"* (Psalm 102:8). His name has become a curse word. People use it as an insult. And his life has been reduced to almost nothing: *"For I have eaten ashes like bread, and mixed my drink with tears, because of your indignation and your wrath; for you have taken me up and thrown me away"* (Psalm 102:9–10).

Ashes for bread. Tears in the cup. Taken up and thrown away. He feels discarded, like something God picked up and then tossed aside. *"My days are like a long shadow. I have withered like grass"* (Psalm 102:11). A long shadow — the kind you see at the end of the day, stretching out as the sun goes down. His life is fading like evening light, and he knows it. That is the dust theme of this whole year in one verse: a life withering like grass, eating ashes.

Then the turn, and it is all about who God is: *"But you, Yahweh, will remain forever; your renown endures to all generations"* (Psalm 102:12). But You. The psalmist is withering. God remains. The psalmist's days are a fading shadow. God endures to all generations. The contrast is total. And that contrast is the source of hope. If God were as frail as you, there would be no hope. But He is not. He remains when you fade, steady as the hills and older than they are.

And because He remains, He will act: *"You will arise and have mercy on Zion; for it is time to have pity on her. Yes, the set time has come"* (Psalm 102:13). The set time. God has an appointed hour for mercy. *"For your servants take pleasure in her stones, and have pity on her dust"* (Psalm 102:14). Even the dust of the ruins is dear to God's people. And dust is dear to God too. He made you from it. He remembers that you are dust (Psalm 103:14). The One who remains forever has pity on dust. That is the gospel of this psalm.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ, the eternal Son, took on dust and withered like grass on the cross. He remains forever, and on the third day He rose. The One who endures has pity on your dust.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you feel yourself withering like grass, do you look to the God who remains forever?

◆

DAY 232 · AUGUST 20 · PSALM 102 (VV. 15–21)

He Regards the Prayer of the Destitute

> *"He has responded to the prayer of the destitute, and has not despised their prayer."*
> — PSALM 102:17

Psalm 102 now looks ahead to a day when the whole world will see God's glory: *"So the nations will fear Yahweh's name, all the kings of the earth your glory. For Yahweh has built up Zion. He has appeared in his glory"* (Psalm 102:15–16). The ruined city is rebuilt. The glory of God appears. And the kings of the earth take notice. What started as one person's lonely prayer on a rooftop becomes a vision for all nations.

Then the verse that gives this day its name: *"He has responded to the prayer of the destitute, and has not despised their prayer"* (Psalm 102:17). The destitute. Those with nothing left. No resources, no strength, no one to help. And God responds to their prayer. He does not despise it. He does not treat it as beneath Him or too small to bother with. The prayer of the poorest person on earth reaches the ear of the King of glory. The beggar's whisper is not drowned out by the noise of the proud. God bends down to hear it.

That is the pattern all through Scripture. God hears the destitute. He hears Hagar in the desert, Hannah weeping at the temple, the blind man shouting by the road. The prayers that feel too small, too desperate, too broken to matter are exactly the ones He answers. And the psalm says it will be written down for the future: *"This will be written for the generation to come. A people which will be created will praise Yah"* (Psalm 102:18). Your answered prayer becomes someone else's reason to praise.

And look at what God is doing from heaven: *"For he has looked down from the height of his sanctuary. From heaven, Yahweh saw the earth; to hear the groans of the prisoner; to free those who are condemned to death"* (Psalm 102:19–20). He looks down. He hears groans. He frees the condemned. That is exactly what Christ came to do. You were condemned to death, and He came down from heaven to set you free. If you feel destitute today, your prayer is not despised. It is heard by the God who came all the way down.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God looked down from heaven and came down in Christ to hear the groans of the prisoner and free the condemned. On the cross Christ took the death sentence Himself, and on the third day He rose. Your prayer is not despised. Pray it today, however destitute you feel.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe God hears and does not despise the prayers that feel too small or desperate?

◆

DAY 233 · AUGUST 21 · PSALM 102 (VV. 22–28)

You Are the Same

"But you are the same. Your years will have no end."
— PSALM 102:27

The end of Psalm 102 returns to the psalmist's weakness: *"He weakened my strength along the course. He shortened my days. I said, 'My God, don't take me away in the middle of my days. Your years are throughout all generations'"* (Psalm 102:23–24). Halfway through life, and already worn out. He asks not to be taken early. And he sets his short life beside God's endless years. The contrast is striking.

Then the psalm looks back to creation: *"Of old, you laid the foundation of the earth. The heavens are the work of your hands. They will perish, but you will endure. Yes, all of them will wear out like a garment. You will change them like a cloak, and they will be changed"* (Psalm 102:25–26). The heavens and the earth will wear out. Like an old coat. Threadbare, faded, and finally folded up and replaced. Even the universe is temporary. The sun will not burn forever. The ground under your house is not permanent. Everything you can see is on its way to wearing out.

"But you are the same. Your years will have no end" (Psalm 102:27). The same. Everything else changes. Bodies age. Mountains erode. Stars burn out. God stays the same. Hebrews quotes these exact verses and says they are about Jesus: *"You, Lord, in the beginning, laid the foundation of the earth... They will perish, but you continue... but you are the same. Your years won't fail"* (Hebrews 1:10–12). And then Hebrews says it plainly: *"Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today, and forever"* (Hebrews 13:8).

That is the anchor for a frail life. Your days may be shortened. Your strength may fade. But the One you trust does not change. James says God is the *"Father of lights, with whom can be no variation, nor turning shadow"* (James 1:17). And because He does not change, His promises do not change either. What He said to Abraham, He still means. The psalm ends with hope for the future: *"The children of your servants will continue. Their offspring will be established before you"* (Psalm 102:28). Your life may be short, but it is held by the One whose years have no end.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the same yesterday, today, and forever. He laid the foundation of the earth, took on a short human life, and died young on a cross. Then He rose, and His years will have no end. When everything around you changes, He does not. Anchor yourself in Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When everything around you is changing, do you anchor yourself in the God who stays the same?

◆

DAY 234 · AUGUST 22 · PSALM 103 (VV. 1–7)

Bless the LORD, O My Soul

“Praise Yahweh, my soul, and don’t forget all his benefits”
— PSALM 103:2

Psalm 103 is a song of praise from start to finish, and it begins with David talking to himself: *“Praise Yahweh, my soul! All that is within me, praise his holy name! Praise Yahweh, my soul, and don’t forget all his benefits”* (Psalm 103:1–2). He tells his own soul to praise. He commands his whole inner life to get in line. And he gives the key: don’t forget. Praise starts with memory. If you forget what God has done, you will not praise Him. Forgetfulness is the quiet enemy of worship. Most believers do not stop praising God because they decide to. They stop because they forget. The blessings blur into ordinary life, and gratitude fades without anyone noticing.

Then he lists the benefits: *“who forgives all your sins, who heals all your diseases, who redeems your life from destruction, who crowns you with loving kindness and tender mercies, who satisfies your desire with good things, so that your youth is renewed like the eagle’s”* (Psalm 103:3–5). Forgives. Heals. Redeems. Crowns. Satisfies. Renews. Six benefits in three verses. And the first one is the greatest: He forgives all your sins. Not some. All. The small ones you have forgotten and the big ones you cannot forget.

Notice the order. Forgiveness comes first. Before healing, before satisfaction, before renewal. Everything else flows from being forgiven. A healthy body with an unforgiven soul is still lost. A sick body with a forgiven soul is safe forever. That is why forgiveness comes first in the list. And then: He redeems your life from destruction. The pit. The grave. The dust. He pulls you out. And crowns you. The one who was in the pit now wears a crown of loving kindness.

“so that your youth is renewed like the eagle’s” (Psalm 103:5). Isaiah uses the same picture: *“those who wait for Yahweh will renew their strength. They will mount up with wings like eagles”* (Isaiah 40:31). Renewed strength. Wings like eagles. That is what God does for dust. Today, tell your own soul to praise. Do not wait for a feeling. Command it, the way David did. Then count the benefits one by one. Forgiven. Redeemed. Crowned. Satisfied. Do not forget even one of them.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Every benefit in Psalm 103 comes to you through Christ. He was crowned with thorns so you could be crowned with loving kindness. He was taken down into destruction so your life could be redeemed from it. He rose, and your youth can be renewed like the eagle’s. Praise Him, my soul.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Which of God’s benefits have you forgotten — and will you command your soul to praise Him for it today?

◆

DAY 235 · AUGUST 23 · PSALM 103 (VV. 8–15)

As Far as the East Is from the West

> *"As far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us."*
> — PSALM 103:12

Psalm 103 now describes God's character, using words from Exodus: *"Yahweh is merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abundant in loving kindness"* (Psalm 103:8). That is the same description God gave of Himself to Moses on Mount Sinai. And then David draws out what it means: *"He will not always accuse; neither will he stay angry forever. He has not dealt with us according to our sins, nor repaid us for our iniquities"* (Psalm 103:9–10).

Not dealt with according to your sins. That is mercy. If God gave you what you deserve, you would be lost. He does not, and He never will. Then the size of His love: *"For as the heavens are high above the earth, so great is his loving kindness toward those who fear him"* (Psalm 103:11). Look up at the sky tonight. Try to measure how high it goes. You cannot. That is how big His love is. Higher than you can see, past every star.

Then the verse that gives this day its name: *"As far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us"* (Psalm 103:12). East and west never meet. You can travel north until you reach the pole and then you start going south. But east and west go on forever without touching. That is how far God has removed your sin. Not a few feet away. Not tucked in a drawer for later. Infinitely removed. Micah says He casts *"all their sins into the depths of the sea"* (Micah 7:19).

Then the tenderest lines in the psalm: *"Like a father has compassion on his children, so Yahweh has compassion on those who fear him. For he knows how we are made. He remembers that we are dust"* (Psalm 103:13–14). He remembers that you are dust. That is the verse at the heart of this year. God does not expect from dust what only He can do. He knows how frail you are. And He has compassion, the way a good father does with a small child who falls. *"As for man, his days are like grass"* (Psalm 103:15). Grass, and deeply loved.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God removed your transgressions as far as the east is from the west by laying them on Christ at the cross. He remembers that you are dust, and He sent His Son to become dust for you. Christ rose, and your sins are gone. Live today as someone forgiven and remembered.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you live as though your sins are still close by — or removed as far as the east is from the west?

◆

DAY 236 · AUGUST 24 · PSALM 103 (VV. 16–22)

From Everlasting to Everlasting

> *"But Yahweh's loving kindness is from everlasting to everlasting with those who fear him"*
> — PSALM 103:17

Psalm 103 continues its picture of human frailty: *"For the wind passes over it, and it is gone. Its place remembers it no more"* (Psalm 103:16). Grass in the field, and then a hot wind, and it is gone. Not even the ground remembers where it stood. That is how short a human life is. Walk through an old cemetery and read the stones. Most of the names mean nothing to anyone now. One generation, and then another, and the names fade. Isaiah says the same: *"All flesh is like grass... The grass withers, the flower fades"* (Isaiah 40:6–7).

And then the contrast: *"But Yahweh's loving kindness is from everlasting to everlasting with those who fear him, his righteousness to children's children"* (Psalm 103:17). From everlasting to everlasting. You are grass. His love is eternal. You wither in a season. His kindness lasts forever, and it reaches your children and grandchildren. The fading flower is held by the love that never fades. That is the whole hope of dust.

"to those who keep his covenant, to those who remember to obey his precepts" (Psalm 103:18). The love is not abstract. It comes to people in covenant with God, people who remember and obey. Then the psalm widens to the throne: *"Yahweh has established his throne in the heavens. His kingdom rules over all"* (Psalm 103:19). Over all. Nothing outside His rule. The God who loves dust is the King of everything.

And so the psalm ends with a call for everyone to join in: *"Praise Yahweh, you angels of his, who are mighty in strength, who fulfill his word, obeying the voice of his word. Praise Yahweh, all you armies of his, you servants of his, who do his pleasure. Praise Yahweh, all you works of his, in all places of his dominion"* (Psalm 103:20–22). Angels, armies, every created thing. And then, last of all, the psalmist comes back to himself: *"Praise Yahweh, my soul!"* (Psalm 103:22). He started by talking to his own soul, and he ends the same way. Peter says, *"the Lord's word endures forever"* (1 Peter 1:25). You are grass. His love is forever. Praise Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ became grass for you and withered on the cross. But His love is from everlasting to everlasting, and on the third day He rose. The fading flower is held by a love that never fades.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you feel how short your life is, do you rest in a love that is from everlasting to everlasting?

◆

DAY 237 · AUGUST 25 · PSALM 104 (VV. 1–7)

O LORD My God, You Are Very Great

> *"Bless Yahweh, my soul. Yahweh, my God, you are very great. You are clothed with honor and majesty."*
> — PSALM 104:1

Psalm 104 begins the same way Psalm 103 ended: *"Bless Yahweh, my soul. Yahweh, my God, you are very great. You are clothed with honor and majesty"* (Psalm 104:1). But where Psalm 103 praised God for forgiveness, Psalm 104 praises Him for creation. It is a hymn to the Maker, walking through the world He made the way Genesis 1 does, day by day, marveling at each part. Light, sky, waters, land, plants, sun and moon, sea creatures, animals, people. Nothing is too small to mention, and nothing is too large for God.

"He covers himself with light as with a garment. He stretches out the heavens like a curtain" (Psalm 104:2). Light is His clothing. The sky is a tent curtain He spreads out. Picture someone setting up camp, stretching canvas over poles. That is how easily God made the heavens. *"He lays the beams of his rooms in the waters. He makes the clouds his chariot. He walks on the wings of the wind"* (Psalm 104:3). Clouds are His chariot. The wind is His road. The weather report is a description of His movements.

"He makes his messengers winds, and his servants flames of fire" (Psalm 104:4). Even the forces of nature are His servants. Then the foundations of the earth: *"He laid the foundations of the earth, that it should not be moved forever. You covered it with the deep as with a cloak. The waters stood above the mountains"* (Psalm 104:5–6). That is the beginning, when water covered everything. And then God spoke: *"At your rebuke they fled. At the voice of your thunder they hurried away"* (Psalm 104:7). The waters ran from His voice like frightened animals, and the dry land appeared.

Most people walk through the world without seeing any of this. The sky is just weather. The clouds are just clouds. The ground is just ground. Psalm 104 asks you to look again and see God's hand in everything. Paul says of Christ, *"For by him all things were created in the heavens and on the earth"* (Colossians 1:16), and *"in him all things are held together"* (Colossians 1:17). Every sunrise is His. Every breeze is His messenger. Look up today. Bless the LORD, my soul. He is very great.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The Maker who stretched out the heavens like a curtain stretched out His arms on a cross. Christ, through whom all things were made, died for the world He made and rose on the third day. Look at creation today and see His hand. Then bless Him. He is very great.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When did you last look at creation and see the hand of the Maker in it?

◆

DAY 238 · AUGUST 26 · PSALM 104 (VV. 8–14)

He Causes the Grass to Grow

> *"He causes the grass to grow for the livestock, and plants for man to cultivate"*
> — PSALM 104:14

Psalm 104 continues with the shaping of the land: *"The mountains rose, the valleys sank down, to the place which you had assigned to them. You have set a boundary that they may not pass over, that they don't turn again to cover the earth"* (Psalm 104:8–9). Mountains up. Valleys down. Water held back by a line God drew. The world has shape and order because God set it that way. The sea stays where He put it.

Then water becomes a gift: *"He sends springs into the valleys. They run among the mountains. They give drink to every animal of the field. The wild donkeys quench their thirst"* (Psalm 104:10–11). Springs in the valleys. Wild donkeys drinking. God provides even for animals no one owns or cares for. *"The birds of the sky nest by them. They sing among the branches"* (Psalm 104:12). Birds singing by the water. That is the sound of God's provision.

"He waters the mountains from his rooms. The earth is filled with the fruit of your works" (Psalm 104:13). Then the line that gives this day its name: *"He causes the grass to grow for the livestock, and plants for man to cultivate, that he may produce food out of the earth"* (Psalm 104:14). Grass for the cattle. Crops for people to plant and tend. God makes it grow, and people work the soil. It is a partnership — God's rain and sunshine, human hands on the plow. The food on your table comes from both, every meal.

Jesus pointed to this same provision: *"See the birds of the sky, that they don't sow, neither do they reap, nor gather into barns. Your heavenly Father feeds them. Aren't you of much more value than they?"* (Matthew 6:26). If God waters the mountains for wild donkeys and grows grass for cattle, He will take care of you. That is not an excuse to be lazy. People still cultivate. But it is a reason not to be anxious. The God who makes grass grow is the God who holds your future. Worry less. Trust more. Work the ground He gives you, and thank Him for the rain.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ told His followers to look at the birds and the grass and stop worrying. Then He gave Himself on the cross to provide what no harvest could — forgiveness and eternal life. He rose, and the Father who grows the grass will care for you. Trust Him with tomorrow.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If God makes grass grow for the cattle, what are you worrying about that you could trust Him with?

◆

DAY 239 · AUGUST 27 · PSALM 104 (VV. 15–21)

Wine to Gladden the Heart

> *"wine that makes the heart of man glad, oil to make his face to shine, and bread that strengthens man's heart."*
> — PSALM 104:15

Psalm 104 names three good gifts from the ground: *"wine that makes the heart of man glad, oil to make his face to shine, and bread that strengthens man's heart"* (Psalm 104:15). Wine, oil, bread. In the ancient world these were the staples — the grape harvest, the olive press, the wheat field. Each one a gift from God, grown from soil He watered. Bread for strength. Oil for health and beauty. Wine for gladness.

That tells you something about God. He is not stingy. He did not only give what is strictly necessary to survive. He gave gladness too. Joy is part of His design, not an accident. At the wedding in Cana Jesus turned water into wine, and the host said, *"You have kept the good wine until now!"* (John 2:10). God gives good gifts, and He wants His people to enjoy them with thanks. Paul told a crowd that God gave *"fruitful seasons, filling our hearts with food and gladness"* (Acts 14:17).

But every good gift can be twisted. Bread can become gluttony. Wine can become drunkenness and slavery. Paul warns, *"Don't be drunken with wine, in which is dissipation, but be filled with the Spirit"* (Ephesians 5:18). If any of God's gifts has become a chain for you, the answer is not to blame the gift but to come back to the Giver. Many people have had to give up something good because it had become a master. That is wisdom, not loss. The Giver is better than any gift.

Then the psalm moves on to trees and animals: *"Yahweh's trees are well watered, the cedars of Lebanon, which he has planted; where the birds make their nests. The stork makes its home in the cypress trees. The high mountains are for the wild goats. The rocks are a refuge for the rock badgers"* (Psalm 104:16–18). Every creature has its place. The stork, the goat, the badger. God thought of all of them. And the deepest gladness He gives is not in a cup. It is in Himself. Jesus said, *"I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will not be hungry"* (John 6:35).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ took bread and wine at His last supper and gave them new meaning: His body broken, His blood poured out for you. He went to the cross and rose, and now He is the true bread and the true gladness of the heart. Enjoy His gifts today with thanks. Then come to Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you enjoying God's good gifts with thanks — or has any gift become a master in your life?

◆

DAY 240 · AUGUST 28 · PSALM 104 (VV. 22–28)

These All Look to You

"These all wait for you, that you may give them their food in due season."
— PSALM 104:27

Psalm 104 walks through the rhythm of a day: *"He appointed the moon for seasons. The sun knows when to set"* (Psalm 104:19). The moon marks time. The sun knows its schedule. Then night falls: *"You make darkness, and it is night, in which all the animals of the forest prowl. The young lions roar after their prey, and seek their food from God"* (Psalm 104:20–21). Even lions hunting at night are seeking food from God. Their roar is a kind of prayer.

Then morning comes: *"The sun rises, and they steal away, and lie down in their dens. Man goes out to his work, to his labor until the evening"* (Psalm 104:22–23). The lions go to bed. People go to work. Night belongs to the animals, day to human labor. And all of it is God's design. Your morning commute and your hours on the job are part of the rhythm He set up at creation. Work is not a curse in itself. It is part of how He made the world.

Then the psalmist stops and marvels: *"Yahweh, how many are your works! In wisdom, you have made them all. The earth is full of your riches"* (Psalm 104:24). How many. He cannot count them. And then the sea: *"There is the sea, great and wide, in which are innumerable living things, both small and large animals. There the ships go, and leviathan, whom you formed to play there"* (Psalm 104:25–26). Leviathan, the great sea creature — God made it to play. That is a delightful picture. The sea monster frolicking in the ocean God gave it.

And then the line that gives this day its name: *"These all wait for you, that you may give them their food in due season. You give to them; they gather. You open your hand; they are satisfied with good"* (Psalm 104:27–28). Every creature waits on God. Lions, badgers, whales, sparrows, people. They all depend on His open hand. Jesus said, *"Aren't five sparrows sold for two assaria coins? Not one of them is forgotten by God"* (Luke 12:6). You wait on Him too. Open your hands today. He opens His.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ opened His hands on the cross, nailed there for you, and in His death and resurrection He gave the bread of life to everyone who waits on Him. Every creature depends on God's open hand, and so do you. Wait on Him today. He will satisfy you with good.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you live as one who waits on God for everything — or as one who thinks you supply your own needs?

◆

DAY 241 · AUGUST 29 · PSALM 104 (VV. 29–35)

When You Send Your Spirit

> *"You send out your Spirit and they are created. You renew the face of the ground."*
> — PSALM 104:30

Psalm 104 now faces the hardest fact about creatures: *"You hide your face; they are troubled. You take away their breath; they die and return to the dust"* (Psalm 104:29). Return to the dust. That is the theme of this whole year. Every living thing depends on God for breath. When He withdraws it, they die and go back to dust. That is true of the sparrow, and it is true of you. *"For you are dust, and you shall return to dust"* (Genesis 3:19).

But the psalm does not end at the grave: *"You send out your Spirit and they are created. You renew the face of the ground"* (Psalm 104:30). The Spirit goes out, and life comes. Creation is renewed. That is the reverse of verse 29. God takes away breath, and creatures die. God sends His Spirit, and creatures live. It goes back to Genesis: *"Yahweh God formed man from the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life"* (Genesis 2:7). Dust plus the breath of God equals a living soul.

That is what revival is. Dust that has gone dry and lifeless receives the breath of God again. Ezekiel saw it in the valley of dry bones: *"Come from the four winds, breath, and breathe on these slain, that they may live"* (Ezekiel 37:9). And they stood up. Jesus did it for His disciples after His resurrection: *"he breathed on them, and said to them, 'Receive the Holy Spirit!'"* (John 20:22). The same breath that made Adam made the church. And it can make you new.

Then the psalm ends with a vow of lifelong praise: *"I will sing to Yahweh as long as I live. I will sing praise to my God while I have any being. Let my meditation be sweet to him. I will rejoice in Yahweh"* (Psalm 104:33–34). As long as I live. Every breath God gives becomes a breath of praise. Paul writes that *"he saved us through the washing of regeneration and renewing by the Holy Spirit"* (Titus 3:5). If you feel dry and lifeless today, ask God to send His Spirit. He renews the face of the ground. He can renew you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ breathed His last on the cross and returned to the dust of the grave. On the third day the Spirit raised Him, and then He breathed that same Spirit on His followers. Dust plus the breath of God becomes a living soul. Ask Him to breathe on you today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where do you feel like dry dust — and will you ask God to send His Spirit and renew you?

◆

DAY 242 · AUGUST 30 · PSALM 105 (VV. 1–6)

Seek the LORD and His Strength

> *"Seek Yahweh and his strength. Seek his face forever more."*
> — PSALM 105:4

Psalm 105 is a history psalm, like Psalm 78, but where Psalm 78 dwelt on Israel's failures, Psalm 105 dwells on God's faithfulness. It opens with a burst of commands: *"Give thanks to Yahweh! Call on his name! Make his doings known among the peoples. Sing to him, sing praises to him! Tell of all his marvelous works"* (Psalm 105:1–2). Give thanks. Call. Make known. Sing. Tell. Five things to do with what God has done.

"Glory in his holy name. Let the heart of those who seek Yahweh rejoice" (Psalm 105:3). Seeking God is not grim work. It makes the heart glad. And then the verse that gives this day its name: *"Seek Yahweh and his strength. Seek his face forever more"* (Psalm 105:4). His strength, because you do not have enough of your own. His face, because you need more than His help. You need Him. And forever more — not a phase, not a season, but a lifelong pursuit.

Many people seek God's hand without seeking His face. It is like calling a friend only when you need a ride to the airport, never when you just want to talk. They want His help with the bills, the health scare, the problem at work. That is not wrong. But it is not enough. God wants to be known, not just used. He is not a vending machine. He is a Father who longs for His children's company. Jeremiah heard God say, *"You shall seek me, and find me, when you search for me with all your heart"* (Jeremiah 29:13). With all your heart. Not as a last resort, but as the first and best pursuit of your life.

Then the psalm tells you how to seek: *"Remember his marvelous works that he has done: his wonders, and the judgments of his mouth, you offspring of Abraham, his servant, you children of Jacob, his chosen ones"* (Psalm 105:5–6). Remember. Seeking God starts with remembering what He has already done. Look back before you look forward. Jesus said, *"But seek first God's Kingdom, and his righteousness; and all these things will be given to you as well"* (Matthew 6:33). Seek His face today. Not only His hand. Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the face of God turned toward you. He came to be found by those who seek Him, went to the cross for them, and rose to be with them forever. Seek His face today, not only His help. Let your heart rejoice in the seeking.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you seeking God's hand for help — or seeking His face because you want Him?

◆

DAY 243 · AUGUST 31 · PSALM 105 (VV. 7–13)

He Remembers His Covenant Forever

"He has remembered his covenant forever"
— PSALM 105:8

Psalm 105 tells the story of God's promise to Abraham: *"He is Yahweh, our God. His judgments are in all the earth. He has remembered his covenant forever, the word which he commanded to a thousand generations"* (Psalm 105:7–8). A thousand generations. That is longer than human history. God's promise does not expire. He remembered it in Abraham's day, in Moses' day, in David's day, and He remembers it now.

"the covenant which he made with Abraham, his oath to Isaac, and confirmed it to Jacob for a statute; to Israel for an everlasting covenant, saying, 'To you I will give the land of Canaan, the lot of your inheritance'" (Psalm 105:9–11). Abraham, Isaac, Jacob. Three generations, one promise. God kept repeating it, confirming it, renewing it. Each generation heard the same word. That is how God keeps a covenant — not once, but again and again, down the line.

And notice who He made it with: *"when they were but a few men in number, yes, very few, and foreigners in it"* (Psalm 105:12). A few. Very few. Strangers in the land. They owned nothing. They were wandering herders living in tents. *"They went about from nation to nation, from one kingdom to another people"* (Psalm 105:13). And God promised them everything — land, nation, blessing for the whole world. He did not choose them because they were many or strong. He chose them because He loved them. Hebrews says, *"These all died in faith, not having received the promises, but having seen them and embraced them from afar"* (Hebrews 11:13).

That covenant reaches you. Paul says, *"If you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring and heirs according to promise"* (Galatians 3:29). You are an heir of the same promise. When Zechariah praised God at the birth of John the Baptist, he said God came *"to remember his holy covenant, the oath which he swore to Abraham our father"* (Luke 1:72–73). God remembered. He sent Jesus. You may feel like a stranger, few and small, wandering. So did Abraham, living in a tent on land he did not own. And God remembered His covenant forever. He remembers it for you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God remembered His covenant with Abraham and kept it in Christ, the promised Offspring who died and rose for all who believe. If you are Christ's, you are an heir of that promise. You may feel few and small today. So did Abraham. God remembers His covenant forever.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you feel few and small — and can you trust that you are an heir of a covenant God remembers forever?

◆

DAY 244 · SEPTEMBER 1 · PSALM 105 (VV. 14–19)

Until the Time His Word Came to Pass

> *"until the time that his word happened, and Yahweh's word proved him true."*
> — PSALM 105:19

Psalm 105 tells the story of Joseph in a few short lines, and it starts with God protecting His people when they were few and weak: *"He allowed no one to do them wrong. Yes, he reproved kings for their sakes, 'Don't touch my anointed ones! Do my prophets no harm!'"* (Psalm 105:14–15). The wandering family of Abraham had no army and no land. But they had God, and God warned kings to keep their hands off.

Then a famine comes, and God has already moved a piece into place: *"He called for a famine on the land. He destroyed the food supplies. He sent a man before them. Joseph was sold for a slave"* (Psalm 105:16–17). Notice how the psalm describes it. Joseph's brothers sold him out of jealousy. But the psalm says God sent him. Both are true. The brothers meant harm. God meant rescue. Joseph himself said it years later: *"you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to save many people alive"* (Genesis 50:20).

And Joseph suffered for a long time: *"They bruised his feet with shackles. His neck was locked in irons"* (Psalm 105:18). Shackles on his feet. Iron around his neck. Years in an Egyptian prison for something he did not do. He had dreams from God about his future, and everything around him seemed to say those dreams were lies. That is a hard place to wait. You may know it — a promise from God on one side, and a life that looks nothing like it on the other.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"until the time that his word happened, and Yahweh's word proved him true"* (Psalm 105:19). Until. There was an end date. God's word tested Joseph in the waiting, and then God's word came true. The irons were not the end of the story. They were the middle. Paul says, *"We know that all things work together for good for those who love God, for those who are called according to his purpose"* (Romans 8:28). If you are in irons right now, waiting for God's word to come to pass, hold on. The word is testing you. It is also coming true.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was sold for silver, bound, and condemned for what He did not do, like Joseph. He waited in the grave until the time God's word came to pass, and on the third day the Father raised Him. If you are in irons today, waiting, the God who kept His word to Christ will keep it to you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What promise of God are you waiting on while the irons are still on — and can you trust His timing?

◆

DAY 245 · SEPTEMBER 2 · PSALM 105 (VV. 20–26)

He Sent a Man Ahead

> *"The king sent and freed him, even the ruler of peoples, and let him go free."*
> — PSALM 105:20

The story of Joseph turns in a single verse: *"The king sent and freed him, even the ruler of peoples, and let him go free"* (Psalm 105:20). Years of prison, and then one day a messenger comes from Pharaoh himself. The doors open. The shackles come off. Joseph walks out of the dungeon and into the palace. That is how God often works. A long season of waiting, and then a sudden turn no one saw coming. Joseph went to bed a prisoner and woke up the next day a ruler.

And Joseph was not only freed. He was lifted to the top: *"He made him lord of his house, and ruler of all of his possessions, to discipline his princes at his pleasure, and to teach his elders wisdom"* (Psalm 105:21–22). From prisoner to ruler. From irons to authority. Stephen told the story in Acts: *"God was with him, and delivered him out of all his afflictions, and gave him favor and wisdom before Pharaoh, king of Egypt. He made him governor over Egypt and all his house"* (Acts 7:9–10).

Then the family follows: *"Israel also came into Egypt. Jacob lived in the land of Ham. He increased his people greatly, and made them stronger than their adversaries"* (Psalm 105:23–24). The brothers who sold Joseph came to him for bread. The family that nearly destroyed itself was saved by the one they betrayed. That is the shape of the gospel. The rejected one becomes the rescuer. The one they threw away becomes the one who feeds them.

Jesus walks that same road. Rejected by His own, sold for silver, condemned and executed. And then raised and exalted. Paul says, *"Therefore God also highly exalted him, and gave to him the name which is above every name"* (Philippians 2:9). Peter preached it: *"God has made him both Lord and Christ, this Jesus whom you crucified"* (Acts 2:36). The one they crucified now rules. And like Joseph with his brothers, He offers bread to the very people who rejected Him. Come to Him today. He has been lifted from the prison to the throne, and He feeds the ones who once turned Him away.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the greater Joseph. He was rejected by His brothers, condemned, and laid in the darkness of the tomb. Then God lifted Him to the highest place and gave Him a name above every name. He now offers the bread of life to those who rejected Him. Come and receive it today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you see how God might be lifting the rejected and turning the prison into the place of rescue?

◆

DAY 246 · SEPTEMBER 3 · PSALM 105 (VV. 27–32)

He Performed His Signs

"They performed miracles among them, and wonders in the land of Ham."
— PSALM 105:27

Psalm 105 moves from Joseph to Moses. Egypt turned against Israel: *"He turned their heart to hate his people, to conspire against his servants"* (Psalm 105:25). The welcome became slavery. And God sent deliverers: *"He sent Moses, his servant, and Aaron, whom he had chosen. They performed miracles among them, and wonders in the land of Ham"* (Psalm 105:26–27). Moses and Aaron, standing before the mightiest king in the world with nothing but God's word.

Then the plagues, told in quick strokes: *"He sent darkness, and made it dark. They didn't rebel against his words. He turned their waters into blood, and killed their fish"* (Psalm 105:28–29). Darkness. Blood. Then frogs: *"Their land swarmed with frogs, even in the rooms of their kings"* (Psalm 105:30). Frogs in the king's bedroom. Then flies and lice: *"He spoke, and swarms of flies came, and lice in all their borders"* (Psalm 105:31). Then hail: *"He gave them hail for rain, with lightning in their land"* (Psalm 105:32).

Notice the repeated phrase: He spoke. God did not need armies or swords to break Egypt. He spoke, and creation obeyed at once. Water turned to blood. Frogs filled the palace. Hail fell from a clear sky. Every one of the plagues struck at something Egypt trusted — the Nile, the land, the crops, the sun. Egypt worshiped the river, and the river turned to blood. Egypt worshiped the sun, and darkness fell. Egypt's gods could not protect it from the God who made everything those gods were supposed to rule.

That is still true. Whatever you are tempted to trust in place of God, He can show it to be powerless. Money, health, reputation, a strong economy — all of it bows to His word. And the same word that broke Egypt is the word that sets you free. John says of Christ, *"In him was life, and the life was the light of men. The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness hasn't overcome it"* (John 1:4–5). The God who sent darkness on Egypt sent light into the world. He spoke, and it was so. He still speaks. Listen to His word today.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The God who spoke and broke Egypt's power spoke His final Word in Christ. Jesus went into the darkness of the cross, under the last plague of death, and the darkness could not overcome Him. On the third day He rose. Whatever powers hold you, His word is stronger. Listen to Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What are you trusting in that God could show to be powerless against His word?

◆

DAY 247 · SEPTEMBER 4 · PSALM 105 (VV. 33–43)

He Brought Them Out with Joy

"He brought his people out with joy, his chosen with singing."
— PSALM 105:43

The last plagues fall on Egypt: *"He struck their vines and also their fig trees, and shattered the trees of their country. He spoke, and the locusts came with the grasshoppers, without number, ate up every plant in their land, and ate up the fruit of their ground"* (Psalm 105:33–35). Then the final blow: *"He struck also all the firstborn in their land, the first fruits of all their manhood"* (Psalm 105:36). That was the night of the Passover.

And then Israel walked out: *"He brought them out with silver and gold. There was not one feeble person among his tribes"* (Psalm 105:37). Slaves who had nothing walked out carrying the riches of Egypt. Exodus says, *"They plundered the Egyptians"* (Exodus 12:36). Not one feeble among them. The old, the sick, the children — all able to make the trip. God did not leave a single one behind. *"Egypt was glad when they departed, for the fear of them had fallen on them"* (Psalm 105:38).

Then God cared for them on the road: *"He spread a cloud for a covering, fire to give light in the night. They asked, and he brought quails, and satisfied them with the bread of the sky. He opened the rock, and waters gushed out. They ran as a river in the dry places"* (Psalm 105:39–41). Cloud, fire, quail, manna, water from the rock. Everything they needed. And the reason: *"For he remembered his holy word, and Abraham, his servant"* (Psalm 105:42). He remembered.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"He brought his people out with joy, his chosen with singing"* (Psalm 105:43). Not with grim faces. Not dragging their feet. With joy. With singing. That is what deliverance sounds like. Jesus spoke with Moses and Elijah on the mountain about *"his departure, which he was about to accomplish at Jerusalem"* (Luke 9:31). The word Luke uses for departure is the word exodus. Jesus was about to lead the greatest exodus of all, out of slavery to sin and death. Paul says, *"Christ, our Passover, has been sacrificed in our place"* (1 Corinthians 5:7). You have been brought out. Walk with joy.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ accomplished His exodus at Jerusalem, dying as the Passover Lamb and rising to lead His people out of slavery to sin and death. He brought you out with joy. Not one of His is left behind. Walk today like someone set free, and let your heart sing.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you walking in the joy of your deliverance — or still living like a slave in Egypt?

◆

DAY 248 · SEPTEMBER 5 · PSALM 105 (VV. 40–45)

That They Might Keep His Statutes

> *"that they might keep his statutes, and observe his laws. Praise Yah!"*
> — PSALM 105:45

Psalm 105 ends with the land: *"He gave them the lands of the nations. They took the labor of the peoples in possession"* (Psalm 105:44). The promise to Abraham came true. The wandering family that owned nothing now had a homeland. Fields they did not plant. Vineyards they did not tend. Houses they did not build. All of it given. That is grace — receiving what you did not earn. Every believer lives in a house of grace like that, enjoying blessings someone else paid for.

And then the purpose of it all: *"that they might keep his statutes, and observe his laws. Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 105:45). That they might keep His statutes. The rescue had a goal. God did not free Israel from Egypt so they could do whatever they wanted. He freed them so they could belong to Him and live His way. Freedom in the Bible is not freedom from God. It is freedom for God. A slave freed to wander alone is not free for long.

Notice the order. First God rescued them. Then He gave them the land. Then He asked for obedience. Grace first, then response. That is how the whole Bible works. God does not say, obey Me and I will rescue you. He says, I have rescued you; now walk with Me. Paul puts it this way: *"thanks be to God, that, whereas you were bondservants of sin, you became obedient from the heart to that form of teaching to which you were delivered"* (Romans 6:17). Obedient from the heart. Not to earn freedom, but because of it.

That is the right way to think about God's commands. They are not a price you pay to get in. They are the shape of life for people who are already in. Jesus said, *"If you love me, keep my commandments"* (John 14:15). Love first, then obedience. And Paul: *"For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared before that we would walk in them"* (Ephesians 2:10). You were rescued for a purpose. Keep His ways today, not to win His love, but because you already have it. And then, like the psalm, end with praise.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ rescued you before you obeyed, dying for you while you were still a slave to sin. He rose and gave you a new heart that can keep His ways. Obey Him today not to earn His love but because you already have it. Then praise Him, the way the psalm does.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you obey God to earn His favor — or because He has already rescued you?

◆

DAY 249 · SEPTEMBER 6 · PSALM 106 (VV. 1–6)

Both We and Our Fathers Have Sinned

> *"We have sinned with our fathers. We have committed iniquity. We have done wickedly."*
> — PSALM 106:6

Psalm 106 is the dark twin of Psalm 105. Where Psalm 105 told the story of God's faithfulness, Psalm 106 tells the story of Israel's unfaithfulness. But it begins with praise: *"Praise Yahweh! Give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 106:1). Before the confession, the psalmist sets God's goodness in front of him. That is the right place to start. You confess sin in the light of His love, not in the dark.

"Who can utter the mighty acts of Yahweh, or fully declare all his praise?" (Psalm 106:2). No one can say it all. Then a blessing: *"Blessed are those who keep justice. Blessed is one who does what is right at all times"* (Psalm 106:3). And a personal prayer: *"Remember me, Yahweh, with the favor that you show to your people. Visit me with your salvation"* (Psalm 106:4). The psalmist wants to share in what God does for His people. He knows he needs it.

Then the confession that gives this day its name: *"We have sinned with our fathers. We have committed iniquity. We have done wickedly"* (Psalm 106:6). The psalmist does not point at his ancestors. He says *"We have sinned"* (Psalm 106:6). The psalmist does not stand apart from the history he is about to tell. He includes himself. He does not blame his ancestors and excuse himself. He says: I am part of this. The same sin that ran through my fathers runs through me. Daniel prayed the same way: *"we have sinned, and have dealt perversely, and have done wickedly, and have rebelled"* (Daniel 9:5).

That is a mature kind of confession. It is easy to see the sins of your parents, your church, your nation. It is harder to admit you share them. But that admission is where healing begins. John writes, *"If we say that we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous to forgive us the sins"* (1 John 1:8–9). You do not have to hide behind other people's failures. Stand with them, confess, and receive the same mercy God has shown to every generation.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ stood with sinners, though He had no sin. He was baptized with them, counted with them, and crucified between them. He took the sin of every generation onto Himself and rose to forgive it. You do not have to stand apart and blame. Confess today, and receive His mercy.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you quick to see the sins of others — but slow to confess your own share in them?

◆

DAY 250 · SEPTEMBER 7 · PSALM 106 (VV. 7–12)

He Saved Them for His Name’s Sake

> *“Nevertheless he saved them for his name’s sake, that he might make his mighty power known.”*
> — PSALM 106:8

Psalm 106 starts its history lesson at the Red Sea, and it begins with failure: *“Our fathers didn’t understand your wonders in Egypt. They didn’t remember the multitude of your loving kindnesses, but were rebellious at the sea, even at the Red Sea”* (Psalm 106:7). They had just watched the ten plagues. They had walked out of Egypt carrying gold. And at the edge of the sea, with Pharaoh’s chariots behind them, they panicked and rebelled. They forgot already. The memory of the plagues was still fresh, and fear wiped it away.

Then one word changes everything: *“Nevertheless he saved them for his name’s sake, that he might make his mighty power known”* (Psalm 106:8). Nevertheless. In spite of their rebellion. In spite of their forgetting. He saved them anyway. Why? Not because they deserved it. For His name’s sake. God’s own reputation was on the line. He had promised to rescue His people, and He would keep that promise even when they did not trust Him.

“He rebuked the Red Sea also, and it was dried up; so he led them through the depths, as through a desert. He saved them from the hand of him who hated them, and redeemed them from the hand of the enemy. The waters covered their adversaries. There was not one of them left” (Psalm 106:9–11). The sea split. The people walked through on dry ground. The army that chased them drowned. And all of it happened for a people who had just been complaining. God did not wait for them to stop grumbling before He split the sea.

That is grace. Isaiah heard God say it: *“I, even I, am he who blots out your transgressions for my own sake; and I will not remember your sins”* (Isaiah 43:25). For My own sake. God saves you not because you finally got it right, but because of who He is. That is good news for people who keep failing. *“Then they believed his words. They sang his praise”* (Psalm 106:12). After the rescue, faith and song. If you have been rebellious and forgetful, look at the Red Sea. He saved them nevertheless. He will save you for His name’s sake.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ saved you nevertheless — in spite of your rebellion and forgetfulness, for the sake of God’s name. He went through the deep waters of death and came up on the other side, and your enemies were drowned behind Him. He rose. Believe His word today, and sing His praise.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe God saves you not because you finally got it right, but for His name’s sake?

◆

DAY 251 · SEPTEMBER 8 · PSALM 106 (VV. 13–18)

They Soon Forgot His Works

"They soon forgot his works."
— PSALM 106:13

The song at the Red Sea did not last long: *"They soon forgot his works. They didn't wait for his counsel"* (Psalm 106:13). Soon. That is the sad word. Not after years. Soon, within days. The people who had just walked through the sea on dry ground forgot what God had done within days. And they did not wait for His guidance. They rushed ahead with their own ideas. Forgetting and rushing go together. When you forget what God has done, you stop waiting for what He will do.

Then the craving: *"but gave in to craving in the desert, and tested God in the wasteland. He gave them their request, but sent leanness into their soul"* (Psalm 106:14–15). They demanded meat. God gave it to them. And with it came leanness of soul. Numbers tells the story: *"The mixed multitude that was among them lusted exceedingly; and the children of Israel also wept again, and said, 'Who will give us meat to eat?'"* (Numbers 11:4). They got their meat, and lost their peace.

That is one of the most sobering lines in Scripture. He gave them their request, but sent leanness into their soul. Sometimes the worst thing that can happen is getting exactly what you demand. Full stomach, empty soul. Busy life, hollow heart. You can get the promotion, the relationship, the house, the thing you have been craving, and find that your soul is thinner than before. When the craving is louder than God's counsel, the gift itself becomes a judgment.

Then jealousy: *"They envied Moses also in the camp, and Aaron, Yahweh's saint"* (Psalm 106:16). Envy of the leaders God had chosen. And the earth opened: *"The earth opened and swallowed up Dathan, and covered the company of Abiram. A fire was kindled in their company. The flame burned up the wicked"* (Psalm 106:17–18). Forgetfulness led to craving. Craving led to envy. Envy led to rebellion and death. Paul says these things *"happened to them by way of example, and they were written for our admonition"* (1 Corinthians 10:11). Remember what God has done. Wait for His counsel. Do not let your cravings drown out His voice.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did not forget the Father's works or rush ahead of His counsel. In the wilderness He refused to demand bread, trusting the Father instead. Then He gave Himself as the bread that fills the soul. He rose. Remember His works today, and let Him fill you instead of your cravings.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What craving is louder than God's counsel in your life right now?

◆

DAY 252 · SEPTEMBER 9 · PSALM 106 (VV. 19–24)

They Exchanged Their Glory

> *"Thus they exchanged their glory for an image of a bull that eats grass."*
> — PSALM 106:20

Psalm 106 reaches the lowest point of the wilderness story: *"They made a calf in Horeb, and worshiped a molten image"* (Psalm 106:19). Horeb is Sinai, the mountain where God had just given the commandments. While Moses was on the mountain receiving the law, the people at the bottom were melting their gold into a calf. Exodus records what they said about it: *"These are your gods, Israel, which brought you up out of the land of Egypt"* (Exodus 32:4).

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Thus they exchanged their glory for an image of a bull that eats grass"* (Psalm 106:20). Their glory was God Himself — the living God who had split the sea and fed them from heaven. And they traded Him for a statue of a cow. A grass-eater. Something that could not see, hear, speak, or save. It is one of the most foolish trades in human history, and the psalm names it with a kind of stunned disbelief.

"They forgot God, their Savior, who had done great things in Egypt, wondrous works in the land of Ham, and awesome things by the Red Sea" (Psalm 106:21–22). They forgot their Savior. That is how idolatry starts. Not with a dramatic decision to reject God, but with forgetting Him. And something has to fill the space. People do not stop worshiping. They just change what they worship. Paul says the same about humanity: they *"traded the glory of the incorruptible God for the likeness of an image of corruptible man, and of birds, four-footed animals, and creeping things"* (Romans 1:23).

What are you tempted to trade God for? Not a golden calf, probably. But a career. A screen. A relationship. A bank balance. A body. A reputation. Anything you look to for what only God can give is a calf that eats grass. It cannot save you. And yet the psalm tells what happened next: *"Therefore he said that he would destroy them, had Moses, his chosen, not stood before him in the breach, to turn away his wrath"* (Psalm 106:23). Moses stood in the gap. He interceded. And God relented. Hebrews says Christ *"lives forever to make intercession for them"* (Hebrews 7:25). He stands in the breach for you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ stood in the breach between a holy God and a people who had traded Him for idols. He did more than pray for them. He took the wrath on Himself at the cross. He rose, and He lives to intercede for you. Turn from whatever calf you have been trusting, and come back to Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What lesser thing have you exchanged the glory of God for — and will you come back to Him?

◆

DAY 253 · SEPTEMBER 10 · PSALM 106 (VV. 24–30)

They Did Not Believe His Promise

"Yes, they despised the pleasant land."
— PSALM 106:24

Psalm 106 now tells of the day Israel stood at the edge of the promised land and refused to go in: *"Yes, they despised the pleasant land. They didn't believe his word, but murmured in their tents, and didn't listen to Yahweh's voice"* (Psalm 106:24–25). The spies had come back with grapes so large it took two men to carry a single cluster. The land was good. God had promised it. And the people looked at the giants and said no. Ten spies spoke fear. Two spoke faith. The crowd listened to the fear.

Despised the pleasant land. That is a strong word. They did not just hesitate. They looked down on the gift. They murmured in their tents — complaining in private, behind closed flaps, where they thought no one could hear. And they did not believe His word. That was the root of it. Numbers records God's question: *"How long will this people despise me? and how long will they not believe in me, for all the signs which I have worked among them?"* (Numbers 14:11).

The result was devastating: *"Therefore he swore to them that he would overthrow them in the wilderness, that he would overthrow their offspring among the nations, and scatter them in the lands"* (Psalm 106:26–27). A whole generation died in the desert. They came all the way from Egypt and never set foot in the promise. Hebrews explains why: *"We see that they weren't able to enter in because of unbelief"* (Hebrews 3:19). Unbelief kept them out. Not the giants. Not the walled cities. Unbelief. The giants were real, but they were never the real problem.

Then more rebellion: *"They joined themselves also to Baal Peor, and ate the sacrifices of the dead"* (Psalm 106:28). And the plague came. *"Then Phinehas stood up and executed judgment, so the plague was stopped"* (Psalm 106:30). Someone stood up, and the judgment stopped. You may be standing at the edge of something God has promised, looking at the giants instead of at Him. Do not murmur in your tent. Do not despise the gift. Believe His word. The promise is good. The One who gave it is stronger than any giant.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the One who believed God's word perfectly and walked into the land of promise for His people. He went into death, the last giant, and defeated it on the third day. Unbelief kept Israel out of the land. Faith in Christ brings you in. Believe His word today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you looking at the giants instead of believing God's word about the promise in front of you?

◆

DAY 254 · SEPTEMBER 11 · PSALM 106 (VV. 31–36)

They Did Not Destroy the Peoples

> *"They didn't destroy the peoples, as Yahweh commanded them"*
> — PSALM 106:34

Psalm 106 mentions Phinehas once more: *"That was credited to him for righteousness, for all generations to come"* (Psalm 106:31). Then it moves to Meribah, where even Moses failed: *"They angered him also at the waters of Meribah, so that Moses was troubled for their sakes; because they were rebellious against his spirit, he spoke rashly with his lips"* (Psalm 106:32–33). Even the great leader slipped. Moses, who had seen God face to face, who had carried the tablets down the mountain, lost his temper by a rock. The people's rebellion provoked him into rash words, and it cost him entry into the land.

That is a sobering reminder. No one is immune. Moses spent forty years leading a complaining people, and in one moment of frustration he lost his temper and disobeyed. Constant pressure can wear down even the strongest faith, the way water wears down a stone, one drop at a time. If you are leading people who keep grumbling — a family, a church, a team — guard your heart. Their rebellion can provoke you into sin of your own.

Then the next generation: *"They didn't destroy the peoples, as Yahweh commanded them, but mixed themselves with the nations, and learned their works"* (Psalm 106:34–35). They went into the land, but they did not finish what God told them. They made peace with what God had told them to remove. And slowly, they became like the people around them. They learned their works. Compromise is rarely sudden. It is a gradual mixing, a slow learning of the ways of the world until you cannot tell the difference.

"They served their idols, which became a snare to them" (Psalm 106:36). A snare. A trap. What they thought was harmless coexistence became a cage. Paul writes, *"Therefore 'Come out from among them, and be separate,' says the Lord"* (2 Corinthians 6:17). That does not mean hiding from the world. Jesus ate with sinners. It means not learning their works — not adopting their idols, their values, their ways. Where have you made peace with something God told you to remove? It may look harmless now. Left alone, it becomes a snare. The vine you allowed to grow along the fence will one day pull the fence down.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ lived among sinners without learning their works. He ate with tax collectors and touched lepers, and He never once compromised with sin. Then He went to the cross to break every snare that holds His people. He rose. Ask Him to show you what you have made peace with that He wants to remove.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where have you made peace with something God told you to remove, and slowly begun to learn the world's works?

◆

DAY 255 · SEPTEMBER 12 · PSALM 106 (VV. 37–43)

Many Times He Delivered Them

"He rescued them many times"
— PSALM 106:43

Psalm 106 now names the worst sin in Israel's history, and it does not soften it: *"Yes, they sacrificed their sons and their daughters to demons. They shed innocent blood, even the blood of their sons and of their daughters, whom they sacrificed to the idols of Canaan. The land was polluted with blood"* (Psalm 106:37–38). Children. Their own children, offered to idols. That is where idolatry ends up. What starts as a small compromise ends in the sacrifice of the most precious and innocent lives.

It is a hard passage to read, and it should be. But it is in Scripture for a reason. God wants His people to see where the road of idolatry leads, so they will not take the first step. Idols always demand more. They promise blessing and take everything. They promise prosperity and consume the next generation. Even today, many idols — money, success, pleasure, comfort — require the sacrifice of children in quieter ways: neglect, absence, broken homes, the slow giving-up of a family for something that cannot love you back. *"Thus they were defiled with their works, and prostituted themselves in their deeds"* (Psalm 106:39).

God's response was judgment: *"Therefore Yahweh burned with anger against his people. He abhorred his inheritance. He gave them into the hand of the nations. Those who hated them ruled over them. Their enemies also oppressed them"* (Psalm 106:40–42). He handed them over to the very nations whose idols they had chosen. That is how judgment often works. God gives people what they choose, and it turns out to be slavery.

And yet the next line is astonishing: *"He rescued them many times, but they were rebellious in their counsel, and were brought low in their iniquity"* (Psalm 106:43). Many times. Over and over. They rebelled. He rescued. They rebelled again. He rescued again. The book of Judges is the long record of it: *"it grieved Yahweh because of their groaning by reason of those who oppressed them"* (Judges 2:18). His patience is beyond measure. No human parent could keep forgiving a child that many times. If you have rebelled many times, He has rescued many times. He has not run out of mercy for you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God rescued His people many times, and finally rescued them once for all in Christ. The innocent blood that cleanses the guilty was shed on the cross, the Son given up for the children of rebels. He rose. However many times you have rebelled, He has not run out of mercy. Come back.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What idol in your life could be quietly costing the people you love — and will you bring it to God?

◆

DAY 256 · SEPTEMBER 13 · PSALM 106 (VV. 43–48)

He Remembered His Covenant

> *"He remembered for them his covenant"*
> — PSALM 106:45

After all the rebellion, Psalm 106 ends with God's heart: *"Nevertheless he regarded their distress, when he heard their cry"* (Psalm 106:44). Nevertheless again. This one word carries more grace than whole books could explain. The same word that appeared at the Red Sea (Psalm 106:8). After the golden calf, after the unbelief, after the idols and the innocent blood — nevertheless. God heard their cry. He looked at their distress. He did not turn away.

Then the reason: *"He remembered for them his covenant, and repented according to the multitude of his loving kindnesses"* (Psalm 106:45). He remembered His covenant. Not their faithfulness — they had none. His own promise. And He relented, according to the multitude of His loving kindnesses. Not according to what they deserved. According to how much He loves. That is a measure without a bottom. You will never reach the end of it, however far you fall.

Then a surprising detail: *"He made them also to be pitied by all those who carried them captive"* (Psalm 106:46). Even their captors felt pity for them, against every expectation. God softened the hearts of their enemies. And then the prayer at the end of the psalm: *"Save us, Yahweh, our God, gather us from among the nations, to give thanks to your holy name, to triumph in your praise!"* (Psalm 106:47). Scattered people asking to be gathered again. Exiles asking to come home. And the reason they want to come home is to praise. Not comfort first. Not safety first. Praise. That is a heart that has learned something in exile.

The psalm closes Book Four of the Psalms with a doxology: *"Blessed be Yahweh, the God of Israel, from everlasting even to everlasting! Let all the people say, 'Amen.' Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 106:48). After forty-seven verses of failure, the last word is praise. That is the shape of the gospel. Human failure is real and long. But God's covenant love is longer. Lamentations says, *"It is because of Yahweh's loving kindnesses that we are not consumed, because his compassion doesn't fail"* (Lamentations 3:22). Say amen today. He remembered His covenant. He remembers it for you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the covenant God remembered. He came to gather scattered exiles, died for a rebellious people, and rose to bring them home. However long your history of failure, His covenant love is longer. Let your last word today be praise. Amen.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

After your own long history of failure, can you believe God remembers His covenant and hears your cry?

◆

DAY 257 · SEPTEMBER 14 · PSALM 107 (VV. 1–6)

Let the Redeemed Say So

"Let the redeemed by Yahweh say so"
— PSALM 107:2

Psalm 107 opens Book Five of the Psalms with a call to give thanks: *"Give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever. Let the redeemed by Yahweh say so, whom he has redeemed from the hand of the adversary"* (Psalm 107:1–2). Let the redeemed say so. If God has rescued you, say it. Out loud. Do not keep it to yourself. Redemption is meant to be spoken. A rescued person who stays silent leaves others thinking there is no rescue. Your story might be the one that gives someone else the courage to cry out.

"And gathered out of the lands, from the east and from the west, from the north and from the south" (Psalm 107:3). From every direction. God gathers His people from everywhere. Then the psalm tells four stories of rescue. Each one follows the same pattern: trouble, a cry, deliverance, and thanks. The first is about wanderers: *"They wandered in the wilderness in a desert way. They found no city to live in. Hungry and thirsty, their soul fainted in them"* (Psalm 107:4–5).

Lost in the desert. No city. No home. Hungry and thirsty. Fainting. You may know that kind of wandering — not in a literal desert, but in a life with no direction, no place to settle, no sense of where you belong. Moving from job to job, relationship to relationship, town to town, always looking for something and never finding it. The soul faints from the search. The longing is real, but every road seems to lead back into the sand.

Then: *"Then they cried to Yahweh in their trouble, and he delivered them out of their distresses"* (Psalm 107:6). They cried. He delivered. That is the whole pattern. No elaborate plan. No earning it. Just a cry and a rescue. It will repeat four times in this psalm, and it repeats in every life that turns to God. Peter says God called you *"out of darkness into his marvelous light"* (1 Peter 2:9). And then Revelation shows the redeemed singing, *"You were killed, and bought us for God with your blood out of every tribe, language, people, and nation"* (Revelation 5:9). If you are one of the redeemed, say so today. Tell someone what He has done.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ redeemed you from the hand of the enemy by His own blood, gathering a people from east and west, north and south. He died and rose so that wanderers could find a home. If you are redeemed, say so today. Tell someone the story of how He found you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If you are one of the redeemed, have you said so — out loud, to someone who needs to hear it?

◆

DAY 258 · SEPTEMBER 15 · PSALM 107 (VV. 7–12)

He Satisfies the Longing Soul

> *"For he satisfies the longing soul. He fills the hungry soul with good."*
> — PSALM 107:9

The wanderers in the desert cried out, and God answered: *"he led them also by a straight way, that they might go to a city to live in"* (Psalm 107:7). A straight way. After years of wandering in circles, God gave them a direct road home. And the destination was a city to live in. Not another campsite. A home. That is what God does for wanderers, and He does it on purpose. He does not just stop the wandering. He gives a place to belong.

Then the refrain that will repeat through the psalm: *"Let them praise Yahweh for his loving kindness, for his wonderful deeds to the children of men!"* (Psalm 107:8). Then the line that gives this day its name: *"For he satisfies the longing soul. He fills the hungry soul with good"* (Psalm 107:9). The longing soul. The hungry soul. God does not just give them enough. He satisfies. He fills. With good.

Many people live with a hunger they cannot name. They try to fill it with food, entertainment, work, relationships, possessions. Some of those are good gifts. Food is good. Work is good. Friendship is good. But none of them satisfy the deepest longing. They are like drinking salt water. The more you have, the thirstier you get. The longing was built for God, and nothing smaller will fill it. Jesus said, *"I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will not be hungry, and whoever believes in me will never be thirsty"* (John 6:35). The longing soul is satisfied in Him.

Then the second story: *"Some sat in darkness and in the shadow of death, being bound in affliction and iron, because they rebelled against the words of God, and condemned the counsel of the Most High"* (Psalm 107:10–11). Prisoners. Bound in iron because of their own rebellion. *"Therefore he brought down their heart with labor. They fell down, and there was no one to help"* (Psalm 107:12). That is tomorrow's story. But notice: God satisfies the longing soul first, and then turns to the prisoners. No one is beyond His reach — not the lost wanderer, not the guilty prisoner. Bring your hunger to Him today.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the bread of life who satisfies the longing soul. He was broken on the cross so the hungry could be filled, and He rose to lead wanderers home by a straight way. Whatever hunger you carry today, bring it to Him. He fills the hungry with good.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What longing in your soul have you tried to fill with things that cannot satisfy?

◆

DAY 259 · SEPTEMBER 16 · PSALM 107 (VV. 13–18)

He Burst Their Bonds Apart

> *"He brought them out of darkness and the shadow of death, and broke away their chains."*
> — PSALM 107:14

The second story in Psalm 107 is about prisoners. They sat *"in darkness and in the shadow of death, being bound in affliction and iron"* (Psalm 107:10). And this time the cause was their own sin: *"because they rebelled against the words of God, and condemned the counsel of the Most High"* (Psalm 107:11). They were not innocent victims, and the psalm does not pretend they were. They had rejected God's word. And their chains were the result.

"Therefore he brought down their heart with labor. They fell down, and there was no one to help" (Psalm 107:12). Brought low. Fallen. No one to help. That is where rebellion leads. You may know what it is to be bound by the consequences of your own choices. The addiction you walked into. The debt you created. The broken relationship you caused. The prison you built yourself. And when you finally fall, there seems to be no one to help.

But then: *"Then they cried to Yahweh in their trouble, and he saved them out of their distresses"* (Psalm 107:13). Even guilty prisoners can cry out. Even those who rebelled. God does not say, you made this bed, now lie in it. He hears the cry of the guilty as well as the innocent. *"He brought them out of darkness and the shadow of death, and broke away their chains"* (Psalm 107:14). He broke the chains. He did not just loosen them or ease them. He broke them, so they could not be used again.

"For he has broken the gates of bronze, and cut through bars of iron" (Psalm 107:16). Bronze gates. Iron bars. The strongest prisons of the ancient world. God tears through them. When an angel came to Peter in prison, *"a light shone in the cell"* (Acts 12:7), and *"His chains fell off his hands"* (Acts 12:7). Jesus said He came *"to proclaim release to the captives"* (Luke 4:18). And Paul says God *"delivered us out of the power of darkness, and translated us into the Kingdom of the Son of his love"* (Colossians 1:13). If you are bound by your own sin, cry out. He breaks chains.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was bound and led away to be crucified, chained for the sins of rebels. He went down into the shadow of death and broke its gates from the inside, rising on the third day. Whatever chains you forged by your own choices, cry out to Him. He breaks them.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What chains have you forged by your own rebellion — and will you cry out to the One who breaks them?

◆

DAY 260 · SEPTEMBER 17 · PSALM 107 (VV. 19–25)

He Sent Out His Word and Healed Them

"He sends his word, and heals them, and delivers them from their graves."
— PSALM 107:20

The third story in Psalm 107 is about the sick: *"Fools are afflicted because of their disobedience, and because of their iniquities. Their soul abhors all kinds of food. They draw near to the gates of death"* (Psalm 107:17–18). They had walked away from God, and their bodies paid the price. So sick they could not eat. So weak they stood at death's door. The psalm does not say all sickness comes from sin. But it is honest that some does, and that wandering from God can cost the body as well as the soul.

Then the same turn as before: *"Then they cry to Yahweh in their trouble, he saves them out of their distresses"* (Psalm 107:19). The cry. The rescue. And this time God uses a particular tool: *"He sends his word, and heals them, and delivers them from their graves"* (Psalm 107:20). He sends His word. Not medicine first, though God uses medicine. Not a ritual. His word. Spoken from heaven, it travels to the sickbed and brings life.

That is the power of God's word. It made the world. It split the sea. And it heals. A Roman centurion understood it when he said to Jesus, *"Just say the word, and my servant will be healed"* (Matthew 8:8). Jesus did, and the servant was healed at a distance. The word does not need to be in the room. It needs only to be spoken by the One who has authority over life and death. Psalm 119:25 prays, *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). The word that heals the body revives the soul.

Then the call to respond: *"Let them praise Yahweh for his loving kindness, for his wonderful deeds to the children of men! Let them offer the sacrifices of thanksgiving, and declare his deeds with singing"* (Psalm 107:21–22). Thanksgiving. Declaring His deeds. And then the fourth story begins, with sailors: *"Those who go down to the sea in ships, who do business in great waters; these see Yahweh's deeds, and his wonders in the deep"* (Psalm 107:23–24). Whatever sickness you carry today — in your body or in your soul — cry out. He sends His word and heals.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Word God sent to heal and deliver from the grave. He carried sickness and sorrow to the cross, went down into the grave, and came out on the third day. He still sends His word. Cry out to Him today, and let His word bring life.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe God's word has power to heal what is sick in your body or soul?

◆

DAY 261 · SEPTEMBER 18 · PSALM 107 (VV. 26–31)

He Made the Storm Be Still

"He makes the storm a calm, so that its waves are still."
— PSALM 107:29

The fourth story in Psalm 107 takes place at sea. Sailors and merchants on the open water, doing business in the deep. And God raises a storm: *"For he commands, and raises the stormy wind, which lifts up its waves. They mount up to the sky; they go down again to the depths. Their soul melts away because of trouble"* (Psalm 107:25–26). Up to the sky, down to the depths. The ship tossed like a cork. Their courage melting like wax. These are not beginners. They are professionals who know the sea, and the sea has beaten them.

"They reel back and forth, and stagger like a drunken man, and are at their wits' end" (Psalm 107:27). At their wits' end. That phrase comes from this verse. All their skill as sailors is gone. All their knowledge of the sea is useless. They do not know what to do. You may be at your wits' end right now. You have tried everything you know. Every plan has failed. The waves keep coming, one after another, with no break between them.

Then the turn: *"Then they cry to Yahweh in their trouble, and he brings them out of their distress. He makes the storm a calm, so that its waves are still"* (Psalm 107:28–29). The God who raised the storm also stills it. The waves that terrified them go flat. And then: *"Then they are glad because it is calm, so he brings them to their desired haven"* (Psalm 107:30). Calm. Gladness. Harbor. Home.

The disciples lived this psalm on the Sea of Galilee. A storm came up, the boat was filling, and Jesus was asleep. They woke Him, and *"He awoke, and rebuked the wind, and said to the sea, 'Peace! Be still!' The wind ceased, and there was a great calm"* (Mark 4:39). And they asked, *"Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?"* (Mark 4:41). They knew Psalm 107. They knew only God makes the storm a calm. And here He was in their boat. When you are at your wits' end, He is not. Cry out to Him. He brings you to your desired haven.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ stood up in the boat and spoke, and the sea obeyed. At the cross He went into the worst storm of all, the storm of God's judgment, and on the third day He rose to bring His people to their haven. At your wits' end, cry to Him. He stills the storm.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you at your wits' end — and will you cry out to the One who makes the storm a calm?

◆

DAY 262 · SEPTEMBER 19 · PSALM 107 (VV. 32–37)

He Turns the Desert into Pools

> *"He turns a desert into a pool of water, and a dry land into water springs."*
> — PSALM 107:35

Psalm 107 now steps back to show God's power over land and water: *"Let them exalt him also in the assembly of the people, and praise him in the seat of the elders"* (Psalm 107:32). Public praise, in front of everyone. Then the reason: God controls the land itself. *"He turns rivers into a desert, water springs into a thirsty ground, and a fruitful land into a salt waste, for the wickedness of those who dwell in it"* (Psalm 107:33–34).

God can dry up rivers. He can turn a fertile valley into salt flats. When people live in wickedness, the land itself can suffer. That is sobering. Blessings are not guaranteed to the proud, and they are not a reward for clever planning. What God gives, He can take away. But then the psalm turns the other direction: *"He turns a desert into a pool of water, and a dry land into water springs"* (Psalm 107:35). The reverse. Dry ground becomes a spring. A wasteland becomes a lake.

Isaiah saw the same promise: *"waters will break out in the wilderness, and streams in the desert. The burning sand will become a pool, and the thirsty ground springs of water"* (Isaiah 35:6–7). And again: *"I will make the wilderness a pool of water, and the dry land springs of water"* (Isaiah 41:18). God specializes in turning dry places into wet ones. That is His signature. Wherever He goes, the desert blooms. The Bible begins in a garden and ends with a river running through a city.

And then He settles people there: *"There he makes the hungry live, that they may prepare a city to live in, sow fields, plant vineyards, and reap the fruits of increase"* (Psalm 107:36–37). The hungry get a home. They build a city. They plant fields and vineyards. They harvest. That is what God does with a desert. You may be in a dry season — spiritually, emotionally, financially. Nothing is growing. The ground is cracked. God can turn your desert into a pool. Jesus said, *"He who believes in me... from within him will flow rivers of living water"* (John 7:38). Bring your dry ground to Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went into the desert of the cross, crying out in thirst, so that rivers of living water could flow from everyone who believes in Him. He rose on the third day, and the desert began to bloom. Bring your dry season to Him today. He turns deserts into pools.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What dry place in your life are you waiting for God to turn into springs of water?

◆

DAY 263 · SEPTEMBER 20 · PSALM 107 (VV. 38–43)

Whoever Is Wise Will Pay Attention

"Whoever is wise will pay attention to these things."
— PSALM 107:43

Psalm 107 closes with a picture of the ups and downs of life under God's hand: *"He blesses them also, so that they are multiplied greatly. He doesn't allow their livestock to decrease"* (Psalm 107:38). Blessing. Growth. Abundance. And then: *"Again, they are diminished and bowed down through oppression, trouble, and sorrow"* (Psalm 107:39). Decline. Oppression. Sorrow. Life goes up and down. Seasons of plenty and seasons of loss. Ecclesiastes says God *"has made the one side by side with the other"* (Ecclesiastes 7:14).

Then a word about the mighty: *"He pours contempt on princes, and causes them to wander in a trackless waste"* (Psalm 107:40). The proud rulers end up lost in the desert, like the wanderers at the start of the psalm. And a word about the poor: *"Yet he lifts the needy out of their affliction, and increases their families like a flock"* (Psalm 107:41). The needy are lifted. The princes are humbled. God reverses the world's order. Mary sang it: *"He has put down princes from their thrones. And has exalted the lowly"* (Luke 1:52).

"The upright will see it, and be glad. All the wicked will shut their mouths" (Psalm 107:42). The upright watch God at work and rejoice. The wicked have nothing left to say. And then the last line of the psalm, which gives this day its name: *"Whoever is wise will pay attention to these things. They will consider the loving kindnesses of Yahweh"* (Psalm 107:43). Pay attention. Consider. Do not just live through the ups and downs. Think about them. Look for God's hand in all of it.

That is what wisdom is. Not just knowing facts, but seeing God's loving kindness in the ordinary rhythm of life. The wanderer who found home. The prisoner set free. The sick one healed. The sailor brought to harbor. The desert turned to springs. Hosea ends his book the same way: *"Who is wise, that he may understand these things? Who is prudent, that he may know them? For the ways of Yahweh are right"* (Hosea 14:9). Today, be wise. Look back at your own life and consider. Where has His loving kindness carried you?

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the clearest picture of God's loving kindness. In Him the wanderer finds home, the prisoner is freed, the sick are healed, the storm is stilled. He died and rose so that every one of these stories could be yours. Consider His loving kindness today. Be wise.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you look back on your life's ups and downs, where can you trace the loving kindness of the LORD?

◆

DAY 264 · SEPTEMBER 21 · PSALM 108 (VV. 1–6)

My Heart Is Steadfast

> *"My heart is steadfast, God. I will sing and I will make music with my soul."*
> — PSALM 108:1

Psalm 108 is unusual. It is built from two earlier psalms joined together — the first half from Psalm 57 and the second from Psalm 60. David takes words he had prayed in other seasons and puts them together into a new song. There is a lesson in that. Old prayers can be prayed again. Words that carried you once can carry you again in a new trouble. You do not always need new words. Sometimes the old ones are exactly right. A psalm you memorized as a child, a verse that held you through a funeral, a hymn your grandmother sang — those words can be pulled out again when the next storm comes.

It opens with steadiness: *"My heart is steadfast, God. I will sing and I will make music with my soul"* (Psalm 108:1). Steadfast. Fixed. Not swinging back and forth with every piece of news. And from that steady heart comes music. Then David wakes up the morning: *"Wake up, harp and lyre! I will wake up the dawn"* (Psalm 108:2). He will not wait for the sun to rise before he praises. He will praise until the sun comes up.

Then the praise goes global: *"I will give thanks to you, Yahweh, among the nations. I will sing praises to you among the peoples"* (Psalm 108:3). Not only in Israel. Among the nations. And the reason: *"For your loving kindness is great above the heavens. Your faithfulness reaches to the skies"* (Psalm 108:4). Above the heavens. Higher than anything you can see. That is the size of God's love. There is no ceiling on it.

"Be exalted, God, above the heavens! Let your glory be over all the earth. That your beloved may be delivered, save with your right hand, and answer us" (Psalm 108:5–6). Your beloved. That is what God's people are. And because they are beloved, David asks God to save them with His right hand. You are beloved. That is not a sentimental word. It is a covenant title. Paul calls believers God's chosen ones, holy and beloved. When your heart is unsteady today, borrow David's words. Fix your heart on God's love, higher than the heavens. Then sing.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Beloved Son, and in Him you are beloved too. God saved His Son with His right hand, raising Him from the dead. That same love, higher than the heavens, holds you today. Fix your heart there. Wake up the dawn with praise.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What old prayer or psalm that carried you once could you pray again in your present trouble?

◆

DAY 265 · SEPTEMBER 22 · PSALM 108 (VV. 7–13)

With God We Shall Do Valiantly

"Through God, we will do valiantly."
— PSALM 108:13

The second half of Psalm 108 comes from Psalm 60. God speaks from His sanctuary and claims the land: *"In triumph, I will divide Shechem, and measure out the valley of Succoth. Gilead is mine. Manasseh is mine. Ephraim also is my helmet. Judah is my scepter"* (Psalm 108:7–8). Mine, mine, mine. Every part of the land belongs to Him, down to the last field. And even the enemy nations: *"Moab is my wash pot. I will toss my sandal on Edom. I will shout over Philistia"* (Psalm 108:9).

Then the question: *"Who will bring me into the fortified city? Who has led me to Edom?"* (Psalm 108:10). Who will lead me in? David knows the task is too big for him. A fortified city. An enemy nation. He cannot do it on his own. And then a moment of honesty: *"Haven't you rejected us, God? You don't go out, God, with our armies"* (Psalm 108:11). He remembers the defeat. The times God did not go with them, and they lost.

So he prays: *"Give us help against the enemy, for the help of man is vain"* (Psalm 108:12). Vain. Empty. Human help, by itself, cannot win. David has learned that lesson in defeat. He has seen what happens when people go out in their own strength. And he does not want to do it again. He wants God's help, because man's help is not enough. Allies fail. Plans fall through. Even the best advice runs out.

Then the confidence that closes the psalm: *"Through God, we will do valiantly. For it is he who will tread down our enemies"* (Psalm 108:13). Through God. Not through human strength. The courage is real, but it is borrowed. And the victory belongs to Him: He will tread down the enemies. That is a word for you if you are facing something too big. A fortified city of a problem. An enemy you cannot defeat. Stop relying on the help of man. Ask for the help of God. Through Him, you will do valiantly. Paul says, *"My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness"* (2 Corinthians 12:9).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ trod down the enemies no human strength could defeat — sin, death, and the devil. He did it not with an army but with a cross, and on the third day He rose victorious. Through Him you will do valiantly. Stop relying on your own strength today. Lean on His.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What fortified city in your life are you trying to take with the help of man instead of the help of God?

◆

DAY 266 · SEPTEMBER 23 · PSALM 109 (VV. 1–6)

Be Not Silent, O God of My Praise

“God of my praise, don’t remain silent”
— PSALM 109:1

Psalm 109 is the most severe of the imprecatory psalms. It is the prayer of someone who has been betrayed, slandered, and attacked by people he loved. It opens with a plea: *“God of my praise, don’t remain silent, for they have opened the mouth of the wicked and the mouth of deceit against me. They have spoken to me with a lying tongue”* (Psalm 109:1–2). God of my praise. Even in this dark psalm, David begins with the God he praises.

Then the attack: *“They have also surrounded me with words of hatred, and fought against me without a cause”* (Psalm 109:3). Without a cause. He did nothing to deserve it. And the most painful part: *“In return for my love, they are my adversaries; but I am in prayer”* (Psalm 109:4). In return for my love. He loved them, and they turned on him. That is the deepest kind of betrayal, and it leaves a wound that does not close quickly. Not an enemy attacking, but a friend you cared for repaying love with hatred.

“They have rewarded me evil for good, and hatred for my love” (Psalm 109:5). Evil for good. Hatred for love. You may know this exact pain. A child who turned away after everything you gave. A friend who spread lies after you helped them. A church that pushed you out after years of service. The wound is not just the harm. It is that it came in return for love.

And look at what David does: but I am in prayer. That is the key line of the whole psalm. When they attacked, he prayed. When they lied, he prayed. When they returned evil for good, he prayed. He did not retaliate with his own hands. He took it to God. That is far harder than striking back, and far better. The harsh words that follow in this psalm are spoken to God, not carried out by David. Peter says Christ, *“When he was cursed, he didn’t curse back. When he suffered, he didn’t threaten, but committed himself to him who judges righteously”* (1 Peter 2:23). When evil is returned for your love, pray.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ loved His own to the end, and they repaid Him with betrayal, lies, and a cross. He did not curse back. He prayed, Father, forgive them. He committed Himself to the Father, who raised Him on the third day. When evil is returned for your love today, pray, as He did.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When someone returns evil for your love, do you retaliate — or take it to God in prayer?

◆

DAY 267 · SEPTEMBER 24 · PSALM 109 (VV. 7–12)

The Cry for Justice

"Let his days be few. Let another take his office."
— PSALM 109:8

The middle of Psalm 109 is the hardest stretch of prayer in the whole Psalter. David asks for judgment on the man who betrayed him, and he does not hold back: *"Set a wicked man over him. Let an adversary stand at his right hand. When he is judged, let him come out guilty. Let his prayer be turned into sin. Let his days be few. Let another take his office"* (Psalm 109:6–8). The curses go on: fatherless children, a widowed wife, creditors seizing everything (Psalm 109:9–11).

How should you read words like these, prayed by a man after God's own heart? First, notice who is speaking them. David is not carrying out these things. He is praying them to God. He has handed the case to the Judge. Second, notice what the enemy did. He returned evil for good and hatred for love (Psalm 109:5). He used his position to crush others. The psalm is a cry for justice against someone who has done great harm and shows no sign of turning.

Third, notice how the New Testament uses this psalm. When the apostles needed to replace Judas, Peter quoted it: *"For it is written in the book of Psalms, 'Let his habitation be made desolate. Let no one dwell in it;' and, 'Let another take his office'"* (Acts 1:20). Peter saw Judas — the friend who betrayed the Messiah for silver — in the enemy of Psalm 109. The worst betrayal in history fulfilled this psalm's darkest lines.

And fourth, notice what Jesus taught. *"But I tell you, love your enemies, bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who mistreat you and persecute you"* (Matthew 5:44). Paul says, *"Bless those who persecute you; bless, and don't curse"* (Romans 12:14). That does not cancel Psalm 109. It shows where its anger is finally resolved. The justice David cried for fell on Christ at the cross, for every sinner who would turn to Him. That frees you to pray for your enemies instead of cursing them. Hand your anger to God. He will judge rightly. And then, if you can, pray for the one who wronged you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The judgment Psalm 109 cries out for fell on Christ, who was betrayed by a friend and condemned for sins not His own. He prayed for His enemies from the cross, and rose to offer them mercy. Hand your anger to God today. Then ask for grace to pray for the one who hurt you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you bring your anger at someone who betrayed you to God — and then pray for them?

◆

DAY 268 · SEPTEMBER 25 · PSALM 109 (VV. 13–19)

He Did Not Remember to Show Kindness

> *"because he didn't remember to show kindness"*
> — PSALM 109:16

Psalm 109 keeps going: *"Let his posterity be cut off. In the generation following let their name be blotted out"* (Psalm 109:13). The prayers are fierce, aimed at a family line that has done great harm. Hold your discomfort for a moment and listen to why. And then the psalm gives the reason, in the verse that gives this day its name: *"because he didn't remember to show kindness, but persecuted the poor and needy man, the broken in heart, to kill them"* (Psalm 109:16). That is the root of it all.

He did not remember to show kindness. He had chances. He had power. He could have used it to help. Instead he used it to crush the poor, the needy, and the brokenhearted. He chased them down. He wanted them dead. The poor had no one else to protect them, and he made sure of it. That is what makes his guilt so heavy. Not a single sin in a weak moment, but a whole life spent refusing mercy and attacking the weakest people around him.

Then the psalm describes what that life produced: *"Yes, he loved cursing, and it came to him. He didn't delight in blessing, and it was far from him. He clothed himself also with cursing as with his garment. It came into his inward parts like water, like oil into his bones"* (Psalm 109:17–18). He loved cursing, so cursing came back to him. He refused blessing, so blessing stayed away. He wore cursing like clothes until it soaked into his bones. That is what a life of cruelty does. It becomes who you are.

Paul says it plainly: *"Don't be deceived. God is not mocked, for whatever a man sows, that he will also reap"* (Galatians 6:7). And James adds, *"For judgment is without mercy to him who has shown no mercy. Mercy triumphs over judgment"* (James 2:13). Mercy triumphs over judgment. That is the warning and the invitation of this psalm. If you have been hard on people, cruel, unforgiving, it is not too late to change clothes. Take off the cursing. Put on mercy. Christ offers it to you, and He gives you the power to show it to others.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ remembered to show kindness. He spent His life lifting the poor, the needy, and the brokenhearted, and then He took the curse of the unkind on Himself at the cross. He rose to give you a new garment. Take off the cursing today. Put on His mercy, and show it to someone.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you remembered to show kindness — or have you been clothing yourself with harshness toward others?

◆

DAY 269 · SEPTEMBER 26 · PSALM 109 (VV. 20–25)

But You, O God My Lord, Deal on My Behalf

> *"But deal with me, Yahweh the Lord, for your name's sake"*
> — PSALM 109:21

Psalm 109 turns from the enemy to David himself: *"This is the reward of my adversaries from Yahweh, of those who speak evil against my soul"* (Psalm 109:20). He hands the whole matter to God. And then the turn: *"But deal with me, Yahweh the Lord, for your name's sake, because your loving kindness is good, deliver me"* (Psalm 109:21). But You. After all the curses, he turns to God and asks for himself, quietly and plainly. Deal with me. Not on the basis of his record, but for God's name's sake.

And he describes how low he has fallen: *"for I am poor and needy. My heart is wounded within me"* (Psalm 109:22). A wounded heart. That is what betrayal does. It goes deeper than bruises, into the places where trust used to live. *"I fade away like an evening shadow. I am shaken off like a locust"* (Psalm 109:23). A shadow at the end of the day, stretching out and disappearing. A locust shaken off a sleeve, flicked away like nothing. That is how small and disposable he feels.

His body shows it too, plainly: *"My knees are weak through fasting. My body is thin and lacks fat"* (Psalm 109:24). He has stopped eating. He is wasting away. Grief has taken his appetite and his strength together. And people mock him: *"I have also become a reproach to them. When they see me, they shake their head"* (Psalm 109:25). Shaking their heads. At the cross, Matthew says, *"Those who passed by blasphemed him, wagging their heads"* (Matthew 27:39). The same gesture, the same contempt. Jesus lived this verse to the letter.

That is the hope of this psalm. David prayed for help from the bottom, and his prayer points forward to the Son of David who went even lower. Jesus was poor and needy, His heart wounded, faded like an evening shadow, mocked by the head-shakers. And He prayed for His enemies instead of cursing them. Because He went there, your wounded heart is not beyond His reach. Pray David's prayer today: deal with me, for Your name's sake, because Your loving kindness is good. He will, every time.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was poor and needy, His heart wounded, the crowds shaking their heads at the cross. The Father raised Him on the third day. Pray today: deal with me, for Your name's sake.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Will you ask God to deal with you for His name's sake?

◆

DAY 270 · SEPTEMBER 27 · PSALM 109 (VV. 26–31)

He Stands at the Right Hand of the Needy

> *"For he will stand at the right hand of the needy, to save him from those who judge his soul."*
> — PSALM 109:31

The end of Psalm 109 is a prayer of hope: *"Help me, Yahweh, my God. Save me according to your loving kindness; that they may know that this is your hand; that you, Yahweh, have done it"* (Psalm 109:26–27). David wants his rescue to be so clearly God's work that even his enemies see it. Not his own cleverness. Not his allies. God's hand. That is a good thing to pray — that God's help in your life would be unmistakable, so plain that no one could give the credit to anyone else.

Then a line that sums up the whole psalm: *"They may curse, but you bless"* (Psalm 109:28). Let them curse. God blesses. Their words cannot undo His. That is freeing, if you let it be. You do not have to control what others say about you. You cannot stop them from cursing. But their curses have no power against God's blessing. *"When they arise, they will be shamed, but your servant shall rejoice"* (Psalm 109:28).

"I will give great thanks to Yahweh with my mouth. Yes, I will praise him among the multitude" (Psalm 109:30). After all the darkness, praise. Out loud. In public. And the reason, the line that gives this day its name: *"For he will stand at the right hand of the needy, to save him from those who judge his soul"* (Psalm 109:31). Remember verse 6? The enemy wanted an accuser at David's right hand. Instead, God stands there. At the right hand of the needy. As defender, not accuser. The place the enemy wanted to fill with a prosecutor is filled by the Judge Himself, on David's side.

That is the gospel in one picture. In the courtroom of heaven, you might expect an accuser at your side. Instead, Christ stands there. Paul asks, *"Who is he who condemns? It is Christ who died, yes rather, who was raised from the dead, who is at the right hand of God, who also makes intercession for us"* (Romans 8:34). And Hebrews says, *"he lives forever to make intercession for them"* (Hebrews 7:25). When people judge your soul, when they curse, when they accuse, the LORD stands at your right hand. They may curse. He blesses.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ stands at your right hand as Defender, not accuser. He was condemned by false judges so that every accusation against you could be answered. He rose and lives to intercede for you. When people curse you today, remember: they may curse, but He blesses.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When others judge or curse you, do you remember the LORD stands at your right hand?

◆

DAY 271 · SEPTEMBER 28 · PSALM 110

Sit at My Right Hand

> *"Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool for your feet."*
> — PSALM 110:1

Psalm 110 is the psalm the New Testament quotes more than any other. It opens with a conversation in heaven: *"Yahweh says to my Lord, 'Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool for your feet'"* (Psalm 110:1). David hears the LORD speaking to someone David calls my Lord. Who could be David's Lord? David was the king. No one in Israel was above him. Except the One who would come from him and yet be greater than him.

Jesus asked the religious leaders that very question. Quoting this verse, He asked how the Messiah could be David's son if David calls Him Lord (Matthew 22:44–45). They had no answer. And on the day of Pentecost Peter preached: *"For David didn't ascend into the heavens, but he says himself, 'The Lord said to my Lord, "Sit by my right hand until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet"'"* (Acts 2:34–35). Peter said this was about Jesus, raised from the dead and seated at God's right hand.

Sit at My right hand. That is the place of honor, authority, and rest. The work is truly finished. The King sits down. And then: until I make your enemies your footstool. The enemies are not all defeated yet in the way you see them. But they will be. God Himself will put them under Christ's feet. *"Yahweh will send out the rod of your strength out of Zion. Rule among your enemies"* (Psalm 110:2). He rules even now, in the middle of His enemies.

Then a remarkable line about His people: *"Your people offer themselves willingly in the day of your power, in holy array"* (Psalm 110:3). Willingly. Not forced. Not dragged. They come gladly to serve the King. And then the line Hebrews builds a whole argument on: *"Yahweh has sworn, and will not change his mind: 'You are a priest forever in the order of Melchizedek'"* (Psalm 110:4). King and Priest. Ruler and Mediator. Hebrews says of Jesus, *"You are a priest forever, according to the order of Melchizedek"* (Hebrews 7:17). The One seated at God's right hand rules for you and prays for you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ died, rose, and sat down at the Father's right hand. His work of atonement is finished, and He reigns now as King and Priest forever. Every enemy will be put under His feet. Offer yourself to Him willingly today. The King on the throne is praying for you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you live as though Christ is seated at God's right hand — reigning and praying for you right now?

◆

DAY 272 · SEPTEMBER 29 · PSALM 111 (VV. 1–5)

Great Are the Works of the LORD

> *"Yahweh's works are great, pondered by all those who delight in them."*
> — PSALM 111:2

Psalm 111 is an acrostic in Hebrew — each line begins with the next letter of the alphabet, a careful and orderly song of praise. It begins with a resolution: *"Praise Yah! I will give thanks to Yahweh with my whole heart, in the council of the upright, and in the congregation"* (Psalm 111:1). With my whole heart. Not halfway. Not distracted. Not with one eye on the clock and the other on the phone. And in the congregation — among God's people, out loud, together.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Yahweh's works are great, pondered by all those who delight in them"* (Psalm 111:2). Pondered. Studied. Thought about. The people who delight in God's works do not just glance at them and move on. They study them. They look closer. They turn them over in their minds. That is what delight does. When you love something, you want to know everything about it. A man who loves old trucks can tell you every model year. A woman who loves her garden knows every plant by name. Love studies.

"His work is honor and majesty. His righteousness endures forever. He has caused his wonderful works to be remembered. Yahweh is gracious and merciful" (Psalm 111:3–4). Gracious and merciful. That is the character behind the works. God does not do great things to show off. He does them out of grace and mercy. And He makes sure they are remembered. Feasts, stories, songs, memorials — God built remembrance into the life of His people, because He knows how quickly they forget.

"He has given food to those who fear him. He always remembers his covenant" (Psalm 111:5). Food for those who fear Him. Manna in the wilderness. Bread on your table this morning. And behind it all, a covenant He always remembers. Revelation shows the redeemed singing about these works: *"Great and marvelous are your works, Lord God, the Almighty! Righteous and true are your ways, you King of the nations"* (Revelation 15:3). Take time today to ponder one of God's works. Not a quick glance. A long look. Study it, and let it lead you to praise with your whole heart.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The greatest of God's works is the cross and the empty tomb. Christ died for sinners and rose on the third day, and believers will spend eternity pondering it. Take time today to study that work. Look closer. Let it lead you to praise Him with your whole heart.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you ponder God's works with delight — or glance at them and move on?

◆

DAY 273 · SEPTEMBER 30 · PSALM 111 (VV. 6–10)

The Fear of the LORD Is the Beginning of Wisdom

"The fear of Yahweh is the beginning of wisdom."
— PSALM 111:10

The second half of Psalm 111 keeps listing God's works: *"He has shown his people the power of his works, in giving them the heritage of the nations. The works of his hands are truth and justice. All his precepts are sure"* (Psalm 111:6–7). Truth and justice. Sure precepts. Everything God does and says is reliable. *"They are established forever and ever. They are done in truth and uprightness"* (Psalm 111:8). Forever. You can build a life on that, and it will still be standing when everything else has fallen.

Then the center of the gospel in one line: *"He has sent redemption to his people. He has ordained his covenant forever. His name is holy and awesome!"* (Psalm 111:9). He has sent redemption. Redemption is a rescue that costs something — a price paid to set a captive free. God did not wait for His people to buy their own way out. He sent the redemption. And in the fullness of time, He sent His Son, the price and the Redeemer in one.

Then the verse that gives this day its name, the famous line: *"The fear of Yahweh is the beginning of wisdom. All those who do his work have a good understanding. His praise endures forever!"* (Psalm 111:10). The fear of the LORD. Not terror that runs away, but awe that draws near. The kind of reverence that takes God seriously, that knows He is holy and awesome, and bows. That is where wisdom starts. Not with intelligence. Not with education or experience. With fear of the LORD.

Proverbs says the same: *"The fear of Yahweh is the beginning of wisdom. The knowledge of the Holy One is understanding"* (Proverbs 9:10). And Paul says Christ is the one *"in whom all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge are hidden"* (Colossians 2:3). The fear of the LORD leads you to Christ, and in Christ you find all wisdom. If you want to be wise, start here. Bow before the holy and awesome God who sent redemption. Wisdom is not first a skill. It is a posture — a heart bowed in awe before the One who saved you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God sent redemption in Christ, who paid the price to set captives free on the cross and rose to give wisdom to all who fear Him. In Him are hidden all the treasures of wisdom. Begin there today. Bow before the holy and awesome God who redeemed you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is your pursuit of wisdom grounded in the fear of the LORD — awe before the God who redeemed you?

◆

DAY 274 · OCTOBER 1 · PSALM 112 (VV. 1–5)

Blessed Is the One Who Fears the LORD

“Blessed is the man who fears Yahweh”
— PSALM 112:1

Psalm 112 is a portrait of a blessed life, and it starts with the root of that blessing: *“Praise Yah! Blessed is the man who fears Yahweh, who delights greatly in his commandments”* (Psalm 112:1). Fears the LORD. Delights in His commandments. Those two belong together. The fear of the LORD is not cringing terror, the kind that makes you hide. It is deep reverence, and it does not make God’s commands feel like a burden. It makes them a delight. Psalm 111 ended with the fear of the LORD. Psalm 112 shows what that fear looks like in a life.

And the blessing spreads out from that root: *“His offspring will be mighty in the land. The generation of the upright will be blessed”* (Psalm 112:2). Children and grandchildren touched by one person’s faithfulness. *“Wealth and riches are in his house. His righteousness endures forever”* (Psalm 112:3). The psalm is not promising every believer a fortune. It is saying that the life rooted in God is rich, and that the righteousness in it outlasts any bank account.

Then a line of hope for hard times: *“Light dawns in the darkness for the upright, gracious, merciful, and righteous”* (Psalm 112:4). Light in the darkness. The God-fearer is not spared dark seasons. But light dawns in them. Notice also the words used to describe the upright: gracious, merciful, righteous. Those are words the previous psalm used to describe God (Psalm 111:4). The one who fears God begins to look like God. Reverence reshapes the worshiper. Over a lifetime, the person who bows before God picks up His ways.

“It is well with the man who deals graciously and lends. He will maintain his cause in judgment” (Psalm 112:5). Generous. Gracious with money. Willing to lend to people in need. Proverbs says, *“He who has pity on the poor lends to Yahweh; he will reward him”* (Proverbs 19:17). That is what reverence for God produces — not a tight fist, but an open hand. If you want to know whether you fear God, look at how you treat His commands and how you treat people in need. A heart bowed before God opens toward others.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the one who perfectly feared the Father and delighted in His commands. He was gracious, merciful, and righteous, and He gave everything for the poor in spirit. He died and rose so that His people could share His likeness. Ask Him today to make you gracious as He is.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Does your reverence for God show up in delight in His commands and generosity toward others?

◆

DAY 275 · OCTOBER 2 · PSALM 112 (VV. 6–10)

A Heart Firm, Trusting in the LORD

> *"He will not be afraid of evil news. His heart is steadfast, trusting in Yahweh."*
> — PSALM 112:7

Psalm 112 continues its portrait: *"For he will never be shaken. The righteous will be remembered forever"* (Psalm 112:6). Never shaken. That does not mean nothing bad ever happens. It means the foundation holds when the bad things come. And the righteous are remembered. Their lives leave a mark. The good they did does not disappear when they die. Long after the funeral, someone remembers a kindness, a prayer, a word of truth spoken at the right time.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"He will not be afraid of evil news. His heart is steadfast, trusting in Yahweh"* (Psalm 112:7). Evil news. The phone call in the night. The doctor's serious face. The text that begins, I am so sorry. Everyone gets bad news. The question is what happens in your heart when it comes. Some hearts collapse. Some go numb. Some panic and start grabbing for control. The one who fears God is not crushed by it. His heart is steadfast — fixed, anchored — because it is trusting in the LORD.

That is not a natural calm. Some people are just steady by temperament. But this steadiness comes from somewhere specific: trusting in Yahweh. The heart is firm because of what it is attached to. Isaiah says, *"You will keep whoever's mind is steadfast in perfect peace, because he trusts in you"* (Isaiah 26:3). And Jesus promised, *"Peace I leave with you. My peace I give to you; not as the world gives, I give to you. Don't let your heart be troubled, neither let it be fearful"* (John 14:27).

"His heart is established. He will not be afraid in the end when he sees his adversaries" (Psalm 112:8). Established. Settled. And the generous life continues: *"He has dispersed, he has given to the poor. His righteousness endures forever. His horn will be exalted with honor"* (Psalm 112:9). Paul quotes this verse when he urges believers to give (2 Corinthians 9:9). The wicked watch and grind their teeth: *"The desire of the wicked will perish"* (Psalm 112:10). If bad news has been shaking you, the answer is not to find a calmer personality. It is to fix your heart on the LORD.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ received the worst news anyone has ever carried — that He would be betrayed, condemned, and crucified — and His heart stayed fixed on the Father. He went to the cross and rose on the third day. Fix your heart on Him today. Bad news cannot shake what is anchored in Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When bad news comes, does your heart shake — or is it fixed, trusting in the LORD?

◆

DAY 276 · OCTOBER 3 · PSALM 113 (VV. 1–4)

From the Rising of the Sun

> *"From the rising of the sun to its going down, Yahweh's name is to be praised."*
> — PSALM 113:3

Psalm 113 begins a group of psalms that Jewish families have long sung at Passover. It opens with a call to praise: *"Praise Yah! Praise, you servants of Yahweh, praise Yahweh's name. Blessed be Yahweh's name, from this time forward and forever more"* (Psalm 113:1–2). Three times: praise. And forever. Not only today. From this time forward and forever more. The praise of God never ends.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"From the rising of the sun to its going down, Yahweh's name is to be praised"* (Psalm 113:3). From sunrise to sunset. That can mean all day long, every hour. It can also mean from the eastern horizon to the western one — every place on earth. Both are true. God's name deserves praise at every time and in every place. Malachi said, *"from the rising of the sun even to its going down, my name is great among the nations"* (Malachi 1:11).

Think about what that means for your day. When you wake up and see the light coming through the window, the LORD is to be praised. When you drive to work, when you eat lunch, when you come home tired, when the sun goes down behind the trees — all of it is time for praise. Not that you must be singing every minute. But that every part of the day belongs to Him and can be offered to Him. Paul says, *"Whether therefore you eat, or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God"* (1 Corinthians 10:31).

And then the reason: *"Yahweh is high above all nations, his glory above the heavens"* (Psalm 113:4). High above. Higher than any nation. Higher than the sky itself. His glory reaches beyond anything you can see. That is why the praise never stops — there is always more of Him to praise. Revelation shows every created thing joining in: *"To him who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb be the blessing, the honor, the glory, and the dominion, forever and ever!"* (Revelation 5:13). Start today with praise at sunrise. End it with praise at sundown. Fill the hours between with the same.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ rose at sunrise on the first day of the week, and every sunrise since has been a reminder of His victory over death. His name deserves praise from the rising of the sun to its going down. Begin today with praise. End it the same way. Fill the hours between with Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Does your praise of God fill your whole day — or only a few minutes of it?

◆

DAY 277 · OCTOBER 4 · PSALM 113 (VV. 5–9)

He Raises the Poor from the Dust

"He raises up the poor out of the dust."
— PSALM 113:7

Psalm 113 asks a question that has only one answer: *"Who is like Yahweh, our God, who has his seat on high, who stoops down to see in heaven and in the earth?"* (Psalm 113:5–6). He sits on high. And He stoops down. The God who is higher than the heavens has to bend down even to look at the sky. That is how far above everything He is. And yet He bends down. He looks. He pays attention to the earth below.

Then the line that could be the motto of this whole year: *"He raises up the poor out of the dust. Lifts up the needy from the ash heap"* (Psalm 113:7). Out of the dust. That is where the poor sit — in the dust, on the ash heap, at the bottom of everything. And that is exactly where God goes. He does not wait for them to climb up to Him. He stoops all the way down and lifts them. Hannah sang almost the same words: *"He raises up the poor out of the dust. He lifts up the needy from the dunghill"* (1 Samuel 2:8).

And He does not just lift them out of the dust. He seats them in honor: *"that he may set him with princes, even with the princes of his people"* (Psalm 113:8). From the ash heap to the royal table. From nobody to a seat with princes. That is the gospel. Paul says God *"raised us up with him, and made us to sit with him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus"* (Ephesians 2:6). Dust, lifted and seated with the King.

Then a tender picture to close: *"He settles the barren woman in her home as a joyful mother of children. Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 113:9). The woman with empty arms, given a full house. God reverses the deepest griefs. The greatest picture of His stooping is Christ Himself, who *"emptied himself, taking the form of a servant"* (Philippians 2:7), and *"humbled himself, becoming obedient to the point of death, yes, the death of the cross"* (Philippians 2:8). God stooped all the way into the dust of death to lift you out. Whatever ash heap you are sitting on today, He sees you. He stoops. He lifts.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God stooped lower than anyone could imagine when Christ came down from heaven, took on dust, and went into the grave. On the third day He was raised up, and now He lifts the poor out of the dust to sit with princes. Whatever ash heap you are on today, He sees you. He lifts.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe the God who sits on high stoops all the way down to lift you from your dust?

◆

DAY 278 · OCTOBER 5 · PSALM 114

Tremble, O Earth, at the Presence of the Lord

"Tremble, you earth, at the presence of the Lord"
— PSALM 114:7

Psalm 114 is a short, vivid poem about the exodus. It begins: *"When Israel went out of Egypt, the house of Jacob from a people of foreign language, Judah became his sanctuary, Israel his dominion"* (Psalm 114:1–2). When God brought His people out of Egypt, they became His dwelling place. Not just a nation God rescued. A people God lived among. The whole nation became His holy place. God did not just set up a building. He made a people His home.

Then creation reacts: *"The sea saw it, and fled. The Jordan was driven back"* (Psalm 114:3). The Red Sea at the start of the road. The Jordan River at the end of it. Both parted, on command. The psalm pictures them like animals seeing something terrifying and running away. *"The mountains skipped like rams, the little hills like lambs"* (Psalm 114:4). Sinai shook when God came down, and the people at its foot trembled with it. The mountains jumped like young sheep in a field.

Then the poet asks them why: *"What was it, you sea, that you fled? You Jordan, that you turned back? You mountains, that you skipped like rams; you little hills, like lambs?"* (Psalm 114:5–6). It is almost playful. What happened to you? Why did you run? And the answer comes in the line that gives this day its name: *"Tremble, you earth, at the presence of the Lord, at the presence of the God of Jacob"* (Psalm 114:7). The presence of God. That is what made the sea run and the mountains skip.

And look at what this terrifying presence does: *"who turned the rock into a pool of water, the flint into a spring of waters"* (Psalm 114:8). The same God who makes mountains tremble makes water come out of rock for thirsty people. His power is fearsome, and it is aimed at blessing His people. Paul says that rock was Christ (1 Corinthians 10:4). And Jesus stood up and said, *"If anyone is thirsty, let him come to me and drink!"* (John 7:37). The God whose presence shakes the earth wants to give you water. Tremble, and then come and drink.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

At the cross the earth shook and the rocks split in the presence of God. Christ, the Rock who was struck, poured out living water for thirsty people, and on the third day the earth shook again as He rose. Tremble at His presence today. Then come to Him and drink.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Does God's presence move you to trembling awe — and to come to Him and drink?

◆

DAY 279 · OCTOBER 6 · PSALM 115 (VV. 1–6)

Not to Us, O LORD

> *"Not to us, Yahweh, not to us, but to your name give glory, for your loving kindness, and for your truth's sake."*
> — PSALM 115:1

Psalm 115 opens with a prayer that cuts against human pride: *"Not to us, Yahweh, not to us, but to your name give glory, for your loving kindness, and for your truth's sake"* (Psalm 115:1). The phrase comes twice. Whatever good has happened, whatever victory has come, do not give God's people the credit. Give it to His name. That is a hard prayer for a proud heart, and a necessary one. Most people want at least a little of the glory.

Then the nations mock: *"Why should the nations say, 'Where is their God, now?'"* (Psalm 115:2). Where is your God? He is invisible. You cannot point to Him. The other nations had idols you could see and touch. Israel's God had no statue. And the answer is bold: *"But our God is in the heavens. He does whatever he pleases"* (Psalm 115:3). He is in the heavens. You cannot see Him, but He is not absent. He does whatever He pleases. He is not stuck on a shelf.

Then the psalm turns to the idols the nations trust: *"Their idols are silver and gold, the work of men's hands. They have mouths, but they don't speak. They have eyes, but they don't see. They have ears, but they don't hear. They have noses, but they don't smell"* (Psalm 115:4–6). Silver and gold. Expensive. Impressive. And completely useless. They look like they could do something, but they cannot. Isaiah mocked the same idols: *"Who has fashioned a god, or molds an image that is profitable for nothing?"* (Isaiah 44:10).

That repeated not is the prayer that guards you from making yourself an idol. Pride is a kind of idolatry — putting yourself where only God belongs. When things go well, it is easy to take the credit. When you are praised, it is easy to keep it. Psalm 115 teaches you to hand it all back. The glory belongs to His name, because of His loving kindness and His truth. Revelation says, *"Worthy are you, our Lord and God, the Holy One, to receive the glory"* (Revelation 4:11). Today, when something good happens, say it: not to me, LORD. To Your name.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did not seek His own glory. He humbled Himself to the cross and gave all the glory to the Father. Then the Father raised Him and glorified Him above every name. Hand back every bit of credit today, and give the glory to His name.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you quietly keeping glory that belongs to God's name?

◆

DAY 280 · OCTOBER 7 · PSALM 115 (VV. 7–12)

Those Who Make Them Become Like Them

> *"Those who make them will be like them; yes, everyone who trusts in them."*
> — PSALM 115:8

Psalm 115 continues its description of the idols: *"They have hands, but they don't feel. They have feet, but they don't walk, neither do they speak through their throat"* (Psalm 115:7). Hands that cannot touch. Feet that cannot walk. Throats that cannot make a sound. Every part of a body, and none of it works. That is an idol. It has the shape of life and none of the reality. Like a mannequin in a shop window, dressed well and completely empty.

Then the warning that gives this day its name: *"Those who make them will be like them; yes, everyone who trusts in them"* (Psalm 115:8). You become like what you worship. Trust a dead idol, and you start to die on the inside. Eyes that do not see. Ears that do not hear. A heart that does not feel. That is not just a curse. It is how worship works. Whatever you give your heart to shapes your heart. You are formed by what you love most. Over years, the face of the worshiper takes on the look of the thing worshiped.

That is true today. If you worship money, you become cold and grasping. If you worship comfort, you become soft and selfish. If you worship approval, you become anxious and fake. If you worship power, you become hard. Idols do not stay outside you. They get in and remake you in their image. John ends his first letter with a simple warning: *"Little children, keep yourselves from idols"* (1 John 5:21).

But the same principle works for good. If you worship the living God, you become more alive. Paul says, *"But we all, with unveiled face seeing the glory of the Lord as in a mirror, are transformed into the same image from glory to glory"* (2 Corinthians 3:18). You become like what you behold. So the psalm calls everyone back to the true God: *"Israel, trust in Yahweh! He is their help and their shield. House of Aaron, trust in Yahweh! He is their help and their shield"* (Psalm 115:9–10). Look at Him. Trust Him. And you will begin to look like Him — slowly, over years, in ways you may not notice but others will.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the image of the invisible God. When you look at Him, you are changed into His likeness, from glory to glory. He died and rose so that dead hearts could become alive again. Turn your eyes from the idols today and fix them on Him. You become like what you behold.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What are you worshiping — and what is it making you into?

◆

DAY 281 · OCTOBER 8 · PSALM 115 (VV. 13–18)

We Will Bless the LORD

> *"but we will bless Yah, from this time forward and forever more. Praise Yah!"*
>
> — PSALM 115:18

Psalm 115 ends with a blessing poured out on God's people: *"Yahweh remembers us. He will bless us. He will bless the house of Israel. He will bless the house of Aaron. He will bless those who fear Yahweh, both small and great"* (Psalm 115:12–13). He remembers. He blesses. Five times the word bless appears in two verses. And notice who is included: small and great. Not only the important people. Everyone who fears Him, whether they are a child or an old saint, a nobody or a leader.

"May Yahweh increase you more and more, you and your children. Blessed are you by Yahweh, who made heaven and earth" (Psalm 115:14–15). Increase. Multiplication. Blessing that keeps growing and reaches the next generation. And the source of it is the Maker of heaven and earth. The idols could do nothing. The living God makes everything and blesses His people from His abundance. He never runs low.

Then a line about where people live: *"The heavens are Yahweh's heavens, but he has given the earth to the children of men"* (Psalm 115:16). God gave the earth to people as a gift and a responsibility. And then a sobering line: *"The dead don't praise Yah, neither any who go down into silence"* (Psalm 115:17). The dead are silent. Their chance to praise on earth is over. That makes the living moment precious. You have breath today. Use it. The chance to praise God in this life, on this earth, among these people, will not last forever.

And so the psalm ends with a vow: *"but we will bless Yah, from this time forward and forever more. Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 115:18). From this time forward. Not someday. Starting now. And forever more. The psalmist does not know yet what Christ would reveal — that even the grave would not stop the praise of God's people. Jesus said, *"I am the resurrection and the life. He who believes in me will still live, even if he dies"* (John 11:25). The dead in Christ are not silent forever. They will rise singing. But today, while you have breath, bless the LORD. Start now, and never stop.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went down into the silence of death and came out singing on the third day. Because He lives, the praise of His people will never be silenced, not even by the grave. You have breath today. Bless the LORD with it, from this time forward and forever more.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

You have breath today. Are you using it to bless the LORD?

◆

DAY 282 · OCTOBER 9 · PSALM 116 (VV. 1–6)

I Love the LORD, Because He Has Heard

> *"I love Yahweh, because he listens to my voice, and my cries for mercy."*
> — PSALM 116:1

Psalm 116 begins with one of the simplest confessions of love in the Bible: *"I love Yahweh, because he listens to my voice, and my cries for mercy"* (Psalm 116:1). Not because He gave me everything I wanted. Not because life was easy. Because He listened. When the psalmist cried out, God heard. And that hearing turned into love. Love for God often starts right there — in the memory of being heard. Not in a theory about God, but in a night when you cried out and something answered. A friend who called at the right moment. A peace that came when nothing else changed. A door that opened when every other one was shut.

"Because he has turned his ear to me, therefore I will call on him as long as I live" (Psalm 116:2). Turned His ear. The picture is God leaning down, bending close, the way a parent leans over to hear a whispering child. And because God leans in, the psalmist decides to keep calling for the rest of his life. One answered prayer becomes a lifelong habit of prayer, the way one good meal at a diner turns into years of breakfasts at the same booth.

Then he tells what he was saved from: *"The cords of death surrounded me, the pains of Sheol got a hold of me. I found trouble and sorrow"* (Psalm 116:3). Death had him wrapped up like rope. The grave had its hands on him. That is not mild trouble. That is the edge of the end. *"Then I called on Yahweh's name: 'Yahweh, I beg you, deliver my soul'"* (Psalm 116:4). A short, desperate prayer. I beg You. Save me.

And God did: *"Yahweh is Gracious and righteous. Yes, our God is merciful. Yahweh preserves the simple. I was brought low, and he saved me"* (Psalm 116:5–6). Brought low, and saved. The simple — the ordinary people with no special wisdom or strength — God preserves them. Jonah prayed from the belly of the fish: *"I called because of my affliction to Yahweh. He answered me. Out of the belly of Sheol I cried. You heard my voice"* (Jonah 2:2). John says, *"We love him, because he first loved us"* (1 John 4:19). If you have ever been heard by God, let that memory turn into love today.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The cords of death wrapped around Christ, and the pains of Sheol took hold of Him on the cross. He cried out, and the Father heard and raised Him on the third day. Because God heard His Son, He hears you. Let the memory of being heard grow into love for Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you trace your love for God back to the times He heard your cry?

◆

DAY 283 · OCTOBER 10 · PSALM 116 (VV. 7–13)

Return, O My Soul, to Your Rest

> *"Return to your rest, my soul, for Yahweh has dealt bountifully with you."*
> — PSALM 116:7

After the rescue, the psalmist speaks to his own soul: *"Return to your rest, my soul, for Yahweh has dealt bountifully with you"* (Psalm 116:7). Return to your rest. The soul had been running, panicking, wrapped in the cords of death. Now it is time to come home and settle down. Not because the psalmist has worked out all his problems first. Because God has dealt bountifully. The rest is based on what God has done.

That is a word many people need. The soul gets used to being on alert. Even after the crisis passes, it keeps scanning for the next threat. The body relaxes, but the heart does not. It stays tense for weeks. And you have to tell your soul, the way the psalmist did: come back. Rest. God has been good to you. Jesus said, *"Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest"* (Matthew 11:28). Hebrews says, *"There remains therefore a Sabbath rest for the people of God"* (Hebrews 4:9).

Then the psalmist counts what God did: *"For you have delivered my soul from death, my eyes from tears, and my feet from falling"* (Psalm 116:8). Soul from death. Eyes from tears. Feet from falling. Three rescues — life, sorrow, and stumbling. *"I will walk before Yahweh in the land of the living"* (Psalm 116:9). Still alive. Still walking. In the presence of God, in the land of the living. That is what grace looks like on an ordinary Tuesday.

Then a question: *"What will I give to Yahweh for all his benefits toward me?"* (Psalm 116:12). How can I repay Him? And the answer is surprising: *"I will take the cup of salvation, and call on Yahweh's name"* (Psalm 116:13). Not give more. Take more. Lift the cup God offers and drink it. The way to respond to God's goodness is to receive more of it. On the night He was betrayed, Jesus took a cup and said, *"This cup is the new covenant in my blood, which is poured out for you"* (Luke 22:20). Take the cup of salvation today. Then let your soul return to its rest.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ drank the cup of wrath so that you could lift the cup of salvation. He poured out His blood for you on the cross and rose to give you rest. You cannot repay Him. You can only receive. Take the cup today. Then tell your soul to return to its rest.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is your soul still on alert after the danger has passed — and will you tell it to return to its rest?

◆

DAY 284 · OCTOBER 11 · PSALM 116 (VV. 14–19)

Precious in the Sight of the LORD

"Precious in Yahweh's sight is the death of his saints."
— PSALM 116:15

Psalm 116 continues with a vow: *"I will pay my vows to Yahweh, yes, in the presence of all his people"* (Psalm 116:14). In public. In front of everyone. The psalmist made promises to God when he was in trouble, and now that God has rescued him, he will keep them where others can see. That is integrity, and it is rarer than it should be. Many people make promises to God in a crisis and forget them as soon as it passes. This one remembers.

Then one of the most comforting lines in the Psalms: *"Precious in Yahweh's sight is the death of his saints"* (Psalm 116:15). Precious. Valuable. Not cheap, not forgotten, not lost in the crowd. When one of God's people dies, God notices. It matters to Him. He does not shrug at a believer's death. He does not file it away. He treasures it, the way you would treasure the last moments with someone you love.

That changes how you think about death. For many people death feels like the end of everything — loss, darkness, being forgotten. For the believer, death is precious to God. It is the moment He welcomes His child home. Paul said, *"For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain"* (Philippians 1:21). And, *"We are courageous, I say, and are willing rather to be absent from the body and to be at home with the Lord"* (2 Corinthians 5:8). At home with the Lord. That is what death is for someone who belongs to Him.

Then the psalmist declares who he is: *"Yahweh, truly I am your servant. I am your servant, the son of your servant girl. You have freed me from my chains"* (Psalm 116:16). A servant whose chains God broke. Freed to serve. *"I will offer to you the sacrifice of thanksgiving, and will call on Yahweh's name"* (Psalm 116:17). The psalm ends in the courts of the temple, surrounded by God's people: *"in the courts of Yahweh's house, in the middle of you, Jerusalem. Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 116:19). If you have lost someone who loved God, their death was precious in His sight. And when your time comes, yours will be too.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's own death was the most precious in the sight of God — the death that purchased the lives of all His saints. He rose, so that death for His people is now a homecoming. If you have lost someone who belonged to Him, their death was precious to God. So will yours be.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have you thought of a believer's death as precious to God — including your own one day?

◆

DAY 285 · OCTOBER 12 · PSALM 117

Praise the LORD, All Nations

"For his loving kindness is great toward us."
— PSALM 117:2

Psalm 117 is the shortest chapter in the Bible. Just two verses. And yet it reaches further than almost any other psalm: *"Praise Yahweh, all you nations! Extol him, all you peoples!"* (Psalm 117:1). All the nations. All the peoples. Not just Israel. Every tribe and tongue and land on the earth. In a tiny psalm, the whole world is invited to worship the God of Israel. It is like a small window that looks out on an enormous view. The God who chose one family, Abraham's, always had every family on earth in mind.

Paul quotes this verse in Romans to show that God always intended to save the Gentiles: *"Again, 'Praise the Lord, all you Gentiles! Let all the peoples praise him'"* (Romans 15:11). The gospel going to the nations was not a new idea in the New Testament. It was right here, in two short verses, centuries before Christ. God's heart has always been for the whole world.

Then the reason the nations should praise: *"For his loving kindness is great toward us. Yahweh's faithfulness endures forever. Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 117:2). His loving kindness is great toward His people. The word great here has the sense of something that overpowers, that prevails, that wins. God's love is stronger than whatever stands against it. And His faithfulness endures forever. It does not wear out, run out, or give up. Human faithfulness has limits. Even the best friend, the most loyal spouse, eventually fails in some way. God's faithfulness has no limit at all.

Two verses. Two reasons. Loving kindness and faithfulness. That is the whole gospel in miniature. God loves with a love that prevails, and He keeps His word forever. That is why every nation should praise Him. And that is why you can too, wherever you come from. You may feel like an outsider to faith — the wrong background, the wrong family, the wrong history. Psalm 117 says all the nations are invited. Revelation shows the result: a multitude *"out of every nation and of all tribes, peoples, and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb"* (Revelation 7:9). There is room for you there.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's loving kindness prevailed over sin and death at the cross, and His faithfulness held when He rose on the third day. He died for people from every nation. Whatever your background, you are invited. Praise Him today with all the peoples of the earth.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you see yourself as invited into the praise of God, whatever your background?

◆

DAY 286 · OCTOBER 13 · PSALM 118 (VV. 1–7)

The LORD Is on My Side

"Yahweh is on my side. I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?"
— PSALM 118:6

Psalm 118 is the last of the Passover psalms, and it may be the one the Gospels have in mind when they say Jesus and His disciples sang a hymn before going out to the Mount of Olives (Matthew 26:30). It opens with a refrain: *"Give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 118:1). Then it calls three groups to say it: Israel, the priests, and everyone who fears the LORD (Psalm 118:2–4).

Then a personal story: *"Out of my distress, I called on Yah. Yah answered me with freedom"* (Psalm 118:5). Distress means a narrow place, a squeeze. And God answered by setting him in a wide, open space. Freedom. Room to breathe. That is how God often answers — not just by removing the pressure but by giving you a larger place to stand.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Yahweh is on my side. I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?"* (Psalm 118:6). On my side. God is not neutral. He is not watching from a distance to see who wins. He is on the side of His people. And if He is on your side, what can anyone else do? People can do a great deal — they can lie, cheat, harm, even kill. But they cannot defeat the God who stands with you. Hebrews quotes this verse: *"The Lord is my helper. I will not fear. What can man do to me?"* (Hebrews 13:6).

"Yahweh is on my side among those who help me. Therefore I will look in triumph at those who hate me" (Psalm 118:7). The psalmist expects to see God's victory. Paul draws the same conclusion: *"If God is for us, who can be against us? He who didn't spare his own Son, but delivered him up for us all, how would he not also with him freely give us all things?"* (Romans 8:31–32). The proof that God is on your side is the cross. He gave His own Son for you. You do not need to wonder whose side He is on. Stop being afraid of what people can do. The LORD is on your side.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ sang this psalm, perhaps, on the night He was betrayed, and walked into the garden knowing what people would do to Him. They did their worst. The Father was on His side and raised Him on the third day. God gave His Son for you. He is on your side. Do not be afraid.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What are you afraid people might do to you — and do you believe the LORD is on your side?

◆

DAY 287 · OCTOBER 14 · PSALM 118 (VV. 8–14)

Better to Take Refuge in the LORD

"It is better to take refuge in Yahweh, than to put confidence in man."
— PSALM 118:8

Psalm 118 says the same thing twice, in two short lines: *"It is better to take refuge in Yahweh, than to put confidence in man. It is better to take refuge in Yahweh, than to put confidence in princes"* (Psalm 118:8–9). Better. Not just a little better. Far better. People will fail you. Princes will fail you. The LORD will not. That is a lesson most people learn the hard way, often more than once.

You have probably trusted someone who let you down. A friend who did not show up. A boss who made promises and broke them. A politician who said one thing and did another. A family member who was not there when you needed them. None of that is surprising. People are dust, like you. They mean well and fall short. They promise and forget. Jeremiah says, *"Cursed is the man who trusts in man, relies on strength of flesh, and whose heart departs from Yahweh"* (Jeremiah 17:5). And then: *"Blessed is the man who trusts in Yahweh, and whose confidence is in Yahweh"* (Jeremiah 17:7).

Then the psalmist describes being surrounded: *"All the nations surrounded me, but in Yahweh's name, I cut them off. They surrounded me, yes, they surrounded me. In Yahweh's name I indeed cut them off. They surrounded me like bees. They are quenched like the burning thorns"* (Psalm 118:10–12). Surrounded like a swarm of bees. Everywhere he turns, enemies. And each time, the same answer: in the LORD's name. Not in his own strength. In the name of the LORD.

"You pushed me back hard, to make me fall, but Yahweh helped me. Yah is my strength and song. He has become my salvation" (Psalm 118:13–14). Pushed hard, almost fell, and God helped. Then a line that echoes the song Moses sang at the Red Sea: my strength and song, my salvation. God is not only the One who saves. He becomes the song you sing about being saved. Take refuge in Him today, not in people. People are a gift, but they are not a refuge. Only He is. Love them, lean on them a little, but rest your full weight on Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was surrounded on every side — by guards, rulers, crowds, and the powers of darkness. His friends failed Him. He took refuge in the Father, and the Father raised Him on the third day. People will fail you. He will not. Make Him your refuge today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where have you been putting your confidence in people instead of taking refuge in the LORD?

◆

DAY 288 · OCTOBER 15 · PSALM 118 (VV. 15–22)

The Stone the Builders Rejected

"The stone which the builders rejected has become the cornerstone."
— PSALM 118:22

Psalm 118 now sounds like a victory celebration: *"The voice of rejoicing and salvation is in the tents of the righteous. 'The right hand of Yahweh does valiantly. The right hand of Yahweh is exalted! The right hand of Yahweh does valiantly!'"* (Psalm 118:15–16). Three times, the right hand of the LORD. His strong hand has won the day. And the psalmist declares: *"I will not die, but live, and declare Yah's works"* (Psalm 118:17).

"Yah has punished me severely, but he has not given me over to death" (Psalm 118:18). Disciplined hard, but not destroyed. Corrected, not abandoned. Then the gates: *"Open to me the gates of righteousness. I will enter into them. I will give thanks to Yah. This is the gate of Yahweh; the righteous will enter into it"* (Psalm 118:19–20). The psalmist approaches the temple gates and asks to be let in. And then thanks God: *"I will give thanks to you, for you have answered me, and have become my salvation"* (Psalm 118:21).

Then the line that the New Testament quotes again and again: *"The stone which the builders rejected has become the cornerstone"* (Psalm 118:22). A stone the builders looked at and tossed aside. Not good enough. Wrong shape. Too rough. And that very stone ended up as the cornerstone — the most important stone in the whole building, the one everything else lines up on. Jesus quoted this verse about Himself: *"Did you never read in the Scriptures, 'The stone which the builders rejected was made the head of the corner'?"* (Matthew 21:42).

Peter preached it before the council that crucified Jesus: *"He is 'the stone which was regarded as worthless by you, the builders, which has become the head of the corner.' There is salvation in no one else"* (Acts 4:11–12). The rejected stone is Christ. The leaders of Israel threw Him out, nailed Him to a cross, sealed Him in a tomb. And God raised Him and made Him the cornerstone of a new temple, built out of living stones. If you have ever been rejected, look at Him. The stone the builders threw away is the one God built everything on.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the stone the builders rejected. They threw Him out of the city and nailed Him to a cross. On the third day God raised Him and made Him the cornerstone. If you have been rejected, you are standing where He stood. Build your life on Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is Christ the cornerstone of your life — or one stone among many?

◆

DAY 289 · OCTOBER 16 · PSALM 118 (VV. 23–29)

This Is the Day the LORD Has Made

"This is the day that Yahweh has made. We will rejoice and be glad in it!"
— PSALM 118:24

After the rejected stone becomes the cornerstone, the psalm marvels: *"This is Yahweh's doing. It is marvelous in our eyes"* (Psalm 118:23). The LORD did this. No human could have planned it or pulled it off. Rejected and then exalted. Thrown away and then made the center. It is marvelous, beyond anything human hands could arrange. Then the line that people quote on ordinary mornings everywhere: *"This is the day that Yahweh has made. We will rejoice and be glad in it!"* (Psalm 118:24).

In its setting, that day is a specific day. The day the rejected stone became the cornerstone. The day of God's great reversal. And for Christians, that points straight to the resurrection. The day Christ rose is the day the LORD made, the day of all days. Every Sunday since has been a small echo of it. So when you say this verse, you are not only saying, today is a nice day. You are saying, God has acted, and this day belongs to His victory.

Then a cry that the crowds shouted when Jesus rode into Jerusalem: *"Save us now, we beg you, Yahweh! Yahweh, we beg you, send prosperity now. Blessed is he who comes in Yahweh's name!"* (Psalm 118:25–26). That cry, save now, is the Hebrew word behind Hosanna. Matthew records the crowd: *"Hosanna to the son of David! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord! Hosanna in the highest!"* (Matthew 21:9). They sang Psalm 118 as Jesus came. Days later, the same city rejected the stone.

"Yahweh is God, and he has given us light. Bind the sacrifice with cords, even to the horns of the altar" (Psalm 118:27). Bind the sacrifice. The psalm that sings of the coming King also speaks of a sacrifice bound to the altar. Jesus was both — the King who came in the name of the LORD and the sacrifice bound to the cross. And the psalm ends where it began: *"Oh give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 118:29). Today is a day the LORD has made. Whatever it holds, rejoice in Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The day the LORD made is the day Christ rose from the dead — the rejected stone made the cornerstone, the bound sacrifice raised to life. Every day since belongs to that victory. Whatever today holds, it is a day the LORD has made. Rejoice and be glad in Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Can you rejoice in today — not because of what it holds, but because it belongs to the risen Christ?

◆

DAY 290 · OCTOBER 17 · PSALM 119 (VV. 1–8)

Blessed Are Those Whose Way Is Blameless

> *"Blessed are those whose ways are blameless, who walk according to Yahweh's law."*
> — PSALM 119:1

Psalm 119 is the longest chapter in the Bible — 176 verses. It is built in twenty-two sections of eight verses each, one for every letter of the Hebrew alphabet, and every verse in a section begins with that letter. It is a careful, deliberate love song about God's word. And it opens with a blessing: *"Blessed are those whose ways are blameless, who walk according to Yahweh's law"* (Psalm 119:1). Blessed. The same word that opened the whole book in Psalm 1.

"Blessed are those who keep his statutes, who seek him with their whole heart" (Psalm 119:2). Notice that. Keeping God's word and seeking God Himself are not two different things. The psalm is not about rule-keeping for its own sake. It is about seeking a Person with your whole heart, and His word is how you find Him. Every one of the many words for God's word in this psalm — law, statutes, precepts, commandments, ordinances — points back to Him.

Then the psalmist admits he is not there yet: *"Oh that my ways were steadfast to obey your statutes!"* (Psalm 119:5). Oh that. A longing. He wants to be faithful, and he knows he is not fully. That honesty runs through the whole psalm. It is not written by someone who has mastered obedience. It is written by someone who loves God's word and keeps falling short of it. *"Then I wouldn't be disappointed, when I consider all of your commandments"* (Psalm 119:6).

And the first stanza ends with a plea: *"I will observe your statutes. Don't utterly forsake me"* (Psalm 119:8). I will try. Do not leave me. That is where Psalm 119 starts, and it is a good place for you to start too. Not with a claim to be blameless, but with a desire to be, and a prayer that God will not leave you while you learn. Psalm 1 said the blessed one meditates on God's law *"day and night"* (Psalm 1:2). Joshua was told to keep the book of the law in his mouth and *"meditate on it day and night"* (Joshua 1:8). The next 176 verses will show you what that looks like.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the only one whose way was truly blameless, who walked in the law of the LORD perfectly from birth to the cross. He kept every word for you and died for every word you broke. He rose to give you His righteousness. Seek Him with your whole heart today. He will not forsake you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you seek God through His word — or treat His word as a rulebook separate from Him?

◆

DAY 291 · OCTOBER 18 · PSALM 119 (VV. 9–16)

I Have Stored Up Your Word in My Heart

> *"I have hidden your word in my heart, that I might not sin against you."*
> — PSALM 119:11

The second stanza of Psalm 119 asks a practical question: *"How can a young man keep his way pure? By living according to your word"* (Psalm 119:9). The question is about youth, but the answer is for everyone. How do you keep your life clean in a dirty world? Not by willpower alone, which fails. Not by avoiding every temptation. By living according to God's word. The word is the guard, standing at the door of the heart.

"With my whole heart, I have sought you. Don't let me wander from your commandments" (Psalm 119:10). Whole heart, and still a prayer not to wander. The psalmist knows that even a sincere heart can drift. Then the verse that gives this day its name: *"I have hidden your word in my heart, that I might not sin against you"* (Psalm 119:11). Hidden. Stored up deep. Tucked away deep inside, like treasure in a vault. Not just read, but kept. Not skimmed on a busy morning and forgotten by lunch, but carried.

When temptation comes, you will not have time to look things up. You will only have what is already in you. That is why the psalmist hides the word in his heart. Jesus showed this in the wilderness. Every time Satan tempted Him, He answered with Scripture from memory: *"It is written, 'Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceeds out of God's mouth'"* (Matthew 4:4). The word in His heart was His defense.

Then the stanza fills with delight: *"With my lips, I have declared all the ordinances of your mouth. I have rejoiced in the way of your testimonies, as much as in all riches"* (Psalm 119:13–14). As much as in all riches. That is how much he values it. *"I will meditate on your precepts, and consider your ways. I will delight myself in your statutes. I will not forget your word"* (Psalm 119:15–16). Meditate. Consider. Delight. Do not forget. Paul says, *"Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly"* (Colossians 3:16). Hide one verse in your heart today. Carry it with you. It will be there when you need it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Word made flesh, and He had the Father's word hidden in His heart so deeply that He answered every temptation with it. He did not sin. He died for those who do and rose to write His word on their hearts. Hide one verse in your heart today. Let it guard you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What word of God have you hidden in your heart — ready for the moment temptation comes?

◆

DAY 292 · OCTOBER 19 · PSALM 119 (VV. 17–24)

Open My Eyes

"Open my eyes, that I may see wondrous things out of your law."
— PSALM 119:18

The third stanza of Psalm 119 begins with a request for life: *"Do good to your servant. I will live and I will obey your word"* (Psalm 119:17). Keep me alive, and I will keep Your word. Then a prayer that every reader of Scripture needs to pray: *"Open my eyes, that I may see wondrous things out of your law"* (Psalm 119:18). Open my eyes. The psalmist knows that reading is not the same as seeing.

You can read the Bible for years and miss what is there. The words pass in front of your eyes and nothing lands. Or you can read the same passage you have read a hundred times and suddenly see something new — a phrase that shines, a truth that grips you, a word that speaks straight into your life. The difference is not your intelligence. It is whether God opens your eyes. That is why you pray before you read. Reading without prayer is like opening a window at night and expecting to see the view.

Jesus did this for His disciples after the resurrection: *"Then he opened their minds, that they might understand the Scriptures"* (Luke 24:45). They had heard Him teach for three years. They had read the prophets all their lives. And still they needed Him to open their minds. Paul prayed for the Ephesians: *"having the eyes of your hearts enlightened, that you may know what is the hope of his calling"* (Ephesians 1:18). Eyes of the heart. Seeing with more than your eyes, the way faith sees what sight cannot.

Then the psalmist describes himself: *"I am a stranger on the earth. Don't hide your commandments from me"* (Psalm 119:19). A stranger. Just passing through. And because he is a stranger here, he needs God's word like a traveler needs a map. *"My soul is consumed with longing for your ordinances at all times"* (Psalm 119:20). Consumed with longing. And the stanza ends: *"Indeed your statutes are my delight, and my counselors"* (Psalm 119:24). The word becomes his advisers. Before you open your Bible today, pray this verse. Open my eyes. Then read, and expect to see wondrous things.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ opened the minds of His disciples to understand the Scriptures and showed them that every page pointed to Him — His suffering, His death, His resurrection on the third day. Ask Him today to open your eyes before you read. He will show you wondrous things, and He will show you Himself.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you pray for God to open your eyes before you read His word?

◆

DAY 293 · OCTOBER 20 · PSALM 119 (VV. 25–32)

My Soul Clings to the Dust

> *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word."*
> — PSALM 119:25 (NKJV)

This is the verse that gives this whole year its name. Psalm 119:25 prays, *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). The WEB renders it, *"My soul is laid low in the dust. Revive me according to your word!"* (Psalm 119:25). Laid low. Clinging. Either way, the picture is the same: a soul pressed flat against the ground, face in the dirt, unable to rise. That is the dust-bound soul you have been reading about since January.

The Hebrew verb the NKJV renders as clings is davaq, to cling, to stick, to hold fast. It is the word for a soul glued to the ground. And the verb behind *"revive"* is chayah, to live, to be made alive. The prayer is not, help me try harder. It is, give me life. The soul that clings to dust cannot lift itself. It needs to be raised. That is the whole message of this book. Not self-improvement. Revival. Life from God, given according to His word.

Then look at what happens in the rest of this stanza. The psalmist confesses: *"I declared my ways, and you answered me"* (Psalm 119:26). He prays: *"My soul is weary with sorrow: strengthen me according to your word"* (Psalm 119:28). He chooses: *"I have chosen the way of truth"* (Psalm 119:30). And then the same Hebrew verb returns: *"I cling to your statutes, Yahweh"* (Psalm 119:31). The soul that clung to the dust in verse 25 clings to God's word in verse 31. The grip is the same. The object has changed.

That is what revival looks like. Not a soul that stops clinging, but a soul that clings to something better. And the stanza ends in freedom: *"I run in the path of your commandments, for you have set my heart free"* (Psalm 119:32). From clinging to the dust to running free. How does it happen? According to God's word. Jesus said, *"The words that I speak to you are spirit, and are life"* (John 6:63). Ezekiel spoke the word to dry bones and God said, *"I will cause breath to enter into you, and you will live"* (Ezekiel 37:5). Pray this verse today. It is the prayer of this whole year.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ clung to the dust of death for you, laid low in the grave. On the third day the Father revived Him according to His word. Because He rose, your soul does not have to stay in the dirt. Pray it today, and mean it: revive me according to Your word.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where is your soul clinging to the dust today — and will you ask God to revive you by His word?

◆

DAY 294 · OCTOBER 21 · PSALM 119 (VV. 33–40)

Incline My Heart to Your Testimonies

“Turn my heart toward your statutes, not toward selfish gain.”
— PSALM 119:36

The fifth stanza of Psalm 119 is full of prayers for God to do what the psalmist cannot do on his own: *“Teach me, Yahweh, the way of your statutes. I will keep them to the end”* (Psalm 119:33). Teach me. *“Give me understanding, and I will keep your law. Yes, I will obey it with my whole heart”* (Psalm 119:34). Give me understanding. *“Direct me in the path of your commandments, for I delight in them”* (Psalm 119:35). Direct me. Every request asks God to act first. The psalmist does not promise to do better and then ask for help. He asks for help so that he can do better.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *“Turn my heart toward your statutes, not toward selfish gain”* (Psalm 119:36). Turn my heart. The psalmist knows his heart naturally leans toward selfish gain — money, advantage, getting ahead. Left to itself, the heart bends toward what benefits me. He cannot straighten it alone. Hearts do not bend back by themselves, any more than a tree grown crooked straightens on its own. So he asks God to turn it. To bend it back toward His word.

That is an honest prayer. Most people do not admit how much their hearts lean toward selfish gain. It shows up in small ways. The extra hours at work that crowd out time with God. The purchase that feeds pride. The decision made for profit instead of principle. Jesus warned, *“For out of the abundance of the heart, his mouth speaks”* (Luke 6:45). What fills the heart comes out in the life. If your heart is full of gain, gain will drive your choices, even the ones that look spiritual.

Then a related prayer: *“Turn my eyes away from looking at worthless things. Revive me in your ways”* (Psalm 119:37). Turn my eyes. What you look at shapes what you want. And notice the word revive again — chayah, the same verb as verse 25. Revival comes in God’s ways, not in worthless things. The stanza ends: *“Behold, I long for your precepts! Revive me in your righteousness”* (Psalm 119:40). Revive me again. Pray this today: turn my heart, turn my eyes, revive me. God answers that prayer.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ’s heart never leaned toward selfish gain. He emptied Himself and gave up every advantage, all the way to the cross. He rose to turn the hearts of His people toward God. Ask Him today to turn your heart and your eyes, and to revive you in His ways.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where is your heart leaning toward selfish gain — and will you ask God to turn it?

◆

DAY 295 · OCTOBER 22 · PSALM 119 (VV. 41–48)

I Will Walk in a Wide Place

"I will walk in liberty, for I have sought your precepts."
— PSALM 119:45

The sixth stanza of Psalm 119 begins with a prayer for God's love to arrive: *"Let your loving kindness also come to me, Yahweh, your salvation, according to your word"* (Psalm 119:41). Let it come. Loving kindness and salvation, delivered according to God's promise. And the result: *"So I will have an answer for him who reproaches me, for I trust in your word"* (Psalm 119:42). When people mock his faith, he will have something to say. Not a clever argument, but a word from God that he trusts.

"Don't snatch the word of truth out of my mouth, for I put my hope in your ordinances" (Psalm 119:43). Keep the truth in my mouth. Do not let me lose my words. Then a promise: *"So I will obey your law continually, forever and ever"* (Psalm 119:44). And then the line that gives this day its name: *"I will walk in liberty, for I have sought your precepts"* (Psalm 119:45). Liberty. Real freedom. A wide open place. And it comes from seeking God's precepts.

That surprises many people. They think God's commands are a cage. Rules that restrict, fences that hem you in. Psalm 119 says the opposite. Seeking God's word leads to liberty. The commands are not a prison. They are like the banks of a river — they keep the water flowing instead of spreading out into a swamp. Jesus said, *"If you remain in my word, then you are truly my disciples. You will know the truth, and the truth will make you free"* (John 8:31–32).

Sin promises freedom and delivers slavery. God's word looks like restriction and delivers liberty. Paul says, *"Stand firm therefore in the liberty by which Christ has made us free, and don't be entangled again with a yoke of bondage"* (Galatians 5:1). Then the stanza ends with boldness and delight: *"I will also speak of your statutes before kings, and will not be disappointed. I will delight myself in your commandments, because I love them"* (Psalm 119:46–47). Free enough to speak before kings. Free enough to love the commands. Walk in that liberty today, and do not go back to the chains.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the truth that sets you free. He kept the law perfectly and broke the chains of sin and death by His cross and resurrection. In Him, God's commands become a wide place, not a cage. Walk in His liberty today. Seek His word, and find freedom.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you experience God's commands as a cage — or as the path to a wide place of freedom?

◆

DAY 296 · OCTOBER 23 · PSALM 119 (VV. 49–56)

This Is My Comfort in My Affliction

“This is my comfort in my affliction, for your word has revived me.”
— PSALM 119:50

The seventh stanza of Psalm 119 begins with a prayer to remember: *“Remember your word to your servant, because you gave me hope”* (Psalm 119:49). You gave me hope. God spoke a promise, and the psalmist has been leaning on it. Now he asks God to remember that promise. Not because God forgets, but because faith holds God to His word. That is a bold and humble kind of prayer. Bold, because it reminds the King of His promise. Humble, because it has nothing to offer but the promise itself.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *“This is my comfort in my affliction, for your word has revived me”* (Psalm 119:50). This is my comfort. Not a change in circumstances. Not an end to the trouble. The word. In the middle of affliction, God’s word has revived him — the same verb as verse 25, chayah, made alive. The suffering is still there. But the soul has life again. That is what Scripture does in hard times. It does not always change the situation. It changes the person inside the situation.

Many people turn to Scripture only when life is easy, and drop it when life gets hard. They are too tired, too sad, too busy. Psalm 119 says the opposite. Affliction is exactly when you need the word most. It is the comfort that holds when nothing else does. Paul says, *“For whatever things were written before were written for our learning, that through perseverance and through encouragement of the Scriptures we might have hope”* (Romans 15:4).

Then the psalmist faces mockery: *“The arrogant mock me excessively, but I don’t swerve from your law”* (Psalm 119:51). Mocked, and still faithful. He does not swerve, though the pressure is constant. *“I remember your ordinances of old, Yahweh, and have comforted myself”* (Psalm 119:52). Remembering God’s old words brings comfort. *“Your statutes have been my songs in the house where I live”* (Psalm 119:54). Songs in a temporary house. And at night: *“I have remembered your name, Yahweh, in the night, and I obey your law”* (Psalm 119:55). If you are afflicted today, open the word. Let it revive you. That is where comfort lives.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ found His comfort in the Father’s word during His deepest affliction, quoting the Psalms from the cross. He died and rose so that the word would revive you in yours. Whatever affliction you carry today, open the word. Let it make you alive again.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

In your affliction, do you turn to God’s word for comfort — or set it aside until things get easier?

◆

DAY 297 · OCTOBER 24 · PSALM 119 (VV. 57–64)

The LORD Is My Portion

"Yahweh is my portion. I promised to obey your words."
— PSALM 119:57

The eighth stanza of Psalm 119 opens with a declaration: *"Yahweh is my portion. I promised to obey your words"* (Psalm 119:57). My portion. In Israel, every tribe received a portion of land — except the priests, the Levites. God told them He Himself would be their portion. They did not get fields or vineyards. They got God. And the psalmist claims that same inheritance. Whatever else I have or lack, the LORD is my share.

That changes everything about how you measure your life. If God is your portion, then you are rich even when your bank account is small. You are secure even when your job is shaky. You have an inheritance that no one can take, because it is not a thing. It is a Person, and He does not change. Lamentations says, *"'Yahweh is my portion,' says my soul. 'Therefore I will hope in him'"* (Lamentations 3:24). The portion leads straight to hope.

Then the psalmist seeks God's favor: *"I sought your favor with my whole heart. Be merciful to me according to your word"* (Psalm 119:58). And then he does something practical: *"I considered my ways, and turned my steps to your statutes. I will hurry, and not delay, to obey your commandments"* (Psalm 119:59–60). Considered my ways. He stopped and looked at the direction of his life. And when he saw it was off, he turned. And he did not delay. He hurried home.

That is repentance in miniature. Look at your ways. Turn your steps. Do not wait. Many people know their lives are drifting and keep meaning to turn someday. Next month. After the holidays. When things calm down. Someday has a way of never arriving. The psalmist did it now. *"The ropes of the wicked bind me, but I won't forget your law. At midnight I will rise to give thanks to you"* (Psalm 119:61–62). Even bound, he gives thanks at midnight. And the stanza ends looking at the whole world: *"The earth is full of your loving kindness, Yahweh. Teach me your statutes"* (Psalm 119:64). If the LORD is your portion, you have everything. Consider your ways today, and turn.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ made the Father His portion, owning nothing but God, and He gave Himself so that God could be your portion forever. He died and rose to give you an inheritance no one can take. Consider your ways today. Turn your steps toward Him, and do not delay.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If the LORD is your portion, what changes about how you measure your life — and where do you need to turn your steps?

◆

DAY 298 · OCTOBER 25 · PSALM 119 (VV. 65–72)

It Is Good That I Was Afflicted

> *"It is good for me that I have been afflicted, that I may learn your statutes."*
> — PSALM 119:71

The ninth stanza of Psalm 119 begins with a plea for goodness: *"Do good to your servant, according to your word, Yahweh. Teach me good judgment and knowledge, for I believe in your commandments"* (Psalm 119:65–66). Then a confession that may surprise you: *"Before I was afflicted, I went astray; but now I observe your word"* (Psalm 119:67). Before the trouble, he wandered. After the trouble, he obeyed. The affliction brought him back.

"You are good, and do good. Teach me your statutes" (Psalm 119:68). That line is the key to the whole stanza. God is good. And He does good. Even when He allows affliction, He is doing good. Then the psalmist faces lies: *"The proud have smeared a lie upon me. With my whole heart, I will keep your precepts"* (Psalm 119:69). Smeared like mud, and still faithful. *"Their heart is as callous as the fat, but I delight in your law"* (Psalm 119:70).

Then the line that gives this day its name, one of the hardest and most honest verses in the Bible: *"It is good for me that I have been afflicted, that I may learn your statutes"* (Psalm 119:71). Good for me. That is not something you can say in the middle of the pain. It is something you say after, looking back. The affliction taught him what comfort never could. It drove him to God's word. It stripped away what was false and left what was true.

That does not mean every suffering is pleasant or that you should pretend pain is good. The psalmist does not enjoy affliction. He sees its fruit. Hebrews says, *"All chastening seems for the present to be not joyous but grievous; yet afterward it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it"* (Hebrews 12:11). Afterward. And Paul says, *"suffering produces perseverance; and perseverance, proven character; and proven character, hope"* (Romans 5:3–4). The stanza ends with value: *"The law of your mouth is better to me than thousands of pieces of gold and silver"* (Psalm 119:72). You may not see it yet. But the God who is good and does good is doing good in your affliction.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ learned obedience through what He suffered, and His affliction on the cross brought the greatest good the world has ever known. On the third day the Father raised Him. The God who is good and does good is working in your affliction too. Ask Him to teach you through it.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Looking back, can you see how a past affliction drew you closer to God's word?

◆

DAY 299 · OCTOBER 26 · PSALM 119 (VV. 73–80)

Your Hands Have Made and Fashioned Me

"Your hands have made me and formed me."
— PSALM 119:73

The tenth stanza of Psalm 119 begins with the Maker: *"Your hands have made me and formed me. Give me understanding, that I may learn your commandments"* (Psalm 119:73). Your hands. God did not make you from a distance. He formed you, the way a potter shapes clay on the wheel. Job said the same: *"Your hands have framed me and fashioned me altogether"* (Job 10:8). You are handmade. Not mass-produced, not stamped out on an assembly line. Shaped one at a time, with care, by hands that knew exactly what they were making.

And because God made you, the psalmist asks Him to finish the work. Give me understanding. The One who formed the body can form the mind and heart too. Isaiah prays, *"But now, Yahweh, you are our Father. We are the clay and you our potter. We all are the work of your hand"* (Isaiah 64:8). Clay does not shape itself. It yields to the potter's hands. The prayer for understanding is a prayer to stay soft in His hands. Hard clay cracks on the wheel.

Then the psalmist thinks about others: *"Those who fear you will see me and be glad, because I have put my hope in your word"* (Psalm 119:74). His hope encourages others. When people see you hoping in God, it strengthens their faith. Then a hard confession: *"Yahweh, I know that your judgments are righteous, that in faithfulness you have afflicted me"* (Psalm 119:75). In faithfulness. The affliction was not a sign that God had left. It was part of His faithful care, the way a potter presses hard on the clay to shape it.

Then he asks for comfort: *"Please let your loving kindness be for my comfort, according to your word to your servant. Let your tender mercies come to me, that I may live"* (Psalm 119:76–77). That I may live. Revival again. And the stanza ends: *"Let my heart be blameless toward your decrees, that I may not be disappointed"* (Psalm 119:80). Paul says, *"For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works"* (Ephesians 2:10). Workmanship. Handiwork. You are something God is still making. Stay soft in His hands today.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The hands that formed you from the dust were pierced for you on the cross. Christ, through whom all things were made, gave His hands to the nails so that His workmanship could be remade. He rose with scars in His palms. Stay soft in those hands today. He is still forming you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you staying soft in the hands that made you — or resisting the Potter's shaping?

◆

DAY 300 · OCTOBER 27 · PSALM 119 (VV. 81–88)

My Soul Longs for Your Salvation

"My soul faints for your salvation. I hope in your word."
— PSALM 119:81

The eleventh stanza of Psalm 119 is one of the darkest. It begins: *"My soul faints for your salvation. I hope in your word"* (Psalm 119:81). Faints. Worn out with waiting. He has been looking for God's rescue so long that his soul is weak. And yet: I hope in Your word. Even fainting, he still hopes. That is what faith looks like in a long wait. Tired, and still hoping. That kind of hope is not a feeling. It is a decision repeated every morning.

"My eyes fail for your word. I say, 'When will you comfort me?'" (Psalm 119:82). His eyes are tired from looking. When will You come? Then a striking picture: *"For I have become like a wineskin in the smoke. I don't forget your statutes"* (Psalm 119:83). A wineskin hung in the smoke of a tent fire — dried out, blackened, shriveled, cracked. That is how he feels. Used up. Good for nothing, it seems. And still he does not forget God's word.

"How many are the days of your servant? When will you execute judgment on those who persecute me?" (Psalm 119:84). How long? Then he describes the attack: *"The proud have dug pits for me, contrary to your law"* (Psalm 119:85). *"They had almost wiped me from the earth, but I didn't forsake your precepts"* (Psalm 119:87). Almost wiped out. Almost destroyed. But not quite. And through it all, he held on to God's word.

You may feel like that wineskin. Dried out from waiting. Blackened by a long, smoky season. Your soul faint from looking for God's help. This stanza is for you. It does not pretend the waiting is easy. It names it plainly. But it also shows you what to hold on to in the smoke: the word. And it ends with a prayer: *"Preserve my life according to your loving kindness, so I will obey the statutes of your mouth"* (Psalm 119:88). Preserve my life. Keep me alive. If you are fainting today, do not let go of His word. Paul says the Scriptures were written *"that through perseverance and through encouragement of the Scriptures we might have hope"* (Romans 15:4).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ fainted under the weight of the cross, His body dried out and broken, His friends gone. He held on to the Father's word to the end. On the third day He was raised. If you feel like a wineskin in the smoke today, hold on. Hope in His word.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If your soul is fainting from a long wait, what word of God are you holding on to?

◆

DAY 301 · OCTOBER 28 · PSALM 119 (VV. 89–96)

Forever, O LORD, Your Word Is Firm

"Yahweh, your word is settled in heaven forever."
— PSALM 119:89

After the dark stanza comes the brightest one: *"Yahweh, your word is settled in heaven forever"* (Psalm 119:89). Settled. Fixed. Established. Not changing with every season. Not shifting with every opinion. God's word stands firm in heaven, where nothing on earth can touch it. That is the answer to the fainting of the last stanza. When your soul is weak, God's word is still strong. Your feelings rise and fall like the tide. His word does not move an inch.

"Your faithfulness is to all generations. You have established the earth, and it remains. Your laws remain to this day, for all things serve you" (Psalm 119:90–91). The earth stays because God established it. And everything in creation serves Him. The sun rising, the seasons turning, the rain falling — all of it obeys His word. If His word holds the universe together, it can hold you. Nothing in your life is too heavy for the word that keeps the stars in place.

Then a confession that ties back to the anchor of this year: *"Unless your law had been my delight, I would have perished in my affliction"* (Psalm 119:92). I would have died. The word kept him alive. *"I will never forget your precepts, for with them, you have revived me"* (Psalm 119:93). Revived again — the same Hebrew verb, chayah, as in verse 25. God's word does not just inform. It gives life. Jesus said, *"Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away"* (Matthew 24:35).

Then the shortest prayer in the stanza: *"I am yours. Save me, for I have sought your precepts"* (Psalm 119:94). I am Yours. That is enough of a reason to be saved. A child does not have to argue a case to be rescued by a parent. Belonging is the argument. Not because of what he has done, but because of whose he is. And the stanza ends looking at the limits of everything else: *"I have seen a limit to all perfection, but your commands are boundless"* (Psalm 119:96). Every human achievement has an end. God's word does not. Peter says, *"the Lord's word endures forever"* (1 Peter 1:25). When everything else wobbles, stand on what is settled in heaven.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the eternal Word, settled in heaven forever, who became flesh and was laid in a grave. On the third day He rose, and His word will never pass away. When everything around you wobbles today, stand on Him. Tell Him: I am Yours. Save me.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When everything around you is shifting, are you standing on the word that is settled in heaven?

◆

DAY 302 · OCTOBER 29 · PSALM 119 (VV. 97–104)

Oh How I Love Your Law

> *"How I love your law! It is my meditation all day."*
> — PSALM 119:97

The thirteenth stanza of Psalm 119 bursts out with love: *"How I love your law! It is my meditation all day"* (Psalm 119:97). How I love it. Not just respect it. Not just obey it. Love it, deeply. And it fills his thoughts all day long. That is what love does. When you love someone, they are on your mind while you work, while you drive, while you fall asleep. The psalmist loves God's word like that, and it shows in every line.

Then he describes what the word has done for him: *"Your commandments make me wiser than my enemies, for your commandments are always with me. I have more understanding than all my teachers, for your testimonies are my meditation. I understand more than the aged, because I have kept your precepts"* (Psalm 119:98–100). Wiser than enemies, even. Wiser than teachers. Wiser than the old. Not because he is smarter, but because he has been soaked in God's word.

That is a different kind of wisdom from the world's. You can have a degree and lack it. You can be uneducated and have it in abundance. It comes from meditating on God's word and keeping it. Then he says what that looks like in practice: *"I have kept my feet from every evil way, that I might observe your word"* (Psalm 119:101). The word changes where his feet go. It is not only knowledge in the head. It is a direction for the feet.

Then the sweetest line in the stanza: *"How sweet are your promises to my taste, more than honey to my mouth!"* (Psalm 119:103). Sweet. Like honey. Many people experience the Bible as dry, dull, a duty. The psalmist experiences it as dessert. What made the difference? Love and meditation. The more you chew on it, the sweeter it gets. A quick taste rarely satisfies. And the stanza ends with a result: *"Through your precepts, I get understanding; therefore I hate every false way"* (Psalm 119:104). Paul says all Scripture is *"profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for instruction in righteousness"* (2 Timothy 3:16). Taste it today. It is sweeter than you think.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ loved the Father's word so much it was His food. He quoted it in temptation, prayed it on the cross, and fulfilled every promise in it by His death and resurrection. Taste His word today. Chew on one verse all day long. It is sweeter than honey.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is God's word a duty to you — or something sweet that fills your thoughts all day?

◆

DAY 303 · OCTOBER 30 · PSALM 119 (VV. 105–112)

A Lamp to My Feet

"Your word is a lamp to my feet, and a light for my path."
— PSALM 119:105

The fourteenth stanza of Psalm 119 opens with one of the best-known verses in the Bible: *"Your word is a lamp to my feet, and a light for my path"* (Psalm 119:105). A lamp to my feet. Not a floodlight that shows the whole road for miles ahead. A lamp. The kind you would carry at night on a dark trail. It shows you the next step. Maybe two, on a good night. Enough to keep you from tripping, but not enough to see the end of the road.

That is usually how God's word guides. It does not hand you a map of your whole life. It shows you the next faithful step. Many people want to see five years ahead before they move. God gives you enough light for today. Be honest in this conversation. Forgive this person. Pray this morning. Love your neighbor this afternoon. Step by step, quietly, the lamp lights the path, and you walk it one step at a time.

Then a commitment: *"I have sworn, and have confirmed it, that I will obey your righteous ordinances"* (Psalm 119:106). He has made a vow, and he means it. And then the honest truth: *"I am afflicted very much. Revive me, Yahweh, according to your word"* (Psalm 119:107). Afflicted very much. And the prayer of this whole year: revive me according to Your word. That is the same request as verse 25. The lamp does not take away the darkness. It gives light in the darkness.

"My soul is continually in my hand, yet I won't forget your law. The wicked have laid a snare for me, yet I haven't gone astray from your precepts" (Psalm 119:109–110). His life is at risk. Traps are laid for him. And the lamp keeps him from stepping into them. Then the stanza ends with joy: *"I have taken your testimonies as a heritage forever, for they are the joy of my heart"* (Psalm 119:111). Jesus said, *"I am the light of the world. He who follows me will not walk in the darkness, but will have the light of life"* (John 8:12). Take the next step today by His light.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the light of the world. He walked into the darkness of death so that you would never walk in darkness again, and on the third day He rose as the light of life. You do not need to see the whole road. Follow Him one step at a time today. His word is enough light.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you waiting to see the whole road — or willing to take the next step by the light of God's word?

◆

DAY 304 · OCTOBER 31 · PSALM 119 (VV. 113–120)

You Are My Hiding Place and My Shield

"You are my hiding place and my shield. I hope in your word."
— PSALM 119:114

The fifteenth stanza of Psalm 119 begins with a contrast: *"I hate double-minded men, but I love your law"* (Psalm 119:113). Double-minded. Divided. One foot in God's way and one foot out. The psalmist has no patience for that kind of half-heartedness — in others or in himself. He wants an undivided heart, and the way to get it is to love God's word. Love gathers the scattered pieces of a heart and points them one way.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"You are my hiding place and my shield. I hope in your word"* (Psalm 119:114). Hiding place. Shield. One is a place to go. The other is protection that comes with you. When trouble comes, God is the place you can run to and hide. And when you have to walk out into the trouble, He is the shield in front of you. Both at once. Isaiah describes a coming King who *"shall be as a hiding place from the wind, and a covert from the storm"* (Isaiah 32:2).

Then a bold command: "*Depart from me, you evildoers, that I may keep the commandments of my God"* (Psalm 119:115). He sends away the people who would pull him off course. Then a prayer for strength: "*Uphold me according to your word, that I may live. Let me not be ashamed of my hope. Hold me up, and I will be safe"* (Psalm 119:116–117). Uphold me. Hold me up. He knows he cannot stand by himself. He needs God's hand under him, every day, every step.

And the stanza ends with something many readers find surprising: *"My flesh trembles for fear of you. I am afraid of your judgments"* (Psalm 119:120). He hides in God, and he trembles before God. Both are true. God is the refuge and the holy One. You can hide in Him precisely because He is so great. A small God would be no shelter. Paul says, *"your life is hidden with Christ in God"* (Colossians 3:3). That is the safest hiding place there is. When trouble comes today, run there. And let your awe of Him make you braver, not smaller.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is your hiding place and your shield. He took the full force of God's judgment on the cross so that you could hide in Him from it, and on the third day He rose. Your life is hidden with Christ in God. Run there today. It is the safest place in the universe.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When trouble comes, do you run to God as your hiding place — or try to hide somewhere else?

◆

DAY 305 · NOVEMBER 1 · PSALM 119 (VV. 121–128)

It Is Time for the LORD to Act

"My eyes fail looking for your salvation, for your righteous word."
— PSALM 119:123

The sixteenth stanza of Psalm 119 begins with a claim and a plea: *"I have done what is just and righteous. Don't leave me to my oppressors. Ensure your servant's well-being. Don't let the proud oppress me"* (Psalm 119:121–122). The psalmist has tried to live rightly, and still the proud are pressing him. He asks God to stand between him and them, to guarantee his well-being like someone who signs for a loan and puts his own name on the line.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"My eyes fail looking for your salvation, for your righteous word"* (Psalm 119:123). His eyes are tired from watching. He has been looking down the road for God's rescue so long that his vision is worn out. That is a picture of waiting that has gone on longer than expected. You may know it. You have been praying for a child, a marriage, a healing, a breakthrough, and your eyes are tired from looking for the answer.

But notice what he does while he waits: *"Deal with your servant according to your loving kindness. Teach me your statutes. I am your servant. Give me understanding, that I may know your testimonies"* (Psalm 119:124–125). He keeps asking to learn. The waiting does not stop his growth. It becomes a school. And then the bold prayer: *"It is time to act, Yahweh, for they break your law"* (Psalm 119:126). It is time. He tells God the hour has come.

That is not disrespect. It is honest faith. You can tell God what you think the time is. You can ask Him to act. He may not act on your schedule — Peter says, *"The Lord is not slow concerning his promise, as some count slowness"* (2 Peter 3:9). But He hears the prayer. Habakkuk was told, *"Though it takes time, wait for it; because it will surely come. It won't delay"* (Habakkuk 2:3). And the stanza ends with love in the waiting: *"Therefore I love your commandments more than gold, yes, more than pure gold"* (Psalm 119:127). Waiting did not make him bitter. It made him love God's word more. Let your waiting do the same.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God acted at the right time when He sent His Son, born under the law in the fullness of time. Christ died at the appointed hour and rose on the appointed day. Your eyes may be tired from looking for His help. Keep looking. He will act, and His timing is never late.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are your eyes tired from waiting for God to act — and is the waiting making you bitter or making you love Him more?

◆

DAY 306 · NOVEMBER 2 · PSALM 119 (VV. 129–136)

The Unfolding of Your Words Gives Light

"The entrance of your words gives light."
— PSALM 119:130

The seventeenth stanza of Psalm 119 begins with wonder: *"Your testimonies are wonderful, therefore my soul keeps them"* (Psalm 119:129). Wonderful. Full of wonder. Not dull, not dry, not merely useful. The psalmist keeps God's word because it amazes him. People do not usually guard what bores them. They guard what they treasure. That is why he keeps it. You lock up what is precious. You put it where thieves cannot get it.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"The entrance of your words gives light. It gives understanding to the simple"* (Psalm 119:130). The entrance. When God's word comes in, light comes with it. Picture a dark room and a door swinging open. Light pours across the floor. That is what happens when Scripture enters a mind and heart. You see what you could not see before — the shape of your own heart, the face of God, the way forward that was hidden a moment ago. And it works for the simple — not only for scholars, but for ordinary people with no special training.

That is good news for anyone who feels unqualified to read the Bible. You do not need a seminary degree to understand it. You need the light that comes with the word itself. The two disciples on the road to Emmaus felt it: *"Weren't our hearts burning within us, while he spoke to us along the way, and while he opened the Scriptures to us?"* (Luke 24:32). Burning hearts. Light entering. That is what happens when Christ opens the word.

Then the psalmist describes his hunger: *"I opened my mouth wide and panted, for I longed for your commandments"* (Psalm 119:131). Panting, like a dog after a long run, mouth open. That is how much he wants God's word. And the stanza holds a prayer you can borrow: *"Establish my footsteps in your word. Don't let any iniquity have dominion over me"* (Psalm 119:133). And: *"Make your face shine on your servant. Teach me your statutes"* (Psalm 119:135). John says Christ is *"The true light that enlightens everyone"* (John 1:9). Open the door today. Let His word enter. The light will come.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the light that enters when His word enters. He opened the Scriptures to His disciples after rising from the dead, and their hearts burned within them. Open the door to His word today. He gives understanding to the simple, and light to anyone who lets Him in.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When did you last let God's word enter and light up a dark place in your heart?

◆

DAY 307 · NOVEMBER 3 · PSALM 119 (VV. 137–144)

Your Righteousness Is Righteous Forever

"Your righteousness is an everlasting righteousness. Your law is truth."
— PSALM 119:142

The eighteenth stanza of Psalm 119 is about God's righteousness: *"You are righteous, Yahweh. Your judgments are upright. You have commanded your statutes in righteousness. They are fully trustworthy"* (Psalm 119:137–138). Righteous. Upright. Trustworthy. Everything God commands comes out of His own perfect goodness. His word is not arbitrary. It is the expression of who He is. When God says do not lie, it is because He is truth. When He says love, it is because He is love. His commands are a portrait of His character.

Then the psalmist admits his own exhaustion: *"My zeal wears me out, because my enemies ignore your words"* (Psalm 119:139). He cares so much about God's word that watching people ignore it wears him out. Then a line of honest smallness: *"I am small and despised. I don't forget your precepts"* (Psalm 119:141). Small. Despised. Overlooked. And still faithful. Many believers feel small — unnoticed at work, unimportant in the world's eyes. That does not disqualify you. It is where God's word often does its best work. The proud are too full to listen. The small have room.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Your righteousness is an everlasting righteousness. Your law is truth"* (Psalm 119:142). Everlasting. It does not change with the times. What was right in David's day is right today. And His law is truth. Not one truth among many. Truth. In a world that says truth is whatever you feel, Psalm 119 says truth is what God has spoken.

And there is gospel hidden here. God's righteousness is not only a standard you must meet. It is a gift He gives. Paul writes, *"But now apart from the law, a righteousness of God has been revealed... even the righteousness of God through faith in Jesus Christ to all and on all those who believe"* (Romans 3:21–22). The everlasting righteousness of God is given to you in Christ. The stanza ends: *"Trouble and anguish have taken hold of me. Your commandments are my delight. Your testimonies are righteous forever. Give me understanding, that I may live"* (Psalm 119:143–144). If you feel small and despised today, rest in a righteousness that is everlasting and has been given to you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the everlasting righteousness of God made flesh. He was despised and rejected, small in the eyes of the world, and He gave His righteousness to you by taking your sin on the cross. He rose. If you feel small today, rest in the righteousness He has given you. It lasts forever.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you rest in God's everlasting righteousness as a gift — or keep trying to earn it?

◆

DAY 308 · NOVEMBER 4 · PSALM 119 (VV. 145–152)

I Rise Before Dawn and Cry for Help

"I rise before dawn and cry for help. I put my hope in your words."
— PSALM 119:147

The nineteenth stanza of Psalm 119 is a prayer that never sleeps. It opens with urgency: *"I have called with my whole heart. Answer me, Yahweh! I will keep your statutes. I have called to you. Save me! I will obey your statutes"* (Psalm 119:145–146). Whole heart. Answer me. Save me. These are not polite requests. They are cries for help from someone who needs God to come.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"I rise before dawn and cry for help. I put my hope in your words"* (Psalm 119:147). Before dawn. Before the house wakes and the noise starts. Before the day's demands crowd in. He is already on his knees. That is the habit of people who know they need God. They meet Him early. They do not wait until they have handled everything else and have a few minutes left over. Jesus did the same: *"Early in the morning, while it was still dark, he rose up and went out, and departed into a deserted place, and prayed there"* (Mark 1:35).

And at night: *"My eyes stay open through the night watches, that I might meditate on your word"* (Psalm 119:148). Before dawn and through the night. That is a life soaked in prayer. You may not be able to pray all night, but you can begin your day with God before anything else claims it. A few minutes before the phone, before the news, before the coffee is even finished. Let His word be the first voice you hear. Every other voice will have its turn soon enough. Give Him the first word.

Then a prayer for revival: *"Hear my voice according to your loving kindness. Revive me, Yahweh, according to your ordinances"* (Psalm 119:149). Revive me again — the same request as verse 25. And then a comfort: *"They draw near who follow after wickedness. They are far from your law. You are near, Yahweh. All your commandments are truth"* (Psalm 119:150–151). The wicked draw near. But You are near too. Nearer. Lamentations says God's mercies *"are new every morning"* (Lamentations 3:23). Rise early tomorrow and meet the mercy waiting for you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ rose before dawn to pray, and He rose before dawn on the first day of the week from the grave. The mercies of God are new every morning because of Him. Meet Him early tomorrow, before anything else claims your day. He is near.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What would change if you met God before dawn, before anything else claimed your day?

◆

DAY 309 · NOVEMBER 5 · PSALM 119 (VV. 153–160)

Great Is Your Mercy, O LORD

> *"Great are your tender mercies, Yahweh. Revive me according to your ordinances."*
> — PSALM 119:156

The twentieth stanza of Psalm 119 is full of the word revive. Three times in eight verses the psalmist asks for it. He begins: *"Consider my affliction, and deliver me, for I don't forget your law. Plead my cause, and redeem me! Revive me according to your promise"* (Psalm 119:153–154). Plead my cause. Be my advocate. Stand up for me in court. And give me life again. Three requests, all aimed at God doing what the psalmist cannot do for himself.

Then a contrast: *"Salvation is far from the wicked, for they don't seek your statutes"* (Psalm 119:155). Salvation is far from those who do not seek. And then the line that gives this day its name: *"Great are your tender mercies, Yahweh. Revive me according to your ordinances"* (Psalm 119:156). Great are Your tender mercies. Not small, not stingy. Great. And because they are great, he asks for revival. The size of God's mercy is the ground of the request. Small mercy would justify small prayers. Great mercy invites great ones.

That is how you should pray when you need new life. Not on the basis of how hard you have tried. On the basis of how great His mercy is. Paul says, *"But God, being rich in mercy, for his great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead through our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ"* (Ephesians 2:4–5). Rich in mercy. Made alive. That is the answer to the prayer of Psalm 119. Revival is a gift of mercy, not a reward for effort.

"Many are my persecutors and my adversaries. I haven't swerved from your testimonies" (Psalm 119:157). Then one more time: *"Consider how I love your precepts. Revive me, Yahweh, according to your loving kindness"* (Psalm 119:159). Three requests for revival in one stanza. The psalmist is not shy about asking again and again. And the stanza ends with certainty: *"All of your words are truth. Every one of your righteous ordinances endures forever"* (Psalm 119:160). Titus says God saved *"according to his mercy"* (Titus 3:5). Ask for revival today. Ask on the basis of His great mercy. And ask again tomorrow.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God's great mercy made the dead alive together with Christ, raised on the third day. Revival is not something you earn. It is mercy given. Ask Him today, on the basis of how great His tender mercies are: revive me. Then ask again tomorrow. He does not tire of the request.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you ask God for revival on the basis of your effort — or on the basis of His great mercy?

◆

DAY 310 · NOVEMBER 6 · PSALM 119 (VV. 161–168)

Great Peace Have Those Who Love Your Law

> *"Those who love your law have great peace."*
> — PSALM 119:165

The twenty-first stanza of Psalm 119 begins with pressure: *"Princes have persecuted me without a cause, but my heart stands in awe of your words"* (Psalm 119:161). Princes are against him, without reason. And yet what fills his heart is not fear of the princes but awe of God's word. That is a deep exchange. Fear of man pushed out by awe of God. When God's word is bigger in your heart than your enemies, they lose their grip on you.

Then joy: *"I rejoice at your word, as one who finds great plunder"* (Psalm 119:162). Like someone who stumbles onto buried treasure in a field. That is how he feels when he reads God's word. Excited. Surprised. Rich. Then a statement of what he loves and hates: *"I hate and abhor falsehood. I love your law"* (Psalm 119:163). And then a rhythm of praise: *"Seven times a day, I praise you, because of your righteous ordinances"* (Psalm 119:164). Seven times. All day long. Praise woven into the hours like threads through cloth.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Those who love your law have great peace. Nothing causes them to stumble"* (Psalm 119:165). Great peace. Not just a little calm on a good day. Great peace. And nothing causes them to stumble. That does not mean they never have trouble. It means they have footing, solid rock under their feet when the ground around them shifts. Isaiah says, *"You will keep whoever's mind is steadfast in perfect peace, because he trusts in you"* (Isaiah 26:3).

Jesus offered the same: *"Peace I leave with you. My peace I give to you; not as the world gives, I give to you. Don't let your heart be troubled, neither let it be fearful"* (John 14:27). Not as the world gives. The world's peace depends on circumstances. God's peace comes through His word and holds even when circumstances fail. Paul calls it *"the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding"* (Philippians 4:7). If you are anxious today, the answer is not only to fix the problem. It is to love God's word more. Great peace comes to those who do.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the peace of His people. He took the punishment that brought peace on Himself at the cross, and He rose to give a peace the world cannot give. Love His word today. Let it fill your heart until your fears lose their grip. Great peace is waiting.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is fear of people or problems bigger in your heart than awe of God's word?

◆

DAY 311 · NOVEMBER 7 · PSALM 119 (VV. 169–176)

I Have Gone Astray Like a Lost Sheep

"I have gone astray like a lost sheep."
— PSALM 119:176

The last stanza of Psalm 119 is a string of prayers: *"Let my cry come before you, Yahweh. Give me understanding according to your word. Let my supplication come before you. Deliver me according to your word"* (Psalm 119:169–170). Let my cry come. Let my prayer reach You. After 168 verses, the psalmist is still asking. Still dependent. Still needing God to hear. Maturity in faith does not mean needing God less. It means knowing how much you need Him.

Then praise: *"Let my lips utter praise, for you teach me your statutes. Let my tongue sing of your word, for all your commandments are righteousness"* (Psalm 119:171–172). Then a request for help: *"Let your hand be ready to help me, for I have chosen your precepts"* (Psalm 119:173). And revival once more: *"Let my soul live, that I may praise you. Let your ordinances help me"* (Psalm 119:175). Let my soul live. The prayer of the whole psalm, all the way to the end.

And then the last verse, which may surprise you: *"I have gone astray like a lost sheep. Seek your servant, for I don't forget your commandments"* (Psalm 119:176). After 176 verses of loving God's word, delighting in His law, meditating day and night — the psalmist ends by confessing he is a lost sheep. He has wandered. He cannot find his way back on his own. He needs the Shepherd to come looking for him.

That is the most honest ending possible. The longest chapter in the Bible about loving God's word does not end with a boast. It ends with a confession and a plea. Seek me. That is a prayer for everyone, at every stage of faith. Isaiah says, *"All we like sheep have gone astray"* (Isaiah 53:6). And Jesus told about a shepherd who leaves the ninety-nine to find the one: *"When he has found it, he carries it on his shoulders, rejoicing"* (Luke 15:5). Jesus said, *"For the Son of Man came to seek and to save that which was lost"* (Luke 19:10). If you have wandered, pray the last verse of Psalm 119 today. The Shepherd is already looking for you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Good Shepherd who came to seek and save the lost. He left heaven, went to the cross, and rose to carry lost sheep home on His shoulders, rejoicing. If you have wandered, pray it today: seek Your servant. He is already on His way to find you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where have you gone astray like a lost sheep — and will you ask the Shepherd to seek you?

◆

DAY 312 · NOVEMBER 8 · PSALM 120

In My Distress I Called

> *"In my distress, I cried to Yahweh. He answered me."*
> — PSALM 120:1

Psalm 120 begins a group of fifteen psalms, 120 through 134, that each carry a heading calling them a song of ascents. These songs are often understood as pilgrim songs, sung on the road up to Jerusalem for the feasts. And the first one starts far from Jerusalem, in a hard place: *"In my distress, I cried to Yahweh. He answered me"* (Psalm 120:1). The road to God's house begins with a cry from trouble.

"Deliver my soul, Yahweh, from lying lips, from a deceitful tongue" (Psalm 120:2). The trouble is words. Lies. Deceit. He is surrounded by people who do not tell the truth. Then he speaks to the liar directly: *"What will be given to you, and what will be done more to you, you deceitful tongue? Sharp arrows of the mighty, with coals of juniper"* (Psalm 120:3–4). Juniper wood burns hot and long. The liar's words will come back on him like burning arrows.

Then the loneliness: *"Woe is me, that I live in Meshech, that I dwell among the tents of Kedar!"* (Psalm 120:5). Meshech was far to the north. Kedar was in the desert to the east. Distant, foreign places, far from home. He feels like a stranger living among people who do not share his values. That loneliness is real, and many believers carry it at work, in their extended family, or in their own neighborhood. *"My soul has had her dwelling too long with him who hates peace"* (Psalm 120:6). Too long. He is tired of it, worn out by the fighting.

"I am for peace, but when I speak, they are for war" (Psalm 120:7). He wants peace. They want a fight. You may know that feeling — at work, in your neighborhood, even in your family. You try to make peace, and others keep stirring up conflict. That is a lonely place. And it is exactly where the pilgrim road begins. The longing for God's house grows strongest when you feel most out of place. Jesus said, *"Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called children of God"* (Matthew 5:9). Keep pursuing peace. And let your discomfort turn you toward home.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was surrounded by lying lips and deceitful tongues, and He pursued peace while others pursued His death. He made peace by the blood of His cross and rose to lead His people home. If you feel like a stranger among people who love conflict, let it turn your heart toward Him. Start the road home today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where do you feel like a stranger among people who love conflict — and is it turning you toward home?

◆

DAY 313 · NOVEMBER 9 · PSALM 121

I Lift Up My Eyes to the Hills

"My help comes from Yahweh, who made heaven and earth."
— PSALM 121:2

Psalm 121 is a pilgrim song for the road. It opens with a traveler looking up: *"I will lift up my eyes to the hills. Where does my help come from?"* (Psalm 121:1). The hills around Jerusalem could be lovely. They could also be dangerous — bandits hid there, wild animals roamed there, and the climb was steep. A pilgrim looking at the hills might feel small and exposed. Where does help come from on a road like this, with no one but strangers and the open sky?

The answer comes right away: *"My help comes from Yahweh, who made heaven and earth"* (Psalm 121:2). Not from the hills. From the One who made the hills. That distinction matters. People in the ancient world built shrines on hilltops to gods they hoped would protect them. The psalmist looks past every hill to the Maker of heaven and earth. Help does not come from the creation, however impressive. It comes from the Creator.

Then the promise of protection: *"He will not allow your foot to be moved. He who keeps you will not slumber. Behold, he who keeps Israel will neither slumber nor sleep"* (Psalm 121:3–4). He does not sleep. Every other guard eventually nods off. Every watchman gets tired. God never does. Through every night you are awake with worry, He is awake too. Through every night you sleep, He is still watching.

"Yahweh is your keeper. Yahweh is your shade on your right hand. The sun will not harm you by day, nor the moon by night" (Psalm 121:5–6). Shade in the heat. Protection in the dark. *"Yahweh will keep you from all evil. He will keep your soul. Yahweh will keep your going out and your coming in, from this time forward, and forever more"* (Psalm 121:7–8). Six times in eight verses the psalm uses the word keep. God keeps you. Your going out and your coming in — every trip, every day, every year. God told Jacob, *"I am with you, and will keep you, wherever you go"* (Genesis 28:15). Lift your eyes today past whatever hills are in front of you. Your help comes from the Maker.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the keeper who never sleeps. He watched over His disciples in the storm, kept them through the night of His arrest, and rose to keep His people forever. No one can snatch them from His hand. Lift your eyes today past the hills. Your help comes from Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you look at the hills in front of you, where do you look for help?

◆

DAY 314 · NOVEMBER 10 · PSALM 122 (VV. 1–4)

I Was Glad

> *“I was glad when they said to me, ‘Let’s go to Yahweh’s house!’”*
> — PSALM 122:1

Psalm 122 is the joy of arriving. It opens with an invitation remembered: *“I was glad when they said to me, ‘Let’s go to Yahweh’s house!’”* (Psalm 122:1). Glad. Not dutiful. Not reluctant. Glad, when someone said it was time to go up to worship. The pilgrim remembers the moment the trip was planned, and his heart jumped at the thought of being in God’s house. It is the feeling of a child told that the family is going to see the grandparents. The packing, the long road, the early start — none of it matters. What matters is where you are going.

Then he is there: *“Our feet are standing within your gates, Jerusalem”* (Psalm 122:2). The long road is over. He has arrived. Dust on his feet, ache in his legs, and joy in his chest. And he looks around at the city: *“Jerusalem, that is built as a city that is compact together”* (Psalm 122:3). Compact. Tightly built. The houses close together, the walls strong, the whole city bound into one. A picture of unity. Many people from many places, gathered into one city.

“where the tribes go up, even Yah’s tribes, according to an ordinance for Israel, to give thanks to Yahweh’s name” (Psalm 122:4). The tribes go up together. Judah and Benjamin and Ephraim and all the rest. Different families, different towns, different histories — all walking the same road to the same house to give thanks to the same God. That is what worship does. It gathers people who might otherwise never meet. The farmer and the merchant, the old widow and the young family, the rich and the poor, side by side before the same God.

Many people have lost the gladness of Psalm 122. Church has become an obligation, something to fit into a busy weekend or skip when life is full. But this psalm says being invited to God’s house should make your heart glad. Hebrews says, *“not forsaking our own assembling together, as the custom of some is, but exhorting one another”* (Hebrews 10:25). And it describes where believers really gather: *“But you have come to Mount Zion, and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem”* (Hebrews 12:22). Next time someone invites you to the house of the LORD, let your heart be glad.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the temple where God and people meet, and through His death the way into God’s house was opened. He rose and now gathers His people from every tribe into one city. When you gather with His people this week, go gladly. He is waiting there.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Does the invitation to gather with God’s people make you glad — or feel like an obligation?

◆

DAY 315 · NOVEMBER 11 · PSALM 122 (VV. 5–9)

Pray for the Peace of Jerusalem

> *"Pray for the peace of Jerusalem. Those who love you will prosper."*
> — PSALM 122:6

The second half of Psalm 122 turns from arriving to praying: *"For there are set thrones for judgment, the thrones of David's house"* (Psalm 122:5). Jerusalem was the seat of justice, where the king judged the people. And then the call: *"Pray for the peace of Jerusalem. Those who love you will prosper"* (Psalm 122:6). Pray for peace. The city of God was meant to be a city of peace, and the pilgrims were called to pray for it.

"Peace be within your walls, and prosperity within your palaces" (Psalm 122:7). Peace inside the walls. Not only safety from enemies outside, but harmony among the people inside. A city can be secure from invaders and still be torn apart by its own quarrels. A church can be safe from persecution and still split over the color of the carpet. The psalmist prays for both: protection from outside, peace within.

Then he tells you why he prays: *"For my brothers' and companions' sakes, I will now say, 'Peace be within you'"* (Psalm 122:8). For the sake of the people he loves. His family, his friends, his fellow worshipers. He prays for the peace of the city because the people he cares about live there. And for one more reason: *"For the sake of the house of Yahweh our God, I will seek your good"* (Psalm 122:9). For God's house. Because God dwells there, its peace matters. Love for God and love for His people go together.

That is a pattern for your prayers too. Pray for the peace of God's people — your church, your fellowship, the believers around the world. Pray for peace within the walls, not just safety from outside threats. Many churches are not destroyed by enemies but by division from within. Paul urged believers to be *"eager to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace"* (Ephesians 4:3). And Paul said Christ *"is our peace, who made both one, and broke down the middle wall of separation"* (Ephesians 2:14). Seek the good of God's people today. Pray for their peace, for the sake of the people you love and for the sake of His house.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the peace of His people. He broke down the walls between them by His death on the cross and rose to build one house out of many. Pray today for peace within the walls of His church. Seek its good, for the sake of the people you love and for His sake.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you pray for peace within God's people — not just safety from outside threats?

◆

DAY 316 · NOVEMBER 12 · PSALM 123

To You I Lift Up My Eyes

> *“so our eyes look to Yahweh, our God, until he has mercy on us.”*
> — PSALM 123:2

Psalm 123 is a short prayer of someone looking up: *“I lift up my eyes to you, you who sit in the heavens”* (Psalm 123:1). Looking up. Not at the hills this time. Straight at the One enthroned in heaven. Then a picture from everyday life in the ancient world: *“Behold, as the eyes of servants look to the hand of their master, as the eyes of a maid to the hand of her mistress”* (Psalm 123:2). A servant in a household, watching the hand of the master.

Why watch the hand? Because the hand tells you everything. The master points, and you go. The hand opens, and you receive. The hand gestures for you to come near, or to wait, or to rest. A good servant keeps eyes on the hand, ready to respond. In a busy house, with many guests and much to do, that steady watching was a skill. And that is how the psalmist describes his posture toward God: *“so our eyes look to Yahweh, our God, until he has mercy on us”* (Psalm 123:2). Until. He keeps looking until mercy comes.

That is a picture of patient, attentive prayer. Not glancing at God now and then. Fixing your eyes on Him and waiting. Watching for His hand to move. Many people pray once and then look away, back at their problems. The prayer becomes a brief interruption in the worry, instead of the worry becoming an interruption in the prayer. The psalmist keeps looking. Lamentations says, *“Yahweh is good to those who wait for him, to the soul who seeks him”* (Lamentations 3:25).

And why does he need mercy? *“Have mercy on us, Yahweh, have mercy on us, for we have endured much contempt. Our soul is exceedingly filled with the scoffing of those who are at ease, with the contempt of the proud”* (Psalm 123:3–4). Contempt. Scoffing. The comfortable and the proud looking down on them. Being mocked for your faith by people who have it easy wears on the soul. If you are tired of the scoffing today, do what the psalmist did. Lift your eyes. Fix them on the hand of God. Keep looking until His mercy comes.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ endured the contempt of the proud and the scoffing of those at ease, all the way to the cross. He fixed His eyes on the Father’s hand, and the Father raised Him on the third day. When you are weary of scorn today, lift your eyes to Him. Keep looking until His mercy comes.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are your eyes fixed on God’s hand, waiting for His mercy — or darting back to your problems?

◆

DAY 317 · NOVEMBER 13 · PSALM 124

If the LORD Had Not Been on Our Side

> *"If it had not been Yahweh who was on our side, let Israel now say"*
> — PSALM 124:1

Psalm 124 is a song of looking back and imagining the worst: *"If it had not been Yahweh who was on our side, let Israel now say, if it had not been Yahweh who was on our side, when men rose up against us; then they would have swallowed us up alive, when their wrath was kindled against us"* (Psalm 124:1–3). If. What if God had not been there? The answer is terrifying. They would have been swallowed alive.

Then a picture of a flood: *"then the waters would have overwhelmed us, the stream would have gone over our soul; then the proud waters would have gone over our soul"* (Psalm 124:4–5). A flash flood roaring down a dry wadi, sweeping away everything in its path. That is what would have happened without God. The psalmist does not pretend the danger was small. He looks at it squarely and sees how close the disaster came, the way a driver shakes after a near miss on an icy road.

That is a healthy exercise. Look back at your own life and ask: where would I be if God had not been on my side? The car accident that could have been worse. The diagnosis that came early enough. The temptation you almost gave in to. The season of despair you somehow survived. Many people take these rescues for granted. Psalm 124 asks you to stop and realize how close the flood came, and Who held it back.

Then the praise: *"Blessed be Yahweh, who has not given us as a prey to their teeth. Our soul has escaped like a bird out of the fowler's snare. The snare is broken, and we have escaped"* (Psalm 124:6–7). Like a bird in a trap. The snare clamped down, and then it broke, and the bird flew free. The bird did not break it. God did. And the psalm ends with a line many churches open worship with: *"Our help is in Yahweh's name, who made heaven and earth"* (Psalm 124:8). Paul asks, *"If God is for us, who can be against us?"* (Romans 8:31). Look back today. Count the floods that did not drown you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went into the flood that would have swallowed you. The proud waters of judgment went over His soul at the cross, and the snare of death closed on Him. On the third day the snare broke and He rose. Because He was swallowed, you escaped. Count the floods He held back from you today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Looking back, where would you be if the LORD had not been on your side?

◆

DAY 318 · NOVEMBER 14 · PSALM 125

Like Mount Zion, Which Cannot Be Moved

> *"Those who trust in Yahweh are as Mount Zion, which can't be moved"*
> — PSALM 125:1

Psalm 125 uses the mountains of Jerusalem to describe the people of God: *"Those who trust in Yahweh are as Mount Zion, which can't be moved, but remains forever"* (Psalm 125:1). Mount Zion. Solid rock. It has stood for thousands of years. Armies have marched past it, empires have risen and fallen around it, and the mountain is still there. That is what a person who trusts God is like. Not easily moved by fear or pressure. Still standing when everything else falls.

Then a second picture: *"As the mountains surround Jerusalem, so Yahweh surrounds his people from this time forward and forever more"* (Psalm 125:2). Jerusalem sits in a ring of hills. Wherever you stand in the city, there are hills on every side. That is how God surrounds His people. Not just in front of them or behind them. All around. Every direction covered. Paul says nothing *"will be able to separate us from God's love which is in Christ Jesus our Lord"* (Romans 8:39).

Then a promise about evil: *"For the scepter of wickedness won't remain over the allotment of the righteous; so that the righteous won't use their hands to do evil"* (Psalm 125:3). Evil rule will not last forever over God's people. And there is a reason: if it lasted too long, even the righteous might be tempted to give up and join it. God limits the time of oppression so that His people do not break. He knows how much you can bear. That does not make the hard season easy, but it gives it an end.

"Do good, Yahweh, to those who are good, to those who are upright in their hearts. But as for those who turn away to their crooked ways, Yahweh will lead them away with the workers of iniquity. Peace be on Israel" (Psalm 125:4–5). Two paths. The upright and the crooked. And the psalm ends with a blessing: peace. Isaiah says, *"For the mountains may depart, and the hills be removed; but my loving kindness will not depart from you"* (Isaiah 54:10). Even if the mountains move, God's love will not. Trust Him today, and be like Zion.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the mountain that cannot be moved. Death itself could not shake Him; the grave could not hold Him. He rose, and now those who trust in Him are as steady as Zion, surrounded by the Lord forever. Even if the mountains move, His love for you will not. Trust Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When everything around you shifts, are you trusting in the LORD who surrounds you like mountains?

◆

DAY 319 · NOVEMBER 15 · PSALM 126

Those Who Sow in Tears

"Those who sow in tears will reap in joy."
— PSALM 126:5

Psalm 126 remembers a moment of joy so great it felt like a dream: *"When Yahweh brought back those who returned to Zion, we were like those who dream"* (Psalm 126:1). Like a dream. When the exiles came home from Babylon, they could hardly believe it was real. They had wept by the rivers for years. A whole generation had grown up in a foreign land, hearing stories of a home they had never seen. And now they were walking back into Jerusalem.

"Then our mouth was filled with laughter, and our tongue with singing. Then they said among the nations, 'Yahweh has done great things for them'" (Psalm 126:2). Laughter and singing. Even the foreign nations noticed. Look what God has done for them. And the people agreed: *"Yahweh has done great things for us, and we are glad"* (Psalm 126:3). Great things. Gladness. That is what restoration feels like after a long exile.

But the psalm does not stay there. It turns to a prayer, because the restoration was not finished: *"Restore our fortunes again, Yahweh, like the streams in the Negev"* (Psalm 126:4). The Negev is a desert in the south of Israel. Its riverbeds are dry most of the year. Then the rains come, and suddenly they rush with water. That is what the psalmist asks for — a sudden flood of renewal in a dry land. Not a slow trickle. A rush.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Those who sow in tears will reap in joy"* (Psalm 126:5). Sowing in tears. Planting seed when everything is hard, when you are grieving, when there is no sign of a harvest. And the promise: you will reap in joy. *"He who goes out weeping, carrying seed for sowing, will certainly come again with joy, carrying his sheaves"* (Psalm 126:6). Weeping on the way out. Joy on the way back. Paul says, *"Let's not be weary in doing good, for we will reap in due season, if we don't give up"* (Galatians 6:9). If you are sowing in tears today — praying for a child, serving without thanks, grieving and still obeying — keep sowing. The harvest is coming.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went out weeping, carrying the seed of His own life to the cross. He was planted in the ground like a grain of wheat and rose on the third day to bear much fruit. Because of Him, your tears are seeds, not waste. Keep sowing today. You will reap in joy.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you sowing in tears right now — and can you trust that you will reap in joy?

◆

DAY 320 · NOVEMBER 16 · PSALM 127

Unless the LORD Builds the House

> *"Unless Yahweh builds the house, they who build it labor in vain."*
> — PSALM 127:1

Psalm 127 has a heading that connects it to Solomon, the king who built the temple. And it begins with a sobering truth: *"Unless Yahweh builds the house, they who build it labor in vain. Unless Yahweh watches over the city, the watchman guards it in vain"* (Psalm 127:1). In vain. All the work, all the planning, all the effort — useless without God. The builder can lay every stone perfectly. The watchman can stay awake all night. If God is not in it, it comes to nothing.

That applies to every kind of house. A family. A business. A church. A career. A life. You can work hard at all of them and still build on sand. The question is not only how hard you work, but whether God is the builder. Jesus said, *"But seek first God's Kingdom, and his righteousness; and all these things will be given to you as well"* (Matthew 6:33). Seek Him first. Then build.

Then a word to the overworked: *"It is vain for you to rise up early, to stay up late, eating the bread of toil, for he gives sleep to his loved ones"* (Psalm 127:2). Early to rise, late to bed, eating anxious bread. Many people live that way. Grinding. Worrying. Never resting. And the psalm says it is vain if it comes from anxiety instead of trust. God gives sleep to His beloved. Rest is a gift. It is a sign of trust. You can lie down because God is still working while you sleep.

Then the psalm speaks about children: *"Behold, children are a heritage of Yahweh. The fruit of the womb is his reward"* (Psalm 127:3). A heritage. A gift from God, not a product of human effort. For those who have children, that is a call to receive them with thanks and raise them under God's hand. For those who do not, the deeper point still holds: everything good in your life is a gift, not an achievement. Jesus welcomed the little children and said, *"God's Kingdom belongs to such as these"* (Mark 10:14). Let God build your house today. Then rest. He gives sleep to His loved ones.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the builder of God's house. He laid Himself down as its foundation on the cross and rose to build a people for God out of living stones. Stop building in vain today. Let Him build your house. Then lie down and sleep. He is still working while you rest.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What are you trying to build in your own strength, eating the bread of anxious toil?

◆

DAY 321 · NOVEMBER 17 · PSALM 128

Blessed Is Everyone Who Fears the LORD

> *"Blessed is everyone who fears Yahweh, who walks in his ways."*
> — PSALM 128:1

Psalm 128 begins with a blessing that is open to everyone: *"Blessed is everyone who fears Yahweh, who walks in his ways"* (Psalm 128:1). Everyone. Not only kings or priests or the especially holy. Anyone who fears the LORD and walks His road. The fear of the LORD is not a feeling that stays in the heart. It shows up in the feet. It walks. It changes where you go and how you live.

Then a picture of ordinary blessing: *"For you will eat the labor of your hands. You will be happy, and it will be well with you"* (Psalm 128:2). Eat what you work for. That sounds simple, but in the ancient world it was not guaranteed. Raiders stole harvests. Landlords took the crops. Drought ruined fields. To eat the fruit of your own labor was a real gift. The blessing of God reaches into the daily work of your hands.

Then the household: *"Your wife will be as a fruitful vine in the innermost parts of your house, your children like olive plants around your table"* (Psalm 128:3). A vine in the house. Olive shoots around the table. The psalm pictures a family gathered for a meal, growing and green. Not every reader has that kind of household. Some are single. Some are widowed. Some long for children who have not come. The deeper promise is for all of them: the one who fears the LORD is not left without His blessing at the table of life.

"Behold, thus is the man blessed who fears Yahweh. May Yahweh bless you out of Zion, and may you see the good of Jerusalem all the days of your life. Yes, may you see your children's children. Peace be upon Israel" (Psalm 128:4–6). The blessing widens from the house to the city to the nation. One person's faithfulness ripples outward. Proverbs says, *"The fear of Yahweh is the beginning of knowledge"* (Proverbs 1:7). And Jesus said, *"Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest"* (Matthew 11:28). Walk in His ways today, at work and at home. His blessing meets you there.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ walked in the ways of the Father perfectly, and He gives the blessing of Psalm 128 to everyone who is in Him — married or single, with children or without. He died and rose to bring His people to His own table. Walk in His ways today. You are not left out of His blessing.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

How does your fear of the LORD show up in your work and your home today?

◆

DAY 322 · NOVEMBER 18 · PSALM 129

They Have Not Prevailed Against Me

> *"many times they have afflicted me from my youth up, yet they have not prevailed against me."*
> — PSALM 129:2

Psalm 129 is the song of a survivor. It begins with Israel looking back over its whole history: *"Many times they have afflicted me from my youth up. Let Israel now say, many times they have afflicted me from my youth up, yet they have not prevailed against me"* (Psalm 129:1–2). From youth. From the very beginning. Egypt, the wilderness, the Philistines, Assyria, Babylon. Enemy after enemy. Empire after empire. And yet. They have not prevailed. Every one of those great powers is gone now, and the people of God are still here.

Then a painful picture: *"The plowers plowed on my back. They made their furrows long"* (Psalm 129:3). Plows dragged across the back, cutting long grooves. It is a picture of whipping — deep, cruel wounds, like a field torn open. That is what the nations did to Israel. And when you read it after the Gospels, it is hard not to think of Jesus, whose back was torn by a Roman scourge before He was crucified. Isaiah said, *"by his wounds we are healed"* (Isaiah 53:5).

Then the turn: *"Yahweh is righteous. He has cut apart the cords of the wicked"* (Psalm 129:4). The plowers had their animals harnessed with cords. God cut the ropes. The plow stopped. The cruelty ended. Not because Israel was strong enough to fight back, but because the LORD is righteous. He sets a limit to oppression. The plowing does not go on forever. There is a day when the furrows end, and the field is left to heal.

You may carry long furrows on your back. Years of affliction, from your youth up. Abuse, poverty, illness, injustice, grief. And maybe you have wondered whether it will ever stop. Psalm 129 says: they have not prevailed. You are still here. The cords have been cut before, and they will be cut again. Jesus said, *"In the world you have trouble; but cheer up! I have overcome the world"* (John 16:33). The psalm ends by wishing the oppressors would wither *"as the grass on the housetops, which withers before it grows up"* (Psalm 129:6). Shallow roots. No harvest. The afflicters fade. The afflicted, held by God, remain.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's back was plowed by the scourge, the furrows long and deep. He bore those wounds for you, and by them you are healed. On the third day He rose, and the cords of death were cut forever. Whatever furrows you carry today, they have not prevailed. He has overcome.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What long furrows have been plowed on your back — and can you say, they have not prevailed?

◆

DAY 323 · NOVEMBER 19 · PSALM 130

Out of the Depths

"Out of the depths I have cried to you, Yahweh."
— PSALM 130:1

Psalm 130 begins at the bottom: *"Out of the depths I have cried to you, Yahweh"* (Psalm 130:1). The depths. The deep waters. The pit. The place where the light barely reaches. This is not a prayer from a comfortable chair. It is a cry from the bottom of everything. And notice what the depths are, in this psalm. Not only trouble from outside. Guilt. The weight of sin pulling the soul down.

"Lord, hear my voice. Let your ears be attentive to the voice of my petitions" (Psalm 130:2). Then the question that every honest person has to face: *"If you, Yah, kept a record of sins, Lord, who could stand?"* (Psalm 130:3). If God kept score. If every sin were written down and counted against you. Who could stand? No one. Not the best person you know. Not you. The record would bury everyone.

Then the line that turns the whole psalm: *"But there is forgiveness with you, therefore you are feared"* (Psalm 130:4). But. Forgiveness. With You. God does not keep the record against His people. He forgives. And notice what forgiveness produces: fear. Not terror, but deep reverence. You would think forgiveness would make people careless. The opposite is true. When you understand how much you have been forgiven, you stand in awe of the God who forgave you. John says, *"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous to forgive us the sins"* (1 John 1:9).

Then waiting: *"I wait for Yahweh. My soul waits. I hope in his word. My soul longs for the Lord more than watchmen long for the morning, more than watchmen for the morning"* (Psalm 130:5–6). A night watchman on the city wall, cold and tired, staring at the eastern sky, waiting for the first gray light. That is how the soul waits for God. And the psalm ends in hope: *"Israel, hope in Yahweh, for there is loving kindness with Yahweh. Abundant redemption is with him. He will redeem Israel from all their sins"* (Psalm 130:7–8). All their sins. Paul says, *"There is therefore now no condemnation to those who are in Christ Jesus"* (Romans 8:1). Cry from the depths today. There is forgiveness.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went into the depths for you, carrying the full record of your sins to the cross, where it was nailed and canceled. On the third day the morning came, and He rose. There is forgiveness with God because of Him. Cry to Him from your depths today. Abundant redemption is waiting.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If God kept a record of your sins, who could stand — and do you believe there is forgiveness with Him?

◆

DAY 324 · NOVEMBER 20 · PSALM 131

Like a Weaned Child

"Surely I have stilled and quieted my soul"
— PSALM 131:2

Psalm 131 is only three verses long, and it may be the quietest psalm in the whole book. It begins with humility: *"Yahweh, my heart isn't arrogant, nor my eyes lofty; nor do I concern myself with great matters, or things too wonderful for me"* (Psalm 131:1). Not arrogant. Not looking down on others. Not trying to grasp things too big to understand. David had been a king. He knew about great matters. And he chose to set them down.

That is a freeing choice. Many people exhaust themselves trying to understand everything, control everything, figure out every mystery. Why did this happen? What is God doing? How will it all work out? Some questions have answers. Others are too wonderful for anyone — beyond what a human mind can hold. Psalm 131 says you do not have to carry those. You can leave them with God. Paul says, *"doing nothing through rivalry or through conceit, but in humility, each counting others better than himself"* (Philippians 2:3).

Then the picture that gives this day its name: *"Surely I have stilled and quieted my soul, like a weaned child with his mother, like a weaned child is my soul within me"* (Psalm 131:2). A weaned child. Not a nursing baby, crying for milk, restless and demanding. A child old enough to be weaned, who sits on a mother's lap content just to be near, not grabbing for what it wants. Quiet. Still. At rest because the parent is there.

That is a picture of mature faith. Not frantic. Not demanding. Content to be near God even when you do not get everything you ask for. That takes time to learn. Paul said, *"I have learned in whatever state I am, to be content in it"* (Philippians 4:11). Learned. It does not come naturally. Jesus said, *"unless you turn, and become as little children, you will in no way enter into the Kingdom of Heaven"* (Matthew 18:3). The psalm ends: *"Israel, hope in Yahweh, from this time forward and forever more"* (Psalm 131:3). Still your soul today. Sit quietly with God. You do not have to understand everything to be at rest.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ humbled Himself and did not grasp at what was His, emptying Himself all the way to the cross. He rested in the Father's will in Gethsemane and rose on the third day. Still and quiet your soul in Him today. You do not have to understand everything. You only have to stay near.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What great matters are you trying to carry that you could set down, and rest like a weaned child?

◆

DAY 325 · NOVEMBER 21 · PSALM 132 (VV. 1–6)

He Swore to the LORD

> *"until I find out a place for Yahweh, a dwelling for the Mighty One of Jacob."*
> — PSALM 132:5

Psalm 132 remembers David's passion for God's house: *"Yahweh, remember David and all his affliction, how he swore to Yahweh, and vowed to the Mighty One of Jacob"* (Psalm 132:1–2). David made a vow. And it was intense: *"Surely I will not come into the structure of my house, nor go up into my bed; I will not give sleep to my eyes, or slumber to my eyelids"* (Psalm 132:3–4). No rest. No sleep. Not until something was done. It is the language of a man consumed by one thing.

What was it? *"until I find out a place for Yahweh, a dwelling for the Mighty One of Jacob"* (Psalm 132:5). A place for God. David lived in a palace of cedar, and the ark of the covenant was in a tent. It bothered him deeply, the way a good son is bothered when his father has less than he does. He could not rest comfortably while God's house was less than his own. Second Samuel tells the story: David wanted to build a house for God, and God told him his son would build it instead (2 Samuel 7:12–13).

That kind of passion for God's presence is rare. David cared more about God having a place among His people than about his own comfort. You may not be building a temple, but the question is the same. Does your passion for God's presence outweigh your passion for your own comfort? Do you lose sleep over your house — the mortgage, the repairs, the furniture — more than you think about making room for God in your life?

Then the psalm remembers the search: *"Behold, we heard of it in Ephrathah. We found it in the field of Jaar"* (Psalm 132:6). Ephrathah is near Bethlehem, David's hometown. The ark had been sitting in a field, nearly forgotten, for years. And they went to find it and bring it to Jerusalem. That is the shape of revival. God's presence had been neglected, left in a field. And someone cared enough to go and bring it home. Jesus said His own body was the true temple (John 2:21). God has made His dwelling with people in Christ. Make room for Him today.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

David longed to build a house for God, and God built a house for David instead — a dynasty that led to Christ. Jesus is the true temple, destroyed on the cross and raised in three days. God now dwells with His people through Him. Make room for Him in your life today, ahead of your own comfort.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Does your passion for God's presence outweigh your concern for your own comfort?

◆

DAY 326 · NOVEMBER 22 · PSALM 132 (VV. 7–12)

Arise, O LORD, to Your Resting Place

> *"Arise, Yahweh, into your resting place, you, and the ark of your strength."*
> — PSALM 132:8

Psalm 132 now pictures the people bringing the ark to Jerusalem: *"We will go into his dwelling place. We will worship at his footstool"* (Psalm 132:7). His footstool. The ark was seen as the place where God rested His feet on earth. To worship there was to kneel at the feet of the King. It is the humblest place in the house, and the closest. Then the prayer: *"Arise, Yahweh, into your resting place, you, and the ark of your strength"* (Psalm 132:8).

Arise, LORD. Come up into Your resting place. These words echo what Moses said whenever the ark set out in the wilderness. Now the ark is not traveling anymore. It is coming to rest in Jerusalem. God is settling among His people. And the psalm prays for the priests and the people: *"Let your priests be clothed with righteousness. Let your saints shout for joy!"* (Psalm 132:9). Clothed with righteousness. Shouting for joy. The priests dressed in what God gives, and the people unable to keep quiet.

Then a prayer for the king: *"For your servant David's sake, don't turn away the face of your anointed one"* (Psalm 132:10). And then God's answer, a promise: *"Yahweh has sworn to David in truth. He will not turn from it: 'I will set the fruit of your body on your throne'"* (Psalm 132:11). God swore an oath. He will not turn from it. A son of David will sit on the throne. That promise runs through the whole Old Testament and lands in the New. Through exile and ruin and four hundred silent years, it waited.

Peter preached it at Pentecost: *"being a prophet, and knowing that God had sworn with an oath to him that of the fruit of his body, according to the flesh, he would raise up the Christ to sit on his throne, he foreseeing this spoke about the resurrection of the Christ"* (Acts 2:30–31). The fruit of David's body is Jesus. God kept His oath. He raised Christ and seated Him on David's throne forever. The angel told Mary, *"There will be no end to his Kingdom"* (Luke 1:33). Worship at His feet today. The promise has been kept.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God swore to David that his son would sit on the throne forever, and He kept that oath when He raised Christ from the dead. The Son of David now reigns, and His kingdom will have no end. Worship at His feet today. Every promise God swore has come true in Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you live as though God has kept His oath — with Christ on the throne right now?

◆

DAY 327 · NOVEMBER 23 · PSALM 132 (VV. 13–18)

This Is My Resting Place Forever

> *"This is my resting place forever. I will live here, for I have desired it."*
> — PSALM 132:14

The last part of Psalm 132 is God Himself speaking about His chosen city: *"For Yahweh has chosen Zion. He has desired it for his habitation"* (Psalm 132:13). Chosen. Desired. God did not end up in Jerusalem by accident. He wanted to live there. He chose it. And then He says it Himself: *"This is my resting place forever. I will live here, for I have desired it"* (Psalm 132:14).

My resting place forever. God is not a visitor who stops by and leaves. He settles. He makes His home, the way a family moves into a house and hangs pictures on the walls. And the reason is desire. He wants to be with His people. That is astonishing. The God who fills heaven and earth chooses a place to rest, and that place is among people. Revelation sees the final fulfillment: *"Behold, God's dwelling is with people, and he will dwell with them, and they will be his people"* (Revelation 21:3).

And God promises what He will do there: *"I will abundantly bless her provision. I will satisfy her poor with bread. I will also clothe her priests with salvation. Her saints will shout aloud for joy"* (Psalm 132:15–16). Bread for the poor. Salvation for the priests. Joy for the saints. Where God rests, blessing flows, the way water spreads from a spring into the dry ground around it. Then a promise about the king: *"I will make the horn of David to bud there. I have ordained a lamp for my anointed"* (Psalm 132:17). A horn — strength. A lamp — light that keeps burning.

"I will clothe his enemies with shame, but on himself, his crown will shine" (Psalm 132:18). The enemies wear shame. The king wears a shining crown. That is Christ. His enemies once clothed Him in a purple robe and a crown of thorns to mock Him. Now He wears a crown that shines forever, and no one can mock it again. And God has chosen to rest among His people through Him. Jesus said, *"I am going to prepare a place for you"* (John 14:2). God desires to dwell with you. Let Him make His home in your heart today.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God chose to make His resting place among people, and He did it most fully in Christ, who wore a crown of thorns before a crown of glory. Christ rose and prepares a place for you, so that God can dwell with you forever. He desires to be with you. Make room for Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe God desires to make His home with you — and are you making room for Him?

◆

DAY 328 · NOVEMBER 24 · PSALM 133

How Good and Pleasant Is Unity

> *"See how good and how pleasant it is for brothers to live together in unity!"*
> — PSALM 133:1

Psalm 133 is a short song about something rare and precious: *"See how good and how pleasant it is for brothers to live together in unity!"* (Psalm 133:1). Good and pleasant. Two words that do not always go together. Some things are good but not pleasant, like hard medicine. Some things are pleasant but not good, like too much dessert. Unity among God's people is both. Good for the soul, and sweet to experience.

Then a strange picture: *"It is like the precious oil on the head, that ran down on the beard, even Aaron's beard, that came down on the edge of his robes"* (Psalm 133:2). When Aaron was anointed as high priest, oil was poured on his head, so much that it ran down his beard and onto his robes. It was a sign of being set apart for God. Unity among believers is like that anointing — rich, overflowing, a mark of God's blessing that spreads from the head down to the whole body.

Then a second picture: *"like the dew of Hermon, that comes down on the hills of Zion"* (Psalm 133:3). Mount Hermon, far to the north, was known for heavy dew. The psalm imagines that dew falling on Zion. Fresh, life-giving moisture on dry ground. That is what unity does in a community. It refreshes. It brings life. And then the reason: *"for there Yahweh gives the blessing, even life forever more"* (Psalm 133:3). There. In the place of unity. That is where God commands His blessing.

Division in God's family is common, and it is painful. Churches split. Friendships break. Families stop speaking. And every division drains the life out of a community. Jesus prayed for His people on the night before He died: *"that they may all be one; even as you, Father, are in me, and I in you"* (John 17:21). One. Paul urged believers to be *"eager to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace"* (Ephesians 4:3). Eager. Working at it. Is there someone in God's family you need to make peace with? Unity is good and pleasant. It is also where God pours out His blessing.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ prayed that His people would be one, and then He died to make them one, breaking down every wall between them. He rose, and His Spirit binds His people together. Where is division in your life with another believer? Take a step toward peace today. That is where God commands the blessing.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is there someone in God's family you need to take a step toward, for the sake of unity?

◆

DAY 329 · NOVEMBER 25 · PSALM 134

Bless the LORD, All You Servants

"Lift up your hands in the sanctuary. Praise Yahweh!"
— PSALM 134:2

Psalm 134 is the last of the Songs of Ascents. The pilgrims have traveled up to Jerusalem, worshiped in the temple, and now the psalm speaks to the people who stay behind when the crowds go home: *"Look! Praise Yahweh, all you servants of Yahweh, who stand by night in Yahweh's house!"* (Psalm 134:1). The night shift. The priests and Levites who kept watch in the temple after dark, when no one else was there. The lamps burned low. The courts were empty. The city was asleep.

They were not on stage. No crowds were watching. The festival was over. And still they stood in God's house through the night. That is a picture of faithful service that goes unseen. Many believers serve this way. The nursery worker no one thanks. The person who prays for the church every night. The one who cleans the building, stacks the chairs, sits with the dying. Night-shift faithfulness. God sees it all. He notices the hours no one else notices. He keeps the record no one else keeps. Not one quiet act of service is wasted in His sight.

Then the call: *"Lift up your hands in the sanctuary. Praise Yahweh!"* (Psalm 134:2). Lift up your hands. In the dark, in the quiet, with no one watching, lift your hands to God and bless Him. Praise is not only for the big gatherings with music and crowds. It belongs in the night watches too. The servant who praises God alone in the dark is just as much a worshiper as the choir on a feast day.

And then the blessing returned: *"May Yahweh bless you from Zion, even he who made heaven and earth"* (Psalm 134:3). The servants bless God, and God blesses the servants. It goes both ways, like a conversation between friends at the end of a long day. And the One who blesses is the Maker of heaven and earth. Jesus spent whole nights in prayer: *"he went out to the mountain to pray, and he continued all night in prayer to God"* (Luke 6:12). If you are serving in a quiet, unseen place right now, you are not forgotten. Lift your hands tonight. Bless the LORD. He blesses you back.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ served in the night watches, praying alone on mountains while others slept, and in Gethsemane while His friends could not stay awake. He went to the cross unseen by most of the world and rose to bless His servants forever. Your unseen service is seen by Him. Lift your hands tonight.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you serving unseen — and will you lift your hands and bless the LORD there?

◆

DAY 330 · NOVEMBER 26 · PSALM 135 (VV. 1–7)

Praise the Name of the LORD

> *"Praise Yah, for Yahweh is good. Sing praises to his name, for that is pleasant."*
> — PSALM 135:3

Psalm 135 opens with a call to the people who serve in God's house: *"Praise Yah! Praise Yahweh's name! Praise him, you servants of Yahweh, you who stand in Yahweh's house, in the courts of our God's house"* (Psalm 135:1–2). It sounds like Psalm 134 continued. The night shift has finished, and now everyone is called to praise. Then the reason: *"Praise Yah, for Yahweh is good. Sing praises to his name, for that is pleasant"* (Psalm 135:3).

Good, and pleasant. Again those two words together. God is good, and singing to Him is pleasant. Praise is not a heavy duty you drag yourself through. It is sweet. When your heart is turned toward God, singing His praise is one of the most satisfying things you can do. It is like finally saying thank you to someone who has done everything for you. The relief and joy of it, the burden lifting as the words come out.

Then a reason for praise that should humble you: *"For Yah has chosen Jacob for himself, Israel for his own possession"* (Psalm 135:4). Chosen. His own possession. Jacob was not chosen because he was impressive. He was a schemer and a liar. God chose him anyway, out of grace. Peter applies this to believers in Christ: *"But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God's own possession"* (1 Peter 2:9). You are His. Not because you earned it. Because He chose you. That is the deepest ground of praise there is.

Then the psalm declares God's greatness: *"For I know that Yahweh is great, that our Lord is above all gods. Whatever Yahweh pleased, that he has done, in heaven and in earth, in the seas and in all deeps"* (Psalm 135:5–6). Whatever He pleases, He does. And the psalm points to the weather: *"He causes the clouds to rise from the ends of the earth. He makes lightnings with the rain. He brings the wind out of his treasuries"* (Psalm 135:7). Clouds, lightning, rain, wind. All of it from His storehouses. Praise Him today. He is good, and it is pleasant to sing to Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the chosen One, and in Him you are chosen too — part of God's own possession, purchased by His blood on the cross. He rose, and now praise to His name is the sweetest work there is. Sing to Him today. He is good, and it is pleasant to praise Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you experience praise as a heavy duty — or as something good and pleasant?

◆

DAY 331 · NOVEMBER 27 · PSALM 135 (VV. 8–14)

The LORD Will Vindicate His People

"For Yahweh will judge his people and have compassion on his servants."
— PSALM 135:14

Psalm 135 turns to the history of God's rescue: *"He struck the firstborn of Egypt, both of man and animal. He sent signs and wonders into the middle of you, Egypt, on Pharaoh, and on all his servants"* (Psalm 135:8–9). The plagues. The Passover. God's power poured out on the empire that enslaved His people. Then the conquest: *"He struck many nations, and killed mighty kings, Sihon king of the Amorites, Og king of Bashan, and all the kingdoms of Canaan"* (Psalm 135:10–11).

Sihon and Og were kings east of the Jordan, strong rulers who stood in Israel's way. God brought them down. And then He gave the land: *"and gave their land for a heritage, a heritage to Israel, his people"* (Psalm 135:12). A heritage. An inheritance. Not earned, but given. Then the psalm turns to God's name: *"Your name, Yahweh, endures forever; your renown, Yahweh, throughout all generations"* (Psalm 135:13). Kings fall. Empires fade. His name lasts. Who remembers Sihon today, except as a name in this psalm? But everyone who reads it remembers the God who brought him down.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"For Yahweh will judge his people and have compassion on his servants"* (Psalm 135:14). Judge and have compassion. Those two go together. God will set right what is wrong among His people — vindicate them, defend them, bring justice. And He will have compassion on them. He sees their suffering. He feels it. His justice is not cold. It is warm with mercy. A good judge can be fair without caring. God is fair and cares deeply at the same time.

That is good news for anyone who has been wronged and is waiting for God to act. He will judge. He will set things right. And He will do it with compassion for you. Lamentations says, *"It is because of Yahweh's loving kindnesses that we are not consumed, because his compassion doesn't fail"* (Lamentations 3:22). His compassion does not fail. Whatever kings stand in your way, whatever empire seems to hold you, the God who brought down Sihon and Og is the same God who sees you with compassion today.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ took the judgment His people deserved so that God's judgment toward them would be vindication and compassion. He died and rose, and now He defends His servants. Whatever powers stand in your way today, the LORD will judge and have compassion on you. His compassion does not fail.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you trust God to both set things right and have compassion on you?

◆

DAY 332 · NOVEMBER 28 · PSALM 135 (VV. 15–21)

Bless the LORD, O House of Israel

> *"House of Israel, praise Yahweh! House of Aaron, praise Yahweh!"*
> — PSALM 135:19

Psalm 135 returns to the theme of Psalm 115 — the emptiness of idols: *"The idols of the nations are silver and gold, the work of men's hands. They have mouths, but they can't speak. They have eyes, but they can't see. They have ears, but they can't hear, neither is there any breath in their mouths"* (Psalm 135:15–17). No breath. That is the key detail. The living God breathed life into dust. The idols have no breath at all. They are dead things made by living hands. The craftsman breathes while he carves them. The idol never will.

"Those who make them will be like them, yes, everyone who trusts in them" (Psalm 135:18). The same warning as before. You become what you worship. Trust in breathless things, and you become breathless — lifeless, empty, unable to hear God or see His work. That is the danger of idolatry. It does not just waste your devotion. It hollows you out. The more you give to a breathless thing, the less breath you have left. People who chase money or approval for decades often end up empty in a way they cannot describe.

Then a call to everyone to praise the true God instead: *"House of Israel, praise Yahweh! House of Aaron, praise Yahweh! House of Levi, praise Yahweh! You who fear Yahweh, praise Yahweh!"* (Psalm 135:19–20). Four groups. Israel — all the people. Aaron — the priests. Levi — the temple servants. And those who fear the LORD — anyone, from any nation, who reveres Him. The circle widens until no one is left out, not even the stranger at the edge of the crowd.

And the psalm ends where it began: *"Blessed be Yahweh from Zion, who dwells at Jerusalem. Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 135:21). The living God dwells among His people. Not a statue on a shelf, but a God who breathes and speaks and acts. The choice is simple. You can trust a dead idol and become like it. Or you can praise the living God and come alive. Revelation shows the redeemed singing: *"Great and marvelous are your works, Lord God, the Almighty! Righteous and true are your ways"* (Revelation 15:3). Praise Him today, whatever house you belong to. He is alive.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the living God who breathes life into dust. The idols have no breath, but He breathed His last on the cross and then rose on the third day, alive forever. Turn from every breathless idol today. Praise the living God, and come alive in Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Which breathless idol are you tempted to trust — and will you turn to praise the living God instead?

◆

DAY 333 · NOVEMBER 29 · PSALM 136 (VV. 1–6)

His Steadfast Love Endures Forever

> *"Give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good; for his loving kindness endures forever."*
> — PSALM 136:1

Psalm 136 is built like a litany. Every single verse ends with the same line: *"for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 136:1). Twenty-six times. It was probably sung with one voice calling out the first half of each verse and the whole congregation answering with the refrain. Over and over. His loving kindness endures forever. By the end, no one could forget it. It would be ringing in their ears on the walk home.

It begins: *"Give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good; for his loving kindness endures forever. Give thanks to the God of gods; for his loving kindness endures forever. Give thanks to the Lord of lords; for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 136:1–3). Good. God of gods. Lord of lords. Three titles, three reasons to give thanks. And every one ends with the same refrain. Whatever else is true about God, this is true: His love endures forever.

Then the psalm turns to creation: *"to him who alone does great wonders; for his loving kindness endures forever: to him who by understanding made the heavens; for his loving kindness endures forever: to him who spread out the earth above the waters; for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 136:4–6). The heavens, made with wisdom. The earth, spread out over the waters. And every act of creation is tied to His love. He made the world because He loves. Not because He needed it, not because He was lonely, but because love overflows and makes room for others.

Repetition can feel boring, like a child asking the same question again. But some truths need to be repeated until they sink in. You may know that God loves you. But do you know it deep down, in the place where fear and shame live? Psalm 136 does not say it once. It says it twenty-six times, because the human heart is slow to believe. John says, *"In this is love, not that we loved God, but that he loved us, and sent his Son as the atoning sacrifice for our sins"* (1 John 4:10). Say the refrain today, out loud, again and again. His loving kindness endures forever. Let it sink in.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The greatest proof that God's loving kindness endures forever is the cross, where Christ gave Himself for you, and the empty tomb, where His love outlasted death. Say it today, again and again, until it sinks in: His loving kindness endures forever. It is true for you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you know deep down — where fear and shame live — that God's loving kindness endures forever?

◆

DAY 334 · NOVEMBER 30 · PSALM 136 (VV. 7–13)

To Him Who Divided the Sea

> *"to him who divided the Red Sea apart; for his loving kindness endures forever"*
> — PSALM 136:13

Psalm 136 moves from creation to the lights in the sky: *"to him who made the great lights; for his loving kindness endures forever: the sun to rule by day; for his loving kindness endures forever; the moon and stars to rule by night; for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 136:7–9). The sun and moon and stars. Every sunrise, every moonlit night, every starry sky is a reminder that His loving kindness endures forever. You do not have to go to church to see a sermon. Look up.

Then the psalm turns to history, and the refrain keeps going: *"to him who struck down the Egyptian firstborn; for his loving kindness endures forever; and brought out Israel from among them; for his loving kindness endures forever; with a strong hand, and with an outstretched arm; for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 136:10–12). The Passover. The exodus. The strong hand and the outstretched arm of God, rescuing slaves from the world's mightiest empire.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"to him who divided the Red Sea apart; for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 136:13). Divided the sea. The waters stood up like walls, and the people walked through on dry ground. Exodus says, *"the waters were a wall to them on their right hand, and on their left"* (Exodus 14:22). And the psalm says that miracle happened because His loving kindness endures forever. The sea split because God loves His people.

That is how to read your own story. When God opens a way through what should have drowned you, it is not luck. It is not chance or good timing. It is His loving kindness, steady and personal. When He keeps the sun rising on your worst days, it is His loving kindness. When He brings you out of what enslaved you, it is His loving kindness. Every act of God in your life ends with the same refrain. Paul says, *"in all these things, we are more than conquerors through him who loved us"* (Romans 8:37). Look back today at the seas He has divided for you. Add the refrain to each one.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ divided the sea of death for His people. He went into its depths at the cross and came up on the other side on the third day, opening a way through for everyone who follows Him. Every rescue in your life is His loving kindness. Add the refrain today: His love endures forever.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When you look back at the seas God has divided for you, can you add the refrain — His loving kindness endures forever?

◆

DAY 335 · DECEMBER 1 · PSALM 136 (VV. 14–20)

Through the Midst of the Sea

"and made Israel to pass through the middle of it; for his loving kindness endures forever"
— PSALM 136:14

Psalm 136 keeps its refrain going through the exodus: *"and made Israel to pass through the middle of it; for his loving kindness endures forever; but overthrew Pharaoh and his army in the Red Sea; for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 136:14–15). Through the middle of the sea. Not around it. Not over it. Right through the middle, with walls of water on either side. And the same water that made a road for Israel swallowed the army chasing them.

Then the wilderness: *"to him who led his people through the wilderness; for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 136:16). Forty years of desert. Forty years of manna and water from the rock and a cloud by day. Every step of it led by God, and every step of it explained by the same refrain. He led them because His love endures. The wilderness was not abandonment. It was a long walk with a God who would not let go.

Then the kings who stood in the way: *"to him who struck great kings; for his loving kindness endures forever; and killed mighty kings; for his loving kindness endures forever: Sihon king of the Amorites; for his loving kindness endures forever; Og king of Bashan; for his loving kindness endures forever"* (Psalm 136:17–20). Great kings. Mighty kings. Named one by one. Every obstacle between God's people and the promise was removed, and every removal is set to the same music.

Notice what the psalm is teaching you. Every chapter of your story, including the hard ones, can be sung to that refrain. The sea you thought would drown you. The wilderness that went on longer than you expected. The giants who blocked your way. God was in all of it, and His love was the reason. You may be in the middle of the sea right now, with water piled up on both sides and no shore in sight. Keep walking. The road He made through the sea does not collapse while His people are on it. Paul says nothing in all creation *"will be able to separate us from God's love which is in Christ Jesus our Lord"* (Romans 8:39).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went through the middle of the sea of death and came out on the third day, opening a road for everyone who follows Him. The waters that closed over Him cannot close over you. Keep walking today, even if the shore is not yet in sight. His loving kindness endures forever.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What sea are you walking through right now — and can you trust the road God has made through it?

◆

DAY 336 · DECEMBER 2 · PSALM 136 (VV. 21–26)

He Remembered Us in Our Low Estate

“who remembered us in our low estate”
— PSALM 136:23

Psalm 136 ends with God’s care brought close to home: *“and gave their land as an inheritance; for his loving kindness endures forever; even a heritage to Israel his servant; for his loving kindness endures forever”* (Psalm 136:21–22). An inheritance. A heritage. Land given, not earned. Then the line that gives this day its name: *“who remembered us in our low estate; for his loving kindness endures forever”* (Psalm 136:23).

Low estate. The bottom of everything. Slavery in Egypt, exile in Babylon, the dust of defeat. That is where God remembered His people. He did not wait for them to climb up to a respectable level. He remembered them low. That is the order of grace: remembered first, lifted second, and never the other way around. Mary sang about this when she was carrying Jesus: *“for he has looked at the humble state of his servant”* (Luke 1:48). And: *“He has put down princes from their thrones, and has exalted the lowly”* (Luke 1:52).

That is the God of this whole year. He remembers dust. He looks at the low. You may be in a low place right now — a low season, a low bank account, a low point in your faith. That is not where God forgets you. That is where He remembers. *“and has delivered us from our adversaries; for his loving kindness endures forever”* (Psalm 136:24). Remembered and rescued. The two go together. When God remembers, He acts. His memory is never idle.

Then the widest circle of all: *“who gives food to every creature; for his loving kindness endures forever”* (Psalm 136:25). Every creature. The sparrow, the lion, the cattle, you. His love feeds them all. And the psalm closes as it began: *“Oh give thanks to the God of heaven; for his loving kindness endures forever”* (Psalm 136:26). The greatest proof of this refrain came when God remembered the whole world in its low estate and sent His Son. Paul says, *“But God commends his own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us”* (Romans 5:8). While still in the low place, before any change. That is when love came.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God remembered you in your low estate when Christ came down to the lowest place — a manger, a cross, a tomb. He died for you while you were still in the dust and rose on the third day to lift you up. He has not forgotten you in your low place. He remembers.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe God remembers you in your low estate — not after you climb out?

◆

DAY 337 · DECEMBER 3 · PSALM 137 (VV. 1–4)

By the Waters of Babylon

> *"By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down. Yes, we wept, when we remembered Zion."*
> — PSALM 137:1

Psalm 137 is a song of exile, and it opens with tears: *"By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down. Yes, we wept, when we remembered Zion"* (Psalm 137:1). The rivers of Babylon — the Euphrates and its canals, far from home. God's people sat on the riverbanks and cried. Jerusalem was in ruins. The temple was burned. Their homes, their land, their worship — all gone. And they remembered. Every street, every gate, every song they had sung in the temple courts. Memory made the loss sharper.

"On the willows in that land, we hung up our harps" (Psalm 137:2). They had brought their instruments into exile. But they could not play them. The music had dried up. So they hung the harps on the trees and left them there. That is what grief does. It silences the songs you used to sing. Things you once did with joy become things you cannot bear to touch. A favorite hymn you skip. A place you avoid. A photo album you leave on the shelf.

Then the cruelty: *"For there, those who led us captive asked us for songs. Those who tormented us demanded songs of joy: 'Sing us one of the songs of Zion!'"* (Psalm 137:3). The captors mocked them. They wanted a happy song about the God who, as they saw it, could not save His own city. It was a taunt. And the exiles answered with a question: *"How can we sing Yahweh's song in a foreign land?"* (Psalm 137:4). How could they? It did not feel possible.

You may know that question. You are in a place you never wanted to be. A diagnosis. A divorce. A move far from home. A grief that has made the world feel foreign. And people around you expect you to be cheerful, to sing the old songs, to act like nothing has changed. Psalm 137 says it is all right to weep. It is all right to hang up your harp for a season. Scripture keeps this lament because God's people need it. Peter calls believers *"foreigners and pilgrims"* (1 Peter 2:11). This world is not fully home yet. Weep by the river if you must. God is there by the river too.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ wept over Jerusalem and was led out of the city like an exile, to die outside its walls. He knows what it is to be in a foreign land, far from His Father's house. He rose and is preparing a home for you. Weep by the river if you must today. He is with you there, and He is bringing you home.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where have you hung up your harp — and can you bring your grief to God by the river?

◆

DAY 338 · DECEMBER 4 · PSALM 137 (VV. 5–9)

If I Forget You, O Jerusalem

> *"If I forget you, Jerusalem, let my right hand forget its skill."*
> — PSALM 137:5

In the middle of exile, the psalmist makes a vow: *"If I forget you, Jerusalem, let my right hand forget its skill. Let my tongue stick to the roof of my mouth if I don't remember you, if I don't prefer Jerusalem above my chief joy"* (Psalm 137:5–6). If I forget. Let my hand fail. Let my tongue go silent. He would rather lose his ability to play and sing than forget the city of God. Jerusalem matters more to him than his own happiness.

That is a fierce kind of loyalty. In Babylon there were comforts. There were jobs, houses, gardens. Many exiles settled in and stopped thinking about home. The psalmist refuses. He will not let the comforts of exile erase his longing for God's city. That is a word for you. This world has its comforts. It is easy to settle in and stop longing for the city of God. Hebrews says the faithful *"desire a better country, that is, a heavenly one"* (Hebrews 11:16).

Then the psalm turns dark, and you should not look away from it: *"Remember, Yahweh, against the children of Edom in the day of Jerusalem, who said, 'Raze it! Raze it even to its foundation!'"* (Psalm 137:7). Edom cheered when Jerusalem fell. And then the hardest lines in the whole book: *"Daughter of Babylon, doomed to destruction, he will be happy who repays you, as you have done to us. Happy shall he be, who takes and dashes your little ones against the rock"* (Psalm 137:8–9).

How do you read that? Not as a command. Not as permission. It is the raw cry of people who watched their own children killed by Babylon's army, and who handed their rage to God instead of acting on it. The Bible records it plainly. But it does not leave you there. Paul says, *"Don't seek revenge yourselves, beloved, but give place to God's wrath"* (Romans 12:19). And Jesus taught, *"love your enemies"* (Matthew 5:44). The answer to Babylon's cruelty is not your vengeance but God's justice — and, at the cross, God's mercy for even His enemies. Remember Zion. Hand your rage to God. Let Him judge.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ never forgot Jerusalem; He set His face toward it and wept over it. There He bore the full weight of God's justice against every cruelty, so that even enemies could be forgiven. He rose. Hand your rage to Him today, and keep your longing fixed on the city He is preparing.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Have the comforts of this world made you forget your longing for the city of God?

◆

DAY 339 · DECEMBER 5 · PSALM 138

You Regard the Lowly

> *"For though Yahweh is high, yet he looks after the lowly; but he knows the proud from afar."*
> — PSALM 138:6

Psalm 138 is a song of thanks after rescue: *"I will give you thanks with my whole heart. Before the gods, I will sing praises to you"* (Psalm 138:1). Whole heart. Out loud. In front of anyone. Then the reason: *"I will bow down toward your holy temple, and give thanks to your Name for your loving kindness and for your truth; for you have exalted your Name and your Word above all"* (Psalm 138:2). His love and His faithfulness. And His word, lifted high above everything.

"In the day that I called, you answered me. You encouraged me with strength in my soul" (Psalm 138:3). That is the simplest summary of a life with God. I called. You answered. You made me strong inside. Not always by changing the outside. Often by strengthening the soul so it could face what was there. Then the psalmist imagines kings joining in: *"All the kings of the earth will give you thanks, Yahweh, for they have heard the words of your mouth"* (Psalm 138:4).

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"For though Yahweh is high, yet he looks after the lowly; but he knows the proud from afar"* (Psalm 138:6). High, and looking after the lowly. The God who is above everything pays close attention to the people at the bottom. And the proud? He knows them from a distance. They keep Him at arm's length, and that is where He stays. Isaiah says God dwells *"with him also who is of a contrite and humble spirit, to revive the spirit of the humble"* (Isaiah 57:15). James says, *"God resists the proud, but gives grace to the humble"* (James 4:6).

Then a promise for hard times: *"Though I walk in the middle of trouble, you will revive me"* (Psalm 138:7). Revive me — the Hebrew is chayah, the same verb as Psalm 119:25. In the middle of trouble, God gives life. And the psalm ends with a confidence you can carry: *"Yahweh will fulfill that which concerns me. Your loving kindness, Yahweh, endures forever. Don't forsake the works of your own hands"* (Psalm 138:8). He will finish what He started in you. Humble yourself today. The High One looks after the lowly.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ, the High One, came down to the lowly. He humbled Himself to the cross, and God exalted Him. He rose to revive the humble and finish the work He began in you. Bow low before Him today. He looks after the lowly, and He will fulfill what concerns you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you keeping God at arm's length with pride — or bowing low where He looks after the lowly?

◆

DAY 340 · DECEMBER 6 · PSALM 139 (VV. 1–6)

You Have Searched Me and Known Me

"Yahweh, you have searched me, and you know me."
— PSALM 139:1

Psalm 139 is one of the most personal psalms in the Bible, and it begins with being known: *"Yahweh, you have searched me, and you know me"* (Psalm 139:1). Searched. Known. Not partly, not on the surface, but all the way down. God has looked into every corner of you. Nothing is hidden. That can be frightening or comforting, depending on whether you trust the One who is looking. A stranger reading your diary is a violation. A loving parent who already knows everything is a refuge.

Then the psalm lists what God knows: *"You know my sitting down and my rising up. You perceive my thoughts from afar. You search out my path and my lying down, and are acquainted with all my ways"* (Psalm 139:2–3). Sitting and rising. Thoughts before they are spoken. The path you walk and the bed you lie in. Every ordinary moment. *"For there is not a word on my tongue, but, behold, Yahweh, you know it altogether"* (Psalm 139:4). He knows your words before you say them, and the ones you swallow before they come out.

That can feel like being watched. But listen to the next line: *"You hem me in behind and before. You laid your hand on me"* (Psalm 139:5). Hemmed in. Surrounded. And His hand on you. Not a hand that grabs or punishes, but a hand that rests on you, the way a parent rests a hand on a child's shoulder in a crowd. God's knowledge of you is not surveillance. It is closeness. He knows you because He is near.

"This knowledge is beyond me. It's lofty. I can't attain it" (Psalm 139:6). Too wonderful. The psalmist cannot get his mind around how completely he is known. You may have spent your life hiding parts of yourself — from others, from yourself, even from God. Psalm 139 says the hiding was never working. He already knows. And He has not walked away. Jesus asked Peter three times after his denial, and Peter said, *"Lord, you know everything. You know that I have affection for you"* (John 21:17). Known fully, and loved still. That is the deepest rest there is.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ knew everything about you before He went to the cross — every sin, every secret, every word before you spoke it. He died for you anyway and rose to keep you near. You are fully known and fully loved. Stop hiding today. Let His hand rest on you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What part of yourself have you been hiding from the God who already knows you completely?

◆

DAY 341 · DECEMBER 7 · PSALM 139 (VV. 7–12)

Where Shall I Flee from Your Presence?

> *"Where could I go from your Spirit? Or where could I flee from your presence?"*
> — PSALM 139:7

Psalm 139 now asks a question: *"Where could I go from your Spirit? Or where could I flee from your presence?"* (Psalm 139:7). Where could I run? It is a question some people ask in fear, wanting to escape God. Others ask it in wonder, realizing they never have to be alone. The psalm answers it by going to the ends of everything.

Up and down: *"If I ascend up into heaven, you are there. If I make my bed in Sheol, behold, you are there!"* (Psalm 139:8). Heaven, the highest place. Sheol, the grave, the lowest place. God is in both. Then east and west: *"If I take the wings of the dawn, and settle in the uttermost parts of the sea, even there your hand will lead me, and your right hand will hold me"* (Psalm 139:9–10). The sunrise in the east. The far edge of the sea in the west. Wherever you go, His hand is already there, leading and holding.

Jonah tried to run. *"But Jonah rose up to flee to Tarshish from the presence of Yahweh"* (Jonah 1:3). He got on a ship going the opposite direction. And God followed him into the storm and into the belly of a fish. You cannot outrun God, however fast you go. Not by moving away, not by changing jobs, not by burying yourself in work or distraction or sin. He is already wherever you are going, waiting.

And even in the darkest place: *"If I say, 'Surely the darkness will overwhelm me. The light around me will be night,' even the darkness doesn't hide from you, but the night shines as the day. The darkness is like light to you"* (Psalm 139:11–12). Darkness is not dark to God. The night you are afraid of, the depression that feels like a closing sky, the grief that turns day into night — none of it hides you from Him. John says, *"God is light, and in him is no darkness at all"* (1 John 1:5). If you have been running, stop. If you have been afraid of the dark, take heart. He is there too, and His hand is holding you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ went to the farthest place anyone could go — into the darkness of the cross and down into Sheol — and even there the Father's hand held Him and raised Him on the third day. There is nowhere you can go that He has not already been. His hand is holding you in the dark today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you trying to flee from God — or have you found comfort that there is nowhere He is not?

◆

DAY 342 · DECEMBER 8 · PSALM 139 (VV. 13–18)

Fearfully and Wonderfully Made

“I will give thanks to you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made.”
— PSALM 139:14

Psalm 139 turns to the beginning of life: *“For you formed my inmost being. You knit me together in my mother’s womb”* (Psalm 139:13). Knit. Like someone working yarn with needles, carefully, stitch by stitch. That is how God made you. Not by accident, not by chance, but by hand, in the hidden place before you were born. Your inmost being — your heart, your mind, your personality — was formed by Him.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *“I will give thanks to you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Your works are wonderful. My soul knows that very well”* (Psalm 139:14). Fearfully and wonderfully. That means with awe and with skill. God made you with the kind of care that makes the psalmist stand back in wonder. You may not feel wonderfully made. You may look in the mirror and see only flaws. But your Maker sees His own workmanship. Paul says, *“For we are his workmanship”* (Ephesians 2:10).

“My frame wasn’t hidden from you, when I was made in secret, woven together in the depths of the earth. Your eyes saw my body. In your book they were all written, the days that were ordained for me, when as yet there were none of them” (Psalm 139:15–16). Every one of your days was written in His book before the first one began. Your life is not random. It was known and planned by God before you took your first breath. God told Jeremiah, *“Before I formed you in the womb, I knew you”* (Jeremiah 1:5).

“How precious to me are your thoughts, God! How vast is their sum! If I would count them, they are more in number than the sand. When I wake up, I am still with you” (Psalm 139:17–18). More than the grains of sand. That is how many thoughts God has toward you. And when you wake up each morning, He is still there. This psalm speaks into every life that has been called worthless — the unborn, the disabled, the elderly, the one who feels like a mistake. God knit you. He wrote your days. He thinks about you more than you could count. Give thanks today. You are fearfully and wonderfully made.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was knit together in a mother’s womb too, the eternal Son taking on a human frame. He gave that body on the cross and rose with it on the third day. In Him your life is precious beyond counting. Give thanks today. You were made with awe and skill, and you are still with Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you see yourself as God’s workmanship, fearfully and wonderfully made — or mostly as a list of flaws?

◆

DAY 343 · DECEMBER 9 · PSALM 139 (VV. 19–24)

Search Me and Know My Heart

"Search me, God, and know my heart. Try me, and know my thoughts."
— PSALM 139:23

The end of Psalm 139 takes a sharp turn. After all the tenderness about being known and formed, the psalmist bursts out against evil: *"If only you, God, would kill the wicked. Get away from me, you bloodthirsty men! For they speak against you wickedly. Your enemies take your name in vain"* (Psalm 139:19–20). He is angry at people who hate God. *"Yahweh, don't I hate those who hate you? Am I not grieved with those who rise up against you? I hate them with perfect hatred"* (Psalm 139:21–22).

Those are strong words. The psalmist is loyal to God and outraged at evil. But then he does something remarkable. He turns the searchlight back on himself: *"Search me, God, and know my heart. Try me, and know my thoughts. See if there is any wicked way in me, and lead me in the everlasting way"* (Psalm 139:23–24). Right after condemning the wicked, he asks God to check whether there is wickedness in him. That is the mark of real humility.

It is easy to see evil out there. The violent, the corrupt, the people who mock God. And it is right to grieve over it. But the danger is that you become so focused on the evil around you that you miss the evil in you. Jesus warned about seeing the speck in someone else's eye and missing the log in your own. Paul said, *"For I know nothing against myself. Yet I am not justified by this, but he who judges me is the Lord"* (1 Corinthians 4:4). You cannot fully search your own heart. You need God to do it.

So the psalmist asks. Search me. Know my heart. Try me. See if there is any wicked way. Not because he wants to be condemned, but because he wants to be led — *"lead me in the everlasting way"* (Psalm 139:24). God's searching is not a raid. It is a doctor's examination before the cure. And the promise for those who let Him search is cleansing: *"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous to forgive us the sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness"* (1 John 1:9). Pray this prayer today. Search me, God. Then let Him lead you.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was searched by God and found without sin, and then He took your wicked ways onto Himself at the cross. He rose to lead you in the everlasting way. Pray it today without fear: search me, God. What He finds, He has already paid for. Let Him lead you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you quick to see wickedness in others — and willing to ask God to search your own heart?

◆

DAY 344 · DECEMBER 10 · PSALM 140 (VV. 1–6)

You Are My God

"You are my God."
— PSALM 140:6

Psalm 140 is a prayer for protection from violent and deceitful people: *"Deliver me, Yahweh, from the evil man. Preserve me from the violent man: those who devise mischief in their hearts. They continually gather themselves together for war"* (Psalm 140:1–2). They plan harm. They gather to attack. And their favorite tool is the mouth: *"They have sharpened their tongues like a serpent. Viper's poison is under their lips"* (Psalm 140:3).

Words like snake venom. Slow-acting, deadly, hidden. That is what slander and lies can do. Then the traps: *"Yahweh, keep me from the hands of the wicked. Preserve me from the violent men who have determined to trip my feet. The proud have hidden a snare for me, they have spread the cords of a net by the path. They have set traps for me"* (Psalm 140:4–5). Snares. Nets. Traps along the road. Someone is trying to make him fall. He cannot see the traps. He only knows they are there, somewhere along the road ahead, and that one wrong step could bring him down.

Then the turn: *"I said to Yahweh, 'You are my God.' Listen to the cry of my petitions, Yahweh"* (Psalm 140:6). You are my God. Four short words. In the middle of the snares and the poison, the psalmist plants his feet on one fact. Whatever these people say, whatever traps they set, You are my God. That declaration is the anchor of the whole psalm. It does not remove the snares. It changes who is standing with him among them. A person who knows whose they are can walk a dangerous road without panic, because the outcome does not rest on their own cleverness.

That is what faith does under attack. It does not first try to win the argument or outsmart the trap. It says to God: You are mine, and I am Yours. Everything else flows from that. Paul faced people who wanted him dead and friends who abandoned him: *"At my first defense, no one came to help me, but all left me... But the Lord stood by me and strengthened me"* (2 Timothy 4:16–17). The Lord stood by me. When people set traps for you today, say it out loud: You are my God. Then let Him deal with the traps.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ walked a road lined with snares. The religious leaders set trap after trap for His words, and finally they nailed Him to a cross. He said to the Father, You are My God, all the way to the end. He rose. When traps are set for you today, plant your feet on the same words.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When people set traps for you, do you first try to outsmart them — or say to God, You are my God?

◆

DAY 345 · DECEMBER 11 · PSALM 140 (VV. 7–13)

The Strength of My Salvation

> *"Yahweh, the Lord, the strength of my salvation, you have covered my head in the day of battle."*
> — PSALM 140:7

Psalm 140 continues with a picture of protection: *"Yahweh, the Lord, the strength of my salvation, you have covered my head in the day of battle"* (Psalm 140:7). Covered my head. Like a helmet. When the blows came, God shielded the place where a strike would be deadly. The psalmist looks back on a day of fierce conflict and sees that God was over him the whole time. He did not notice it in the moment. Looking back, he sees the hand that was shielding him.

Then he asks God not to let evil win: *"Yahweh, don't grant the desires of the wicked. Don't let their evil plans succeed, or they will become proud"* (Psalm 140:8). That is a wise prayer. If the wicked succeed, they become prouder, and their next scheme will be worse. The psalmist asks God to stop them, not only for his own sake but for the sake of everyone they might hurt next.

Then a prayer for justice to come back on the attackers: *"As for the head of those who surround me, let the mischief of their own lips cover them"* (Psalm 140:9). Let their words come back on them. Then: *"An evil speaker won't be established in the earth. Evil will hunt the violent man to overthrow him"* (Psalm 140:11). Lies do not last. Violence turns on the violent. That is how God has built the world. Evil carries its own undoing. It may flourish for a season, but it is built on rot, and rot does not hold weight forever. The liar eventually trips over his own lies.

And then the psalm settles into confidence: *"I know that Yahweh will maintain the cause of the afflicted, and justice for the needy. Surely the righteous will give thanks to your name. The upright will dwell in your presence"* (Psalm 140:12–13). I know. Not I hope. I know. God will stand up for the afflicted. He will give justice to the needy. And the righteous will live in His presence. Paul says the resources of the believer's fight *"are not of the flesh, but mighty before God"* (2 Corinthians 10:4). Your covering in the hard day is not your own strength. It is the LORD.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ's head was not covered on the day of His suffering. It was crowned with thorns and struck with a reed, so that your head could be covered in your hard day. He rose, and He maintains the cause of the afflicted. Let Him be the strength of your salvation today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When the hard day comes, are you relying on your own covering — or on the LORD who covers your head?

◆

DAY 346 · DECEMBER 12 · PSALM 141 (VV. 1–5)

Set a Guard Over My Mouth

> *"Set a watch, Yahweh, before my mouth. Keep the door of my lips."*
> — PSALM 141:3

Psalm 141 is an evening prayer: *"Yahweh, I have called on you. Come to me quickly! Listen to my voice when I call to you. Let my prayer be set before you like incense; the lifting up of my hands like the evening sacrifice"* (Psalm 141:1–2). Like incense rising in the temple. Like the evening offering at the end of the day. The psalmist wants his prayer to go up to God the way smoke drifts up from the altar.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Set a watch, Yahweh, before my mouth. Keep the door of my lips"* (Psalm 141:3). A guard at the door. A sentry watching who goes in and out. The psalmist knows his mouth is dangerous. Words slip out before he can stop them. Anger, gossip, complaint, cruelty. So he asks God to post a guard. James says, *"For we all stumble in many things. Anyone who doesn't stumble in word is a perfect person"* (James 3:2).

Many people pray for many things but never pray for their mouths. They ask God to change their circumstances, heal their bodies, fix their families. But they never ask Him to guard what comes out of their own lips. And yet so much damage comes from the mouth. One careless sentence can wreck a friendship. One sharp word can wound a child for years. Paul says, *"Let no corrupt speech proceed out of your mouth, but only what is good for building others up"* (Ephesians 4:29).

Then the psalmist goes deeper than the mouth to the heart: *"Don't incline my heart to any evil thing, to practice deeds of wickedness with men who work iniquity. Don't let me eat of their delicacies"* (Psalm 141:4). The mouth follows the heart. Jesus said, *"out of the abundance of the heart, the mouth speaks"* (Matthew 12:34). And then a surprising request: *"Let the righteous strike me, it is kindness; let him reprove me, it is like oil on the head"* (Psalm 141:5). He welcomes correction from good people. That is rare. Pray today for a guard on your lips — and a heart that welcomes a friend's rebuke.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ kept the door of His lips perfectly. When He was reviled, He did not revile in return. When He was accused, He was silent. He spoke only what the Father gave Him, all the way to the cross. He rose to give you a new heart and a guarded mouth. Ask Him today to set a watch over your lips.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you pray for God to guard your mouth — and do you welcome correction from people who love you?

◆

DAY 347 · DECEMBER 13 · PSALM 141 (VV. 6–10)

My Eyes Are Toward You

"For my eyes are on you, Yahweh, the Lord. In you, I take refuge."
— PSALM 141:8

The second half of Psalm 141 is harder to read. The text is difficult, and the images are dark: *"Their judges are thrown down by the sides of the rock. They will hear my words, for they are well spoken"* (Psalm 141:6). Then a grim picture: *"As when one plows and breaks up the earth, our bones are scattered at the mouth of Sheol"* (Psalm 141:7). Bones scattered at the mouth of the grave. It is a picture of complete devastation, nothing left standing, the people of God broken and spread on the ground like turned-over soil.

And then, out of that wreckage, the line that gives this day its name: *"For my eyes are on you, Yahweh, the Lord. In you, I take refuge. Don't leave my soul destitute"* (Psalm 141:8). My eyes are on You. Not on the bones. Not on the open grave. Not on the enemies. On God. That is the choice faith makes in the worst places. When everything around you is broken, you fix your eyes on the One who is not.

Hebrews gives the same instruction: *"looking to Jesus, the author and perfecter of faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross"* (Hebrews 12:2). Looking. Eyes fixed. Not glancing occasionally, but staring steadily at Christ. Paul says, *"Set your mind on the things that are above, not on the things that are on the earth"* (Colossians 3:2). Where you look shapes how you feel, and how you walk. Look at the bones long enough and you will despair. Look at God and you will find refuge.

Then a prayer about the traps: *"Keep me from the snare which they have laid for me, from the traps of the workers of iniquity. Let the wicked fall together into their own nets while I pass by"* (Psalm 141:9–10). While I pass by. The psalmist imagines walking safely past the traps set for him, while the wicked get caught in their own nets. That is what happens when your eyes are on God. He guides your feet around the snares. Look up from the scattered bones today. Fix your eyes on Him.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ fixed His eyes on the joy set before Him and endured the cross. His own body was broken and laid at the mouth of the grave, and on the third day He rose. When everything around you looks like scattered bones, fix your eyes on Him today. He is the refuge that does not break.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When everything around you is broken, where are your eyes fixed?

◆

DAY 348 · DECEMBER 14 · PSALM 142

You Are My Refuge

"You are my refuge, my portion in the land of the living."
— PSALM 142:5

Psalm 142 has a heading that places it in a cave, when David was hiding from Saul. And it is the prayer of someone completely alone: *"I cry with my voice to Yahweh. With my voice, I ask Yahweh for mercy. I pour out my complaint before him. I tell him my troubles"* (Psalm 142:1–2). Pour out. Tell. He holds nothing back. He brings every complaint, every trouble, every fear and lays it before God.

"When my spirit was overwhelmed within me, you knew my route. On the path in which I walk, they have hidden a snare for me" (Psalm 142:3). Overwhelmed. But God knew the way. Even when David did not know where to turn, God knew his path. Then the loneliest verse: *"Look on my right, and see; for there is no one who is concerned for me. Refuge has fled from me. No one cares for my soul"* (Psalm 142:4). No one. Look to the right, where a friend or protector would stand, and the place is empty.

You may know that kind of loneliness. Not just being by yourself, but feeling that no one cares. No one asks how you are. No one would notice if you disappeared. That is a dark place. And David names it plainly before God. He does not pretend to have friends he does not have. He tells God the truth: no one cares for my soul. And then he turns.

"I cried to you, Yahweh. I said, 'You are my refuge, my portion in the land of the living'" (Psalm 142:5). You are my refuge. When no one else is there, You are. You are my portion — my share, my inheritance, the one thing I have when I have nothing else. *"Bring my soul out of prison, that I may give thanks to your name. The righteous will surround me, for you will be good to me"* (Psalm 142:7). From alone in a cave to surrounded by the righteous. Hebrews says God has promised, *"I will in no way leave you, neither will I in any way forsake you"* (Hebrews 13:5). If no one cares for your soul today, God does. Tell Him so.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ knew what it was to look to His right and find no one. His friends fled, and He was left alone. He went to the cross and the tomb, and on the third day the Father brought Him out of that prison. If no one cares for your soul today, He does. He is your refuge and your portion.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If you feel no one cares for your soul, can you say to God, You are my refuge and my portion?

◆

DAY 349 · DECEMBER 15 · PSALM 143 (VV. 1–6)

No One Living Is Righteous

> *"Don't enter into judgment with your servant, for in your sight no man living is righteous."*
> — PSALM 143:2

Psalm 143 begins with a plea that cuts to the heart of the gospel: *"Hear my prayer, Yahweh. Listen to my petitions. In your faithfulness and righteousness, relieve me"* (Psalm 143:1). Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Don't enter into judgment with your servant, for in your sight no man living is righteous"* (Psalm 143:2). Do not take me to court. Do not put me on trial. Because if You do, I will lose. No one living is righteous before You.

That is a startling prayer from David, a man after God's own heart. He does not plead his good record. He does not list his victories or his worship. He asks God not to judge him by his record at all. Paul quotes the idea in Romans: *"There is no one righteous; no, not one"* (Romans 3:10). And then he gives the answer: *"for all have sinned, and fall short of the glory of God; being justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus"* (Romans 3:23–24).

Justified freely. By grace. That is the only way anyone can stand before God. Not by being righteous enough, but by being given a righteousness that is not their own. Paul says it again in Galatians: *"a man is not justified by the works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ"* (Galatians 2:16). David's prayer — do not enter into judgment with me — is answered in Christ. God did enter into judgment. But He entered it with His Son, on the cross, in your place.

The rest of the stanza shows why David needs this mercy: *"For the enemy pursues my soul. He has struck my life down to the ground. He has made me live in dark places, as those who have been long dead"* (Psalm 143:3). Struck down to the ground. That is the dust. *"Therefore my spirit is overwhelmed within me. My heart within me is desolate"* (Psalm 143:4). Then he remembers and reaches out: *"I spread out my hands to you. My soul thirsts for you, like a parched land"* (Psalm 143:6). Dry ground reaching for rain. Stop pleading your record today. Plead the righteousness of Christ.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God did enter into judgment — with His Son, on the cross, in your place. Christ bore the verdict you deserved so that you could be justified freely by grace. He rose. You do not have to plead your record today. Spread out your hands like parched land, and receive His righteousness.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you still pleading your own record before God — or resting in the righteousness of Christ?

◆

DAY 350 · DECEMBER 16 · PSALM 143 (VV. 7–12)

Teach Me the Way I Should Go

> *"Teach me to do your will, for you are my God. Your Spirit is good. Lead me in the land of uprightness."*
> — PSALM 143:10

The second half of Psalm 143 is urgent: *"Hurry to answer me, Yahweh. My spirit fails. Don't hide your face from me, so that I don't become like those who go down into the pit"* (Psalm 143:7). My spirit fails. He is near the end of his strength. And then a request that you can pray every morning: *"Cause me to hear your loving kindness in the morning, for I trust in you. Cause me to know the way in which I should walk, for I lift up my soul to you"* (Psalm 143:8).

Hear Your love in the morning. Know the way to walk. Those two go together. First, hear that God loves you. Then, be shown where to go. Love first, direction second. Most people want direction first — just tell me what to do. But David asks to hear God's love before he asks for the map. When you know you are loved, you can follow wherever He leads.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Teach me to do your will, for you are my God. Your Spirit is good. Lead me in the land of uprightness"* (Psalm 143:10). Teach me. Not just tell me, but teach me — train me, shape me, help me learn. And the reason: You are my God. And then a striking confession: Your Spirit is good. The Spirit of God is not harsh or cold. He is good. And He leads people onto level ground, the land of uprightness. Paul says, *"For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, these are children of God"* (Romans 8:14).

Then one more prayer for revival: *"Revive me, Yahweh, for your name's sake. In your righteousness, bring my soul out of trouble"* (Psalm 143:11). Revive me — chayah again, the same Hebrew verb as Psalm 119:25. For Your name's sake. Not because I deserve it. Because of who You are. Jesus promised, *"the Counselor, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, will teach you all things"* (John 14:26). Ask Him today to let you hear His love in the morning, and then teach you the way to walk.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ promised the Spirit to teach His people and lead them on level ground. He went through the pit of death and rose so that His good Spirit could dwell in you. Ask Him tomorrow morning to let you hear His love first, and then to teach you the way. Revive me, LORD, for Your name's sake.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you ask to hear God's love in the morning before you ask Him for directions?

◆

DAY 351 · DECEMBER 17 · PSALM 144 (VV. 1–8)

What Is a Mortal That You Regard Him?

"Yahweh, what is man, that you care for him?"
— PSALM 144:3

Psalm 144 opens with David praising God as his protector: *"Blessed be Yahweh, my rock, who teaches my hands to war, and my fingers to battle: my loving kindness, my fortress, my high tower, my deliverer, my shield, and he in whom I take refuge"* (Psalm 144:1–2). A king who had fought many fights gives God the credit for every one. My rock. My fortress. My shield. Every title is a name for the God who kept him alive. David does not credit his own skill or strength. Whatever he could do, God taught him.

Then, right in the middle of that confident praise, a humble question: *"Yahweh, what is man, that you care for him? Or the son of man, that you think of him?"* (Psalm 144:3). Who am I that You would notice me? David asks almost the same question Psalm 8 asked. And the answer is sobering: *"Man is like a breath. His days are like a shadow that passes away"* (Psalm 144:4). A breath. A shadow. Here and gone.

That is the dust again. The great king, the strong fighter, the ruler of Israel — a breath. And yet God cares for him. God thinks of him. That is the wonder. Not that people are impressive, but that a God so great pays attention to creatures so small. James asks, *"For what is your life? For you are a vapor that appears for a little time, and then vanishes away"* (James 4:14). A vapor that God watches over.

Then David asks God to come down: *"Part your heavens, Yahweh, and come down. Touch the mountains, and they will smoke"* (Psalm 144:5). Come down. Tear open the sky and come. *"Stretch out your hand from above, rescue me, and deliver me out of great waters"* (Psalm 144:7). That prayer was answered more fully than David could have imagined. God did come down. Hebrews quotes the question of Psalm 8 and applies it to Jesus: *"What is man, that you think of him?... You crowned him with glory and honor"* (Hebrews 2:6–7). The God who cares for breath became breath, and lived among His people. You are small. You are cared for.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

God answered David's prayer to part the heavens and come down. He came in Christ, who took on a life like a breath and a shadow and gave it up on the cross. On the third day He rose, crowned with glory. You are a breath, and the Maker of heaven cares for you. Rest in that today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you feel how small you are — and how wonderful it is that God still cares for you?

◆

DAY 352 · DECEMBER 18 · PSALM 144 (VV. 9–15)

Blessed Are the People Whose God Is the LORD

> *"Happy are the people whose God is Yahweh."*
> — PSALM 144:15

The second half of Psalm 144 turns to singing: *"I will sing a new song to you, God. On a ten-stringed lyre, I will sing praises to you. You are he who gives salvation to kings, who rescues David, his servant, from the deadly sword"* (Psalm 144:9–10). A new song for a new rescue. God saves kings. He rescued David again and again. And David keeps finding fresh reasons to sing. A life with God never runs out of new songs, because God never runs out of new mercies.

Then a picture of a blessed nation: *"Then our sons will be like well-nurtured plants, our daughters like pillars carved to adorn a palace"* (Psalm 144:12). Children growing strong and lovely. *"Our barns are full, filled with all kinds of provision. Our sheep produce thousands and ten thousands in our fields. Our oxen will pull heavy loads. There is no breaking in, and no going away, and no outcry in our streets"* (Psalm 144:13–14). Full barns. Growing flocks. Safe streets. Peace.

That is a picture of what life looks like when God's blessing rests on a people. Not perfection, but flourishing. Children thriving. Work producing. Neighborhoods safe. No one breaking in, no one being dragged away, no cries in the streets at night. It is the kind of life everyone wants. And many people chase it by every means except God. They work harder, plan better, save more, and still the barns feel empty, because the blessing they are reaching for was never something they could build alone.

Then the psalm says where it comes from: *"Happy are the people who are in such a situation. Happy are the people whose God is Yahweh"* (Psalm 144:15). The last line is the key. Not happy are the people with full barns. Happy are the people whose God is the LORD. The barns may be full or empty in any given year. Harvests fail. Economies crash. But the people whose God is the LORD have something no drought can take. Jesus said, *"But seek first God's Kingdom, and his righteousness; and all these things will be given to you as well"* (Matthew 6:33). Seek Him first. The blessing that matters most is having Him as your God.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the reason anyone can say the LORD is their God. He died to bring rebels into God's family and rose to give them a happiness no empty barn can take away. Whatever your barns look like this year, if the LORD is your God, you are blessed. Rest in Him today.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Are you seeking full barns — or seeking the God whose people are truly happy?

◆

DAY 353 · DECEMBER 19 · PSALM 145 (VV. 1–7)

I Will Extol You, My God and King

"Great is Yahweh, and greatly to be praised!"
— PSALM 145:3

Psalm 145 is the last psalm with David's name in its heading, and it is pure praise. It is an acrostic in Hebrew, each verse beginning with the next letter of the alphabet, an orderly song from A to Z. And it opens with a vow: *"I will exalt you, my God, the King. I will praise your name forever and ever. Every day I will praise you. I will extol your name forever and ever"* (Psalm 145:1–2). Every day. Forever. Praise without end. Not a single song on a good Sunday, but a life set to music.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Great is Yahweh, and greatly to be praised! His greatness is unsearchable"* (Psalm 145:3). Unsearchable. You cannot find the bottom of it. You cannot measure it. You can study God for a lifetime and still not reach the edge of His greatness. Isaiah says, *"His understanding is unsearchable"* (Isaiah 40:28). And Paul exclaims, *"Oh the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and the knowledge of God! How unsearchable are his judgments"* (Romans 11:33).

That should make worship an adventure instead of a routine. If God is unsearchable, you will never run out of things to praise Him for. Every day there is more, the way a mountain range keeps revealing new peaks as you climb. Then the psalm speaks of passing it on: *"One generation will commend your works to another, and will declare your mighty acts"* (Psalm 145:4). Grandparents to parents, parents to children. Each generation tells the next what God has done.

"I will meditate on the glorious majesty of your honor, on your wondrous works. Men will speak of the might of your awesome acts. I will declare your greatness. They will utter the memory of your great goodness, and will sing of your righteousness" (Psalm 145:5–7). Meditate. Speak. Declare. Utter. Sing. Every way a voice can be used, used for His praise. As this year draws to a close, look back over the twelve months. What has God done that you could tell the next generation? Write it down. Say it out loud. His greatness is unsearchable, and you have only begun.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the unsearchable greatness of God made visible. He humbled Himself to the cross and was raised to the highest place, and every generation since has passed on His story. As this year closes, tell someone younger what He has done for you. You will never reach the end of His greatness.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

As this year closes, what has God done for you that you could tell the next generation?

◆

DAY 354 · DECEMBER 20 · PSALM 145 (VV. 8–14)

The LORD Upholds All Who Are Falling

> *"Yahweh upholds all who fall, and raises up all those who are bowed down."*
> — PSALM 145:14

Psalm 145 describes God's character in words that echo Exodus: *"Yahweh is gracious, merciful, slow to anger, and of great loving kindness"* (Psalm 145:8). Gracious. Merciful. Slow to anger. Great in love. That is the way God described Himself to Moses on Mount Sinai, and it is the way David praises Him here. It is the most repeated description of God in the Old Testament, as if God wanted His people never to forget it.

Then the reach of His goodness: *"Yahweh is good to all. His tender mercies are over all his works"* (Psalm 145:9). Good to all. His mercy covers everything He made. Then the response: *"All your works will give thanks to you, Yahweh. Your saints will extol you. They will speak of the glory of your kingdom, and talk about your power"* (Psalm 145:10–11). And His kingdom lasts: *"Your kingdom is an everlasting kingdom. Your dominion endures throughout all generations"* (Psalm 145:13).

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"Yahweh upholds all who fall, and raises up all those who are bowed down"* (Psalm 145:14). Upholds all who fall. Raises those bowed down. The great King of an everlasting kingdom spends His strength catching people who stumble and lifting people who are pressed to the ground. That is the God of this whole year. The God who raises dust. He does not wait for the fallen to get up on their own. He reaches down, and He lifts, as often as it takes.

You may be falling right now. Stumbling under a weight you cannot carry. Bowed down by grief or guilt or exhaustion. Psalm 145 says the King is not watching from a distance. He is reaching down. He catches the falling. He lifts the bowed. You may have fallen many times this year. He has caught you every time. Paul says, *"God is faithful, who will not allow you to be tempted above what you are able, but will with the temptation also make the way of escape"* (1 Corinthians 10:13). And the psalm adds: *"Yahweh is faithful in all his words, and loving in all his deeds"* (Psalm 145:13). If you are bowed down today, let Him lift you. That is what He does.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ was bowed down to the ground in Gethsemane and fell under the weight of the cross on the road to Golgotha. The Father raised Him from the dust of death on the third day. Now He upholds all who fall. If you are bowed down today, let Him lift you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where are you falling or bowed down — and will you let the LORD lift you?

◆

DAY 355 · DECEMBER 21 · PSALM 145 (VV. 15–21)

You Open Your Hand

"You open your hand, and satisfy the desire of every living thing."
— PSALM 145:16

Psalm 145 now pictures all creation waiting at God's table: *"The eyes of all wait for you. You give them their food in due season"* (Psalm 145:15). The eyes of all. Every creature, from the smallest bird to the largest whale, looks to God for food. And He gives it in due season — at the right time, in the right amount. The whole world is a family at the table, waiting for the Father to serve. The sparrow does not plan ahead. The lion does not store up. They wait, and He provides.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"You open your hand, and satisfy the desire of every living thing"* (Psalm 145:16). An open hand. Not a closed fist. Not a reluctant grip. An open hand, giving. That is the posture of God toward His creation. Generous. Overflowing. Jesus pointed to it: *"See the birds of the sky, that they don't sow, neither do they reap, nor gather into barns. Your heavenly Father feeds them. Aren't you of much more value than they?"* (Matthew 6:26).

Then the character behind the open hand: *"Yahweh is righteous in all his ways, and gracious in all his works. Yahweh is near to all those who call on him, to all who call on him in truth"* (Psalm 145:17–18). Near. Not far off, not distant. Near to everyone who calls. And then: *"He will fulfill the desire of those who fear him. He also will hear their cry, and will save them"* (Psalm 145:19). He hears. He saves. He fulfills. Not grudgingly, but gladly, because that is who He is.

"Yahweh preserves all those who love him, but he will destroy all the wicked" (Psalm 145:20). And the psalm ends with a call to everyone: *"My mouth will speak the praise of Yahweh. Let all flesh bless his holy name forever and ever"* (Psalm 145:21). All flesh. Every living thing. As the year ends, think about what God's open hand has given you this year. Food on the table. Breath in your lungs. Grace for your sins. People who love you. Count it. Then bless His name. The hand is still open.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ opened His hands on the cross, and they were nailed there for you. From those wounded hands comes every good gift — forgiveness, life, the bread of heaven. He rose with the scars still in His palms, and His hand is still open. Count what He has given you this year, and bless Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What has God's open hand given you this year that you have not yet thanked Him for?

◆

DAY 356 · DECEMBER 22 · PSALM 146 (VV. 1–5)

Put Not Your Trust in Princes

> *“Happy is he who has the God of Jacob for his help, whose hope is in Yahweh, his God”*
> — PSALM 146:5

The last five psalms in the Bible all begin and end with *“Praise Yah”* — Hallelujah. Psalm 146 opens with the psalmist talking to his own soul: *“Praise Yah! Praise Yahweh, my soul. While I live, I will praise Yahweh. I will sing praises to my God as long as I exist”* (Psalm 146:1–2). While I live. As long as I exist. Praise for the rest of life, however long it is.

Then a warning: *“Don’t put your trust in princes, in a son of man in whom there is no help”* (Psalm 146:3). Princes. People in high places. Leaders, politicians, celebrities, experts. Do not trust them for what only God can give. They can make policy. They cannot make you new. Why not? *“His spirit departs, and he returns to the earth. In that very day, his thoughts perish”* (Psalm 146:4). He dies. He goes back to the dust. And all his plans die with him. The leader you are counting on will one day be in the ground, and his promises will go with him.

That is not cynicism. It is realism, the kind every graveyard teaches. Human leaders can do good. But they cannot save you. They are dust, like you. Jeremiah says, *“Cursed is the man who trusts in man, relies on strength of flesh, and whose heart departs from Yahweh”* (Jeremiah 17:5). The problem is not respecting leaders. It is resting your whole hope on them. Every election season, every news cycle, people hang their hope on princes. And every time, the princes die.

Then the contrast: *“Happy is he who has the God of Jacob for his help, whose hope is in Yahweh, his God”* (Psalm 146:5). The God of Jacob. Jacob was a liar and a schemer, and God was still his God. That is the God you can trust. Not a prince who will die, but the LORD who made heaven and earth. *“who made heaven and earth, the sea, and all that is in them; who keeps truth forever”* (Psalm 146:6). He keeps truth forever. No prince can say that. Put your hope in Him today, not in anyone who will return to dust.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Prince who did not stay in the dust. He returned to the earth in death, and on the third day He rose, and His promises did not perish. Every other leader will die. He lives forever. Put your hope in Him today, not in princes who return to the dust.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Where have you been putting your hope in princes — leaders who will return to the dust?

◆

DAY 357 · DECEMBER 23 · PSALM 146 (VV. 6–10)

The LORD Sets the Prisoners Free

"Yahweh frees the prisoners. Yahweh opens the eyes of the blind."
— PSALM 146:7–8

Psalm 146 now lists what the LORD does, and it reads like a job description: *"who executes justice for the oppressed; who gives food to the hungry. Yahweh frees the prisoners"* (Psalm 146:7). Justice for the oppressed. Food for the hungry. Freedom for the prisoners. These are the people the princes of the world often ignore. God goes straight to them. He does not wait until they have been cleaned up or made respectable. He starts with the people at the bottom.

Then more: *"Yahweh opens the eyes of the blind. Yahweh raises up those who are bowed down. Yahweh loves the righteous"* (Psalm 146:8). Sight for the blind. Lifting for the bowed down. And then: *"Yahweh preserves the foreigners. He upholds the fatherless and widow, but he turns the way of the wicked upside down"* (Psalm 146:9). Foreigners. Orphans. Widows. The people with no one to defend them. God defends them. He takes up their cause as if it were His own, because it is.

That list should sound familiar. When John the Baptist sent messengers to ask whether Jesus was the Messiah, Jesus answered: *"the blind receive their sight, the lame walk, the lepers are cleansed, the deaf hear, the dead are raised up, and the poor have good news preached to them"* (Matthew 11:5). In Nazareth He read from Isaiah: He has been sent *"to proclaim release to the captives, recovering of sight to the blind"* (Luke 4:18). Jesus did exactly what Psalm 146 says the LORD does. He was not only pointing to God. He was doing God's own works, in God's own way, with God's own authority.

That is how you know who Jesus is. He did the works of God. He freed prisoners from the chains of sin and illness. He opened blind eyes. He lifted the bowed down. He welcomed foreigners and cared for widows. A man born blind said, *"One thing I do know: that though I was blind, now I see"* (John 9:25). You may be a prisoner today — of a habit, a fear, a past. You may be blind to something you cannot see. Bring it to Him. *"Yahweh will reign forever; your God, O Zion, to all generations. Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 146:10).

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ did every work of Psalm 146. He freed prisoners, opened blind eyes, lifted the bowed down, and defended the forgotten. Then He went to the cross to set the deepest prisoners free, and rose to reign forever. Whatever chains or blindness you carry today, bring them to Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What prison or blindness do you need to bring to the One who frees prisoners and opens blind eyes?

◆

DAY 358 · DECEMBER 24 · PSALM 147 (VV. 1–7)

He Heals the Brokenhearted

"He heals the broken in heart, and binds up their wounds."
— PSALM 147:3

Psalm 147 opens with joy: *"Praise Yah, for it is good to sing praises to our God; for it is pleasant and fitting to praise him"* (Psalm 147:1). Good. Pleasant. Fitting. Praise is right, and it feels right. Then a picture of restoration: *"Yahweh builds up Jerusalem. He gathers together the outcasts of Israel"* (Psalm 147:2). The city rebuilt. The scattered gathered home. The ones who were pushed out, brought back in.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"He heals the broken in heart, and binds up their wounds"* (Psalm 147:3). Broken in heart. Wounded. God does not ignore broken people or tell them to toughen up. He heals. He binds up the wounds, the way a nurse wraps a bandage around a cut. Gentle, careful, close. He does not rush the healing or shame the wound. Isaiah says the Messiah would come *"to bind up the broken hearted"* (Isaiah 61:1).

And then the psalm does something remarkable. Right after the tender picture of binding wounds, it zooms out to the stars: *"He counts the number of the stars. He calls them all by their names"* (Psalm 147:4). The same God who bandages a broken heart counts the stars and names every one. Billions upon billions. And He knows each by name. *"Great is our Lord, and mighty in power. His understanding is infinite"* (Psalm 147:5). Infinite understanding, bending over a single wounded heart. Nothing about you is too small for the God of the galaxies.

Tonight, on the eve of Christmas, that is exactly what happened in Bethlehem. The God who names the stars came down to bind up broken hearts. The angel told the shepherds, *"Don't be afraid, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy which will be to all the people. For there is born to you today, in David's city, a Savior, who is Christ the Lord"* (Luke 2:10–11). The Star-Namer became a baby. He came for the broken. If your heart is broken this season — and holidays often make that ache sharper — He came for you. *"Yahweh upholds the humble"* (Psalm 147:6). Let Him bind your wounds tonight.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

The God who counts the stars came down as a baby in Bethlehem to heal the brokenhearted. Christ grew up, went to the cross, and was wounded so that your wounds could be bound. On the third day He rose. If your heart is broken this season, He came for you. Let Him bind it up tonight.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If this season makes an old ache sharper, can you bring your broken heart to the One who came to bind it?

◆

DAY 359 · DECEMBER 25 · PSALM 147 (VV. 8–13)

He Takes Pleasure in Those Who Fear Him

> *"Yahweh takes pleasure in those who fear him, in those who hope in his loving kindness."*
> — PSALM 147:11

Psalm 147 turns from healing hearts to running the world: *"Sing to Yahweh with thanksgiving. Sing praises on the harp to our God, who covers the sky with clouds, who prepares rain for the earth, who makes grass grow on the mountains"* (Psalm 147:7–8). Clouds. Rain. Grass on the high slopes where no farmer plants. God tends it all. *"He provides food for the livestock, and for the young ravens when they call"* (Psalm 147:9). Even the noisy young ravens, squawking in the nest, are fed by Him.

Then a surprising line about what God does not delight in: *"He doesn't delight in the strength of the horse. He takes no pleasure in the legs of a man"* (Psalm 147:10). Not strength. Not speed. Not the things people usually admire. The war horse, the athlete, the impressive and the strong — none of that impresses God. So what does? The line that gives this day its name: *"Yahweh takes pleasure in those who fear him, in those who hope in his loving kindness"* (Psalm 147:11).

Those who fear Him. Those who hope in His love. Not the strong, but the trusting. Not the self-made, but the dependent. God takes pleasure in people who look to Him. That is the message of Christmas. God did not come to the palace or the arena. He came to a stable, to a young couple with nothing, to shepherds on a night shift. Isaiah had said it: *"For a child is born to us. A son is given to us"* (Isaiah 9:6). Not a horse. Not a champion. A child.

On this day the Word became flesh: *"The Word became flesh, and lived among us. We saw his glory, such glory as of the one and only Son of the Father, full of grace and truth"* (John 1:14). The God who takes no pleasure in the legs of a man took on the frail legs of a newborn. And Zephaniah says what God feels toward the people He came for: *"He will rejoice over you with joy. He will calm you in his love. He will rejoice over you with singing"* (Zephaniah 3:17). Today, God takes pleasure in you — not because you are strong, but because you hope in His love. That is why He came.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

On this day Christ was born, not in strength but in weakness, a child laid in a manger. He came for those who fear God and hope in His love. He would grow up to die on a cross and rise on the third day. God takes pleasure in you today, not for your strength, but because you hope in Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

This Christmas, are you trying to impress God with strength — or simply hoping in His love?

◆

DAY 360 · DECEMBER 26 · PSALM 147 (VV. 14–20)

He Sends Out His Word

"He sends out his commandment to the earth. His word runs very swiftly."
— PSALM 147:15

The end of Psalm 147 returns to Jerusalem: *"Praise Yahweh, Jerusalem! Praise your God, Zion! For he has strengthened the bars of your gates. He has blessed your children within you. He makes peace in your borders. He fills you with the finest of the wheat"* (Psalm 147:12–14). Strong gates. Blessed children. Peace on the borders. The finest wheat. Everything a city could need, given freely by God.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"He sends out his commandment to the earth. His word runs very swiftly"* (Psalm 147:15). His word runs. Like a messenger sprinting across the hills. God speaks, and His word does not sit still. It moves. It goes out and does what He sent it to do. Isaiah describes it: *"so is my word that goes out of my mouth: it will not return to me void, but it will accomplish that which I please"* (Isaiah 55:11).

Then the psalm shows the word at work in winter: *"He gives snow like wool, and scatters frost like ashes. He hurls down his hail like pebbles. Who can stand before his cold?"* (Psalm 147:16–17). Snow like wool. Frost like ashes. Hail like pebbles. Winter is God's word spoken in ice. And then the thaw: *"He sends out his word, and melts them. He causes his wind to blow, and the waters flow"* (Psalm 147:18). The same word that freezes also melts. One word, and the ice breaks and the streams run again.

That is a picture of what God's word does in a frozen heart. A heart can be locked in winter — cold, hard, numb. And God sends His word, and the ice begins to crack. The streams start to flow again. That is revival. And the psalm ends with the privilege of having that word: *"He shows his word to Jacob, his statutes and his ordinances to Israel. He has not done this for just any nation"* (Psalm 147:19–20). You have His word. Hebrews says it is *"living and active"* (Hebrews 4:12). If your heart has been frozen this year, let His word run to you today. It melts what nothing else can.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the Word God sent running to the earth. He came in the middle of winter's darkness, went to the cross, and rose on the third day, and His word still melts frozen hearts. If yours has been cold this year, open His word today. Let it thaw you.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is there a frozen place in your heart that you need God's word to melt?

◆

DAY 361 · DECEMBER 27 · PSALM 148 (VV. 1–7)

Praise Him, All His Angels

> *"Let them praise Yahweh's name, for he commanded, and they were created."*
> — PSALM 148:5

Psalm 148 calls all of creation to praise, starting at the top: *"Praise Yah! Praise Yahweh from the heavens! Praise him in the heights! Praise him, all his angels! Praise him, all his army!"* (Psalm 148:1–2). The angels first. The hosts of heaven. The beings who stand closest to God's throne are called to lead the song. Then the sky: *"Praise him, sun and moon! Praise him, all you shining stars! Praise him, you heavens of heavens, you waters that are above the heavens"* (Psalm 148:3–4).

Sun, moon, stars, sky. The psalm calls them to praise as if they could hear. And in a sense they can. They praise God by being exactly what He made them to be. The sun praises Him by shining. The stars praise Him by burning in their places. Every created thing glorifies its Maker by doing what it was made to do. Revelation hears *"every created thing which is in heaven, on the earth, under the earth, on the sea"* (Revelation 5:13), saying, *"To him who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb be the blessing"* (Revelation 5:13).

Then the reason: *"Let them praise Yahweh's name, for he commanded, and they were created"* (Psalm 148:5). He commanded. They were created. The stars exist because God spoke. That is reason enough for them to praise Him. And He keeps them in place: *"He has also established them forever and ever. He has made a decree which will not pass away"* (Psalm 148:6). The universe is not random. It runs on God's decree.

Then the psalm turns from the heights to the depths: *"Praise Yahweh from the earth, you great sea creatures, and all depths"* (Psalm 148:7). From the highest heaven to the deepest ocean, everything is called to praise. And if the angels and stars and sea creatures praise Him, so should you. You too exist because He commanded. You too are held in place by His word. You were made to do what every creature does at its best: give glory to the One who made it. As this year nears its end, join the choir. Praise Him with the angels and the stars.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ, through whom the angels and stars were made, was born into His own creation and laid in a feeding trough. The angels sang at His birth. He went to the cross and rose on the third day, and all creation will one day bow. Join the choir today. You were made to praise Him.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If the angels and stars praise their Maker by being what He made them to be, what would it look like for you to do the same?

◆

DAY 362 · DECEMBER 28 · PSALM 148 (VV. 8–14)

He Has Raised Up a Horn for His People

"He has lifted up the horn of his people"
— PSALM 148:14

Psalm 148 brings the whole earth into the choir: *"lightning and hail, snow and clouds; stormy wind, fulfilling his word; mountains and all hills; fruit trees and all cedars; wild animals and all livestock; small creatures and flying birds"* (Psalm 148:8–10). Weather. Mountains. Trees. Animals. Insects. Birds. Everything that moves or grows or blows, called to praise God. Even the storm is fulfilling His word. The wind that rattles your windows tonight is doing what it was told. Nothing in creation is outside His command.

Then people, every kind: *"kings of the earth and all peoples; princes and all judges of the earth; both young men and maidens; old men and children"* (Psalm 148:11–12). Kings and commoners. Judges and ordinary folks. Young and old, male and female. No one is too important to praise God, and no one is too small. The choir includes the king and the child, the judge and the farmer. Every voice belongs. The old man with a cracked voice and the child who cannot carry a tune. God wants them all.

"let them praise Yahweh's name, for his name alone is exalted. His glory is above the earth and the heavens" (Psalm 148:13). His name alone. Not the king's name. Not the judge's name. His. And then the reason that is personal to God's people: *"He has lifted up the horn of his people, the praise of all his saints, even of the children of Israel, a people near to him. Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 148:14). A horn — the symbol of strength. God has raised up strength for His people. And they are near to Him.

Zechariah, the father of John the Baptist, used this very picture when he praised God for the coming of Christ: *"Blessed be the Lord, the God of Israel, for he has visited and redeemed his people; and has raised up a horn of salvation for us in the house of his servant David"* (Luke 1:68–69). The horn is Jesus. God raised up a strong Savior for His people. And He made them a people near to Him. You are near to God, if you belong to Christ. Not far off, not on the outside. Near. Praise Him today with every voice in creation.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the horn of salvation God raised up for His people, born in the house of David. He brought them near by His blood on the cross and rose on the third day as their strength. You are near to God in Him. Praise Him today with every voice in creation.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you live as someone near to God — or as someone still standing on the outside?

◆

DAY 363 · DECEMBER 29 · PSALM 149 (VV. 1–4)

The LORD Takes Pleasure in His People

> *"For Yahweh takes pleasure in his people. He crowns the humble with salvation."*
> — PSALM 149:4

Psalm 149 calls for a new song: *"Praise Yahweh! Sing to Yahweh a new song, his praise in the assembly of the saints"* (Psalm 149:1). A new song, sung together, among God's people. Then joy in the Maker and the King: *"Let Israel rejoice in him who made them. Let the children of Zion be joyful in their King"* (Psalm 149:2). He made you. He rules you. Rejoice in both. Many people resent their Maker's rule, as though being governed were a burden. Psalm 149 says the right response to a good King is joy. You are not ruled by a tyrant. You are ruled by the One who made you and loves you.

"Let them praise his name in the dance! Let them sing praises to him with tambourine and harp!" (Psalm 149:3). Dancing. Tambourines. Harps. Joy that spills out of the body, too big to stay inside. Not stiff, not grim, not careful. Glad. That kind of praise may not fit every church's style. But it fits the heart of God's people when they remember what He has done.

Then the line that gives this day its name: *"For Yahweh takes pleasure in his people. He crowns the humble with salvation"* (Psalm 149:4). God takes pleasure in His people. Not tolerates them. Not puts up with them. Delights in them. And He crowns the humble — the lowly, the bowed down, the people who know they cannot save themselves — with salvation. Salvation is the crown. It is placed on the heads of those who did not earn it.

That is the end of the story this whole year has told. The dust-bound soul, clinging to the ground, is lifted up and crowned. Not with gold, but with salvation. Paul says, *"For our light affliction, which is for the moment, works for us more and more exceedingly an eternal weight of glory"* (2 Corinthians 4:17). Dust to glory. That is the arc. And God takes pleasure in every step of it. Zephaniah says, *"He will rejoice over you with singing"* (Zephaniah 3:17). If you are humble today — if you know your need — the crown is for you. God delights in you. Sing a new song.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ wore a crown of thorns so that the humble could be crowned with salvation. He was lowered into the dust of death and raised on the third day in glory. Now God takes pleasure in His people and crowns the lowly. If you know your need today, the crown is yours. Sing a new song.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Do you believe God takes pleasure in you — and crowns the humble with salvation?

◆

DAY 364 · DECEMBER 30 · PSALM 149 (VV. 5–9)

Let the Godly Exult in Glory

> *"Let the saints rejoice in honor. Let them sing for joy on their beds."*
> — PSALM 149:5

Psalm 149 continues: *"Let the saints rejoice in honor. Let them sing for joy on their beds"* (Psalm 149:5). On their beds. Not only in the assembly, but alone at night. Lying awake, and singing. That is a picture of joy so deep it follows you home. The praise does not stop when the service ends. It goes to bed with you. When the lights go out and the worries come, a song is waiting. That is a gift for anyone who lies awake at night.

Then the psalm turns fierce: *"May the high praises of God be in their mouths, and a two-edged sword in their hand, to execute vengeance on the nations, and punishments on the peoples; to bind their kings with chains, and their nobles with fetters of iron; to execute on them the written judgment. All his saints have this honor. Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 149:6–9). Praise in the mouth and a sword in the hand. That is a picture from Israel's history, when God's people were His instruments of judgment on nations that opposed Him.

How should believers read that today? Not as permission to take up arms in God's name. The New Testament changes the shape of the conflict. Paul says the believer's sword is *"the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God"* (Ephesians 6:17). Hebrews says, *"the word of God is living and active, and sharper than any two-edged sword"* (Hebrews 4:12). The two-edged sword is now God's word, cutting through lies and setting captives free. It does not wound the body. It heals the soul.

And the final judgment of the nations belongs to Christ. Revelation pictures Him: *"Out of his mouth proceeds a sharp, double-edged sword"* (Revelation 19:15). The sword comes from His mouth — His word. He will judge the earth, and His people share the honor of His victory, not by wielding steel but by standing with Him. So the high praises of God stay in your mouth, and the word of God stays in your hand. That is the honor of the saints. Sing for joy tonight, even on your bed. The King has won, and His word is sharper than any sword.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ is the King whose word is a two-edged sword. He won the decisive victory not by taking life but by giving His own on the cross, and on the third day He rose triumphant. His people share His honor. Keep His praise in your mouth and His word in your hand. Sing for joy tonight.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Is your joy in God deep enough to follow you home — to sing even on your bed at night?

◆

DAY 365 · DECEMBER 31 · PSALM 150

Let Everything That Has Breath Praise the LORD

"Let everything that has breath praise Yah! Praise Yah!"
— PSALM 150:6

The last psalm in the Bible is a burst of praise from start to finish: *"Praise Yah! Praise God in his sanctuary! Praise him in his heavens for his acts of power!"* (Psalm 150:1). Where? In His sanctuary and in His heavens — everywhere. Why? *"Praise him for his mighty acts! Praise him according to his excellent greatness!"* (Psalm 150:2). For what He has done, and for who He is. How? With everything you have.

"Praise him with the sounding of the trumpet! Praise him with harp and lyre! Praise him with tambourine and dancing! Praise him with stringed instruments and flute! Praise him with loud cymbals! Praise him with resounding cymbals!" (Psalm 150:3–5). Trumpet. Harp. Tambourine. Dancing. Strings. Flute. Cymbals, loud and clashing. Every instrument in the temple orchestra, all at once. The book of Psalms began with a quiet meditation by streams of water. It ends in a full orchestra.

Then the last line of the whole book: *"Let everything that has breath praise Yah! Praise Yah!"* (Psalm 150:6). Everything that has breath. That takes you back to the beginning of the Bible, when *"Yahweh God formed man from the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life"* (Genesis 2:7). Dust plus the breath of God. That is what you are. And the breath God gave you was given for this — to praise Him. Every breath you take is borrowed from Him and meant to return to Him as praise.

This year began with a cry from the dust. Psalm 119:25 prays, *"My soul clings to the dust; Revive me according to Your word"* (NKJV). You have walked through all 150 psalms — lament and joy, confession and thanks, the pit and the high tower. And the book ends here, not in the dust, but in breathless praise. That is the arc of the whole gospel. Dust, revived by God's word, lifted to glory. Revelation shows where it finishes: *"a great multitude, which no man could count, out of every nation"* (Revelation 7:9), crying, *"Salvation be to our God, who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb!"* (Revelation 7:10). You have breath today. Praise Him with it.

LIFT UP YOUR EYES

Christ breathed His last on the cross and lay in the dust of death. On the third day the breath of life returned, and He rose. Because He lives, everything that has breath will one day praise Him. You have breath today. Spend it on Him. Praise the LORD.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

As this year ends, how will you spend the breath God has given you?

◆